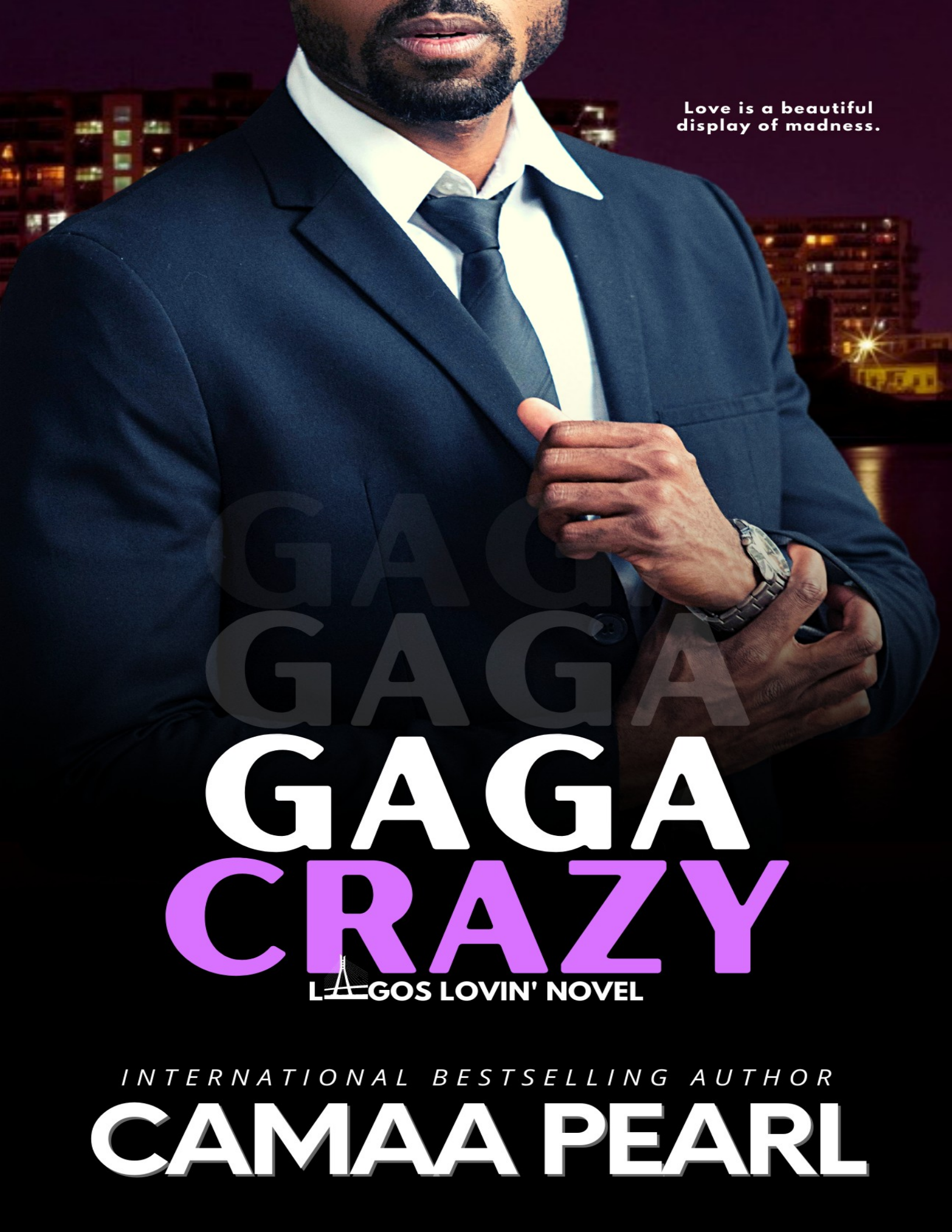

Love is a beautiful display of madness.
GAGA CRAZY
LAGOS LOVIN' NOVEL
INTERNATIONAL BESTSELLING AUTHOR
CAMAA PEARL

TITLES BY CAMAA PEARL

Lagos Lovin' Novels
Gaga Crazy (Zoya & Manir)
*Bottom Belle (Summer 2022)

Skyline Novels
*Call Me Jemila (Summer 2022)

Flawed Perfections Novels
** First Impressions
** Crossroads
** Romantic Illusions

Twin Bliss Resort Novel
** Escape (Lola & Onahi)

Standalones
** Nine Hours Till Five

Short Stories & Anthologies
** Hell Hath No Fury, An African Christmas Romance Anthology
** Nights at Club Nova, An Erotic Romance Anthology
** Roses Aren't Red, An African Romance Anthology
** Butterfingered

** - Dates are susceptible to change*
*** - writing as Margaret Adetimehin*

OceanofPDF.com

PRAISE FOR CAMAA PEARL

WRITING AS MARGARET ADETIMEHIN

"Margaret is one author I would look out for."
Sally Kenneth-Dadzie, award-winning and best-selling author

"Margaret's writing is impeccable."
Jessica Tagbajumi, Author, Wings of the Night Sky

"I love you, Margaret. Seriously I do, your style of writing, the hilarious characters and how they feel so real."
Precious Batubo, Amazon Reviewer

"Margaret writes beautiful stories infused with life's lessons."
Onome Omodara, Host of Naked with Onome Podcast

"...Margaret writes stories you will pick up and not drop until you are done..."
Otegbayo Joy, Relationship Coach

"...Margaret's style is refreshingly unique in content and approach— fictional, motivational, conversational, inspirational— altogether..."
Peter Adeshina Babalola (PAB), CEO, PowerTalk

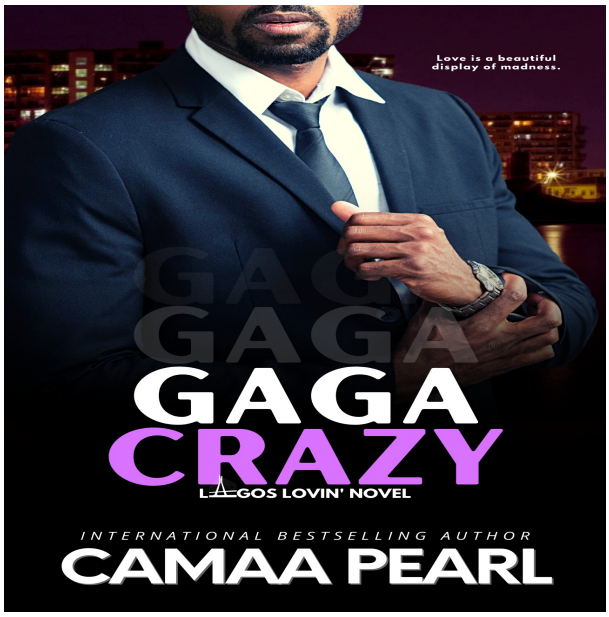
"...a real Nigerian treasure."
Glory Abah, Author and Creative Writing Coach

"Margaret uses the protagonists in sharing their own stories. ...there is no alteration of the message."
Certified Book Lover

"Margaret does a great job of giving us a deep understanding of the main characters."

BooksXwine

OceanofPDF.com



CAMAA PEARL

OceanofPDF.com

COPYRIGHT

Published by IfeNla.
An imprint of Irinajo House LLC

irinajohouse.com

Gaga Crazy © 2022 by Margaret Adetimehin writing as Camaa Pearl
The right of Camaa Pearl to be identified as the author of this work has been asserted by her in accordance with the copyright laws.

All rights reserved.
No part of this eBook may be used or reproduced or transmitted in any manner whatsoever without written permission of the copyright holder, except in the case of brief quotations embodied in critical articles or reviews.

This book is a work of fiction. Names, characters, businesses, organizations, places, events, and incidents either are the product of the author's imagination or are used fictitiously. Any resemblance to actual persons, living or dead, events, or locales is entirely coincidental.

For more information, kindly visit irinajohouse.com

First Edition: May 2022

OceanofPDF.com

CONTENTS

Titles By Camaa Pearl
Praise For Camaa Pearl
Contents
Acknowledgements
Playlist
One - Lagos Quanta
Two - Bumwad
Three - The Appraisal
Four - Pre-Qualification
Five - Counteroffer
Six - Proof Of Funds
Seven - Escrow Holder
Eight - Jeez. Cladding
Nine - Inspection Officers
Ten - Floorplan
Eleven - Due Dilligence Contingency
Twelve - Out Of Context
Thirteen - Covenants, Conditions & Restrictions
Fourteen - Leave Trash For Lawma
Fifteen - Fenestration
Sixteen - Collectible Concepts
Seventeen - Owambe
Eighteen - Title Search
Nineteen - Blind Offer
Twenty - Turnkey Ready
Twenty-One - Subject To Inspection
Twenty-Two - Street Is Here
Twenty-Three - Johnny Just Come

Twenty-Four - Seller Disclosure
Twenty-Five - Facade
Twenty-Six - Shine Your Eye
Twenty-Seven - Backsplash
Twenty-Eight - Jega…
Twenty-Nine - There Is God
Thirty - Curtain Walls
Thirty-One - Backup Offer
Thirty-Two - Private Showings
Thirty-Three - Conscious Living
Thirty-Four - Accentuation
Thirty-Five - Wrong Scales
Thirty-Six - Turn Up
Thirty-Seven - Trust Scale
Thirty-Eight - Pre-Approval
Thirty-Nine - Spatial Organization
Forty - Building Envelope
Forty-One - As Is
Forty-Two - Preliminary Report
Forty-Three - Days On Market
Forty-Four - Finial
Epilogue - Buttress
A Letter To You
Camaa's Recipes
About Camaa Pearl
An Excerpt From Bottom Belle, Lagos Lovin' #2
Enjoyed This Book?

OceanofPDF.com

For Raphael.
And you, going through something they don't know about.

OceanofPDF.com

ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

I will not lie, this book would never have made it out of my pile of manuscripts without the help of God, grim determination, and the special people I'm about to list.

Think Tank & Design: Adesina Oluwatobi and Oluwole Fanegan.

Architects: Arc. Adebusola Adeoye (ARCON; MNIA), Owolabi Oluwatomisin Samuel, Timothy Oluwaseyi Uzoigwe (Assoc. AIA, LEED AP), and the anonymous architects (winks).

Critique & Beta readers: Nelly Uyiosa, Daniel Bawa, Maggie Smart, and Glory Abah.

My Confessor (*lol*): L. Leigh, thank you for everything, putting up with my anxiety. Reminding me to take a step back to look at the bigger picture.

Thanks to The Dream, my family, friends and writing pals on my YouTube and Telegram channels.

Lastly, thanks to you, survivors, and mental health advocates around the world.

OceanofPDF.com

PLAYLIST

Ara—Brymo
Gaga Crazy—Chuddy K
No One Like You—P Square
The Marriage Prayer—John Waller
Careless Whisper—George Michael
What's My Name—Rihanna & Drake
Hey There Delilah—Plain White T's
5 and 6—Naeto-C
Fall in Love—D'Banj
Hey Lovely—Omolara
Yeah 3x—Chris Brown
Strong Ting—Banky W
Ki Ni Big Deal—Naeto-C
Last Night—Keyshia Cole
Someone Like You—Adele
Whenever You Call—Mariah Carey
These Words—Natasha Bedingfield
Without You—David Guetta, Usher
Love You Like A Love Song—Selena Gomez
Kiss Me Thru The Phone—Soulja Boy Tell'em
I Need A Doctor—Dr. Dre, Eminem, Skylar Grey
Party Rock Anthem—LMFAO, Lauren Bennett, GoonRock
Ain't No Mountain High Enough—Marvin Gaye, Tammie Terrell

Listen here: bit.ly/gagacrazyplaylist

OceanofPDF.com

The madness of love is the greatest of heaven's blessings.

—Pedro Calderon de la Barca

OceanofPDF.com

ONE

LAGOS QUANTA

Zoya

Feels like I'm living someone else's life. It's fun but can't wait for them to see and accept my designs.

"***YOU NO FIT COME DOWN FOR*** *this side oh, LASTMA dey here!*"

I stare at the bus conductor in disgust as he hollers at us like we're naughty school children on a field trip. His nasal voice, comical, considering that his counterparts have thicker thuggish voices.

"But you picked a passenger by the road..." a woman in corporate wear says, trying to be sensible with the bus conductor.

That's not how to speak to a bus conductor in Lagos. I shake my head, fold my arms, then lean on the window, listening as everyone in the bus fights for their right. Occasionally, I turn my head to confirm who is speaking.

"Why we no fit come down?" a man asks.

"Go slow dey here na!" A lady shouts from behind. *"Shey we go wait till we reach bus stop ni?"*

"My friend," a middle-aged man in black who has been quiet since he got into the bus shouts, "open that door!"

Now that's the way to speak to bus conductors, I release a micro smile. They only understand aggression. If you're nice to them while in their buses, they will walk all over you.

It is almost seven in the morning and traffic on the Lagos-Ibadan expressway is wild. Cars are doubly parked in stagnant queues of unopened fueling stations. There is also the thoughtless overtaking of some drivers trying to avoid traffic, followed by tantrums if their vehicle got scratched. It is pitiful watching such displays of madness in the early morning traffic.

It's unbelievable that about three weeks ago—New Year's Day—the most beloved President of our country, and his Cabal removed fuel subsidy from petroleum products and Nigerians, like me, got angry. We took to the street for twelve days.

Twelve days!

All systems shut down, unions went on strike, even schools. We sang *solidarity forever*. Trended on Twitter for days with *#occupynigeria*. Media houses—local and international—televised us. Nigerians in diaspora took to the streets. We cried, sang, and cried again. Hmm. It was a cause we were ready to die for.

We successfully paralyzed the economy to be heard by those we put in power.

And it worked. They heard us.

However, fueling companies and their staff are hoarding petroleum products, reporting they are short on supply. Meanwhile, multiple incidents of tanker explosions occur on busy highways, making road commuters move with extra caution when they sight tankers. The year just started, and it feels like we are in year 2020.

Commercial bus drivers are also playing a significant role in this mess. They are milking the situation; increasing the price of every destination by fifty naira, even though the new pump price for petrol is now 97 Naira, from the initial 65 Naira. All that backstory is to let you know I am paying extra than normal to arrive at work late and this bus conductor is stressing me out!

The bus grunts, then jerks, before it eases into a crowded bus stop. People maul themselves, trying to get on the bus without knowing its destination.

Another thing about Lagos is its glamourous trademarked yellow *danfo* buses always have one fault or the other. Either they swayed liked dancers, made weird sounds or emitted enough carbon dioxide to kill all the fishes in a pond.

A familiar vibration makes me scramble into my favorite D&G bag for my phone. Upon unlocking the screen, I pull down the notification bar to find Manir, my favorite human, just pinged me. I smile into my phone, forgetting the annoying bus conductor exists.

7:07 AM
Mighty Man: Morning beauty, slept well?

"Fine geh. Fine geh wey dey press fone."

I turn to look at the bus conductor.

"*Adjust for that place. This place dey take five people.*"

I shoot him a scowl before moving my ass for the new passenger. He is arranging us five in a row, instead of the usual four, like we are sardines in a can! And he's having two people hang onto the door with him. Just 'cause of the extra bucks he will get. Why won't the buses groan and complain? *This is an eighteen-seater bus!*

The disrespect is uncalled for. I should complain like other passengers, but the clouds are dark, heavy with rain and not all bus drivers have recovered from the fuel scarcity... Joining the growing crowd at the next bus stop is not

the best choice. The aftermath of our twelve-day rebellion is affecting everyone, and now it's survival of the fittest.

"*Madame. I talk am before you enter. Na one-fifty I dey collect*."

From the lurch of the bus, I know we have resumed our journey to Lagos Island. I type a response to Manir, and as I hit send, I remember I should be angry with him.

7:08 AM
Queen Zo: Morning.
Lol.
You can say that cos you've not seen me yet.
I slept well.

"Abeg na…" the elderly woman pleads. *"I no get that kain money this morning. Na market I wan go carry."*

"Pilot!"

I look to find the driver has spared the bus conductor a glance through the rearview mirror.

"Abeg, where you see space park, person wan drop."

What an irritating human being.

Ignoring the plea of the elderly woman, he focuses on collecting fare rides from other passengers. *"Your money there… I tell you say make you enter with change now…"*

Mighty Man is typing a message…

This bus conductor is greedier and more insulting than others I have encountered. No chill pill at all.

Probably because he spent hours in a long queue trying to purchase fuel from black markets, but that doesn't give him an excuse to be so rude early in the morning.

The bus violently lurches with hiccup like noises when the driver changes gear and I sway with it. *God, please, please don't let this bus break down halfway.*

Going by public transport has made all of us in Lagos seamen, and most of us don't know.

7:10 AM

Mighty Man: Sorry about last night. Got distracted.
And don't doubt my judgement. If I say you are beautiful, you are.
Ok?

You are so cute. I forgive you already. Manir... I sigh, staring at my phone's screen, smiling. *I have moved past the phase of delayed gratification, the stage of making you wait.*

7:10 AM
Queen Zo: Lol. Yes boss.

Talk to me. Tell me anything! Anything to take my mind off the fact that I'm being squeezed in this godforsaken bus.

I used to play that unscripted game of if he delays in replying in two minutes, multiply your response time by two. Or delay in replying no matter how interesting the topic is, make him sweat.

Manir is technically my bestie, but Chiluba aka Luba, must not hear this. She has been occupying the position long before he came along. Chiluba doesn't understand my fascination with comparing Manir with my other male friends.

"You know it's because you're not dating him he looks perfect?"

"Nah... He is real. The real deal. But I'll never meet him, so..." I shrugged.

In standard friendship terms, Chiluba is the female bestie, while Manir is the male bestie. He is my advisor on all things since he is pretty smart and worldly—advising me on family, friends, romance, and work.

Four years ago, I was wrapping up NYSC when I came across a tweet. "It's impossible to have a male bestie and not have sex with them. Fear women that have such!"

The profile image was of a man, and I wanted to give him and all his followers a run for their money. So, I responded to the tweet. "Have you had sex with all your female best friends?"

"I don't hope to," came a stranger's reply with the handle @mighty_man1.

"All of them! They even send me the color of their panties daily," another stranger replied. And there were several others.

My response to @mighty_man1 was. "And this is because you're married? If you're married and have a bestie that's not your wife, now that's a problem."

He replied. I replied. He replied. I replied and soon, we started a viral thread.

@mighty_man1 slid into my DM and we continued our aggressive but playful chat. One thing led to another, we exchanged BBM pins, as I was reluctant to share my phone number. He told me his name was Manir, and we kicked it off from there—there wasn't a dull moment.

From missing him when he wasn't available, online or in business meetings, to him missing me when I was busy, writing exams or working on projects. Our bond grew stronger.

Manir doesn't post pictures. He is not vain like me. Even now that there's Instagram, he said he only created an account to stalk me. Me, on the other hand, I enjoy seeing the music he listens to on my BBM status update, which is why I am skeptical about getting a Samsung phone. BBM is the future.

What started towards the end of my NYSC lasted through my second degree, which I was opportune to carryout in UK, all thanks to the Commonwealth Scholarship.

7:13 AM

Queen Zo: Where are you? Prepping for work?
Are you serious about us meeting this year?

We've maintained our relationship without ever seeing each other for over four years. We have touched and argued on every subject, ranging from politics to religious views, to life and career goals, including relationship and marital plans.

When he went on dates, he told me. When he met a new girl or had questions about the feminine gender, he reached out to me, and I did the same.

He is like a brother I never had, a big brother. No drama, just pure companionship and understanding. I sometimes wish we were more, but... I am happy the way things are. And I really do have a big brother, but that's a story for another day.

Upon my return to Lagos from the UK, I was either interviewing to get a job, or he was out of town on business. When I finally landed this job, my excuse has been that my work schedule is filled and I need to focus, hence can't travel. Speaking of focus, it's high time I resume preparing for my Professional Practice Exam, PPE, which is due in March, less than two months away.

I love the idea of seeing him, putting the blood and bone of the human who was always in my head right in front of me, but I am scared...

What if he has body odor? What if he is just a great person from a distance? Meeting him in person might ruin my ideology of him. The thought of looking into his eyes, knowing that he knows my fears, wants, needs... Things I will not acknowledge about myself even to Chiluba... My dirty secrets which no one, no one in my entire universe, not even my sister, Zena, knows about.

Nah...

I want him to be my best-kept secret. It is best we stay social media buddies. If all goes well and a jealous girlfriend or boyfriend doesn't come along, we will most likely be lifelong friends.

"Conductor," I call succinctly in my not-so-cool pidgin English, "my change o."

I will not be this bus conductor's benefactor. He is so rude... Lagos bus conductors are of the habit of intentionally not giving change on time and I have fallen victim one too many times, which is fine by me. But whether or not I was late or chatting with my man crush every day, I am not letting this rude one go with my eight hundred and fifty naira change.

I look out the window to find people hurrying to shelter before the heavy clouds let loose. A woman who had set up shop is chasing after her umbrella, but a passerby gets to it before she does and hands it to her. It is clear the rain has started ahead of us.

My phone buzzes with a response.

7:21 AM

Mighty Man: Dead serious.
Almost at the office. Series of meetings today.

Queen Zo: Wow, so early.
Aren't you supposed to be meditating or something?

Manir had started some sort of early morning yoga practice after a recent business trip to India. All I know about his business is that it involves lots of travel, meetings, and he makes good money, enough to retire today if he wanted to.

7:23 AM
Mighty Man: Nawti you.
I feel foggy headed tho.
Got into Lagos last night. Hope to see you today before I leave.

Last night where I was googling everything about Architect Wole's cousin. I didn't even have time to think of Manir. Architect Wole's cousin is somewhat like my new crush, just that he looks too old for my liking even though he's in his early thirties. He had a tragic childhood, both parents

dying in a car crash. They were great business partners and the perfect parents until death snatched them. Must have been hard growing up without both parents. He's doing well for himself, running a luxury realty business with offices in Africa, Middle East and Europe.

7:23 AM
Queen Zo: What!
You flew into Lagos and didn't tell me?

Mighty Man: It's supposed to be a surprise.
Why do you think I told you we need to meet?

7:24 AM
Queen Zo: Because you always say it?

Mighty Man: I mean it this time around.
Don't know how long I'll be gone.
Send me your address so I can stop by after work.

I'm ignoring his last message because, well… it's what we always do.

7:28 AM
Mighty Man: Getting ready for work?

7:30 AM
Queen Zo:
On my way.
Looks like it's about to rain.
I hope I beat it.

As I hit the send button, a fat droplet of water hits me. I struggle, with the help of the conductor, to shut the bus's window as rain cascades at an unrelenting pace.

Unwashed bodies, mouth odors from complaining lips, and heavy cologne mingled with the earthy smell of rain—the overcrowded bus now has a musty smell to it. I want to get off now.

7:48 AM

Queen Zo: It is raining. Heavy rain.
I seriously need to get a car.

Outside, people run seeking shelter, like chicken without heads. I wince when I see a woman with a heavily made-up face use her prized handbag to cover her face. Where a gutter should be, pressed plastic bottle containers, dried sucked orange skins and nylons, hang on to a net in murky water, clogging the drainage system, making it useless as overlapping waste moves into the street. The sight is horrendous.

By the looks of it, it is better sitting in this musty bus than being stuck under the rain. My saving grace is that my office's building is under ten minutes' walk from the bus stop and if the conductor is nice, he will drop me in front of the building.

7:48 AM

Mighty Man: Pele.
All in good time.
Thought you resumed at 9am.

Yes, ahh… my challenging job that I'm late for.

I'm a proactive titled Junior Architect doing the job of Senior Architects. Nothing glamourous, but I'm getting there. Because I am yet to pass my Professional Practice Exam. It is some hierarchy thing in the overall professional architectural system, but I'm loving my job.

7:49 AM

Queen Zo: Today is an exception.

"Adeniji!" the bus conductor calls.

"*Owa ooo*," I respond, quickly typing 'TTYL' to Manir.

The bus comes to a stop. With two people blocking the bus's exit, I alight as gracefully as I can, without falling headfirst into the tarred road. He could have just moved forward a bit, almost by my building. Thank God it's only drizzling here.

I turn to the bus conductor. "My ch—"

He leans on the door, counting my change. "Pilot! Those boys dey come. Fire!"

Before I can say 'which boys,' the bus zooms off.

Scampering to avoid the water splashing from the tyres, I stare at the smoky cloud trail the bus leaves behind. *What just happened? Did he really?* I look around and see none of the bus stop thugs or whomever the conductor was in a hurry to avoid. Argh!

OceanofPDF.com

TWO

BUMWAD!

Zoya

Paris is lovely! As much as I hate Lagos, I've never imagined living somewhere else.

HE SCAMMED ME OF MY CHANGE. That mannerless, rude, thieving rogue scammed me!

I really need to get a car. Only a handful of twenty-something-year-old ladies living in Lagos owned cars, and I am more than excited to join that club now.

Owning a car in Lagos as a young woman today equals calling unwarranted attention to yourself, but it is a necessity. The reason I didn't want to get a car in the past was because if someone bashed me—which is inevitable in Lagos from the number of accidents I see in traffic daily—they would either say it's my fault, because I'm a woman, or that I'm too young to be driving. Then the mechanics will try to swindle me, except I go there with a man. The reasons are endless.

Calm down Zoya, just head to the office and get settled in.

I begin a brisk walk, keeping my steps short and calculated, avoiding colliding with others scurrying off to work in the opposite direction.

Should have just resumed at my usual time, but I really wanted to join Architect Wole in his discussion with his cousin. I helped Architect Wole in his research for his cousin's project and he was eager to have me meet his cousin today. Not like I am in any way related to that project, but Mercury Consults is one big family and, well, I am one of the favorite children. Although I didn't give him a definitive answer, I decided to come in on time to see what the fuss about this cousin of his was.

The automatic front door to the office building opens to reveal the grand reception area. To the left-hand side, are elevators, but first I need to stop at Mr. Riliwan's.

Mr. Riliwan, the building's security officer, is already at his post in his starched and ironed uniform. He gives me a warm smile, holding out an access card to me.

"Ah... Mr. Riliwan, thank you." I smile, accepting the card. Since I started working here, I still can't bring myself to call him Riliwan like others do.

Mr. Riliwan is a darling. On my way out yesterday, I forgot my access card on his desk while having a chit-chat with him. He later called me on my phone not to worry—he had kept it.

He has been there for me since my interview with Madam Nelly. It is funny now that I think about it. He had directed me to the eighth floor and had shared tips on how to wow Madam Nelly. He was tired of people going and coming, not getting the job.

Mr. Riliwan beams as I try adjusting my appearance. "You're in early today. I hope everything is alright?"

He is years older than me, in experience and age, but still maintains professionalism. Discussions with him are impressive. It was through one that I found out he was taking classes to get a degree and apply for a job to become

a draftsman in the engineering department. I respect that a lot about him, even donated to the cause.

"Everything is fine. Thank you." Shaking out my braids to let moisture out, I search my bag for tissues, but nothing. Oh no.

"That's good. Because I'm seeing old familiar faces." He smiles.

Architect Wole and his cousin must be in then. I need to freshen up if I want to join them in the conference room, can't go in there looking like something the cat dragged in.

"Please, can I have a tissue or—do you have a towel? Something to clean my shoes and bag?"

"Yes ma." He looks around his corner for something to offer me. "*Oh, you see rain?*"

Seriously? Mr. Riliwan? Like I would get a bottle of water on my way to work to sprinkle on my body. Such a Nigerian thing to do—asking the obvious. Forcing a smile, I collect a towel from him and begin dabbing.

Assessing the fix-up I have done and okay with it, I drop the towel on his desk. "Thank you, Mr. Riliwan." I'll thank him more appropriately later.

Instead of continuing my brisk pace, I take dainty steps towards the elevator and hit the button. It doesn't take long for an empty car to arrive. Most offices in the building resume at nine.

Whew! Solitude.

I step in and press number eight.

The door is about to close when three men in suits step in. Giving them a courteous smile, I move to make space, holding my head high, damp clothing and all. I almost groan out loud when they click different levels in the building. On the third floor, one of them holds the door for a lady in casual wear.

"So sorry," the lady says when she gets in, before hitting five.

A tight smile graces my face. *It is okay. Everything is fine. You won't miss much of the presentation.*

After getting past the sixth floor without stopping, I begin tapping my feet. The bell chimes, and I fly out.

Ever the classy lady, I walk with calculated calmness, cooing greetings to those I run into. Goosebumps pops on my skin as chilly air from the blasting air conditioner comes in contact with my skin.

Opening the door to the hallway that leads to where the senior executives work from, I exchange pleasantries with Kaffy, the secretary.

Kaffy is at work before 8:30 AM? Now I understand why she is always disgruntled by 2:00 PM.

We're all in this together. As a junior architect working with three senior architects on different projects at different stages, let's not add the interns I mentor, I tend to stay on till past ten most nights.

As I make a turn, a body collides with mine, causing me to almost grind my teeth in frustration. But when the clean, clay-like fragrance of talcum powder from the body's owner reaches me, I stop.

Nelly Uzoghelu, my first and only supervisor since I joined Mercury Consults, also known as Madam Nelly. She's more excited than I am to pass my professional exams so they can officially promote me and I can see my building designs come to life with my name on it. She, more than anyone, knows how much of a valuable asset I am to the company, sometimes citing how she can see her younger ambitious self in me.

What a morning…

I like her, but Madam Nelly is nosy about my business. Okay, not just my business, the woman makes it her business to know everybody's business. It might have been part of her job training, but it gets irritating, like now.

"Why are you just getting in?" Her warm, elderly eyes inspect my attire. She sometimes asks where I get my clothing from and at first it felt nice, but somewhere along the line, it started making me feel uncomfortable. I would prefer if she complimented me and let it go instead of making everything about her. I know she means no ill, but I don't need to know what she did with her wardrobe in the 90s.

Why am I just getting in? Um… I'm not supposed to be here in the first place. Just feeding my curiosity.

I spare her a tight smile. "Architect Wole's—"

"I know. But you are supposed to be here before eight. I sent you an email last night to come in on time to cover for him."

She sent me a message? When? "I didn't—"

"Please hurry before he leaves."

Mercury Consults is a lean business and Madam Nelly has been here for years, so there are some things she automatically knows. Rumor also has it that Madam Nelly is or was at one time, Architect Wole's side chic.

"Zoya?"

"Um?" Bringing my focus back to her.

"This is no way to get that Architectural title. Please get going."

Oh.

I scramble to my office to get a note and pen, pull out my laptop from my bag, and have it running. When did she send the message? Do I still have access to the presentation? What were the things Architect Wole pointed out? What am I supposed to clarify?

Knowing I have a client waiting, I still opt to confirm if she had sent a message. And yes, I see one, sent some minutes to midnight.

> From: *nelly@mercuryconsults.com*
> To: *ehizoya@mercuryconsults.com*
> **Subject: Urgent: Last Minute Meeting Update**
>
> Hello Ehizoya,
>
> I understand this is short notice, but Arc. Wole will not be able to make it in tomorrow as he has been diagnosed with a severe case of food poisoning.

However, he still wants the meeting with Mr. Dosu-Andrews to go on as scheduled with you taking the lead. Please come in earlier to cover for him.

Kind regards,

—

Arc. Nelly
Operations Executive

OceanofPDF.com

THREE

THE APPRAISAL

Manir

When I'm in between relationships, I have girls who come to my crib, office, name it. Sex is food.

8:02 AM, THE DECORATIVE WALL CLOCK glares at me.

That's it. If the incompetent soul my uncle employed doesn't show up in three minutes, I am done with this. Whatever this was. The assistant could have emailed, called, or you know… sent a bird over.

Don't know why I must explain to some nitwit what I can tell Uncle Wole over the phone or why he didn't reschedule our meeting for my next Lagos visit.

Before setting up this meeting, I had told him I had a meeting for ten at Lekki, but Uncle Wole persuaded me to stop by as he wanted to discuss business with me in person and catch up.

“Killing two birds with one stone,” he’d said. “You’re always on the move, so squeeze in this time to see me.”

“You’re making it sound like you don’t see me enough.”

“Ah… do I? Even during family meetings, you breeze in and breeze out. As if something is chasing you.”

Maybe something is, I thought, palming my forehead. “It’s work Uncle…”

“Hmm. You need to find a woman and settle down,” he’d said in Yoruba.

I laughed. Settling down is something I’m game for, but I’m yet to find the woman who checks all the boxes.

“Okay, you’re laughing. You think I’m joking. Age is not on your side.”

I’m over thirty, most people my age are married. “I know.”

“Good. Because when you marry and have two children calling you daddy, you’ll learn to calm down.”

“That’s why I need to make this money now.” Sighing, I gave in to his demand.

Had to squeeze this meeting in for this morning, made it down here as early as I could, only to be stood up.

Madam Nelly had popped in earlier with a lady bearing a tray of fresh coffee and biscuits. It was a nice way to apologize, but I have a lot planned out for today.

The snack is good, biting into one as my mind drifts, but if this is how they operate, I’m not sure I would stop by any time in the future. The whole point of meeting in person is baseless now that Uncle Wole is sick and can’t make it.

Picking up my phone, I read online news, steering clear of blogs. They never report important stories. From my perspective, I believe they prefer posting news that makes their page views increase, putting out fake or controversial news for clickbait’s sake. Only few mainstream media entities stay true to real journalism.

8:04 AM
Tiwa Lagos: Can I come over?
Manir: Just for the night. I leave tomorrow.

There is still nothing being done about the fuel scarcity. Just meeting upon meetings in Aso Rock with nothing to show for it. Another kidnapping in Rivers State. A popular blogger and a musician exchanging words on social media. There's also the steady fall of naira to the dollar and with time, it will get worse.

Timing is everything. They ingrained it in my genes. Timing made my great-grandfather start the family business. He built houses for others in Makoko after a great flood destroyed homes. He taught his son his craft. Upon the death of his father, my grandfather had moved to the city to become an artisan, carrying cement and sand for building contractors before moving up the ladder and becoming a building contractor himself.

Andrews and Sons' services started full time after my grandfather hit a million-naira contract back in the day. Grandfather, his three sons—Bashir, Dele, Wole—and daughter, Rekiat, did everything they could to ensure they continued the family legacy.

My father, Dele, expanded the business into real estate (Black Onyx). Uncle Wole manages the architectural arm (Mercury Consults), while Uncle Bashir focuses on structural engineering and construction (Obsidian Constructs). Their only sister, my aunt, became an interior decorator (Sapphire Consults).

The siblings pulled together their resources, renamed the company the Reporium Group, and assigned themselves a portion of the business as a division. I have cousins whose part of the empire is in the exportation and importation of building materials. Reporium Group is more than just a home builder, it is a legacy.

When I hit my first billion in Naira at twenty-nine from multiple realty investments that paid off overseas, they featured me in Times Magazine. People wanted me to speak at their events, become a mentor, while some were

curious about my lifestyle. Bloggers carried my story, and that was how my love-hate relationship with them began.

They asked for interviews, probing me with irrelevant questions. Some went ahead to write that I was a young achiever, riding on my family's wealth —a young dude, born into a prominent family, who has it easy, and they hate me for it. That I shouldn't be revered as it is easy to make money from money. If only they know. Anyway, I like it that way.

The only person I've thought of sharing tidbits about my life with is a woman I consider to be a sister. Calling a lady who knows that much about me a sister is impertinent. Confidante is more like it. Therapist? Hmm... make that, confessor.

My personal confessor… Queen Zo.

I always look forward to sharing details of my day with her. We have never spoken on the phone, but our chats make up for it. I have pseudonym social media accounts which I use to listen to others because officially, you can't find me online.

Holding long conversations with women outside business tops my list of top five hardest tasks to perform. But with Queen Zo, it flows. Her quirky posts on social media makes my day. Her tweets and retweets make me shake my head in indulgence. Meeting her online is one of life's blessings I thank God for. Although... I doubt she would be as engaging in person as humans are a unique specie, saying one thing, meaning something else.

She is always available for chats, but with her recent job, her presence online has been affected. I don't mind. As long as we chat daily, late at night, midday, it doesn't matter. I'm usually in different time zones and having her chide me to go to bed on time makes me feel loved. She does care.

I've been in Nigeria for too long, I need out. Seven weeks is a long time for me. Usually, I leave the country on a whim. But because of multiple projects in different states, I've been tied down.

Tempted to chat Queen Zo, I pause, recollecting she had typed TTYL. I had the privilege of getting instant responses from her earlier, but she had

mentioned something about getting into work on time. Unlike the executive whom I'm waiting for, who thinks the world revolves around her.

Raising my head from my phone to glance at the clock, my eyes catch movement outside the conference room, which is glass walled.

What am I seeing? Blinking, I correct myself. *Who am I seeing?* Did my mind conjure the apparition walking towards me?

I'm used to seeing ladies dressed in grey corporate attire looking like school proprietresses but, on this lady, it looks extraordinary. Like she invented the word corporate chic. From her neck, the gown molds with her skin—which is a shade between chocolate and caramel—skimming above her knees, giving her an air of class. How can someone wearing grey look so hot! The color is grey. Grey!

The neckline of the gown is so high, with only the teasing skin of her neck visible. Is the back of the dress low? I've been to some events with women wearing gowns that look innocent in front but wild, with a low cut behind. What does the back look like?

She's holding a laptop with some notes as she continues towards me. Her open-toe heels make a statement, giving her height a boost, with white painted toenails peeking from it. She's headed here. To me.

Should I get up when she walks in or keep my seat? Is she the assistant's replacement? Because she looks like a woman who has her stuff together, not some executive who keeps people waiting. Why am I so hot and bothered? I need to get my act together.

Oh no... I didn't see the cleaning lady coming from the corner. Would have warned her. Got so blindsided by her looks and carriage. But mehn! She's got everything in check, everything in control.

Her mission must be to apologize for her colleague's tardiness, just like Madam Nelly did. It has truly been a while since I visited Uncle Wole's office. When did they hire this sophisticated lady? Not like I keep tabs of who comes and goes but...

The smile she gives the cleaner is reassuring—I wouldn't mind being the receiver of such smile—before resuming her walk towards the conference room. As she draws closer, I notice her cheekbones are high, sculptured to perfection, with a confident leftover smile.

It can't be.

Turning my face to the window overlooking the busy street of Lagos Island, I begin calculating the possibilities.

If I didn't know better, I'd be thinking my mind conjured my personal confessor to life. It's been a while since she posted pictures online, but I swear, that lady is her doppelgänger.

The slight change of air announces the presence of someone joining me and I turn to find the lady has pushed open the doors.

When our eyes meet, she offers a professional smile before opening her mouth to say something. For the life of me, I watch her lips move in slow motion, fascinated by the movement and remarkable cupid bow. The sound that comes out of it is silky, sonorous, smooth...

"Good morning Mr. Dosu-Andrews. Apologies for the delay."

OceanofPDF.com

FOUR

PRE-QUALIFICATION

Zoya

Ever had sex in your office? Ignore that. Reading a book where the boss bangs the babe on the table. It's hot.

HEADING INTO THE CONFERENCE ROOM WITH an air of positivity, I begin speaking to the meeting's outcome. This is beyond meeting the *cute* Architect Wole's cousin, this is show yourself, wow him.

I will walk in there, smile, share small talk on Lagos and traffic, then we will talk business. No awkwardness involved. He will see my potential and even offer me a consultant job on the spot, but I'll turn him down, telling him I can't because I'm loyal to Mercury Consults when in truth, I just want to get my architectural title and figure out what's next in my life.

Sounds like a plan.

In my state of optimism, I almost run into Mercy, the cleaner. The only reason I am not drenched is because her bucket is empty.

It makes little sense, bumping into people and near water accidents all morning. *God, are you showing me a sign or something? I need to learn to decode your voice.*

I spot the profile of Mr. Dosu-Andrews through the glass walled conference room. His face is away from me, looking out the window. What is he thinking about? I wish I have the power to read people's thoughts, so I'll know if being all smiles and chatter works for him or stick to being curt.

Be yourself!

I take a deep breath. Count. *One… Two, three*. Then push open the door, breezing into the room.

He turns sharply, acknowledging my presence with a dissecting gaze, which I counter with a bright smile. "Good morning Mr. Dosu-Andrews. Apologies for the delay."

That is a good start. You did good girl!

Smartly placing my laptop and notepad on the table, I did not take my time to process the man before me. If I had, I would have looked closely at him before stretching my hand for a shake.

His expression is passive as he stands to receive my outstretched hand. He appears younger—with short glistening beard, dark lips hooding pink bottom lips and compelling dark eyes—way younger than the recycled online pictures painted him to be, looking like a neatly wrapped candy in an impeccable crisp black suit. His hand touches mine and I swear, neurons from somewhere in my head runs to the spot between my legs.

He curves one side of his mouth.

Okay… he is a little amused. What is the joke?

I swear, his eyes are smiling while the rest of his face holds a bored, disinterested look. For the life of me, I can't fathom why.

Is it my gown? I cast a quick look down but see nothing untoward. Chiluba herself had designed this gown, so I know it is spectacular. *I look spectacular. It's not me.*

Then what?

Because you just had a micro-orgasm, and he knows…

Heck no!

His eyes and hand hold mine a second longer than necessary before I pull away.

I force a smile, pushing my adulterous thoughts aside, and sit on a chair, one seat away from him.

"Good morning…" His deep, authoritative baritone sounds more like a question for what my name is, than the greeting it is supposed to be as he settles into his seat, his functional but obviously high-class jacket stretching in place, giving me an idea of what lays beneath them.

"Miss Zoya—Ehizoya Ainabe." I feel silly, I should have introduced myself the moment I stepped into the room.

He lifts a thick, inquiring eyebrow that protects bedroom eyes. "Miss Zoya? Or Ehizoya?"

Bedroom eyes? What has gotten into me? When did I start thinking about body features like that? I think it was because they looked heavy-lidded in that moment before switching to a shrewd, business look. I can stare at his face all day, trying to read all the micro expressions. He is too busy to spare young, inexperienced people like me macro expressions. He has probably visited the seven world wonders, and nothing fazes him anymore. No one would faze me if I had too. I can't wait to share this experience with Manir.

Get a grip Zo. He's waiting for an answer!

Clearing my throat, I respond. "Miss Ehizoya." That's what colleagues call me. I reserve *Zoya* for family and friends.

He nods slowly, compelling dark eyes on me, making me feel warm all over. If his eyes and a simple handshake can do this, what will—Nah… *Something is wrong with me*.

"So, you enjoy doing this?" he asks, his voice sending shivers down my spine.

The only word that makes sense in what he said is enjoy. *Yes, I will enjoy spending time with you, enjoy listening to you talk. Enjoy? Yes.*

Uh-oh. This is not normal. This is bad.

He is not throwing his weight around or threatening to call his uncle.

Hmm… Have I read news about him? Yes. Did I spend last night frowning at his recycled headshots? Yep. Does he look like the image? No. Meeting him in person is proof that he is not photogenic, as he looks younger, way younger than the online pictures.

Oh no. Architect Wole will be so embarrassed at my train of thought. Something must have happened to me on my way to work. Maybe the elderly woman insulting the bus conductor had used voodoo, and me, the innocent bystander, was suffering from the side effects.

"Architecture? Design? Meetings?" My eyes darting between him and my laptop screen. "Yes, I do." Another thing I should have mentioned earlier. "I'm sorry Architect Wole won't be joining us."

"I know." He wears a smirk on his face.

My response is to suppress a growl with a smile as I continue setting up my laptop. If he is trying to insult me, for being late… it is best he comes out with it. Whatever. He has every right to be angry, but not make me feel small or dumb.

After setting up my laptop in record time, I pass a document to him, which he briefly inspects before settling dark eyes on me. Ignoring him, I flip pages. On second thoughts, maybe he is not trying to make me feel small, only trying to keep the conversation flowing.

His jaw is moving in a grinding motion. A grown man grinding his teeth. A bad habit he should have gotten rid of. It looks *cute* on him, but he would need his dentist later.

Um… The screen.

"Before we begin, I need to set this up." Moving as fast as my legs can carry me towards the big screen. The silence in the room is loud. I don't know what to say to liven it. His personality is not making it easy. With my back to him,

I can feel his eyes on me. What if I dramatically turn and start dancing like a stripper? I hold back a giggle, fiddling with the buttons.

"How has it been like," his voice low, unhurried, shattering the toneless silence, "working one on one with Architect Wole?"

Straightening my back, I reset my face to be professional, before turning to face him. "It's been good..." I blurt. "Really good."

His eyes bore into mine. *Trying to see through my words? Or trying to cover up that you find me attractive? I wish to God we are not in a business setting, I would have called you out for checking me out while setting up.*

As I walk back to my seat, I notice the main office is filling up. Ife, a project manager in the engineering department nods at me as he walks by. When I joined the company, he helped me settle in nicely and even tried kicking it off romantically with me.

"Glad to hear that." He says.

I struggle to recollect what we are discussing.

"It must be overwhelming for some." He continues. "Isn't it like... living someone else's life?"

Please don't do this. Like you have ever worked a day of your life for someone else. I am not Architect Wole's personal assistant, duh. But that statement sounds familiar.

"Uh huh..." I agree with a tight smile, ready to present to my audience, who has gone back to looking bored, but I can tell his intelligent dark eyes are analyzing me, flipping a coin in his head, whether or not he should ask me out after this meeting. It will not be the first-time men at work approach me, I am used to it, knowing how to push back.

"I have gone through the documents and would need clarifications for pages seven and... twenty-five." I begin.

"We can do that later."

Later? What—

"Why don't you go straight into what I need to know?"

OceanofPDF.com

FIVE

COUNTEROFFER

Zoya

Relationships are a lot of work.

FEW MINUTES INTO MY MONOLOGUE PRESENTATION, with him adding supportive *yeses*, and *hmms*, he starts tinkering with his phone. The thought of banging the table to get his full attention crosses my mind.

A little respect will go a long way, mister.

He looks up when my phone vibrates, I make no move to pick it.

Duh. Learn from me.

The same message pops up on my laptop, popping on the big screen too, because I connected my laptop to my social media accounts.

No!

Moving fast, I disable the notification function on my laptop, setting the focus mode to priority only. That should hold off all notifications while I present.

"I'm listening," he says, flicking his wrist studded with a large stainless-steel watch.

I don't need to be reminded that he's the stuff. His deep voice is becoming familiar every second we spend together.

Continuing my monologue, I see he is still paying attention to his phone, not the screen, with an occasional quirky smile on his face. Whatever he is doing on his phone must be interesting and way more fun than my presentation that will cost him millions of naira.

"...The designs Black Onyx has in mind for the five hundred apartment units are all the same. However, looking at the trends, we would like to suggest that the designs be split—" The buzzing of my phone distracts me, again. I move to pick it, so I can silence the distracting device. It is rare for me to get messages at this time of the day.

He raises his head from his phone at my unexpected silence, his expression hinging on... gloating? Like he knows something I don't.

"I'm sorry about that. I'll—"

"Don't worry, you can check it."

Like I need your permission to touch my phone. Bossy prick.

Successfully silencing my phone, I place it under the documents and give him a half-smile. "I'll do that later. I'll be taking up much of your time as it is."

Gone was what I felt was a gloating look, in its place is a smirk.

"It could be an emergency... or... your boss." He nods toward my phone, giving me a once-over. He definitely checked me out when I was setting up.

"Oh, yeah... Please give me a moment."

It takes pulling my notification bar down for my brain to remind me I communicate with Architect Wole via email. Before I set my phone down, a new message pops on the screen and I open it. There are earlier messages too.

8:35 AM

Mighty Man: You look so hot spouting numbers, this might be a new turn on for me.

8:39 AM
Mighty Man: Why haven't we met sooner?

8:40 AM
Mighty Man: Grey looks good on you.

My brows crease as I stare at the messages for seconds that feel like hours. What does he mean? There's a vacuum forming in my tummy, and I swallow. I know we're not dating or a thing, but knowing that he had sent this to me by mistake makes me feel... jealous?

I spare Mr. Dosu-Andrews a quick glance. "Please give me a moment."

"Take your time," he smiles, but I'm no longer interested in him or deciphering his expressions.

What is going on with Manir? He doesn't have time to push to visit me but can catch up with other ladies. *You're in a meeting. Get a grip Zo! Manir is just a friend.*

But…

I should be looking at my client. I should be asking him questions. *Grey looks good on you.* Hmm? It can't be. I scroll up our chat... reading between the lines. He said he had a meeting this morning... *Dosu-Andrews is Manir?* Has he been playing me all along? *Grey looks good on you.* I look closely at Mr. Dosu-Andrews. I knew there was something amiss with his dissecting gaze and our encounter so far.

Taking a deep breath, I count zero to five. *What's the worst that can happen if he's not the one?*

"So..." My voice soft but resonant. "You're Manir? The M in Oladele M. Dosu-Andrews stands for Manir?"

A small smug smile that reaches his dark eyes lights up his face. His lips pout, like he is biting inside his bottom lips.

"You knew who I was all along?" *Duh. He texted you.*

Oh, no… let it not be. All this while… While I was going on with the presentation, he must have been replaying our conversations, trying to pair me up with the image in his head.

Clearing his throat, he relaxes back in an angle on his seat. "Not until today. Before you came in here, I was not so sure… Until you chose your name." He flicks his wrist before settling an elbow on one arm of the chair.

Keep talking… This is the longest he has spoken to me in one go and his voice is deep… Mellow… With an edge to it.

"Then I sent a message, just for extra validation." He shrugs, his eyes twinkling.

"Oh, God…" I mutter underneath my breath. "Oh, God…" Sitting on the closest chair, while occasionally staring at him as he continues his theory.

He pauses. "Are you okay?"

Am I okay? I'm meeting someone who I never imagined I'll ever meet and you're asking if I'm okay. "I almost ruined this meeting with you. Right now, I think God is playing a prank on me. And maybe…" I hear him snort, which makes me narrow my eyes at him. "It's not funny."

He shrugs, his well-manicured nails tapping the wooden table. "I'm not laughing."

"Jeez." Biting my lower lip, I study him. He is too good to be true. "I didn't plan on meeting you like this—"

"Neither did I."

You were never supposed to meet me! Don't you get it?

"You have other meetings today." I need to find a way out so I can analyze these emotions pushing at me. "I'm so sorry I delayed you."

"Apologies…" he gives a dramatic pause, his nails pausing in the act too, "not yet accepted." A wry smile crosses his face.

"Um, like you have a choice." Not in a million years will I have imagined us meeting this way. And it all boils down to what brought us together. "Did

you listen to everything I said? The presentation…"

The mischievous twinkle in his eyes confirms he had only been playing along. I know him enough to know that he despises meetings like this, he lived for the action part, so he'd said.

"Manir…" I say in frustration, but a big smile spreads across my face. "I still can't believe this. I really want to run to you and hug you… But this space," my hands go up, "everyone will be on my matter before I complete that act."

"It's fine." He sighs. "So long as you promise to do it when we meet outside work settings."

Are you always so in control? Why can't you express joy at finally meeting me in person too?

"You bet I would." I give him a once-over, the knowledge that I've been friends with him all these years, and never knew he was… him, plagues me. "I can't believe you're the same person who won't attend your monthly family meetings."

He sits upright at this. "Where did you hear that?"

I shrug. At least that got a reaction from him. "Architect Wole and I do chat, you know…"

He scoffs.

"Yeah… Prior to this meeting, he continuously badgered me with his love-hate relationship with you." When I was helping with the slide, he had gone on and on about *Oladele* doing his own thing and not engaging him enough.

"He misses me," he says, looking smug, so sure of himself. "I need to leave soon. Got a meeting for ten."

It is fascinating that I finally meet Manir, and I can't do anything but sit in a chair, pretending to hold a civil conversation when what I want to do is hug him, laugh and reminisce about the history of our friendship.

I hold his gaze and this time around, the silence in the room is calming, disturbed only by the buzzing hum of the air conditioner and periodic click of shoes from outside.

The universe is funny. Granting his wish of meeting up, just like that. After all our attempts at seeing face to face, we finally meet on one of my most awful days as an employee in his uncle's company. I don't know who would love the gist more; Zena or Chiluba.

Breaking eye contact, I flip through the document without aim. What am I doing? *Confront the elephant in the room girl!*

"Um..." I start, breaking the silence. "Where do we go from here?" My gaze settling on him. *Are we still meeting today? Is it all still talk?*

He looks like he has a lot to say.

'What do you think about ditching work, to go on a date and catch up? Talk about nothing and everything.'

He doesn't say that.

I am taking back my initial misgiving of him being a disrespectful bore. On chats, he is lively, conversational. And maybe he was only trying to figure out who I was hence why he was on his phone earlier. I want to meet the person behind this stoic mask. Not the one who poses for magazines, not Oladele Dosu-Andrews, but Manir. My mighty man... the one I know and call bestie.

Do you know I consider you to be my bestie? A laugh almost escapes me at the absurdity of everything, but his voice brings me to the present.

"What if I give you a breakdown of all Architect Wole needs to know?" He leans back, crossing his ankles. "Would you allow me pick you up after work today? For... dinner... so we can catch up."

Close to what I had imagined. Almost... I pick a pen, playing with it as I consider his proposal.

"I won't tell on you..." He raises both eyebrows. *Hmm... Playful... This is new*. He is acting like the man I chat with.

"That's blackmail and you know it." Placing the tip of my pen on my lips thoughtfully.

"You know you want to." His voice, deep, provocative.

So sure of himself. My thighs clench of their own accord at what his words and voice were insinuating.

I thought we were done with my body responding to him. Argh! What a traitorous body.

"Maybe..." I smile... drumming the pen on the table.

"I didn't throw a fit when someone walked in seven minutes late."

"Okay, you win. But first, we must go through those documents one last time. I know you need to get out of here soon, but please indulge me."

Uncrossing his legs, he leans in, both elbows on the table, like he has all the time in the world. "Go on."

OceanofPDF.com

SIX

PROOF OF FUNDS

Manir

I don't think Eric is the one for you. It's best you call it quits. My candid opinion.

I'M OUTSIDE. TAKE YOUR TIME. **I** type, then hit send.

Dropping my phone in the car's cup holder, I sigh, leaning back on the leather seat. My thought flickers through the meetings I sat on today before settling on my first meeting. Not the meeting, the lady from the meeting. Nothing on earth prepared me for a meeting with Queen Zo. The lady who haunted every other meeting.

My initial reaction had been one of doubt when I spotted the lady in grey body-hugging gown outside the conference room. When my head put two and two together, everything in my head—the purpose of the meeting, my irritation at her arriving late—everything disappeared. In its place, a new purpose formed—mine.

Couldn't help but stare as she walked in, looking professional and sexy all at once. For her sake and the sake of her job, I resisted the urge to shove all the contents on the table, take her right there and then, and have her apologizing into my lips. Would have killed two birds with one stone—fulfil her sexual fantasies and grant myself release. I laughed it off in my head, trying to make light of it.

The constant twitching of her legs under the table. The subtle movement of her thighs between her gown. I had seen them all.

With my dick at half-mast, I held on to the last shred of my willpower throughout the meeting. I should have pushed for us to meet a long time ago had I known our sexual chemistry would be this strong.

Queen Zo... I know what she wants, what she needs. Now I'm curious about the real-life Zoya. Is the real-life Zoya one and same with Queen Zo?

Our online chemistry is friendly, courteous, occasionally naughty, but this real-life chemistry? It's sizzling, ready to burn. BFF zone be damned. I am ready to cross the line. I just need her to say the word.

I don't feel like traveling anymore. I want to spend time with Queen Zo. Could even take her home tonight, but she lives with her *loving* father. That's impossible. If I can't get her to come home with me, I'll have to spend all the time I can with her.

I deserve happiness.

Good thing my latest project will see me often in Lagos. Now, meeting Queen Zo has me imagining all sorts of things that can go down in my Magodo apartment. Living full time in Lagos might not be an inconvenience after all.

We can hang out every other day. We'll go on tours—to places she wants to visit—and get to know each other better. I'm ready to explore our newfound physical friendship. I didn't want to meet her because I fear she would be like other girls. And although I had promised myself to do so today, fate wasted no time putting us together.

She is... different. There's just something about her.

I pick up my phone to find multiple new messages. It's the one from Queen Zo I open. I'm so getting her phone number today. Enough of the social media communication.

6:48 PM
Queen Zo: Where are you parked?

6:52 PM
Queen Zo: Hello?

6:53 PM
Mighty Man: My hazard lights are on.

Queen Zo: Oh sweet.

The rapping sound on my window indicates her presence. I unlock the door and she slides in. A light fruity feminine scent envelopes the surrounding space, filling it with renewed energy.

"Hey stranger," she says, getting comfortable on the seat, dropping her bag by her feet.

The bright glow of her smile eases weights on my shoulder I didn't know I had. She is wonderful therapy, online and now in person. Now I know the reason why she is different.

I need to be around you often.

Giving her a once over, I grin. "Hi yourself."

She pouts.

Oh boy, am I glad she is free around me. No forming, just acting natural, like we do this every other day—me picking her from work.

"I can't believe we are seeing in flesh, just like that." She starts as she pulls on the seat belt. "When I googled your full name today, I was like, why didn't I know you were the one I was chatting with all along? Then it got me

wondering if I truly knew you." Her honest brown eyes hold mine in place as her words sink in.

"I see..." is all I can offer.

Taking her glance off me, she attempts to buckle herself in, but fails, due to obvious reasons. She pauses in her struggle to get the seat belt on, her face to me. "Do I know you?" Then continues with the seat belt without waiting for an answer.

Maybe I should help her.

"Because I have been open with you." The clicking sound of metal assures me she has gotten the task done. "Overly open with you and I hope you have been too." Staring forward, she blows air from her mouth, before turning to me.

I shrug in response. "You know all there is to know about me."

Her eyes meet mine and the beating of my heart turns erratic. She must have some spiritual powers I'm unaware of.

"Are you sure?" her voice, warm enough to melt butter. "Hmm?"

I nod my head, a wry smile in place, then face forward, avoiding her questioning gaze. There's a lot about me she needs to know, but now is not the best time. Would most likely scare her off. We're still getting to know each other. "You know the important things." My solemn gaze returns to her.

She seems satisfied with my answer, but there's still traces of doubt written on her face. I'm expecting her to hound me with questions later. That's something I've gotten used to in our chats, but now that I've seen her in person, we'll just have to see how it goes.

"Ready to go? Should I adjust the seat?"

"Um..." She fidgets, trying to locate the button that controls the position of the seat. "Yes please..." she sighs, accepting defeat.

Unstrapping my seat belt, I stretch over to adjust the seat. A faint fruity scent hits my nostrils as I come in close contact with her.

Did she spray herself before stepping out of the building? Had she wanted to look pretty for me? The thought that she might have spent an extra minute in the bathroom excites and freaks me out simultaneously. Was it just her being her or was it for me?

In this position, it is easy for me to turn my face, dip it into those glorious mounds just inches away, that made her take her precious time with buckling in. With all her attempts, the belt does a great job of making each mound somewhat independent.

Inhale Manir.

"More?" I ask.

"Hmm..."

"More?"

"Yes, yes. There," she stretches her legs. "Perfect."

My brain can't remove images of us doing something else with similar sounds and questions fast enough. With all my experience and women I have met, I am yet to meet a lady who will make my head turn like this. I mean, she is doing it without trying. What if she tried? I'll be a goner.

Focus... focus.

"Oh... the button was just by this corner?" She swallows, eyes looking everywhere but mine.

Oh... you felt that too?

I move back to my position, buckling myself in. "Yeah. I got the car because they promised ease of use."

The corners of her mouth turn up as she mocks me with her eyes. "Show off."

"It's because you don't have a car." I tease.

"I'll get one soon."

"That's the first time you'll say that. What changed your mind? Tired of driving daddy's car?"

"Every morning I wake up and spend hours in Lagos' traffic. This morning was worse." She leans into the headrest, eyes closed.

"Hmm." Encouraging her to continue.

"The whole fuel scarcity fiasco has all drivers and bus conductors feeling like kings. Insulting people as they like. Driving like drunks and—hmm..." She turns a tired gaze to me. "I just want to go home. I've had a long day."

Smiling back at her, I rev up the engine. "Your wish is my command."

I ease the car into the road, and we immediately join the rush hour traffic. I've ceased to make sense of Lagos traffic and the timings. One would expect traffic to be less congested at 6 PM, but no, it's as though everyone just left work.

"I can't believe I'm in the same car with you," she says.

For a split second, I want to believe she is star-struck, but I know the Queen Zo I've been chatting with for years—she rarely ever gushes. Is what the online Queen Zo thinks herself to be, real?

Raising a finger, she explains further. "Before you think it's 'cause of what I'm finding out about you... it's actually because I never thought..."

Her words fade out the moment her hand briefly touches my thigh. Blood rushes from every corner of my body to that spot. *Oh boy, it's too soon for this.*

"You too?" she asks.

What did she say? Since she had been talking about our chanced meeting, I say the first thing that comes to mind. "I never imagined you would be like this in reality. Queen Zo..."

She frowns. "Like this?"

"Like your chats... playful, curious, sarcastic, lively." I point out.

She grins widely. "I'm not... playful. But sarcastic, yes. Lively, hmm... depends on where I'm at and who I'm with." Cocking her head to the side, I feel her eyes on me. "No more Queen Zo. My name is Zoya. We've met in person. That should count."

I like her eyes on me. And she is bossy... I like that too.

"Nice to meet you Zoya. I'm Oladele to the public, but close pals call me Manir or Manny."

With a quick, ironic smile, she asks, "Which am I?"

"We'll have to find out."

"Oh… But you're travelling soon. There's no time to find out in person. Are you trying to say our years of friendship means nothing?"

"I'm not saying that. Besides, I have a new project that'll see me often in Lagos. I'll be staying at my apartment in Magodo. That's the closest I could get to Anthony. Anthony, that's your area, right?"

Her eyes pop in surprise. "You are joking."

"Dead serious. I have a place at Magodo, acquired it about two years ago." It was strategic. Been wanting to meet her in person for the longest but develop cold feet every time because I don't want to ruin what we have.

"Oh…"

"Yeah. And my trip to Dubai—I'll be a panelist at a conference—won't be for more than a week. Let's look at the bright side."

"Hmm…"

"When I return to Lag, I'll really love to spend more time with you in person. And please call me whatever you like."

"Mighty man…" she drawls, and a short but infectious laugh follows.

I grin. "I think I like that one best."

"It's Manir for me. But let's see how this goes."

Let's see how this goes? We're going all the way Zo. I smirk as the light turns green. "Calm down. I know you are thrilled to have me around."

"Me? No."

"Thrilled."

She shakes her head, dumbfounded. "It would take a while getting used to having you around." Sucking air between her teeth.

I understand how she feels, but I'm positive it will be fun here in Lag.

"How has your day been?"

"My day?" I scoff. "You really want to know?"

"I'm asking..."

Turning into a street, I indulge her. "It started off annoy—"

"But I apologized..." she says in a new and coaxing voice, completely different from the authoritative one she had used on me at work.

"Relax. I'm not pointing fingers." I chance a glance at her as I artfully drive through the crazy Lagos after-work traffic, and she has a mischievous smile on. "It started off annoying, then became exceptional. And before you ask, good exceptional."

She snickers, and it lights up the dark places in my life.

"And yours?"

"It started off shitty I swear, but along came you. Remember Madam Nelly? I almost..." She gestures with her arms, animatedly sharing how her day went.

This is real. Queen Zo and I—Zoya and I—I mean, are having a conversation about our day and it's not via chat, but in person.

Four years of social media friendship. It was worth the time and effort. Meeting her, bonding, clicking like this. If we had met earlier, before I got to know how her brain worked, I probably wouldn't give us the chance to be introduced, but now, in this crazy Lagos traffic, I'm glad we've had this rapport going for the longest.

As I drive, exchanging memories with Zoya, some past promises and dares come to mind. I'm more than enthusiastic about following through with them.

OceanofPDF.com

SEVEN

ESCROW HOLDER

Manir

I want a real one.

AFTER DRIVING FOR OVER AN HOUR through Lagos traffic, we arrive her father's house with her direction, Google maps and the help of bus drivers.

Lagos is one city that has many shortcuts and the fastest way to beat traffic and shame Google maps is to figure out who the smart bus driver is and tail them. My driver, Ìgè, had mentioned he had to be swift about it—not to let the car get too close or far off—so as not to get lost.

Zoya's neighborhood is about twenty-five-minute drive to my Magodo apartment, but I doubt it will take me that exact time to get there on a day that's not Sunday. Lagos has the power to triple the time it will take to travel one mile.

"You know you owe me something, right?"

The thought of getting what she owes me under the cloak of darkness, right before her father's house, excites a debauched part of my brain. Although she had let it slip earlier that her dad was working longer hours because of his current project and her sister was at her Place of Primary Assignment, we don't have to go inside the house for her to pay what she owed me… more like what she owes us.

"Nah. Not in this life." Batting her lashes, she makes to open the door.

Not so fast.

I hit a button—*click, click*—and the uniform sound of the central lock hints at her with what I have done.

She turns slowly to me, eyes, wide in bewilderment. "Manir? Are you kidding me?"

I smirk, imitating her. "Nah. Not in this life."

She cocks her head to the side, furrowing her brows, a smile threatening to break free. "I don't sound like that."

I can get used to her cocking her head to the side when she wants to make a point. It makes her look… innocent. Almost childish.

"I really didn't want to hold you to it, but you left me with no choice."

"How?" She leans on the door, as if trying to get away from me, the big bad wolf.

Taking my hands off the steering wheel, I turn to face her. The dim orange light from the streetlamp creates shapes with different shades on her face, like an origami. Complete innocence, that's the picture it was going for. Oh, but the things she wanted to do. The things she had told me she'd done.

She lets out a frustrated sigh. "Manir, just because I sent you a kissing smiley, and you said you wanted a real one and I said when we ever meet in person you can kiss me all you want doesn't mean I meant it."

"I believe you're a woman of your word."

"Gaslighting doesn't look good on you."

"Hmm…" Gaslighting wasn't what I was going for. "But you are not leaving until we get what you promised. It will be unfair to us."

I roll my shoulders like a boxer getting ready for a fight, hoping she concedes, and I get a taste of her lips. Just for keepsakes. Yeah… and to set boundaries. *More like mess up our burgeoning relationship,* but I'm not one to wait and wonder what it will be like kissing her. Yeah, I delayed meeting her in person. But that's all in the past.

"Manir…" That is the sound of someone who wants to do something they like but didn't want to be caught doing it or liking it.

I am here to help you fulfil your wild imagination.

Watching her bite her lips, while she contemplates the dare, it crosses my mind that she is the same lady who had described how she gave her first blow job without throwing up at nineteen. She's still a virgin, having not had penetrative sex, but I know some things she has done and some she wishes to do. Against my better judgement, I believe it's best we get this over and done with than have it hanging over our heads.

"We've got all night, Zo. A promise is—"

She sits up. "You need to prepare for your flight."

"You are not my assistant. Besides, I have that covered."

"Manir… We just met and—"

"I'm not asking you to have sex with me."

She rolls her eyes at that, leaning back on the door, her lips in a pout, moving left and right, contemplating.

The sideways motion of her lips makes me want to run my tongue over that cupid bow, end the stalling, take what she promised.

I had intended it to be a simple mouth-pecking kiss, but with this effort I'm putting in to cajole her, it might end up being a full-blown make-out session. Maybe we might like it more than we know.

I don't mind the idea of having sex too, but Zoya is more than a hasty romp between the sheets. She's wife material for someone. Ticks all the spots

and… I know she's more than a hasty romp between the sheets.

"I'm only asking for a simple kiss. I can remember another time where you said Christians should greet their *brothers* with *holy* kisses."

Her eyes go round like saucers. "That wasn't me!"

I surprise myself with a distinctly inane laugh. "I was reporting an argument with a friend. And it was a joke."

She is good for my soul. So easy to tease.

"It's just a kiss." I might have to stop this and let her go, but her eyes and body language are saying something different. "A simple kiss—"

"What if I was just teasing you all along?"

"Truth or dare?"

We play it whenever we're bored from listing our daily routine or answering how was your day. In the early stages of our friendship, it helped us get to know each other better.

"Truth."

Opting for the easy way out. "Chicken." Two can play the game. "Have you ever thought of kissing me? Now or in the past."

A sharp intake of breath and a glare is her response, but I am not backing down.

"Yes or no, Queen Zo?"

She exhales loudly and swallows. "Yes. Your point?"

"I'm not so sorry I had to do that, but I wanted to prove to you and myself that you've been sincere with me about your… disclosures."

Unbuckling my belt, I lean towards her, whispering, "It's *just* a kiss between two longtime friends."

Closing her eyes, she murmurs, "Okay, okay. It's *just* a kiss." Then puckers her lips.

If only she knew I have been thinking of this moment since I realized the naïve but sexy lady who was ensuring she kept our meeting professional and

neutral was Queen Zo.

Smiling, I take in her beauty. My eyes trace her delicate features; sharp nose she once told me she was self-conscious of, thick black eyelashes she's proud of. I can't wait to find the patch of hair she had mistakenly cut off while loosening her braids some months back. It had led her to cut her hair in Anita Baker's hair style.

"Hurry up, Manir. I have never kissed a stranger before. I want to—"

She freezes when my lips touch hers. Warm breath fans my face and I inhale deeply. I do nothing—I don't bring out my tongue to touch her lips like I am dying to, neither do I put my arms around her. We remain this way until I feel her tongue graze my lips. In a flash, I cup her face, deepen the kiss, then withdraw back to my space.

My heart… It's beating like a warrior's drum. I can't control my breath. This has happened before. A long time ago.

Oh boy.

I blink.

Zoya is like a sister to me. I am the big brother she never had. But big brothers do not think of tongue kissing their sisters, neither do they react to them sexually. I've messed with the balance of our relationship.

I need to apologize. Get things back to normal.

She makes a sound from her side of the car, and I'm on the verge of apologizing.

Turning to do so, I see a glint in her eyes and a curve on her lips. She's chuckling! Covering her mouth while at it. I must have looked silly staring off like that. Did she notice?

Adjusting myself to conceal my growing erection, I give her a tight smile.

"For one second," she begins when her laughing fit ends, "I thought I'd have to teach you to kiss."

"You…" Scoffing, I shake my head, hitting the central lock button. She's still got some leftover smile.

Oh boy, what have I done to us? My bearing is everywhere. I need to understand what's happening.

"Who knows? You might have been joking about your many conquests," she says, opening the door. "Thanks for the ride. And um… have a safe flight?" She has one leg out of the car already.

"Thank you. Give me your phone, please."

"What for?"

"Trust me." With a puzzled expression, she reluctantly hands me her unlocked phone and I dial my number.

"Oh," she gasps when she hears my phone ring.

"We will see when I return?" It's more of a statement than a question.

"Definitely." She winks as she gets out of the car.

"Have a great night." *You were chuckling yeah?* I couldn't resist adding, "And say hi to Eric."

"Get out!" She slams the door shut.

Grinning, I watch as she walks to the gate and presses the bell. A security guard appears with a fond smile, unlocks the gate, and before she enters, she spares me an amusing sidelong glance.

We're going all the way Zo.

Zoya had once said she could not fathom how people with partners kiss, make out, or have sex with other people. I might be ready to show her the way. Just taking my big brother duties serious.

OceanofPDF.com

EIGHT

JEEZ. CLADDING.

Zoya

I can't work with him when I return.

SHIT. SHIT. SHIT.

My bag lands with a thud on the floor before I fall face down on my laid bed.

What was that? Why did I go through with that challenge? Why is he way better than my imagination? He smells so... good and now he's just few minutes away. *But that is when he is in Lagos*. So out of my league too. I punch my bed twice, in frustration.

Breathe. Breathe…

Stopping my actions, I count one to ten to understand what exactly I am feeling. Which emotion is taking the forefront in my head? Excitement? Intrigue? Shame? Curiosity? Ugh.

I can't nail it down.

Kissing a total stranger without thinking of Eric was just so… Immoral. Jeez… I didn't want the kiss to end. What is becoming of me? Although Manir mentioned it before the kiss, I didn't think about it until he gloated. *And say hi to Eric.*

Tscheww.

Nonsense. It was just a kiss. A simple childish kiss. Manir is not a total stranger. I know more about him than all his girlfriends put together. Him asking the boyfriend question was a low blow.

Whew.

I am at fault too. Telling my business to a random stranger for years. I never thought I'll ever meet him in person. With him travelling all over the place.

Manir…

Manir knows the origin of my relationship with Eric. Of course, since he knows the origin, he was also there when I complain about how tiring the relationship was becoming. He even encouraged me to break it up multiple times.

Biting my bottom lip, I remember the night I sent him a message about two months ago.

8:13 PM
Queen Zo: Eric is a useless excuse for a boyfriend.

8:19 PM
Mighty Man: I hope all is well.

8:21 PM
Queen Zo: All will be well when I find it in me to break up with him already.

Mighty Man: What happened this time?

8:23 PM
Queen Zo: Nothing out of the ordinary.

Just me thinking in this traffic as I watch a lady on a call, complaining to her friend about her boyfriend.

8:24 PM
Mighty Man: Lol. Transferred aggression?

8:26 PM
Queen Zo: Maybe? It's just… in the past three days, I am yet to hear from him. And when I think of it, I do all the calling, caring, and listening. He never for once tries to reverse it or take the lead.

8:28 PM
Mighty Man: So, what do you want to do?

When I had imagined a relationship before Eric, it was one in which the other party cannot live without the other. I think I am old-fashioned, but I want that kind of love—waking up to calls and messages from the other party and all the mushy things that come in between. With my hectic work schedule, and vow of chastity before marriage, I guess Eric… he's not cut out for that.

Stretching to get my phone from my bag, I pull it out, then turn, facing the ceiling. The thought of preparing dinner crosses my mind, but I am way too elated to consume anything tonight.

Flipping through my social media apps, I find nothing from Eric. Does that make me feel better or worse? Hmm. Mixed feelings. However… there's an Instagram notification from Chiluba. She tagged me in a message with a cute couple and wrote #relationshipgoals.

I should check up on Eric. Maybe his phone fell, the screen is cracked, and can't dial my number. Or he's just waiting for me to call him… as usual. I dial Chiluba's number instead.

"Oh… Manir." I grin, kicking my legs in excitement. I just want to tell someone that I met the man of my imagination, and he is one of the coolest people I have ever met in person!

Chiluba's cheerful voice comes through on the fifth ring. "Hey babes, what's up?"

Indistinct voices and humming sewing machines serve as Chiluba's background noise.

Chiluba is the perfect friend-turn-sister for my baby sister, Zena. I have long given up on contesting to be the perfect sister. I will never win in Zena's book because I never contested in a beauty pageant where I won Miss Amity, nor am I a fashion queen or entrepreneur. In summary, I am a constant reminder of a career we both at one point disliked.

Zena enjoys my relationship with Chiluba more than I do. They are constantly taking selfies when we hang out. Chiluba always has one design from her collections to gift Zena so she can... *kill them* in school. Watching both together, they fit perfectly.

Weird thing is they are always at each other's throats about who is a better friend to me. It is so bad that Zena had one day taken a selfie with me and when uploading it, tagged Chiluba then added the hashtags: #sister4life #mylove #lovesmemost. This doesn't hold though when Chiluba comes bearing gifts. I think they just find joy in taunting each other.

"I'm good. Just got in from work. Still at work?"

"Yes oh. I'm thinking of not paying these people this month. It is stressful getting my staff to finish a project they started these days. Imagine the family selling *aso ebi* to others not being able to wear their own *aso ebi* for their event."

Everyone and their problems. Chiluba, CEO of 34 Threads, made the 25 under 25 CEO list recently, and since then she has gotten more visibility than the beauty pageantry brought her at nineteen. Her designs are spectacular, so is her keenness for detail and her fashion sense... She didn't need models to promote her fashion line but uses them anyway.

"You'll figure it out."

"Ehen..."

"You thrive in bringing order to chaos, enjoy your kingdom. I actually called to gist you about my day."

"What happened to it?" She sounds like she is biting into something. "Give me a moment... Anita, please whip this one."

I envision Chiluba adjusting a tape rule on her neck, pins in her mouth, handing the material with her to someone else.

"Sorry about that. *Oya,* continue."

"Remember that guy I'm always chatting with?" There is a thoughtful silence from Chiluba's end.

"Yeah... Your imaginary boyfriend."

"Duh..." I sit up, deciding its best I eat something light.

"What happened to him?"

"He's no longer imaginary. I met him today!"

"Okay? And..."

That wasn't exciting? I roll my eyes, making my way to the kitchen. Why did I bother calling her? She's making the whole thing sound less exciting. And the kiss? My ears burn.

Oh no. I'm not thinking about that right now.

"Um... He's working with Mercury."

"Your company? He just got a job?"

"No."

"He has been working with you and you didn't know?"

"Okay, okay." I find a dish that will work for my late-night dinner. "Not really working with my company, his company is part of Reporium Group but that's not it, he has a project my boss is working on."

"Hmm. How come you are only just finding out today?"

Good question. "Well... we have different projects and portfolios. I don't walk around looking for him. And... his public name is different."

"Zoya? Is that the gist?"

This is not the response I was envisioning.

Squeezing my eyes shut, I can feel my face getting hot. She's going to want to hear the whole gist after this. "His real name is Oladele Dosu-Andrews..." I rush the remaining part of the gist. "... and we kissed."

"Hey!" Chiluba cackles, which has me smiling. "Not you Anita." I guess she scared the poor girl. "Zo! Zo!" Chiluba can be extra sometimes.

"Stop being dramatic Luba."

"No... Don't dodge the drama." She cackles again. "You mean it? You met a random stranger and kissed him today?" She clicks her tongue. "What have you been watching... and reading?"

"Excuse me," I grin, "the only things I've been reading are work related." I take a portion from the jollof rice I made over the weekend and place it in the microwave. "And he is not a complete stranger."

Is he?

Chiluba scoffs. "I thought I was the bad *geh*. You have a boyfriend, remember?" As if on second thought, she adds, "Even though I don't like him."

It is high time I end the childish nonsense I call a relationship. Let everyone know I am single.

"It was just a kiss. An old dare—"

"That's how it starts. You liked it. Ah... Zoya, you have enter street..."

I liked it? Did I really? Was I under playing everything when I laughed at him after the kiss?

Chiluba is speaking, but I can't hear her clearly. "You said?"

"You said his real name is different. Has he been lying to you?"

"By omission... yes."

"What's his name again?"

"Oladele M. Dosu-Andrews."

"Same person as the luxury real estate guy?"

"Yep. The same. He's doing something for the masses now." I mutter the last sentence under my breath.

"You've been friends with a big fish!" Only Chiluba will put it like that. "Do you like him?"

Taking out the jollof rice from the microwave, I struggle to find the right words to describe my feelings.

"Zoya?"

"Huh?"

"Still with me?"

"Yeah."

"Did he look good in person?"

I sigh, shoving a spoonful of jollof rice into my mouth. "Even better." I giggle, recalling how my traitorous body reacted to him during the meeting.

"Hmm. Aunty Zo!"

"No. It's not like that. I like him. He's a great guy, but I know low key, he is a fuckboy." And maybe a Yoruba demon, considering the way I'm feeling now.

"Aren't they all? How did you know he is the one you've been chatting with? Like for sure."

"Luba, he sent me live messages. It can't get *realer* than that."

"Awwn, cute love story." Chiluba is such a romantic but hides it so well. "You better take your head out of the clouds."

I retract that. She's not a romantic.

"You'll give me full gist when we see on Sunday. Don't think this is all."

I smile, shaking my head at how predictable she can be.

"I'm happy you got to meet him, but first confirm he is not married. Then bring him to me for final vetting. On to important business, how far your

uncle and Silhouette introduction?"

Not again. My heart pounds at an abnormal rate with cold icy fingers brushing my spine—a familiar feeling that comes whenever Chiluba talks about exploring something different in her entrepreneurial journey. It is not jealousy, just a feeling that I should clamor for more in life. Like I am not doing enough. Like I don't want enough; wanting to be an architect like dad, starting my business, falling in love, getting married and having kids, making sure everyone is happy.

"The rate at which you start and run businesses," I begin in a light tone, "makes me feel like I am not serious with my life."

"Haba. Zo! You're the one enjoying. You're not thinking of paying employees at the end of the month, nor are you feeling like a failure for trying too many ventures and barely breaking even."

"Story. All this is investment. When you start cashing out, it will look like you did blood money." Letting out a lazy smile, I continue, "Sincerely speaking, I feel like I have all the tools to be a successful entrepreneur and I am wasting them—"

Chiluba spares a short ironic laugh. "You've worked with big agencies abroad, gotten featured in articles, at this speed, you're onto something big. Ignore this entrepreneurial farce for now oh. If only you know how many times a day I wish I had a job like yours that's predictable."

Predictable? My job involves hours spent planning, designing, presenting, and even supervising—taking on the workload of senior executives—and in the end paid stipends. Then returning home to continue studying to prove to some old grumpy architects that I know what I do. I fight to maintain a healthy work-life balance. The only predictable thing is the salary.

Life... "For my uncle, let's look at late February. He's not in the country yet."

"Hmm..."

Uncle George is my uncle-in-law. A European who married my late aunt and built his life here. "He is visiting family."

"February it is. How is Zena?"

We discuss Zena, work, and current happenings in the entertainment industry before I hang up.

Taking the last spoonful of my meal, I clean the dish, then head to the bathroom. After carrying out my nightly ritual, I lay in bed, ready to sleep but my phone vibrates with a message.

10:02 PM
Mighty Man: Would have called, but it's noisy here.

10:03 PM
Queen Zo: Out clubbing?

10:03 PM
Mighty Man: At a bar with business partners.
Last minute plan.

10:04 PM
Queen Zo: Oh.

Manir: It was great seeing you today.

Zoya: Same here.

Manir: I return next week. See you then?

10:05 PM
Zoya: You bet.

OceanofPDF.com

NINE

INSPECTION OFFICERS

Manir

Saving their partner's name with something like cupcake, my heart, my love. It's just not my thing.

THE NIGHT I MET QUEEN ZO, I couldn't sleep. Forgot I had invited a surly Tiwa over, had to leave her at home to hang out with the boys. All I wanted was to remind myself Zoya was real… That kiss. It was nothing compared to what I had imagined when we were in the conference room, but it is enough to make me know… It isn't just the kiss, our rapport too. Queen Zo is real and even better in person than online. Calling hours after bidding her goodnight crossed my mind, but I spent the energy and enthusiasm going through legal documents. I can spend my time daydreaming or move my ass if I want to see her again.

Although it's less than a week since we saw, I'm itching to get out of here. Should I be concerned?

I'm lodged in a suite with a living space that faces the glamorous streets of Dubai, while the bedroom overlooks the pool area. My first morning here, I took a picture of the rising golden sun, sent it to Zoya, inviting her to come out. But knowing she has a full-time job and will not indulge me on a whim, I tell her we can plan and make it a reality soon.

My phone buzzes and I peep to find a ping from her. She was working from a site today, spent little time in the office and didn't communicate much with me. I've been sensing some sort of withdrawal from her end. Is it because we have met in person?

11:03 PM
Queen Zo: Did you see the news? Kano bombings?
Manny: I did. Call you in a minute.

"These people are getting out of hand. Why choose violence?" We've been texting for years and to some degree, I know her, but hearing the emotion behind her concerns takes the connection we have to another level of real.

She continues, her voice low and hesitant, "What do they want? For real, what do they want?"

If I had an answer for these types of questions—what do you want—I'll be millions richer. But one thing I know I want right now is spending time with her.

She sighs deeply, "The pawns don't know why they're fighting."

"It's something we might not understand for the next few years, but I'm sure they will be hunted down soon. It's..." I hesitate, "it's life's way of keeping balance—good and evil—"

She scoffs. "The fight between good and evil. Good and bad. These days, I think evil is prevailing more. Don't you think?"

What would the world be like if there was no evil at all? A wry, humorless smile escapes me. "I'll leave God to answer that. How are you?"

"I'm good. I'm simply processing... this depressing news."

It is depressing. Over hundred people killed in a single day with coordinated bombings and shootings, shortly after a terrorist group told Christians to leave northern Nigeria.

A short bitter laugh comes from her end. "What if they try that in Lagos?"

"They'll never."

"I know. But..." She blows air into the phone. "People are dead. No one is being held responsible for that."

"There are some battles we fight and some we sit out."

"Yeah..."

"Remember when you asked if it was sensible to join the occupy Nigeria protest?"

"Mm hmm. You said it was totally sensible."

Atta girl. "And I believe I was right."

She snorts. "Your point?"

"This one..."

"Yes?"

"We sit this one out."

"Hmm..."

"Trust me." Silence comes from her end which says a lot... and nothing.

She eventually sighs.

Did she accept my advice? She'll try to stop worrying? "And..." I press, "I need you to do me a favor."

"What's that?"

Curious, are you? "Think of our next meeting instead."

Her sweet and most satisfying laugh warms me up inside. Better. *I prefer you this way, happy, without a care in the world.*

At this point, I wish we are together, not miles or hours apart. Once I return to Lag, I'm not slowing down. Just one problem. Eric. What hold does

he have on her? Four out of five times we've talked about him, she complains, yet chooses to stay put.

"Got a date for next week?" Zoya's voice jars me to the present. "I'm asking so I can schedule my calendar."

I really want to see her, but... "Not yet. I'm not sure. Might spend a few extra days here." It's been a crazy week; from being a panelist at the conference, to meeting up with a longtime client who wants to buy properties here. Thinking I had it all under control, I showed them modern properties that should whoa them, but I guess they're stuck in another era. Now I must spend the rest of my week looking for something befitting, calling out favors, going on tours. Things are warming up and they look promising.

"Oh wow."

I caught it. The slight catch in her voice. I've not been avoiding her since I got here. All my spare time, I am calling her, but she would cancel saying she is busy via text and when I'm busy, she's calling back. We're yet to have a decent conversation since we last saw in person, and I'm now more than ever, excited to return to Lag so we can continue where we stopped.

"I'm sorry." *It's doesn't hurt you as much as it hurts me. I genuinely want to spend more time with you.* "I'll keep you updated with my movement."

There's a heavy silence on her end for a while. "Since we're not seeing soon —"

"It's not fixed." I rush to assure her. "Anything can happen. Just some loose ends I need to tie up and I'll be with you pronto." *Slow down… she has a man. She doesn't have expectations of you.*

"It's okay... I understand." Her overtly agreeable feminine voice puts me on the edge. "Let's live in the knowledge of what we know and have experienced."

"Hmm." What is confessor Zoya trying to say?

"I've been wanting to ask this..." she pauses, "What was your first thought when you confirmed it was me."

I'm sure she has been dying to ask the question. "I saw angels... singing hallelujah." She laughs before chiding me to be serious. "She is pretty. After

putting two and two—trying my luck by sending you messages. When I heard the second vibration of your phone, I knew I had hit jackpot." *You don't want to know the cave man idea that formed in my head after I found out you checked most of the boxes.* "Good Lord, she is the complete package and more."

"Why didn't you let me know immediately? Jeez, I felt so embarrassed."

I was still processing my good fortune. "There was no way to do it without being rude."

"Hmm."

"How was I supposed to do it? Hi Zoya, can you please stop spouting numbers, because it's me Mighty Man." Ready to take you out of this office setting to my cave so you can count how many kisses I'll be trailing down your lovely face, especially your nose. "I knew you were the one because the last picture you posted on Instagram, about seven months ago, the one with you dressed up for a site visit?" She nods slowly. "I memorized every bone structure on your face."

"It would have been hilarious." She laughs throatily. "Like you were a stalker or something."

Stalker? "Not me. I'm clean."

"Is that all?"

"Um?"

"Pretty? Complete package? What else?"

"Are you fishing for compliments?"

She clears her throat, but I can hear the smile in her voice when she says, "We just met… and we've said a lot of things… a lot about people we've met."

Ah… I see. My dates. I must have said a lot of things after them. "It was official, Zo. We were in the office."

Zoya tut-tuts before heaving a sigh. "Okay…" I envision her smiling as she asks, "What didn't you expect about me?"

To complete my vision, I go back in time, to when we were in the car, and she is placing a hand on my thigh as she asks the question.

Fuck.

My dick is at half-mast, again.

Returning my lecherous mind back to our discussion, *Was that a trick question? Some sort of shit test?* "I plead the fifth."

"No, you can't. Not in Zoya's chambers."

"Hmm... Zoya's chambers..."

"Take your mind out of the gutter." I laugh as she continues. Her mind must be in the gutter to know where mine is. "Answer the question sincerely. I won't use it against you. What didn't you expect?"

"I don't know." She had always been the lady I told a lot of things, checked out on social media and occasionally shared lewd jokes with. Never imagined meeting her in person without planning to. "Hmm... I assumed you were taller—"

"I'm five-seven." She chuckles. "I'm not that short."

What? "I'm just saying. You asked my sincere answers, and I'm sharing." I liked the height difference. Didn't notice it until I was leaving the office. Some girls love it.

"Hmm. How tall are you?" she asks.

"Six-two."

"You're not that tall." She hisses, drawing a smile from me.

"Hello? Compared to you, I'm a giant."

"Hmm."

I laugh. "I like the way you look. Doesn't change the fact that you're beautiful inside out."

"But?"

"But what?" Is she trying to put words in my mouth?

"I could hear a but. Like you were about to say, I like the way you look but..."

"You lack the right amount of adipose tissue in one specific area I keep in mind when choosing a partner." There. It's out in the open.

"Adipose what?" she asks in wonder.

"The fat on your bum. The adipose tissue there." She gasps, but I continue since she asked the question. "I like it. It's beautiful. I believe it's something sex or pregnancy can help with. You've got an hourglass shape."

"Jeez. So much information. Thanks for sharing."

There's a beat of silence between us. Have I said too much? I need to check myself. I hope I am not overtly excited about us. "And me? What did you like?"

"Your car…" she giggles, and I smile.

"Be serious, Zo." *I really want to know what you think*. It's not much of a big deal to me. Did I meet her expectations? I know she has seven deal breakers, qualities she looks for in a man.

"You don't stink."

"Zo…" I warn, bursting into laughter, remembering a day she said she developed the courage to ask a guy she had been admiring out, only to find out he had chronic body odor on their first date. Her head ached from the smell oozing from the guy, and she had to excuse herself halfway because she couldn't stand it.

"I have a sensitive nose," she says in that coaxing voice I'm coming to understand is her whining voice. "I have to be careful where I stick my nose."

"You should."

"Contrary to your online pictures, you look good in person."

"Thank you." Got it. I'm not photogenic.

"And… I liked your smile."

"Hmm." I think I made only three on her list. I'll have to worm my way into her world to show her I've got all seven and more.

"I'm sure this is not the first time someone is telling you that."

“I can’t recall.” Why am I thinking about worming my way into her world? She’s like a sister—it’s been a while I thought of her as that. She has a boyfriend—but she doesn’t like him. She’s not thinking about me this way—you don’t know for sure.

“What didn’t you like?” I blurt out before I think twice about it. “What didn’t you like about me?”

“You were cold? Arrogant? Rubbing off the wrong way. Is that a regular thing?”

Rubbing off the wrong way. I get it. It’s nothing new. People have told me worse things about myself, especially my loving family. Something I'm struggling to embrace about myself—my approach to life. In all our discussions, I’m yet to tell her this because I don’t know how she would take it. Although she is well-educated, she might not understand someone like me.

I’ll play it low, evade the real question. There will be time for explaining when our relationship goes past this phase. “Was just wondering how the lady I was cussing earlier was turning out to be my personal confessor, working in my uncle’s firm.”

“Jeez…” She tut-tuts again. There’s an ominous silence permeating the air. “Um…” she starts, “speaking of work, you know I am preparing for my qualification exams in March.”

“I will not forget that if I forget everything about you. You deserve not just a building with your name on it as the architect, but the opportunity to start your company.”

“Yes.”

There’s a silent beat on her end. I’m learning about her, how her mind works. Chatting differs from talking on the phone, differs from meeting in person.

“It's the next step for my career.”

“I'm tempted to speak to my uncle about it.”

“Don’t you dare—I’m sorry.” She rushes on. “That’s why I brought up the topic. I’m going at my pace.”

“Chill Zo.” Have I led her to believe I’m capable of doing something like that to her?

She sighs. “You know how important this is to me. Doing it on my own.”

I knew she was going to say that. She walks the talk. Her father is Michael Ainabe, a renowned architect, lecturer and role model. She was already *doing it on her own* by choosing not to work with his firm. Wanting to prove something. It’s crazy how she can't see herself making the similar mistakes her father made, but I guess it's a family thing.

“I understand. Got plans for tonight?”

“Plans? I’m going to bed. And you should be too.”

“I’ve got things to do.” Catch up on emails and review some listings.

“At one in the morning?”

“Almost one.” Welcome to my world Queen Zo. I should have taken sleep pills earlier but got engrossed with other activities. Now that I’m in the zone, best to make use of the energy. “Don’t worry about me or anything at all.”

“Hmm.”

“Do what Paul said to do instead of worrying.”

“Which is?”

“Pray.”

She smiles. “The way you move topics around. I’ll need to take a class or two.”

Great! I think I just confirmed four on her list.

OceanofPDF.com

TEN

FLOORPLAN

Zoya

How do people start a relationship within few weeks of breaking up with the love of their life?

"I HOPE THIS DOESN'T COME AS a shock to you, but I believe it's best we break up and start seeing other people." I pick my fries with steady fingers, my eyes on his clean-shaved jaw, gauging his reaction. His elbows are on the table, and he is rubbing his wrists.

Breaking up is demanding. I shouldn't have believed Chiluba when she said it'll be like taking a walk to the bus stop. I should have confirmed how long the walk would be because this already feels like ten miles with no end in sight. Jeez. His response is taking too long. There are tiny tingles running through my fingers and toes.

We had settled in our booth after ordering our meal, making comments about our individual trips to this Sweet Sensation outlet. I dipped my first fries in ketchup and couldn't hold back anymore. Why play it nice when I

want to break it off? I know this is what I should do—should have done a long time ago. Note to self: never delay a breakup.

The steadiness of my fingers surprises me as I continue with my fries. We are sitting in a booth at Sweet Sensation, a place Eric loves for their fried rice and chicken. It was my compensation for when telling him the news. Same reason I did it the week before valentine. It is high time I end the unfulfilling partnership I call a relationship. Let everyone know I am single.

"You met someone new?" his taut, hard voice sounds pretentious. *He is covering his hurt.* I never imagined him responding like this. For someone who had invested little in the way of emotions during the months we dated, his reaction is confusing.

"Eric, no… No." I stretch a hand to his, but he flinches, pulling away, taking his hands from view. He looks at the food before him, then back at me, unblinking. *What?!*

I don't count Manir as someone new. He has always been in the background. Way before I met you! You don't know him and… Well, meeting Manir in person made me realize I can make something beautiful with someone worth the hassle. Someone like Manir. Not like I am considering a relationship with someone who is like a brother to me. A brother I have been fantasizing about for days now.

He blinks and I sigh.

"Did I do anything wrong?"

I let out a huge breath. "No." Maybe that is the problem, but no.

"Then why don't we just continue?" His posture is stiff.

What have you done, Zo?

"We would find—"

"Eric, I don't want us to waste our time."

"Being with me is a waste of time?" His lips pinched together.

Oh, God… It's times like this I wish I was blasé. I know he cares about me, but he never calls, hardly chats, and we rarely hang out except I force him to. I

know I have a fault in the hanging out part because I'd rather hang out at home than go out, but he doesn't want to tempt his faith. Am I making sense?

Thing is, Eric and I were never in love. We never fooled ourselves we ever were. Initially, we enjoyed each other's company. We met at the airport last year, on my final return from UK. He introduced himself as a social entrepreneur, working in the financial industry. We clicked. He wooed me like no tomorrow, agreed to my 'no sex' terms and I thought I had won the lottery.

All was going fine until we began dating and I found out he was the type that can survive without hearing from his girlfriend. How? Why? I can't. I just can't. No matter how busy work is for me, I find time to communicate with those important to me. To check the trends on social media. To feel those around me.

But Eric... He is different. What I want, not exactly what I need. He has done nothing wrong, awful or cruel. He has only been himself. I got into the relationship because I believed him not being clingy—not being all about my business—will not affect my career, but now I know I want that attention and he is incapable of providing it.

Inhaling deeply, I explain. "I don't think we are compatible. No offense, but I have been miserable for the past months, and you never notice—" I raise a finger to stop him from speaking, then continue. "You never noticed this. I've got exams... Certifications... Work... and they're affecting me. I think it's best we break up and use whatever energy we have... focus on our careers and... businesses. Chase our dreams. Make money. Find someone new. Be happy. We are young Eric. We could cross paths again."

Cross paths again? I doubt it. The ocean is an enormous expanse of water with a variety of fish. In all this, I don't regret him being my boyfriend.

"Is this because I didn't keep my end of the bargain?"

I'm tempted to ask, *which one?* There are so many deals and bargains we've made over the course of our premature relationship that he's skipped. It was my responsibility to teach him how to be a romantic. Time for him to use

what he has learnt to get into another relationship. Mine with him was his third. "Part of it."

"I'm sorry Zoya. I'm not that type of guy. Me not calling you doesn't mean I'm talking to someone else."

"I know. It's not that."

He looks away, then back at me. "I never cheated on you. Or did anything bad. I don't know why you're doing this—"

"I'm-I'm. I'm not saying you did anything." It's me. Me... I kissed someone last month, I mutter beneath my breath. Jeez. I thought I was over that. This has nothing to do with Manir. Or the kiss. Or anything. I've just not had time to break things up. "We're just... incompatible."

"You're sure there's no one?"

I nod.

"And there's nothing we can do?"

I tut-tut. "Nothing." We've tried the bargains, those didn't work. Another lady might like the... freedom, the-the autonomy of not having someone over their shoulder but I want to be in a relationship where I feel the push and pull. "What I need from you—from a relationship—it will be selfish of me to insist you change who you are for my sake."

"But we are good together."

"Are we?"

He gives me an odd, unreadable glance which I don't back down from. This is for your sake. My sake. Our sanity. There's nothing going on in this relationship. It's stagnant. "You know..." I lean in, elbows resting on the table, "As friends, we were better than this. Once we started dating," I shrug, "we lost that spark."

"So... friendship. That's what you're proposing?"

"If you want it." Nodding slowly, I watch as he comes to a quick decision. He's got a bright future—his startup is getting funding and recognition. But I'll be foolish to stay back because of greed.

The corners of his eyes crinkle with a polite, vacant smile. "I can't imagine a world without you."

Breaking up is hard to do. My eyes hold his as a small smile of relief floods me. I didn't know I was all tensed. Was I expecting him to throw a fit of not letting go or to resume insulting me and my gender?

His initial expression when I told him we break up was, I am lost without you, why would you do this to me? But my speech seemed to have done it for us. I pray he finds someone compatible.

"Thank you," I say.

He nods, before looking down at his meal. A rocket scientist need not tell me he has lost his appetite. Me too. Although I feel light-headed for putting our relationship to an end, I don't feel like eating anymore. I want to call Man—no Chiluba, with the news.

"Um," I look up, at the sound of his voice, "if it's okay with you, I want to leave now."

Are you asking for my permission to leave? Oh God. Please let him find love soon. He's a good guy, just not for me. "Sure. Sure." I have a quick look around for anything I might be forgetting. "I'm set to go too."

When we step outside, under the friendly February sun, we wish each other well, and he stretches his arms for a hug. I sigh, walking into them.

"Promise to call me if you ever need my help?" He whispers in my ear.

Nodding, I smile, pulling out of the hug. *Lord, please don't let me ever need his help.* He was not there during our relationship, now he wants to be there afterward?

"And... I wanted to tell you I'll be moving to Port Harcourt for expansion but," he shrugs, squinting, "I guess... you surprised me."

I move my mouth to speak but no word comes out.

His lips tighten to a smile, nodding, "Take care Zoya."

Nodding, I tear my gaze from him, hastening to the car I borrowed from my dad.

OceanofPDF.com

ELEVEN

DUE DILIGENCE CONTINGENCY

Manir

You're hurting. Share these thoughts with him. He is your father. He should understand.

"YOU KNOW YOU'RE SUPPOSED TO COME for the fitting this weekend." Bucknor says the moment I accept the call.

Oh boy, I thought it was Zoya calling back as promised. Was tying my shoelace, getting ready for the gym when the call came in. I still sense Zoya's withdrawal, which confirms something is up, and she's not saying much. Can't force words out of her mouth, simply glad she's not cut me off completely. I intend to find out more, but I'm torn between reality and what I want.

"Manir?"

"Fitting?" I'm not the one getting married, but with all the appointments and stuff Bucknor keeps telling me his wife-to-be, Bose, wants us to get into, I might as well walk down the aisle with a bride. "I thought my tailor was speaking with yours."

Bucknor asked me to be his best man last year. For someone else, I wouldn't have thought about it. Just give them a straight no, not Bucknor. All Bucknor had to do was tell me where and when. His new enthusiasm to get married is a wake-up call—the few friends I have are moving off the single chart.

"Dude, it's not just about sending your measurement. They need to check if the suit fits proper."

"The wedding isn't until May, Bucknor. I will not add ten pounds overnight." Besides, most of my attires are couture and I don't go in for fittings for every shirt, traditional wear, or suit.

Bucknor scoffs. "I have told Bose that a thousand times, but she's adamant about her special day. I keep reminding her it's our wedding, not hers."

I laugh, hearing the frustration in his voice. From what he's said about Bose, she's a perfectionist. If she chooses to make anything hers, she will go the extra length to get it or make it better. That's what she has done in his life, their ecommerce business, and their relationship. "Manny, she's laying it on thick."

"You'll survive." Somewhere deep down, he loves her dominating him.

"Mm hmm. She won't walk down the aisle alone. Back to the fitting thing. Other groomsmen will be there, it's supposed to be some sort of bonding time before the wedding."

Is this what it takes to plan a wedding? Dress fittings, harassing friends to get in line? "I don't think I'll make it this weekend. But maybe next week?"

He sighs. "You're not sure."

"Don't worry, I got you."

"You guys—including Bose—you all are driving me nuts."

"Has Kien gone in for this fitting?"

"He hasn't." Bucknor hisses. "He's busy advising his old men in Bayelsa."

No, he's not. He's busy sleeping with any willing Lagos girl.

Kien is a mutual friend from college, an honorary special adviser to the governor of Bayelsa on Hospitality and Tourism. The type of friend you tolerate because you can't save them from themselves. Got married three years ago merely to look responsible, impregnates the lady every other year so he can continue sowing his wild oats.

I've got something to compensate Bucknor with. Not my best move but should make him feel better. "Kien is in Lagos. My place." Most likely with a woman who is not his wife.

"Ah... I'm giving him a call after this. You won't believe he told me he won't be in until next week."

Kien's political connections and the rottenness of the system keeps him afloat. I don't know which he loves more, fair-skinned women or sex. "So, we're even."

"Thanks man."

"I'll update my schedule for the fitting. Please send me the details."

"Will do. I know you manage your schedule well, but please fix nothing on my wedding date."

I give a short laugh. "It's still free. Need to wrap up things here. Got to return to Lagos as soon as possible." This Dubai trip is taking longer than expected.

"As soon as possible..."

"What's wrong?"

"No. No. What's happening that I don't know about?"

"Nothing." Zoya. I met Queen Zo.

"Guy... it's rare to hear you say something like that outside Nigeria. Return to Lagos as soon as possible, eh? Share the good news. Is that why Kien is at yours earlier? Deals?"

"Yes, a development project I'm working on with this client of mine." Since Bucknor is the one getting married, maybe he should know more. I'll need his

help to woo her. “And there’s this babe I’ve been chatting with for a while now. I’m exploring that option. Might need—”

“I knew it!” He releases a joyous rollicking laugh. “I knew something was up.”

“Stop making a big deal out of it. If she’s game, I might ask her out and probably get married on the same day as you.” It’s a joke but thinking about it, if Zoya and I still have something going on in the coming months, we could—

“Married?”

“It’s a joke.” One I’m willing to bring to existence.

“No offense. How long have you known this babe?”

Eyes closed, I rub the middle of my forehead, a flashing image of the brief kiss we had. “It's this girl I’ve been chatting with for over four years now. We met few weeks ago. I think she’s cool.”

“Hey… slow down, Mann. chatting with for four years? Naija babe?”

“Yeah…”

“Hmm… be careful o.”

“I can’t.” I grin. “She’s the one.” A deep unnatural silence ensues my proclamation causing my grin to fade. I know her inside out—that’s how I feel about her. Although she's not hundred percent what I’d imagined she’d be physically, we’re a perfect match.

“Does she know?”

Pressing my lips together in a slight grimace, I shake my head, but then remember we’re on a phone call. “Not yet.”

Another abrupt silence. It’s not something I should tell her when nothing is for sure. Get into a relationship, earn her trust, tell her about it, that’s how it should be. I’ve had time to think it through these past days and I suppose she can handle it better when we’ve earned each other’s trust.

“Mighty man!” Bucknor hails from his end.

However, my mind has gone down a dark path and is clawing its way back to the light.

"This is good news."

I nod, reassuring myself that I'm making the right decision.

"When is the wedding date?"

"Bucknor," I smile, the thought of legally binding myself with Zoya is spreading light further in my heart, "don't think because you're getting married everybody needs to get married pronto. Like I said, it's a joke."

"Joke or not, I'll be your best man."

"Chill dude. I've not asked her out yet."

"What are you waiting for?"

"She has a boyfriend."

"And so? *Na Husband?*"

"The way you're talking, like you'll be cool if Bose walks off with another man because you are yet to wed her."

"Dem no fi try am. I go treat their fuck up." Going all defensive and protective, about his fiancée while giving me silly advice. "Are you really considering marriage—dating? With your work, frequent travels, your mileage—"

Hmm. "There comes a time where a man has to settle down." According to uncle Wole.

"Ha. Mighty man! Will you offer some mileage points to Bose and I?"

"Bucknor..."

He laughs.

I smile. I doubt marriage will stop me from globe-trotting.

"I'm proud of you, Mann! You're killing the game, making big moves, getting the bag and the girl."

"She's still got a boyfriend."

"I know… I know… If you're serious about this relationship—"

"Dude, I'm serious." Zoya is the one.

"Then you've got your work cut out for you."

Enough of me and talk of relationships. Opening the door to my suite, I step into the hallway, making my way to the gym. "Guess which one of the guys called me lately?"

"Who?"

It's a guessing game, dude. *Never gets the game*, I snort. Instead of beating about the bush, I reveal at once. "Sanmi."

"He's not called since then?"

I shrug, stepping into the elevator. "Never. But surprisingly, dude called asking if he could buy me a drink."

"Which club?"

"That's not the point. Point is, he's so heartbroken, he reached out to me."

"The Yale girl?"

"Yeah."

Short story. Sanmi had a childhood sweetheart studying in Yale. Speaks so highly of her. Two Christmases ago, we all—a group of friends, their partners and some cousins of mine—spent time together. We got into a card game, and she said something offensive she had heard from my cousin to me. More like, wanted to confirm something she'd overheard. I ignored her but later spoke to Sanmi about cautioning his woman. He grew all defensive, swearing and cussing. Bringing the girl to question what I had said. It was demeaning. It would have come to blows if I had no control. After that, he completely ignored me—at gatherings, for business opportunities and more.

"They're done."

"Cause?"

"Cheating." Caught the said girl humping a guy in her apartment a week ago, regrets everything he had done for her. Sanmi obsession blinded him.

Anyone who stepped close enough could see she was fake, but all Sanmi could see was the smart young girl she was. Yes, she was smart, from a good home but she lacked character.

"By who?"

"Is there a reason you're slow this evening?"

Bucknor laughs. "I'm supposed to be sleeping, but I made a promise to catch up with the boys and the wedding after getting some."

"I don't want to know the details." Is he saying he just finished—no…?

"So… What are you going to do?"

"What options do I have?"

"Ignore the fool?"

Wish I could. "I've forgiven him. We'll have that drink when I'm back."

"You're a good friend."

I know I am. And it feels good hearing it from someone else.

****

11:03 PM
Manir: I'm in Lagos.
Got the last flight.

05:24 AM
Zoya: Welcome back ;D

OceanofPDF.com

TWELVE

OUT OF CONTEXT

Zoya

I have strange expectations when it comes to courtship.

MANIR AND I ARE BACK TO stage one. Since our first meeting, I'm yet to see him in flesh. The days have swept by at snails' pace, making me question if indeed I had met him. Time drags and the only proof we have met in person is Obsidian Constructs coming in for preliminary meetings on his project.

Manir returned to Lagos last Sunday and since then, it has been one meeting that ran late for him or one project I have to complete, with Madam Nelly hovering on my neck.

When I am free, he is busy. When he is free, I am busy. It is difficult than ever for us to meet each other halfway. The horror of our previous experience, planning but never seeing, taunts me.

Now that we have met, I want to spend more time with him. Get to know him better. See if he fits this prince charming character I have created in my

head.

Ugh.

My emotions are going bananas. In retrospect, I think our first meeting without planning has created a jinx. We have less time to chat, in its place, stolen moments to place unfulfilling brief calls.

I fear sharing my random thoughts with him now. He is real—flesh and blood. I need to tread carefully and not put myself out there… Like, you know, look cheap?

With senior architects reviewing the company's projects, there's nothing to say but watch and learn. My phone vibrates as they go through the last item on the meeting's agenda. Experience should have taught me to silence the device at work or when I'm in the conference room. Speak of the devil.

10:16 AM
Manir: Happy Valentine's Day!

Same to you, I type back discreetly. I have been knee-deep in work projects, getting my logbook updated and visiting showrooms when I have no business there. Day-to-day activities should feel normal, but I know I'm hiding. Hiding from him. From the reality of things.

Breaking up comes with guilt. Well, guilt when you do it because you met someone else that's not as into you as you thought they were. Then you start reading up online articles to console yourself that the guilt you feel is a natural human reaction.

Chin up Zo! Meeting Manir was the catalyst. You didn't wait till this day or past this day to call it off with Eric. It will have been totally unfair to him and for you. You couldn't see a long-term future with Eric. It was for the best.

Nothing has really changed. My relationship with Eric didn't come with commitments or expectations. There's nothing I'm missing out on. And I'm not looking for another man. I'm young, chasing my dreams, living happily.

As I step out of the conference room where I struggle to keep my experience with Manir at the back of my mind, Favor, an intern I occasionally supervise, struts past with a bouquet of roses and a basket of exotic chocolates in hand.

"Ehizoya..." she grins.

I'm ready to bang my head on my desk for getting out of the meeting early. I want to be alone.

We had picked random names from a basket last Friday to be our work Val. An act of love, Madam Nelly had said, her eyes glazing with excitement. I never knew how stressful it was to buy a gift for someone I hardly know. Images of Manir's large stainless-steel watch came to mind, but that would cost a fortune. I had picked Pelumi, the new guy, and didn't want to settle for the regular chocolate gift, so I added a productivity planner to the mix.

"Do you think this is too much?" Favor asks, whispering with a wrinkle on her nose.

"It's not yours?" It's no hidden secret Favor's got a lot of admirers in the office, on site, and out of work. God favored her with a Coca-Cola bottle body shape, a pretty face that makes her look dumb, and an extra sharp mind. It's a beautiful combination of opposites that works to her advantage. Few times I let her get close, she regals me with tales of her university days. She claims to know her worth and won't settle for less.

"No, it's not. I got it for Ife," she winks.

Ife the project manager? Why didn't I see this coming? He is Mr. Nice Guy who loves getting into the pants of colleagues even when office policy expressly states otherwise. Favor is smart, but this interest in Ife won't end well.

"A guy shouldn't be the only one making big moves," she adds.

Cocking my head to the side, intending to make her see that she's playing with fire, I begin. "You know this is against office policy. And Ife's record with __"

"I know..." she cuts me, with a low, wistful voice. "But we're solid." A grin accompanied by flashing twinkling eyes replaces the sadness in her voice.

What does she know about Ife's record? That Ife has six years work experience over her and knows better is something her smart ass should tell her is a red flag. Rumor has it, he impregnated an intern a year before I joined, but no one was sure as the lady left without a thank you to the firm or resignation letter. And... I know I sometimes complain about being paid stipends for all my hassle, but Mercury Consults is one of the few companies that pay lower-level architects well. If throwing away the opportunity to get a full-time position here is not top priority on her list, then who am I to stop her from playing with fire?

I saw them—Favor and Ife—at the parking lot last Friday after the random name picking thingy. Favor, dressed in a pair of palazzo trousers I admired earlier, got into Ife's car with an overnight bag.

"I'm dropping her at her bus stop." Ife had said to the guys after much banter.

Ife and Favor walked into the office yesterday, Monday morning, and she was wearing the same palazzo trousers she had worn on Friday with a different top. It was odd seeing her. Favor, who hardly repeats her wardrobe in a month. With this Valentine fever, I can conclude they've gone past he's dropping me at my bus stop stage. Late night working on project designs might have contributed to their whirlwind romance they think no one is privy to, and I wish them the best.

"O-kay." I shrug, in a haste to leave Favor, who has got it all figured out. "Happy Valentine." I force a fake smile, which fades the moment I leave her standing there to get my logbook.

Less than four weeks to the exam and my logbook where I report the top three building projects I have worked on for the past two years is complete. All I need is Madam Nelly's signature. With the recent project I completed with Arc. Ivie in there, I should crush the report segment. Submitting the logbook is not all, I've got to prepare for the exam and following interview. Senior architects from the national organization will interview juniors like me,

to see if we're cool enough to be given the title that will unlock doors for us, and I need to put my best foot forward.

There are tutorials... classes available, but with my workload and my preference for hands-on experience, I'm not attending any of that. Instead, I'll be present at the compulsory seminar. That is a task I'm not eager to complete. I've seen the way other architects look at me when they find out I studied and worked for a while in UK. The unasked questions of why didn't she remain there? Why did she return to Nigeria? And I choose to ignore them.

12:43 PM
Manir: Valentine's Day is a great day to let those you love know how special they are. I want to let you know you're an incredibly special friend.

12:45 PM
Queen Zo: This is so sweet of you.

1:08 PM
Manir: Spoiler alert.
Queen Zo: You forwarded it from another friend? *Hand on face emoji*

1:11 PM
Manir: :D
Got it from Google.

1:14 PM
Manir: Wanted to share something with you.
To make you know you are special to me.

I don't know how to tell him without making it look like I cleared the path for him. Part of my heart has been secretly waiting for Kaffy or maybe Mr. Riliwan to ring me up. Tell me someone left a package—but I kill it. He still thinks I'm with Eric and it will be disrespectful of him to send me something. Manir and I are not dating. We're not—I'm not even thinking of it. He's a friend, an old buddy.

2:03 PM
Queen Zo: That's so sweet.

****

"Don't sleep on me, Queen Zo."

"I swear I'm not." Holding my phone close to my ear. "Only closing my eyes." Three hours in Thursday traffic is not for the weak. In fact, being on Lagos' roads after 4:30 PM any day of the week is not for the faint-hearted.

"That means you didn't hear my last question."

"Hmm? Come again please." *I'm not regretting we're not chatting. Seriously, I'm not.* I force my eyes open, turn my bedside lamp on, so the brightness from the lamp forces me awake.

Tuesday morning started off slow and merry with Valentine's celebration in the air, however once the clock struck one, it was as though someone hit fast forward. Travelling from one site to another, paperwork to be done, delegated duties from the senior architects.

"Come over this Saturday? I'll clear my schedule."

"Sure. Sure."

"Great. You'll have to come early. Breakfast is..." his voice fades then goes silent. "You down?" His voice comes through.

"Yes. Yes." Blinking, I clear my head. What did I just agree to? What is he implying? "Manir, slow down. What's happening?"

"Happening?"

"What did I just agree to?"

He chuckles. "You're fully awake?"

"As awake as I can be. What's happening to breakfast?"

"You agreed to come to my apartment this weekend and you'll be preparing breakfast."

“Haba. I am your visitor now. I shouldn’t be cooking.”

“I’ll help you. Anything you want to prepare, I’ll help you. It’s a date.”

“No, Manir… Where have you seen people doing this type of date?” I know of going for cooking classes, but that’s not popular in this part of the world.

“I read that in a Vanguard article, mind blowing ideas for first dates.” He sighs. “Jokes apart. I want a home-cooked meal. I’m tired of ordering in. Help a brother.”

Laughing, the sleep completely clears from my eyes. “You want me to cook for you? That’s so low budget.”

“There’s no other reason I can think of to ask you over to my place. Did that work?” I can feel the warmth of his grin through the phone.

OceanofPDF.com

THIRTEEN

COVENANTS, CONDITIONS & RESTRICTIONS

Zoya

Wanting the first time to be special doesn't mean I can't practice with a willing specimen.

WHENEVER I THINK OF HIM, ALL I see are flowers, lingering kisses, affectionate hugs after work, warm cuddles on cool rainy days as we watch lone raindrops slide down the window and… and babies. Those are not brotherly or friendly thoughts. I need to put my head in place. *But the messages we've been exchanging lately…* I need not read much into anything. I'm overthinking.

This was what I was thinking after accepting his invitation. The same thing I was thinking on my way here. Yes, it is what I am thinking as I prepare brunch for us.

His house, which he calls an apartment, is a spacious fenced one-story bungalow with three bedrooms and a gatekeeper's house. During the compulsory tour he gave me upon my arrival, I found he'd converted the only

room on the ground floor to a study/game room. The living room, done in shades of grey, walnut brown and black, contains only the basics, with the rooms scantily but tastefully decorated. The rooms, especially the living room, gets a lot of natural light.

"What do you want to listen to?" He calls from the living room.

"Anything is fine."

Adele, singing Rolling in the Deep, has me swaying my hips, lip syncing, while I go through the kitchen cabinet for spices.

"Need my help?"

"Oh!" I jump, hands on chest, turning to find Manir grinning knowingly, his hip leaning on the kitchen island decorated with ingredients I have been pulling from their hiding place. "You did that intentionally." I suck my teeth, shaking my head at his theatrics, then resume my search, feeling his eyes following my movement.

"I couldn't help it."

"Hmm..." Should I stop swaying to the music or... Whatever. Taking my mind off what he thinks about my bum and dance moves, I find three different dried parsley containers. "You have so many spices here." I turn to him with a smile, dropping my new find on the island. "Is there a secret chef behind the suit?"

"I honestly don't know what's in here." He picks items off the island and inspects them.

"Then who buys all these? Your girlfriend?" Or maybe an ex.

He smirks. "It's my cook. She comes in once in two weeks. Prepares meals, freezes them..." rubbing is palms together, "Life goes on."

"Hmm..." Pursing my lips in concentration, I read through the expiration date of spices laid out on the island. He's not always around and he's got a cook making meals every other week.

"You know I don't have a girlfriend. Just friends who come around."

"I said nothing." I grin, shrugging. "What's my business if you do?" Minding my business, I arrange the valid spices on the counter, debating whether to start cooking or continue in my expired products search.

"Yeah." Manir shrugs. "What's your business if I do?"

"She must really love spices." Okay, I need to shut up.

Manir attempts to roll his eyes, and I'm tempted to laugh. This is fun. Taunting him is priceless and his reaction is so it. But I need to shut up because I don't know if I'm asking out of curiosity now, or.... Jealousy? *Mm hmm. Don't think about it.*

"Who?"

"Your cook. Most of the items here are expired. Trash them or leave them?"

"Please do as you wish with them."

"Thanks, but I'll pass. You already roped me into cooking. Now you want to add cleaning." I shake my head, offering a way too sweet smile. "No, thank you."

"I didn't ask." *Cocky Manny*. He spares a lopsided smile, that causes my heart to skip a beat. Why did I agree to this? This is a bad idea. *Oh. Because I wanted to spend time with him.* "And thanks for bringing it to my notice," he sounds sincere. "I'll tell the housekeeper."

He is too cute for his own good. In a suit, he was yummy and now, in ripped jeans and grey shirt, he is delish. *Attention Zoya! He. Is. Your. Friend!*

I move to cutting and peeling yam while Manir leans on the island, going through his phone. This feels like a ritual we have done a thousand times. It's feels so natural having Usher and David Guetta sing Without You in the background while a handsome man ogles me as I prepare a meal.

Is he ogling me? I observe him from the corner of my eyes. Man is busy on his phone, ignoring my presence. Ogling me, right? I need to tame my wild imagination.

"Shit." I mutter. The knife narrowly missed my forefinger.

"You good?"

He is so close. How did he—

"Can I see?"

"I'm good." I force a grin. "Thank you." Not only do I need to tame my wild imagination, I also need to concentrate on my task.

Stepping back when he realizes it's a false alarm, he says smugly, "Focus on the cooking, Zo."

"You could volunteer to help like you promised." I tell him instead, trying to act indifferent to the charm he exudes without even trying.

"That's why I'm here." His eyes taunt me as he pockets his phone. "So..." bringing both hands together before him, "How can I help?" His voice carries a suggestive tone.

Wrap your arm around me from behind while I prepare this meal. Whisper nothings in my ear that'll make me giggle and...

Ugh! Stop it Zoya. This is Manir. Thoughts like that are not welcomed. You are friends. You are here as a friend. We are spending quality time together like friends do.

But you just finally broke up with Eric because you want to be with him.

No... I did not *just* break up with Eric to be with *him*.

I size him up, scrunching my nose. "What can you do?"

"I'm yours for hire." He leans on the counter. "Anything the lady desires, I'll do. Just know this." He winks. "I rarely come this cheap."

"I see... If that's the case, I need you to help with the smoked fish."

"Just that?"

What else is there to do, so he doesn't watch me watching him? "Yeah... Just that. I'll think of something else later." I push the bowl containing smoked fish to him.

"Thanks, your highness," he says, accepting the bowl with a look of glee.

Jeez. I just made a mistake. I hope he doesn't finish eating the fish before he's done removing bones from them.

He had sent a text asking what I would need for this date, and I had sent him a list of ingredients. I don't know who did the errand—I'm only finding out that asides his driver, he has a housekeeper and a cook. Whoever did, they bought everything in bulk. If I use all the ingredients bought, Manir will eat pottage every day for the next three months. With his smug attitude today, I am tempted to do that, but that would be a waste of resources on my part.

Better, now I can look at him to my heart's content as he debones the fish.

When he'd opened the door, I thought I had gotten the wrong address. The man looked homey, in ripped jeans and grey t-shirt which he had rolled up at the sleeves, revealing muscular arms and bare wrists. Images of his large stainless-steel watch had imprinted themselves on my brain, I thought it was an everyday apparel. He was a total contrast to the man I had met at the office.

His arm muscles flex as he carries out the menial task of deboning smoked fish and I imagine him taking so much care with me—Don't go there, Zo. Think butterflies. Wrong choice. Think... think chats.

I just noticed he enjoys chatting, not only on the phone, but in person too. Not like he is talkative, but... conversation with him flows. During our earlier chats, I found it hard to understand him as his words were ambiguous, but getting to know him better, I'm realizing he is one sarcastic, fun-loving individual. Sarcastic? Fun loving? Really?

We fall into sync and begin discussing different cooking processes yam can go through compared to rice, his favorite food of all time. Then which is healthier, yam or sweet potatoes? He had wanted sweet potato pottage for breakfast, and I only agreed to prepare breakfast if it was yam.

"Yam is a super food," I say. "You can't argue that."

"But sweet potato is everyone's favorite. That's like the prince of all tubers."

"Not everyone's favorite. I don't like sweet potatoes."

"You're missing. Doesn't itch when you peel it. Comes in unique shapes and sizes, and they're naturally sweet." He eyes me, a wicked gleam in his eyes.

“For a guy who has spent a lot of time in the north, I thought you would champion Irish potatoes.”

“Sweet potatoes all day. We should have made this sweet potato pottage instead.”

I burst out laughing, pointing a fork at him. “I got you. There’s no such thing as sweet potato pottage. Just like you can’t fry rice like you can fry yam. Hah!”

“There is.”

“Prove it.” He attempts to fork a piece of smoked fish and I tap his hand away.

His response is a cheeky grin. “Zo… it’s a worldwide fact. Sweet potato is a super food that can undergo multiple processes. Way super than yam.”

“Prove it.” I sing. “Gross. It will be so mushy and too sweet.”

Folding his arms, he stares at me, a twinkle in his eyes. “Do you try other cuisines when you travel out of the country?”

“When there are Nigerian ingredients and restaurants? Then there are fries and burgers.”

“I thought as much. Don’t even start this argument with me. I’ll win you left, right and center.”

“But sweet potatoes pottage? You like that?”

“They’re sweet.”

“Eissh.”

“And you are adding ripe plantains to the pottage?” He asks, baffled, as I add the said plantain to the mix.

“Secret ingredient.” I grin.

He is curious about the cooking process, eager to unwrap seasoning cubes, but reluctant to cut onions. The mix in the pot is ready to take in the fish when I see him forking another bit of fish into his mouth.

"Not again Manny!" I whine, moving too slow for my liking to get the fish about to be sacrificed in his mouth. We run round the kitchen island like kids. Laughing as we go in circles. This is fun! It feels good!

Table turns and I don't understand how I am the hunted one. Amidst shrieks and screams of delight, Manir grabs me from behind, maneuvers me till he has my back pinned to a cabinet, hands captured above my head. He towers above me, barely breathing, while I'm panting like a fish out of water.

"Manir... Manir..." My insides are vibrating. "You win..."

Panting, I close my eyes as excitement washes through me. Bolts of energy. Blood. Passion. Lust. Everything. They travel from my nipples down to my nether region. A thought so wanton builds up in my mind, wanting to force its way past my lips. *Press your body on mine. Fuck me!*

I blink my eyes open to look down. His legs are splayed apart, his toes almost a foot away from mine. This is it. Our moment! Heaving chest, thudding with excitement, I look up at him. Ignoring his slightly fishy breath, I savor the moment as his breath mingles with mine.

"That's it, Manir..." I say breathlessly, before taking a sharp intake of breath. "Stay out of the kitchen."

This is how it plays out in movies and romance novels. The guy pins the girl to the wall. She resists, then he says something, and they kiss.

I skittishly trace the outline of his face, then lock in on his eyes. I flex my hand, testing his hold. He must not know what is going on in my treacherous body system. He can't know. Someone can—We are the only ones in his house. Why hadn't I thought this through before accepting the invite? My brain is not functioning properly... for me to think this is a movie or romance novel.

"What did I do wrong?" His voice is low... authoritative, deep, and coaxing. Like he is asking something of me. We're playing a dangerous game.

I squirm as sticky liquid slides out of my vagina, dampening my panties. *Oh no*. His compelling dark eyes are rich with knowledge of what is happening to me. *No, he does not know. He does not!*

Why did I choose to wear a gown with only panties beneath? I should have worn tights, leggings, or jeans, like I'm going to inspect a site. How can a childish run around the kitchen cause me to be all watery down there?

Trying to keep an indifferent façade, I ruin it by responding in a breathy voice. "Thank you for your help. Ah-em," I clear my throat. "But I am no longer in need of your services—service."

He flexes his hold on, sizing me up. "User." He accuses in a husky voice, his eyes seeing through me.

"I'm not. Just don't need your help anymore."

I'm playing with fire. We are supposed to be friends. Not friends with benefits or friends for useful occasions, only plain, basic friends.

But you were just thinking of him kissing you.

With my eyes still on him, I feel more than I see, him moving his head down to my face.

Should I turn my face away? Should I be bold and explore my imaginations of him? Does he know what he is doing? If I tell him no, would he stop? Do I want him to stop?

The tip of his nose touches mine as he moves his head from side to side. It is a simple movement, but it's so... sensuous.

"But I want to help you." His low baritone moves some nerves in my body, and I shiver, dazed. The corners of his eyes crinkle in amusement.

The continuous, slow, and torturous back-and-forth movement of his nose on mine makes me question his statement. I close my eyes, taking slow, tortured breaths. Did he mean for it to sound double barreled? Is he talking about what we are doing? I meant cooking.

"You can—" Rihanna's voice, asking What's My Name, stops me from completing my statement.

All traces of the teasing Manir disappears. He lets go of my hands in one swift move, giving me enough space to walk away from him. It's as though a

power beyond us manipulated us into action. I hear him blow air through his teeth and make no comment about it.

He felt what I was feeling! He would have to be a rock to say that rough play did not affect his senses.

After adjusting my dress, I add the coveted fish into the cooking pot. My movement is frantic from frazzled nerves, but I get the fish and other ingredients successfully into the pot without spilling them on the cooker before making a beeline for my phone.

"Be right back baby. Need to use the bathroom." Manir announces, leaving me perplexed.

Did he just—? There is nothing unique about that. He has called me darling, dear and what-not during chats but... After that episode we just had, he... he called me baby?

OceanofPDF.com

FOURTEEN

LEAVE TRASH FOR LAWMA

Zoya

It ironic how people find it hard to talk to those around them. Maybe not knowing you makes it easier.

THIS IS GETTING INTERESTING. AS INTERESTING as it gets, I need to reset my brain back to its default setting.

Thank God my phone rang on time—our relationship would have exploded from friends, straight to friends with benefits.

Picking up the still ringing phone, the caller ID reads Luba, before the back light goes out. If it is important, she would call again. If not, I'll call her when I'm done cooking. Phone in hand, I walk to the kitchen, and it resumes vibrating angrily before Rihanna asks What's My Name.

"Hello babes, what's up?" I ask, leaning on the kitchen island.

"Funsho just told me he is not sure where our relationship is heading anymore." Her voice is hoarse, as though she just completed a screaming

match. “Couldn’t he just come out and say it’s over? Why put me on a journey of insecurity? Questioning myself and my acts?”

Not again…

Chiluba has been crazily in love with Funsho longer than her previous conquests. Outside business, Funsho is the only human of the male species Chiluba spares time for. She rarely picks calls from her bedridden father.

Sucking air through my teeth, I listen to her rant. On how available and considerate she has been in their relationship. She had even tolerated jabs from his younger sister that’s younger than Zena. And now he’s complaining she’s too busy chasing money to focus on their relationship. Questioning items she owns, insinuating she’s seeing other men on the side. She had to stop buying things for herself, but the fool didn’t consider buying things for her, knowing fully well her love language was gifting and… well… yada, yada, yada.

I had seen through Funsho the first time we met. I knew he would not last. He acted like everyone should bow and be amazed at being in his presence. Chiluba had said it was just Funsho being Funsho as he is a serial entrepreneur, politician, and CEO of one of the happening clubs in Lagos. It is surprising that it took this long for him to show this side to her.

“Is he threatened by my success? I have done all I can to show him he is important to me. He…”

I pace the kitchen slowly, not knowing what to say or do. “You have done more than enough Luba… I’m so sorry, babes.” Chiluba whimpers and I know this is serious.

“Luba… Where are you?”

“I’m home…”

“Was this on a call? Did this happen at your place? Did he visit you?”

“Yes…”

“Yes what?”

“It happened here. My place.”

"How do you feel? Has he left?"

"Ah! Funsho!"

The sure girl I have always known is broken. Over an insecure guy and not a cheesy soap opera. I know Chiluba has every right to cry or laugh and whatever, but this... over Funsho? Someone who almost broke her.

Chiluba is high maintenance. Even at that, she takes care of herself and those around her. It is strange that being able to take care of herself is the problem in their relationship.

"I feel terrible..." her shaky voice calls out to me. "Why? Why? With the way I'm feeling, I'll drink sniper."

"Great. Please sign off all your businesses in my name before you do."

Chiluba's warm giggle reaches me, and I breathe a sigh of relief. That giggle is a good sign. Everything is alright. Shaken, but alright.

What's that smell? "Jeez." I mutter under my breath, making my way to the cooker.

"What happened?"

"I was cooking. Give me a minute."

Dropping my phone, I stir the pottage, turning off the cooker. The color and texture looks perfect. And the taste... Hmm... Manir and I make a wonderful team. Speaking of Manir, isn't he done with his bathroom business?

"I'm currently at Manir's. I'll drop by soon so we can cuss Funsho and his family members over the phone." Remembering her sniper joke, I add. "He was never the one for you. And this feeling of guilt, it's only a phase. It's normal for you to have mixed feelings, but don't let negative thoughts win, okay?"

"He should have just ended things and not say something like that..." Chiluba whines, sounding more like herself. *"Na that one pain me."*

"I agree with you on that."

"I'll be expecting you soon oh." Chiluba's voice is surprisingly calm for someone who was shouting moments ago. "Don't forget the introduction to your uncle for my Silhouette thingy. I'll be damned if I cry for this fool that doesn't know who he's letting go."

You're thinking of Silhouette in between break-up? My one and only drama queen and businesswoman. I remember the sniper joke again. "Keep calm babes. Don't do anything stupid."

"Trust me. Calling you was to clear my mind."

And I trust her. "I'll update you on my movements." I say, ending the call.

Gathering up chopping boards, dishes and cutlery we used during the preparation, I fill up a bowl with water and begin washing up.

I am glad I can be of help when Chiluba needs me. Even more so, be there for her physically. What are friends for if they cannot help in down times?

The problem now is how to tell Manir I need to cut short our date earlier than expected. Or... I can head to Chiluba's then return later. That could work too. Chiluba's home is about thirty minutes drive from Manir's place. Being that it is Saturday, there might be slight traffic from those partying it up, but it would not be as bad as a weekday.

Uhn?

A tingle rushes through me as the hair on the back of my neck rises. Manir is back and is playing games. His short-full beard is ticklish on my nape, and I relax into him with a satisfying sigh.

"You smell nice." He wraps his arms around me from behind.

His chest warms my back and I welcome the feeling.

"What has you all worked up?"

"Hmmm... You mean the food?" I sigh, knowing I should pull away and ask what this madness is. What is the meaning of this? What are we? But my common sense is... let's just say my common sense is out on a break.

If he learned nothing from our last encounter, I would not spell it to him now. Nothing can happen between us. Even the universe is against us.

Chiluba calling me with her fresh break-up story is enough testament to that.

All I'm doing is enjoying the attention. Soaking it all up. I have set my mind to see him as a friend, nothing more. Yeah, and friends hug each other from time to time.

Manir brushing his nose on my neck, inhaling like he would die if he didn't, is part of the normal things normal friends do. Hmm.

"Uhn?" he asks.

"I got a call from Chiluba."

Manir stops brushing his nose on my neck. I want to tell him to continue, that I love the sensation, but I bite my tongue.

"Nice. My regards."

Manir knows Chiluba alright. He was once the imaginary friend that listened to me rant about my other *best* friend.

"This is creepy. You know, right?" I couldn't resist the urge to voice my thought on our situation.

"Hmm..." He murmurs, continuing with the slow assault of my senses.

He places noisy kisses on my shoulder, and I squeal in delight, jumping out of his grasp. A nervous giggle escapes me, and I hold out an arm to hold him off.

"You know that tickles?" My other hand subconsciously rubs my neck.

"It worked. You were all tensed up." He replies with a knowing grin.

"Something smells nice..."

Seeing him move to the pot, his attention gone from me knocks the wind out of my sails. I didn't know I wanted his attention that bad.

Steam rushes out of the pot as he opens it, and he inhales deeply. "I hope it tastes as good as it smells."

"If it doesn't, I'm glad we made it together."

"Then it tastes good."

"Why?"

"Because it has the Manir Magic in it."

"Jeez." I shake my head at him, returning to put away the utensils I had washed. "Please dish the food."

Drying my hands with a towel, I wonder how he would react to me leaving immediately after we're done eating to head over to Chiluba's. With these weird acts he's dishing out and me letting my guard down... it's best I leave here as soon as possible.

He goes ahead to bring out plates and cutlery to dish the meal. "Whoa, I never get to use all these things. My cousin just forces things on me."

Or secret girlfriend. Whatever. What do I even know about him?

"Umm... About Chiluba's call. I might have to leave once we're doing eating."

He turns crestfallen face to me. "Once we're done? What happened to Chiluba?"

I remember telling him Chiluba doesn't have family in Lagos and the drama she had faced with her family for pursuing a modelling career at such a young age.

"Girls stuff."

"Hmm..." I watch as he sets the table. "Don't wanna share?"

"She just got jilted." Folding my arms, I shrug.

"By the same guy stylishly asking you out."

"He didn't ask me out." I let my arms fall to my side. "He called me at inappropriate times." To check up on me, he'd said and when I hung out with them, I'd catch him watching me.

"Odd hours of the night."

I twitch my lips as his point strikes home. Lesson learnt. We'll do better with our next choice of men.

Manir gets bottled water from the fridge and sets it down. "You ladies need to up your dating game."

"Yes master." I say in the voice of the animated character, Igor.

"No jokes. Why did she settle for someone like that?"

"She didn't settle, she chose. And point of correction, it's love." He draws out a chair for me.

"Yes. Blame it on love."

Settling on the chair, I sigh. "I really want to head over to her. Want to boost her morale. You know, as a friend."

"I'm not tying you down here now, am I?"

I angle my head at him. "Meaning?"

"You can go if you want to. Just know that I sacrificed my weekend to spend valuable time with you. And if you prefer spending time with your friend whom you can see later tonight, tomorrow or any other day, no qualms."

"Don't make it sound like I have to choose."

"But that's what you were trying to do. You were trying to convince me you're a good friend and need to leave. When I've planned the whole day with you."

Sighing, I mentally agree with him. Chiluba has been my friend for ages, she would understand. However, Manir and I have been trying to keep this friendship we have and now that we've found time to spend together, I'm trying to pull away.

"Hey!" I tap his hand that's without a spoonful of pottage heading to his mouth and he stares at me askance. "We need to pray before we eat."

OceanofPDF.com

FIFTEEN

FENESTRATION

Manir

Whenever you're ready for the big D, I can give you tips.

I WAS EXPECTING HER TO REJECT the offer of spending time at my place today because… Valentine was on a weekday. If I were in a relationship, I would have something planned for my woman but my surprise when she agreed to my proposal of a home-cooked meal, sparkling wine and a movie of her choice.

Something I've never done in my whole life—double checking to see everything is in order before her arrival—made me realize I'm really a selfish bastard going after another man's girl. I'm not trying to get the girl—yet—nevertheless, I'm making an attempt which should have me checking myself.

Then the call from Chiluba threatening to jinx my stolen moment with her. It would have killed me to watch her leave like that. I didn't mean to have her choose between myself and her friend, but she can always see the girl every other day. I'm on borrowed time here.

“How did you spend your Valentine?” It's a question I've been dying to ask. Yes, I was busy with work and also made a fool of myself by sending her that cheesy message on Valentine’s Day, but I was expecting her to share, at the end of the day, what really went down and zilch. Nothing. However, she has been open to my advances, and it has me curious on my chances with her.

“It was like every other day.” Taking a sip of water.

What gives? Talk to me Queen Zo. I balk, saying nothing, watching the subtle movement of her lips as she plays with the water in her mouth before swallowing.

Biting her lips, she reluctantly adds, “Work. I went to work. Shared gifts with my colleagues. That was it.”

“And Eric?”

She spares me a tight smile. “I broke it off with him. There. Happy?”

Grinning, I lean back on the dining chair, knowing I shouldn’t be showing any form of joy at another brother's loss, but hey, the dating pool is the Wild West. Ladies like Zoya are hard to come by. “What happened?”

“It was time to end it,” she shrugs half-heartedly.

Because of me? I’ll never ask, but it would make the primitive man in me beat his chest in pride. Notwithstanding, this is something I've been telling her to do for the longest and if she had wanted to do it for me should have done it a long time ago. I’m glad she has placed herself on the path for something better. “I'm sorry about that.”

“There's no need to be sorry.” Her lips twitch as she avoids my gaze.

Is this why… If she broke it off with him, then she must be feeling guilty. Or did he?… I place my hand on hers. “I noticed, but I didn’t want to make it an issue. Is this why you've not been responsive to chats?”

She turns to me dramatically, drawing her mouth into a straight line, then bites her lips. “I-I haven't?”

“Ah…” I look for the right words to say not wanting to be presumptuous about the level of friendship we share. Did he do anything she didn’t like? Is

she missing him? “Zoya, tell me what's wrong?”

Her brows draw close, and she shakes her head. “There's nothing wrong.”

If there's nothing wrong, then… “Is there a new guy?” I smile, trying to ease any tension that might be in the room. It's complicated for me to know there is someone already in the picture. Maybe she’s not the good girl I’ve idolized her to be. Is she leading me on?

It can't be. She has been receptive to my advances so far. In the kitchen. The mind game she was playing earlier, trying to confirm the presence of any woman in my life, did not escape me.

She scoffs. “Where would I find him? Is it on construction sites or at work?” She shakes her head. “There's no one, Manny.”

I wish a part of me will be willing to turn back the hands of time. Work it out that we never met so that we can continue enjoying the easy camaraderie we’ve always had. But no. I prefer this. Being in the same room with her. Despite sensing an invisible barrier between us. Despite knowing I now have to decipher what's going on behind those pretty eyes myself.

“So… the problem is you can't find a guy to date, but you’re open to dating?”

“I just got out of a relationship, Manny. Getting into another is the least of my concerns right now.”

“I know. I know. But if offered the opportunity to get into one, you would take it, right?”

“Right now?” She pauses to think for a heartbeat. “I don't know. What’s with the questions?” Then breaks into a bright smile. “Do you want to hook me up with one of your *rich* friends?

She stresses the word *rich*, and I laugh. “Rich friends?” I scoff. “Let’s go watch the movie please. I’ll clear the table.”

Rising from the dining chair, she walks leisurely to the sofa. My eyes follow every waver her short chiffon gown makes. When I had opened the door to find her in the sleeveless dark floral-patterned gown, with a clutch purse, my

breath hitched. That moment I captured her arms in the kitchen, struggling to play it cool, all I could see was the fairer skin of her side breast.

"Yeah, rich friends." Her voice draws me back to the present and I blink, catching myself. *Oh Zoya…* I smile as I occasionally glance at her on the sofa. "You said you lived in an apartment and I'm finding out you live in a full-blown bungalow with enough space to make it a duplex. For a luxury realtor, you need to understand your craft better."

I accept the jab with a wink. "I've got sparkling wine. Moët Rosé. Care for some? Or ice-cream, your pick."

"Wine.... It comes with the package."

Of course. I promised her food, wine, movie, and quality time.

Getting the bottle of sparkling wine, I close the curtains, turn off the lights, before joining her on the sofa where she's busy on her phone. Since I spend little time here, with few of my friends occasionally turning the door to keep the space alive, I kept the design simple. One long L sofa and two single chairs. No throw pillows. None.

We settle to watch Alvin and the Chipmunks: Chipwrecked, since Zoya is a fan. Left to me, we would binge Paranormal Activity so she can scream into my chest, while I take pleasure in being her haven, which can then lead to other things.

"But you've seen this one." I complain as I hit play on, what's the title? Ah... Chipmunks... on a cruise ship. There's no chance of getting to first base.

"I haven't. There are different versions. You might like it. It's 100% PG." She chuckles.

If I don't know better, I'll say she's playing it safe.

As the scene opens, Zoya sings along to the vacation song, and I watch her in wonder. How did I land someone who knows the line to one, two, three... six? Six talking chipmunk songs and is a badass. I envision her with mini us doing the same—singing and laughing.

She's broken it off with Eric. That is glorious music to my ears. There's nothing stopping me from asking her out. A step towards making mini us.

I adjust, moving closer to her. “More?” I tilt the wine bottle and she nods. After pouring a reasonable amount of wine into her glass, she takes a sip, attention back on the screen.

Getting a blanket I had strategically placed on the couch when I left her in the kitchen, I ask, “Wanna snuggle up?” I’m rubbing the magical lamp. All my wishes coming true.

Cocking her head to the side, she considers my offer before deciding. “Sure.”

Didn’t know I was holding my breath until she relaxes into the curve of my arm and the blanket covers our lower bodies. Soft fruity fragrance clouds my senses. Apple? No. It’s not.

I watch the movie through her eyes, marveling at her reactions and involvement with the characters. When she laughs at Alvin’s theatrics, who is both a menace and alpha of the chipmunk pack, tremors run down to my core. There’s also the point where she imitates Simon who now goes by the name Simone. Can I settle for this? Lazy afternoons on a sofa? Resort to watching animals talk and sing to humans just to spend quality time with her?

I am doing a good job. I deserve happiness. I’m Oladele Manir Dosu-Andrews.

When Alvin and his friends begin performing *Ain’t no stopping us now… we got the groove*, on the International Music Awards stage, Zoya not only sings with them, but starts moving to the beat.

“Baby you’re a firework! Make them go oh, oh… As you shoot…” She laughs wiggling to the beat then turns to me. “See why I love these types of movies?”

I watch on, fascinated as she gets up and resumes dancing as the credits roll.

“What…” She uses that coaxing voice on me, grinning. “Come on, join me.”

Not one to miss the opportunity, I join her, mimicking her movements.

“Okay…” She nods, laughing at my moves.

I'm nailing it. I didn't grow up in a big family without competing a time or two in family dance offs. She bursts another move, whining her waist and I get too close. I can think of only one thing we can do horizontally with these dance moves. I miss a step, our legs get tangled and miraculously we land partially on the sofa, my heart in my mouth, one knee on the floor, my dick at half-mast, waiting for her command. A sign.

"You play too much." She chides, giggling as I stare at her, her hands folded on my chest, my heart knocking erratically against them.

We're safe. In the position I had been thinking of that got us where we are. My dick jerks to attention and I think she feels it because she stops giggling as realization dawns on her, zeroing on my lips, panting—music to my ears.

I don't give her the chance to think about it, going straight for her lips. Taunting lips I can't get my mind off since our first kiss.

Our lips merge, and she gasps, turning to a puddle in my arms. I dart my tongue inside her mouth with no hesitation, receiving no resistance. Her taste is rich, fruity—the taste of sparkling wine.

Seeking release, I gently press my pulsing dick to her abdomen. Light-headed from need. Impatient for more. *Feel what you're doing to me. Feel it.* Undulating my hips.

A muffled sound from somewhere at the back of her throat reaches me as her hands feverishly runs through my back, triggering a part of my brain that has been numb for weeks.

I move my leg from the floor, taking her with me, onto the chair, placing me in missionary position between her legs as the kiss turns urgent... demanding.

My tongue and senses are on a mission to search out every nook of her mouth, for the goodness it promises every time she moves them.

Certain my weight is not fully on her, with my hands free to travel her body, I touch her breasts through the light chiffon gown, caressing it, taking slow breaths, while my other hand investigates her lower body.

Her gown makes it easy for me to access her thighs. Under my palm, her skin is silky smooth and has me envisioning flashes of rumpled silk, sighs and groans of pleasure. I want to know her body like my own, every spot and the story behind them.

She makes another sweeping motion on my back as we duel with our lips, successfully getting under my t-shirt. The raw touch of her hands on my skin causes me to press my pelvis into her. Strong undiluted sexual tremors run down my spine as my hardened dick encounters her body warmth. She hugs me tight. *How long before we shed our clothing?*

I never thought I would be this lucky when she accepted my invite but here we are, limbs tangled, panting in the age old rhythm of passion and lust.

"Hmm…." That sound. Was that her or me?

Who cares?

What matters is that I can't get enough of her. Like an addict, not satisfied, I demand more. Testing fate, knowing fully well what her principles and standards are, I move my hand up her crotch to find it wet. Warm. Welcoming. Waiting for my command. At the same time, she stiffens.

"Manir. No." Her low, taut voice, deafening than a screech.

Fuck.

I should have been content with just kissing but it will never be enough. It's all or nothing. Question is, am I ready to take the bait? Do I want to go all in?

Moving off her slowly, trying to absorb the moment so I can relieve it in the privacy of my room, when I'm alone and restless. I sit up, catching a quick glance of the TV. The screen is static. Must have been that way for some time —while we were getting lost in the hazy world of passion.

Free of my weight, she sits up reluctantly, shoving a stray braid behind her ear.

"I'm sorry." Sorry for not asking permission. Sorry for not being content with first base. But not sorry for wanting a part of her.

She grimaces, leaning forward, a hand on her forehead, elbow resting on her knees. “I'm sorry too.”

“Are you still…” I let my question trail off and she nods, confirming.

Oh boy. Grinding my teeth as my decision to go further taunts me. I can always make it up to her. I can be a better man. Try abstinence or celibacy if we get to that point.

She stares at me, expectant.

I smirk, voicing my thoughts, fighting to be heard. They are contrary to my earlier actions, but I let them slip out. “If I were your man. I'll wait until the wedding day, like you want it to be. But after that,” I swallow a lump as she sits up, closely watching me, chest moving in slow-mo. “After that, we’ll be having sex for the rest of our lives. Know that the day you say your vow, is an agreement to a life filled with fucking, making love and sex.” I grin. “Depending on the occasion.”

The corner of her mouth lifts to form a faint smile, easing the tension in the air. “Every day?”

“Every. Single. Day.”

Her smile broadens.

Memories of days we used to chat dirty comes to mind. “If you make me wait that long before I can eat your apple, then I'm going to be having it every day for the rest of my life. Um, except for days when you see your period or are too sick to engage in the holy act. Regardless, I’m down if you are.”

She smiles shyly, shaking her head as she adjusts a stray braid behind her ear.

That’s the gospel truth. If I’m going to wait until after the vows, the lady better be ready for a two-four-seven horny red-blooded male. But I won’t do it for anyone. I won’t. I’ll only do it for and with Zoya. She’s the one. And I’m going to spend the next few months showing her I remember everything she has always wanted but given up as an adult.

6:16 PM

Lina: Please check your email.
Looking forward to your response.

OceanofPDF.com

SIXTEEN

COLLECTIBLE CONCEPTS

Manir

Weird. That's how you want to say I love you?

MEETING SOMEONE AS IMPORTANT AS ZOYA has been the most unplanned event in my adult life and finding time to be with her between schedules and commitments is frustrating enough to have me considering resignation. In between the madness of finding it hard to get time off work—especially from my end—we make up for it with chats and calls.

Our friendship has… I don't know if she's getting the hints I've been dropping, albeit our friendship has been moving in a direction of my preference. The thought of making her a bad girl disappeared when she shared, she had finally broken up with Eric.

I have concluded she did it because she met me. She had been content with patching things up with the guy when she knew she didn't like him and wasn't getting what she wanted in a relationship until she met me. I'm

honored to be the one that shows her almost everything is possible in a relationship.

We're back to talking about virtually all aspect of our lives—friendships, sex, eating habits, life goals, politics—and even mundane things such as the weather.

Zoya is a church girl. She doesn't attend church regularly like most fanatics do, but they've ingrained it in her head to wait until marriage. Probably why that Eric guy didn't stress on spending time with her, his loss.

We are speaking on the phone during our new ritualistic late-night calls when she giggles.

"What's funny?"

"Nothing."

Since we met in person, she has also changed in the way she tells me things. In the past, she let her thoughts drop unfiltered, and I loved it. Now we're dancing with thoughts around each other, becoming who we used to talk about.

I've got your time tonight.

Adjusting myself on the revolving office chair, I stretch my stockinged feet on the table. I don't win awards from staying late at work, but it's a habit I'm used to. I should be back in Lagos soon. "One of these days Zoya, you will tell me what was funny in what I just said." I whisper in a voice I hope caresses her senses.

She giggles again.

Funny, after complaining of a long day and her need to sleep, she still has the strength to laugh and hold a reasonable conversation with me.

"Me wanting to meet is funny, ehn? I haven't seen you in weeks... and—"

"You came to our office last week, Mr. Dosu-Andrews." She says primly.

I like it when she uses my surname, even though I still can't tell if she's unhappy with the suddenness of the situation.

“That’s not fair… That was business. I will be back next week. Agree for a meetup, uhn? Somewhere close to your father’s house so you can stay out longer. Um… Rhapsody’s, Ikeja?” They’re a high-end restaurant with high ratings. I really want to wine and dine her proper now that Eric is out of the picture. “Bills on me.”

I recall seeing a flushed Zoya when she saw me talking to her boss on her return from lunch. We had agreed that discussing our office movement was private now that we knew we worked within the same circle. But I wanted to tell her I will do a quick Lagos detour on my trip from Abuja. It was epic seeing her expression, but there was no time to hang out with her as I had a meeting with my Chinese clients who are looking into the Luxury Hospitality sector of Calabar the next day and needed to come up to speed with the project.

The message I sent to her explaining why I appeared in her office and didn’t spend time with her didn’t get a response until about four hours later, waving it off as insignificant.

“No…” She laughs. “I have to prepare for my exam. It’s so close.”

“I did not forget that.” She’s hell bent on getting her architectural certification and I have no doubt in her getting it with one trial. Being supervised by Architect Nelly has its benefits. “Don’t sideline me because of that minor incident, Zo. It was impromptu.” I had agreed to the detour, thinking I would have spare time to spend with her, but I was only *jonzing* myself. Now I know what it is about her that has me all excited. Seeing her gives me the feeling I get from traveling and closing deals.

“It’s not because of that. I’m not holding it against you. Wednesday is work night and there’s a lot going on at work.”

“I know it's work night, but mehn… I’m missing my Queen Zo. I’ve been on the road with company I will trade in a heartbeat for yours. Is it a crime to have dinner and a night in town with a sexy lady after work hours on a Wednesday? Hmm… is it?”

Zoya snorts. “It’s not a crime—”

“Say yes.”

"Ok..." She drawls.

"While you are being gracious with your presence, wanna be my plus one for a wedding in May?"

"You started attending weddings?"

You know me so well. "I have to familiarize myself with the event if I plan on getting married."

"Hmm..."

"Want me to shock you?"

She chuckles, causing a bubbly feeling to build up in my chest. "Please do."

"I'm the best man."

"Whaaaaaa..." her voice is muffled but I can tell I have my promised effect on her.

I smile. "Calm down Zo." My phone chimes with multiple new messages and I excuse myself.

10:12 PM
Ọpẹ **Johnson:** Will you make it?
Ọpẹ **Johnson:** People out there are looking for families to accept them, but you take it upon yourself to neglect yours.
Ọpẹ **Johnson:** It would be good to see your face.

Ignoring the string of messages, I hear rustling on her end, then it quiets. "You good?" I ask.

"Yes. Yes. So... Who is getting married? How close is this person to you?"

Laughing, I ignore her questions, talking about how extravagant and pointless it is doing all the white wedding formalities when the most important thing of the day is saying the vows. "I need to shop for a best man gift and also go for the last suit fitting." Don't know how the tailor convinced me to return. "Want to join me when I'm back?"

"I'm in. But I'll need to confirm my schedule. And since we're inviting each other to events, Chiluba's 27th birthday is in March. Wanna come?"

Chiluba's birthday party always ends up in blogs. Zoya's best friend is the complete opposite of her. I doubt they would have gotten along if they met as adults, not as kids.

"It will be the perfect opportunity to introduce you guys. You would love her in person."

"I don't think I'll be available for that. And if I was... Jeez, I'll feel so old."

"You're thirty-two Manny. And... you know how to do the d*ougie*."

"Me? I can't move my body to the sound of beats."

"Hey! We danced at yours. Don't even pretend."

She got me. However, it takes us a while to resume our banter as images of the end result of the dance runs through our mind. *We were just entering second base.*

Hell!

We're yet to discuss what happened but I have a plan. Once I have all loose ends tied, she's going to say yes to me.

"So," she breaks the silence, her voice, gentle but firm. "You won't make it, make it?"

"I can't make it..." Other commitments babe.

She sighs. "Surprise me." The excitement in her voice fading, making me desperate to bring it back. "Chiluba has been wanting to meet you."

"I want to meet her too." And Zena as well. Damn. I want to meet everyone in her life. Still desperate to bring the easy banter we had going on earlier, I begin, "Um..."

"What is it? You changed your mind?"

That's the excitement right there. Love it. "Not that. I've always wanted to ask. Have you and Chiluba... Have you ever done...?"

"Done what?"

I laugh at the silly thought. “Have you guys ever kissed? Made out?”

“Gross Manny!” She laughs. “How can you think that?”

“I like how you take her side. She’s the number one friend you tell me about. And you guys complain about your boyfriends. Together. You kind of always break up around the same time too.”

“That’s what best friends do. You’re making it sound like she is a bad influence.”

“No. No. No. I didn’t mean that.”

“Sounded like that.”

“I’m sorry. Was meant to be a joke.”

“Well, that was an expensive joke.”

“I’m sorry.”

“You should be. I love my friend and making jokes like that isn’t funny. You find it funny. I don’t. Is that your fantasy? To have us perform for you? Two girls, one guy?”

Her rant leaves me speechless. Where did all that come from? Why is she so mad? It was only a joke. We’ve said worse jokes about each other to each other.

“Oladele, got some ink?”

What the F!

I swivel my chair to face a smiling Yewande. She’s a forty-something-ish CEO who works on the second floor.

“Yewande.”

“I’ve got work tomorrow.” Zoya mutters. “Goodnight.”

It sounds more like a mandatory recitation than a genuine wish for a long and peaceful night that would involve me asking myself why I asked a question that was meant to be received as a joke.

“Goodnight…” I answer, grinding my jaw, in an attempt to get my thoughts together, waiting to sense that I’m on her good page. Anything to show she’s

not as pained as she just showed, but after about five seconds of awkward silence which feels like an eternity, I end the call.

"Oladele?"

Oh. I glance up, forcing a faint, supercilious smile. "I was on a call."

"Oh sorry... I can comeback another time. Ibro said you were in." Ibro, the security guy.

"It's fine. What do you want?"

"Oh. Just ink." She steps into my office, gingerly. "My printer stopped working, and I need to have this revised page printed."

"Sure thing." I swallow, rising to the occasion.

Why is Zoya acting up? Acting more like a spoilt child than a friend. I never knew she was this sensitive. And Ọpẹ. Damn it! Why the hell is she blowing up my phone?

10:21 PM
Manir: Goodnight, dear.
I'm sorry for making expensive jokes.

OceanofPDF.com

SEVENTEEN

OWAMBE

Zoya

The head architect asked me to work on a presentation with him. Yay!!!

MY WAKEUP ALARM RINGS IMMEDIATELY I close my eyes. Is there no peace for me? Even my alarm is telling me to make a choice—stand up from bed or sleep in and answer queries at work. I choose the first choice but not before picking my bedmate, with little ceremony, to change my BBM display picture of me at work yesterday to that of Chiluba and I. We had taken it not long after my return to Nigeria, on the beach, both of us laughing into the camera, shoulder to shoulder.

Happy Birthday, Lovely Luba, Bestie of Life. Turn Up! I type on my status before rolling out of bed, going through my routine of preparing for work.

Earlier, on the news, they mentioned shocking items were found in a coffin by the Nigerian army. Kidnapping for ransom is now the order of the day as

three girls, kidnapped from their schools' hostel, were returned a week later after asking for 200-million-naira ransom.

Two Saturdays ago, I finally introduced Chiluba to Uncle George of Silhouette and I've known peace since then. I also had to commission three Ankara outfits to 34 Threads for her to completely forgive me for not stopping over at her place when the Funsho incident happened.

Doing all that should seem like the perfect birthday gift, but the Chiluba I know will expect something more... Maybe I should hook her up with Pelumi, the new guy at work. Speaking of work, last week was my PPE exam and interview. I'm hoping and praying all my deeds, proactivity and diligence will pay off.

Hmm... Inviting Pelumi for Chiluba's birthday is not a bad idea. He is caring, well-spoken, but... he lives around Berger—Urgh, Chiluba will never consider dating someone who lives in Berger. I found out during lunch break, the following day after Manny and I had our first fight, Pelumi and I use similar routes home and he drives to work. Since then, Pelumi has taken it upon himself to pick me up at my junction every morning.

Thoughts of getting a car still dances on the edge of my mind, but whenever we encounter traffic on our way home or to work, I'm glad I can snooze and not bother with staying conscious. I'm grateful to God for providing a colleague that has taken my mobility as his personal business.

There are a few things I have accepted will happen today—I will be late for Chiluba's party because I have to go to a construction site with Arc. Ivie later today and I might not have selected the right gift for the birthday girl. Chiluba has everything she needs, except maybe the latest fashion piece, will just have to trust my gifting instinct.

I make my way to the living room to pick my bag, which I had discarded on the sofa the previous night. No sign of Zena. She hasn't deemed it fit to get up from bed. The luxurious life of being a *youth corper* who gives herself vacations, you think the world begins and ends on your bed.

Zena came in from Osun State two days ago, in time for Chiluba's birthday. Her love and adoration for Chiluba is so close to being occultic. I'm glad

Chiluba is a superb role model and doesn't pretend to either of us. I hope Manir surprises us.

Memory of that night's conversation comes unbidden to my mind. What happened that night was born out of period cramps and hormonal imbalance. That is my prognosis. What I am sticking to. Something in me resisted the urge to respond to his message that night and I tossed and turned, questioning my reaction to the voice of the lady, when earlier on the call he had said he was alone in the office.

He called the next day, and I reluctantly picked.

"How's your day coming?"

Oh, that voice... "Fine."

"About last night—"

"It was nothing." We are not dating or anything. I over reacted. What's my business if a woman was with you when you said otherwise? "You were at work. I overreacted to—"

"I thought this was... the expensive joke." It was a statement but came as a question.

Um... Joke? "Yes that."

"Yes. I'm sorry. Can we go back to being friends?"

"I—"

"Also, to clear the air, it wasn't what you thought. You know I'll never do that. Not after I met you. It was some lady on the second floor who needed ink for her printer."

"Oh."

"I know I've not been forthcoming with my intentions. I'm working towards it. But I'll never do that."

"Oh, okay."

"Yes. So, we good now?"

"We're always good." I smiled.

His intentions… From our four years plus record of friendship, I have assimilated facts about him that makes him not just a good friend, but a prospective partner. He's a go getter, caring, God fearing—he is not always around to do church 2-4-7 but prays and reads his bible. Supports my dreams, respects my opinion. Plus, he would be presentable to my dad. The only thing I fear is his sex life. He's a serial monogamist who enjoys sex. It's flattering that he's got intentions for me but can he really wait till after marriage? Or would he tire and move on to the next available lady? I'm not ready for marriage right now, maybe next year, not now.

I miss the days when we were anonymous. Knew meeting in person will jinx things. For example, I don't know his current location and I don't want to ask so it doesn't look like I'm asking for too much. Even though we're friends, have always been friends, there's now some invisible line I can't bring myself to cross.

10:16 AM
Manir: Happy birthday to Chiluba.
Please send my regards to her.

It is a response to my status update.

10:42 AM
Zoya: Good morning, handsome.
Changed your mind?
It would be fun.

****

It's past noon when I see Madam Nelly off to the conference room for her presentation. Time off! Swiveling around, I walk to my desk to put a call through to Chiluba. She picks on the third ring.

"Happy birthday to you…" I serenade gently into my phone's mouthpiece, "Happy birthday to you."

"Oh… thank you," comes her muffled response.

"You deserve it. To be happy."

"Thank you." Her voice, now loud and clear. "Are you turning up? I know you'll be tired from work and all…"

I smile, nodding, before recalling Chiluba isn't here to see me. "No Lagos traffic would keep me from you tonight."

"Yay! That's the spirit." Chiluba chuckles. "You didn't have a choice. That was a test. And you passed! And your dad?" Her voice sounds hopeful.

"I told him a week ago." That I would stay over at Chiluba's for the night. "Zena has been talking about it non-stop." I pick a pen and begin drawing abstracts on a blank A4 paper.

"Zena is the best. She got here on time and has been so helpful."

"Just make sure you pay her."

"What do you take me for? Give me a moment." What is a call without Chiluba getting distracted? "Hello?"

"I'm here."

"Sorry about that. Ehen… Would Mr. Dosu-Andrews make it?" She asks, emphasizing the last syllable of his name.

The day we went to see my uncle, I received a call from Manir, and he said hello, leading to them speaking for a while and Chiluba turned to his champion. God save her when they finally meet. She would turn to a purring cat.

"He won't be able to. But he sends his regards."

"Well." The cheer in her voice is not as high as it was earlier—she's not happy about the information. I tried… "Okay. It's all good. Got to go, work beckons."

"See you soon, birthday girl." Smiling, I end the call.

I check my notifications. Still no reply from him. Is this how it's going to be? Or… is he planning to surprise me? But he doesn't have the address. Silly

me, he can find us easily. I told him the hotel it's going down. That he messaged me to wish Chiluba happy birthday says a lot... He remembers and will stop by for the birthday. *No. Stop it*. I won't think too much about it.

My day goes thus; speak with Pelumi that I won't go home with him. Confirm they have delivered my gift to the birthday girl. Lunch. Still no response from Manir. Birthday girl calls to squeal in my ears.

"I got your package."

"Oh, it came in on time."

"Thank you..." she sounds distracted. "The shoe I bought for my first outing doesn't buckle." She hisses. "After spending all that money on it... and this gown I spent hours making... it's so picky. The only option I have is to wear black heels and I don't want that."

"It's not compulsory to wear shoes, you know."

"Ehn... thank you. I'll walk barefooted on my birthday."

"You and Zena share the same shoe size. She should have something for you."

Not long, Madam Nelly stops by to commend my work on her presentation, then I head over to her office for evaluation. Out with Arc. Ivie and the team to the construction site, then head home.

It is kind of weird of him not to respond. Is he flying? He usually lets me know if the day will be busy for him.

I have the house to myself since Zena has appointed herself assistant birthday girl. It is going to be a long night, so I take a nap.

"You made it!" Chiluba glides to me, giving me a giddy hug. She is adorned in a short black lace gown with delicate gold beads that hugs her in the right places. Pushing her breast so high, with only a nod, I guess her jaw will touch them.

Grinning, I let myself out of her grasp and warm floral scent, giving the space proper scrutiny. Ara by Brymo is playing, giving a groovy vibe. It was stressful getting in, seeing that there is a red carpet outside and another event

happening in the hall next to us. Brightly lit, the space has multiple tables that seats five, with three floral alcoves on the sides and one elaborate cove done in green, pink, blush, peach and gold balloons, in the center for the birthday girl.

After small talk with Chiluba—who keeps touching her signature waist-length human hair wig at every opportunity—and Abebi, her in-house co-designer, Zena appears, looking so grown in a long sleeve knee-length white gown that has a stylish vertical Ankara bow on the left. The neckline is a deep vee, having the effect of a corporate and casual look. "Luba, you need to give your speech now. The schedule."

As we walk with Chiluba to the birthday cove, Zena draws close to me. "You look gooood..." She says, eyeing my knee length sleeveless Ankara gown I had exchanged for my site-supervision-jeans. "You should dress up more often."

I click my tongue, shouldering her. "Shut up, my friend."

She giggles and quickly recomposes herself to the bad bitch she carries herself to be in public. The event planner tells Chiluba to wait a moment before giving her speech.

"How's it coming?" I ask Chiluba as we settle in her cove. There are over five cakes on the table before us. Wow. "This looks great but you..." I shake my head, wondering how I got a real gee like her as a friend. "You look takeaway."

"This is my first look." She spread out her arms so I can take a critical look at the design. There's a lot of pleating, threading and intricacies.

"Love it."

Zena's eyes sparkle. "Have you seen the shoes?" Chiluba strikes a pose and I look down to find the gift I ordered online for her. "They were the perfect match, sent from heaven."

Tears cloud my eyes when I look back up at Chiluba.

"I love them!" Chiluba says and this time, I move in to hug her. "Thank you."

Grinning tightly, I mutter, "You're welcome."

Chiluba gives her speech, thanks us for coming out tonight, then opens the dance floor. Straight to the point. In a blink, the brightly lit room changes to DJ lighting with Party Rock Anthem by LMFAO bellowing from the speakers.

Chiluba, Zena and I are like the power puff girls. Always dancing together, although occasionally, a well-wisher will snag Chiluba away for a while and she will stand off on the edge, smiling and nodding to whatever they are shouting in her ear.

Amid the fun and felicitations, my heart will thump when I see a tall silhouette pass by, hoping it is Manir, but... it only ends up dampening my mood when I find out he is not the one.

Two guys, on separate occasions, walk up to me and I am poor company. I give one my phone number, but I doubt I will ever pick his call.

Excusing myself, I head to the bathroom and do my business. *Don't check your phone. Don't check your phone. Have a good time. Don't check your phone!* But I do. Nothing.

I head back to the cove to find Chiluba surrounded by *friends*. I recognize one, Kola. Met him during a Fashion event Chiluba invited me to last year.

"I thought you were going to miss out on this." He grins.

"I'm here." Forcing a smile, I take in his black shirt on dark trousers, not bad, but not my type. No spark.

"Excuse me. Ladies." We look up to find a man in formal attire. "We need the celebrant on the red carpet."

Chiluba grins, handing her purse and phone to me. "I'll be right back."

"I'm coming with you."

We head out together, moving around guests to get the shock of our lives. It happens in slow motion, the people, the bag of gifts, me pinching Chiluba to accept the small box, the grand reveal.

Chiluba got the latest Range Rover! And...

“Who gave this to you?” Zena asks in awe as we inspect the ride.

“I don't know.” A laughing Chiluba says. “A secret admirer?” Her eyes meet mine and I know. She knows…

But what? I’m happy for my friend. She deserves it!

“Luba, Luba!” Kola begins. “We’re turning up tonight. The Club.” His gaze flickers to one of Chiluba’s *friends*, Ese, who like me, he just met. We take pictures, striking poses, smiling till my cheeks hurt.

Once we return to the cove, I raise a toast. “Farewell to Funsho.” I’m glad he didn’t sully the event by making an appearance.

“Cheers to the good life.” Chiluba toasts, giggling.

Zena looks down at her phone, then raises her head, a wicked grin in place. “Are you ladies ready to get wild?”

Am I?

After a long day involving an evaluation with Madam Nelly, completing my Professional Practice Exam, and breaking up with my ex, am I ready to get wild? Of course!

OceanofPDF.com

EIGHTEEN

TITLE SEARCH

Zoya

You'll never find a friend as true as me. If you do, and want to stop communication with me, don't just cut me off. Invite me to dinner and let's toast to the good times.

BATTLING WITH WARMTH FROM SUN RAYS stroking my cheek by waving my arm instead of standing up to close the curtain is useless. The distant sound of a vendor hawking her goods… and. Is that a snore I hear?

Sulkily, I rise from bed and head to the bathroom I share with my dearest sister, Zena. That I can hear her snore with her room being across from mine is maddening. Less than a week in the house, and I can't wait to wave her farewell tomorrow evening. Although the three-year-age difference between us doesn't reflect much—except for when she's being a pest—I worry about her, but I have since learned to respect her privacy.

Mom had three of us—Zele, I and Zena. But Zele was born twelve years before me, out of wedlock. Dad left mom to study, to chase his dreams and

returned to find her with his son, unwed. He married her, brought her to Lagos, and they had I and Zena. Zele was adjusting to puberty, when I was hanging on to mom's skirt, it set the tone for our relationship, that by the time I turned ten, Zele was out of the country to study. And at fourteen, mom had succumbed to an avoidable death by typhoid.

When dad realized his daughters could fend for themselves, he pursued his architectural career blindly, sometimes I think it's out of grief, that life cheated him of the love of his life, again, but we just lost a mother too, we needed him. Anyway, we had Aunt Clara and from the way we turned out; we did good. Oh, last night...

Chiluba, who had planned on having us over at hers after our club tour ditched us when she met another *friend*—this one I know—at a restaurant we stopped to refuel at two in the morning. Even though I know this friend and agreed to take her new ride home, I sent her messages to confirm her safety before hitting the sack.

After preparing breakfast—bread, egg, and tea—I settle on my bed to unwind with the animated movie, The Smurfs. Pelumi had downloaded movies for me at work earlier this week.

My phone vibrates and I pick it to find it's noon. Scrolling down, I find several notifications from Instagram. I am tagged in over twenty photos! The culprit is Chiluba.

Some pictures are cute, some awkward. And there's a one-minute humiliating video of me holding the hookah pipe and grinding on a random guy with Zena hailing me somewhere in the background. I concentrate on the cute pictures, amazed that although I had been pensive all night, waiting for Manir to magically appear, they could capture dozens of stunning pictures. *I'm a slayer!*

Opening BBM, I find Manir has responded to my message with a screenshot of me dancing with the random guy.

Nice moves. Can't keep up.

He did not reply to my previous message or bother to ask about my well-being. What does he mean by can't keep up? I let out a sigh and opt to call him. Our communication so far has been stiff. Yes, I know he has insinuated us dating and yada, yada, yada, but… We need to talk and understand what is happening between us. He is not picking.

12:09 PM
Zoya: Want to ring me back?

The animated movie is not sinking in anymore. Thoughts of Manir's lack of response is killing me…

He didn't reply to my messages yesterday, the only assurance I had of him being alive was my messages showed he had read them. And he replies with a cryptic text and screenshot.

Ugh!

I brush off tiny beads of moisture gathering on my nose, sniffling. I need to discuss this issue with someone. Am I overreacting? We are just friends, yeah? I like him. Yes, I like him. It's not a crime to like someone and be bothered about their safety. But when they respond with a cryptic text like that and with what went down at their place weeks ago… *you know it's beyond like.* Should I ask him out?

No way! We are not in the same place in life. He travels, has no root and-and, even if I propose being exclusive, who am I deceiving? Wanting to trap a *worldly man*? I need to speak to someone to know I am not overreacting.

Chiluba?

Definitely not. Chiluba is not an option. And she is probably still high from everything she ingested yesterday.

"Who to call? Who to call?" I chant. "Oh." The light bulb turns on in my head. "Aunty Clara!" My face brightens like a petal kissed by the sun.

Aunty Clara is my mother's younger sister who had lived with us after we lost our mother. Zena once whispered that Aunty Clara will be daddy's new

wife. Although I am fond of her—we developed a special bond—the idea didn't sit well with me. It was relieving when she accepted a marriage proposal from a brother in church. Now she lives in Ibadan with her sons.

We've maintained communication through the years. Aunt Clara knows about the legendary Queen Zo and Mighty_man1 friendship—the basic parts. She will be the best source for guidance, with her maturity and experience.

I dial once and it goes through.

"Hello?" comes the questioning childish voice, not Aunt Clara's. If I was not familiar with Jude's antics, I'll believe I dialed the wrong number.

"Hello Jude, its aunty Zoya..." I sing.

"Zoya!" he chimes enthusiastically. Rolling my eyes, I smile at his antics. Talk about kids born in Yankee being disrespectful in Nigeria. Would have loved to indulge him in a chat, but I am too impatient for that.

"Could you please give the phone to mommy?"

"Okay." He drawls, clearly disappointed he's not the one I want to talk to.

His uneven footstep go, and I imagine his six-year-old self, searching for his mommy in their big house.

"Mommy... it's Zoya."

"Next time say aunty Zoya."

I can imagine Aunt Clara wagging her fingers as she collects the phone.

Jude's reply is muffled. "Yes mommy."

Aunt Clara and I exchange pleasantries. Her soothing voice washes through me before I set about explaining my dilemma.

"So, you broke up with your boyfriend to be with him?"

"No aunty. I did no such thing. I broke up with Eric because—that has been a long time coming."

"Hmm..."

"Yes. Now I think I'm liking Manir too much and it's affecting the way I see our friendship. I think I am expecting... too much?"

"Hmm..."

"Because when I think of it, if he eventually ends up in a relationship, would we still be friends?" My palm is cold and moist. "Our-Our friendship is not something I want to give up, but it's been hard going back to the way it was before we met in person..." I rub my palm on my thigh. "With the cryptic message he sent to me, I don't understand." Biting my lips.

"So, what do you want to do?"

Scrunching my eyebrows together, I pick on a lint on my shorts. "Maybe ask him out?"

"Hmm! Ehizoya."

I chuckle. "Aunty, it's that bad o. He too... he has been leading me on."

"He is a man. And sometimes these men need to be guided. Starting the conversation is a subtle way to go. However, you have to be careful and not sell yourself short. No one is forcing you into marriage. I know my in-law would not."

"Ah. Left to daddy, Zena and I will not get married." With the way he is about us not leaving the house before marriage. Zena has confided in me she would move out once she's done with her Service year.

"Is this because you want to leave your father's house? I thought you were focused on your career."

If I see marriage in Manir's package, I'll take it. No one said getting married will stop you from achieving your goals. And I'm only in this house because I want to be.

"I am... The thing with this guy is... This guy is always on my head. In my mind. I want to know whether asking him to ask me out makes sense, or I should ask him out or... I should just..." Closing my eyes, as saying the words out loud tears a part of my heart. "Just end our friendship, because at this point..." I sigh. "It's stressing me unnecessarily."

"You need to find a balance, and this can only work if you both communicate. If you're sure he is single, it wouldn't hurt to try your luck. Doesn't mean you will end up together. The most important thing to get a

relationship going is respect, after that trust. If he respects your feelings, he will make the right choice. All this talk of he is leading me on, I'm leading him on, will be a thing of the past."

Aunty Clara believes in respect. Maybe that was why she took her sweet time in finding and accepting her husband. Our discussion shifts to mundane things after she makes me promise to do what's best for me.

There's a light knock on my door, before it creaks open. I look up to find Zena.

"Who's that?" She mouths, leaning on the door jamb, still in her PJs.

Ignoring her, I smile, announcing to Aunt Clara, "Zena is here."

Zena frowns, stepping into my room, whispering, "Who's that now?"

"I thought she's supposed to be in Osun State," Aunt Clara says.

"She came for Chiluba's birthday. I can place it on loudspeaker."

Zena sits on the bed, annoyed I'm talking about her to someone she doesn't know. "Who now?" she mouths.

"Place it," Aunt Clara says.

I do, tossing the phone on the bed.

Zena sees the caller ID and taps my leg in annoyance. "Aunty Clara," she smiles but turns to me with a frown on her face.

"You ehn!"

"Good afternoon ma."

"Good afternoon yourself. You're in Osun here, you cannot come and visit me, but you can travel all the way to Lagos for a party."

Zena shoots daggers at me as she takes on Aunt Clara's bullets. "It's not like that aunty Clara."

"Even for your nephews. Every other week, Jude and James ask after you."

I grin at the guilt tripping and decide to stoke the flame. "Don't mind her. She has been snoring all morning."

"Zoya!"

I cackle, picking up my phone. "Aunt Clara, I need to go."

"Okay. Ehn Zena, when are you visiting us?"

Zena shakes her head at me. "Soon ma. I will call you."

"Okay oh. Alright. You girls be good, you hear?"

"Yes ma."

"Greet your father for me. Take care."

After asking why I was speaking to Aunt Clara, to which I tell her is a courtesy call, Zena raises her nose before stalking out of my room, looking like a teenager.

"Zena!"

"What?" She returns to my door post.

I smile coquettishly. "Please," pointing at my plate on the floor.

She hisses.

"Thank you."

"Did you make mine?"

"You were sleeping."

"Whatever." She picks the plate, strutting out of the room like a peacock.

Left to my thoughts, I pick my phone and scroll to Manir's BBM page. Does he see me as someone significant? Should I let him know I like him? As Aunty Clara said, does he respect me and my feelings?

I think he does. He has apologized whenever he said or did inappropriate things or things, I don't find amusing. I'm out of my zone on this one.

Trying my best not to sound needy and after much editing, I close my eyes and click the send icon.

1:34 PM
Zoya: Are you still coming to town next week?

Rhapsody's still on?

Delivered it shows, and in seconds it shows, read. I close my eyes and wait for what feels like a lifetime before my phone buzzes.

1:35 PM
Manir: Did you cancel?

What?

My phone rings. *He is calling. He is calling!*

Take a deep breath, take a deep breath...

"Hello?"

"How's Queen Zo doing?"

"I've told you to stop calling me that."

"But I like it... It's regal?"

"Hmm..."

"But if you seriously don't like it. I can stop. Do you like Confessor?"

"Confessor?"

"Google it. You'll like it. That's your new nickname."

Oh Manir... I'm not bothered about nicknames or new names. "I'll take it. So, are you... coming to Lag next week?"

"I didn't know plans changed."

"No... no. I'm just-I just wanted to confirm."

"Nothing will keep me from Lagos next week. And—"

"I—"

"Sorry about yesterday. I got carried away with work and then a lot of things happened."

"Hmm..."

"I got your message. Me being around for the birthday girl."

Best to tell him how I feel now. "I was looking forward to your response, only to get that cryptic message this morning. I was really looking forward to seeing you."

"I'm sorry Confessor. I'm creating time to spend with you by working extra time. You've got great dancing skills, though."

"I'll take that as a compliment, thank you."

"Good. So, we're still up for next week Friday? Because I've specially cleared my calendar for you."

"I'm in."

Immediately I hang up, I jump off my bed and do the *bum bum dance*. It entails touching toes, whining my waist and hopping about.

Yes! I'm going to dance better than I did at the club in church tomorrow.

****

Uptight, I just finished a two-hour meeting with a client when I see a man in a suit, one hand in pocket, coming out of Arc. Wole's office. He is smiling when his eyes meet mine and my breath hitches, making me slow down my stride.

Were it not for the office environment, I would have met him halfway with a welcome back hug. Instead, I gather myself together, dashing to my desk to review some changes on my desktop, a big smile on my face. Seeing him unexpectedly improves my mood because asides the client asking for changes on what the team is halfway through on, I got a piece of bad news earlier.

He pauses by my desk and mentions something—with a serious face, while my smile expands—about my great work ethic, and me deserving a well-planned late dinner at Rhapsody's, Ikeja tonight. With that, he disappears.

3:20 PM

Manir: Are you the lady I saw earlier?
You are glowing! Got a new cream?

3:21 PM
Zoya: Glow?
Hmm.
You'll have to wait till this evening to confirm this glow.

My day continues like something out of a fairytale when Kaffy brings a vase of flowers to my desk.

"Whose are those?" I ask.

"Yours?" She grins.

Accepting the vase, I thank her, staring suspiciously at it.

"There's a card there." Kaffy enthusiastically points at it, still grinning.

"Thank you," I say, picking the sealed card, hanging by a piece of thread.

"Is it your birthday?" She winks.

"Not until December, but..." I turn to her. Does she think I'll open the card and read out the contents to her? We are not friends... "Thank you."

Tonight.

- *Manny*

That's all it reads.

I kick my legs beneath the table, giddy with excitement. What is he hinting at? Gosh! This is getting exciting. I might need to change my dress selection for tonight.

OceanofPDF.com

NINETEEN

BLIND OFFER

Manir

She kept talking about her ex. I couldn't stand it. Had to excuse myself. I'm not a therapist. How was your date?

MY DATE IS LATE. **NEVER HAVE I** ever been this eager for a date to begin. And Rhapsody's, even with their reputation and impeccable service so far, they can do better about their drink offerings. I specifically asked for Tequila Sunrise, not Tequila Surprise. This tastes like a mixture of Five Alive and Nutri C instead of fresh orange juice. Thanks to the server hovering around, thorough with his job. What other surprise do they have for me? Would it be too late for me to change our location? I want only the best for Zoya. Only—my phone vibrates.

9:07 PM
My Confessor: I'm here. Where are you?
Manir: Outside, beside the potted plant in the corner. On the left.

It's a rooftop bar, overlooking the colorful night life of Nigeria's megacity. The intense, phosphorescent moonlight and bright, visible starlit sky alone would have worked perfectly for tonight's agenda, nevertheless, I'm grateful for the artificial blue neon light offered by Rhapsody's. A perfect setting for what I'm about to do. I glance up from my phone.

There she is! I smile, taking in my date, gracefully strutting in fuck-me open-toed high heels, wearing a lemon green turtleneck gown that hugs her in the right places. All eyes are on her as she makes her way to me, and I feel giddy knowing she's here for me.

She styled her medium length afro to look spikey, creating a stunning effect with the hoop earrings she has on. Completely different from the lady I met at work today. The glow is still on though.

I know when she notices me. Her stride changes, her smile brightens. I want to beat my chest to ward off prying eyes. Let them know she is mine. Mine. And I don't share. *So caveman-ish Manir.*

Rising, I move to hug her. Her fruity scent hits my nostrils. *Pineapples*... And she whispers in my ear. "Sorry I'm late."

"This is Lagos." I pull back, smiling. "I'm glad you made it."

Her response is a shy smile and a quick scan of the outdoor restaurant. "Looks lovely. Ah, what is this all about?"

She makes to sit, but I stop her. "Hold on." Pulling out her seat, which causes her to tilt her head at me in surprise. "Come on..." Indulge me.

She sits, still looking perplexed, and I return to my seat.

"You are really going all out tonight."

"Need to. Last time, I invited you to my place, you insinuated it was..." I search for the proper word to describe her reluctance during our call. "Too low budget for you."

"But I ended up liking it."

“I know you did. I was in the mix.” I wink. “But call this change of scenario? Trying something different.” Then nod.

“And I’m sure it’s going to be worthwhile.” We stare at each other for a beat, my chest expanding.

Her smile quavering. “Um… How’s work? And life?”

“All good. Stressful but good. I finally placed your scent. It’s pineapple.” And I’ll never see pineapples the same way again, never.

A relaxed smile crosses her face. “Is that what’s on your mind? Pineapples?”

“No. You.”

Her gaze turns flat.

Oof. You can do better man. “You are on my mind. Have been on my mind. And with the pineapples, I’ve been trying to place your fragrance all along and I just got it.”

“Oh.” A warm smile brightens her face, with her hand cautiously moving to her nape. “It’s my leave-in conditioner.”

“Uhn?”

“For my hair.”

“Oh.” Slowly making doodles on the table with a finger. “You must tell me the brand so I can stock up on it for my travels.”

“Wow. Great remedy for when you miss me, right?”

I squint, smiling hard. “You have no idea.”

“Good evening, sir, ma…”

A voice rudely interrupts our moment and I glance up to find the server who has been hovering around with a menu book in hand.

“What would you like to have?”

Clicking my tongue at him, I turn with a smile to Zoya who is struggling not to laugh. “What are you having?”

She accepts the menu book, perusing it with both eyes and fingers. “Hmm… Prawn suya…”

“You will love that, ma,” the server chimes.

“No. Not that.” Zoya quickly corrects, glancing at the waiter. “I haven’t tried it before. I like the arrangement… Prawn suya accompanied with onion tomato salsa. Hmm…” She’s salivating.

“You want that?” I ask.

“Wait.” She raises one palm, trailing the book with the other finger, reading out loud. “Homemade vegetable chicken spring rolls… This looks interesting.” Raising her head with a smile for me.

I have a foodie in my hands.

“You want that?” I ask again.

Shaking her head, she returns the menu book to the waiter. “I’ll have chicken wings instead.” Then turns to me. “Better to stick to something familiar before I embarrass myself.” She winks.

“Right.” Now I understand. This is officially our first date, and she wants it to be perfect. I’m sorry Confessor, I’m going all out. Glancing at my menu book noting nothing, I hand it to the waiter. “We’ll have everything she mentioned.”

“Manir…”

“We’ll share.”

The waiter nods. “And drinks?”

Zoya looks at me, giving a small laugh. “Water works for me.”

Like I didn’t see her dancing and smoking *shisha* the other night at a club. Hate to be a snob, but no one’s having water on our first date. “I let you order the food. It’s my turn.”

“Okay…”

“Trust me on this.” I grin widely.

Covering her mouth, she stifles a gasp. “Nothing crazy or bitter, please.”

"We mostly serve chapman and cocktails, ma." The server parrots, handing me a drink menu. I'm tempted to tell him to shut up as he continues, "They serve stronger drinks at the bar." His thoroughness is getting on my nerves.

There's a special with Hennessy VS and sprite calling my name and just to look for trouble and start a conversation, I hold a straight face when I inform the server of our order choices. "Lagos Lemonade for me and Virgin Daiquiri for her."

He nods and heads on his way, while Zoya lets out the laugh she has been holding.

"What did you just order?"

"I think you'll like it." The server was just doing his job. My bad for feeling testy.

She shakes her head. "What's in it?"

"Peach, lime, and some other stuff."

"Virgin Da...?"

"Daiquiri."

"Touché."

Our conversation flows from food to travel when the drinks arrive in less than three minutes.

"Besides this being a wonderful way to hang out with you after weeks of being away," I start, ready to get into the business of tonight, "I also want to get to know you better."

"Really? What would you like to know about this enigma that you don't know about yet?"

I stare clueless at her, a smile on my face.

"I was joking." She giggles.

On cue, the waiter returns twice with our meal; six prawn suya decorated with lemons and some green veggies for effect, accompanied with onion and tomato salsa in a little bowl. Four chicken vegetable spring rolls served with

sweet chili and sesame soy sauce and finally the chicken wings marinated in barbecue sauce and a spicy garlic mayonnaise dipping.

"I didn't pass the PPE."

I pause in between bites. "How come?"

Laughing self-consciously, she takes a sip of her drink before responding. "I don't know. I'll have to try again in September."

"I'm sorry about that. You had everything they needed. And I'm sure your interview went well. You did a good job."

"It's Nigeria." She shrugs, picking a vegetable roll in one hand. "So I'm not bothered. Making things unnecessarily difficult."

"That's messed up."

"I'll do better next time. Won't take any chances."

This taints everything I have planned for tonight. "I'm sorry about it."

"Thank you." She forces a smile that doesn't reach her eyes. "Can we talk about something different? Just want to put that out there."

The sesame soy sauce tastes fresh and when mixed with the sweet chili, as Zoya suggests, gives it a spicy taste.

"You know I am seeking to settle down, right?" I begin.

"You say it like an African prince sent off to look for his bride." She says, taking a delicate bite of the barbecued chicken.

An African prince sent off to look for—I laugh. "Well-played." Licking my lips.

She shrugs. "My great African prince, you need my help in seeking your one true love?"

If only you know what has been going on in my head these past weeks. It might sound old school, looking to get into a relationship with *a good girl*, but knowing Zoya to the point of knowing that she has not intimately been with another man makes me excited beyond my wildest dreams. Means that she can be wholly mine.

Mine.

"Can you help?"

She sighs, leaning back in her seat, her face taking on a solemn expression. "Is this our farewell dinner?"

Picking a vegetable roll, I look at the girl who has turned to a woman from across me, a wry smile on my lips. "It's not. Why would you think that?"

"I don't know… We've lost our friendship spark? You met someone?"

"No, to your first assumption. Yes, to the second."

It almost escapes me, but I catch it before she feigns nonchalance. She grimaced. "You're so sweet. So, this is my courtesy break-up dinner?"

I reach for her hand across the table. Her delicate artistic fingers. "Yes…?"

She laughs, too loud and a little brittle, removing her hand from mine. "You don't have to be so dramatic about it." Leaning forward, she asks. "She's the jealous type? Do I know her? One of your exes? Is that why…" Spreading her palm on the table.

"Let's not talk about her?"

"Oh." She sits up. "I don't know her then."

"I'm learning more about her. Daily."

Her eyes sparkle. "She's a new one then." She shakes her head. "I can't believe this is how it will all end." She inhales, placing a hand on her face. "Can I—" Sucking air through her teeth.

I lean forward. What's happening? "Should I—"

Zoya waves one hand to stop me before picking up a serviette. "It's fine. Pepper. The food." She fans her face, looking heavenward, eyes glistening. "I think I got something in my eyes."

"Are you sure you don't want me—"

"It's fine. I can't believe this is happening now." She lets out a bubbly laugh. Dropping her hands, she releases a whooshing breath. "See. I'm fine."

Grinning. “Ah-em,” Clearing her throat. What’s happening? “So, you’re settling down. The wedding you invited me for… is that…”

“It’s Bucknor’s wedding.”

She looks at me funny.

I reaffirm it. “It Bucknor’s. I told you. You’re supposed to be my groomsman, remember?”

“Best man.”

“Yes.” Taking a sip of my almost finished drink, I recall the joke we made years ago. Roughly three years ago, around the same time, she went on about her childhood dream of getting a dating band, only to grow into adulthood to realize it was a childish and unrealistic expectation. “So, trash that thought.”

“Alright. Alright.” She nods, then hugs herself. “It’s getting kind of chilly here.”

I’m tempted to laugh and also draw out this moment of uncertainty, but I like her too much to let her suffer like this. “I’ll wrap this up now. I want to settle down and—”

“You’ve mentioned this before.” She laughs.

“Will you please calm down?” I smirk.

She rolls her eyes, then leans back.

Inhaling slowly… just to rub it in, before exhaling, I begin my well-planned speech. “You know I like you.” I am enough.

Shrugging, she smirks. “It’s obvious.”

I stretch my hand on the table, beckoning her to place hers in mine and she does, with a slow, questioning smile—a what are you up to kind of smile.

“I’m getting there, Zo… It’s ridiculous but, trust me, I need to get it right.”

She looks everywhere but my face. “I can’t believe you rehearsed our breakup.”

“You’re the one who keeps coming up with crazy expectations.” Wedding in Dubai. 1 4 3. Dating band. Chastity till marriage. What am I getting myself

into?

"I was young and childish."

"It made our chats sweet, dramatic and engaging."

Her mood shifts to something sad.

"Hey, I said that with a clean mind. Please smile." Tugging on her hands, she responds with a wan, brave smile.

"What do I need to know, Manir?"

Smiling, I drop my hint again. "That I like you."

She shakes her head, with no clue with what I'm about to do. "You've said that already."

Nodding my head in approval, she lets out that bubbly laugh I'm guessing is her nervous laugh, before remembering we're in a public space.

"Okay..." She nods, with a sympathetic, expectant smile. "I like you too."

"I also want you to know I have been thinking of how we could make the best of our relationship by," I dip my hand into my breast pocket, presenting her with a black ring, "getting this ring to ask you to be my girl." The alarm in her eyes and slow breath intake, assures me I've nailed it completely. "Want to seal this deal?"

Zoya stares at the ring, my face, the ring again, then pulls her hands from mine.

"Manir..." She looks to the side suspiciously, fanning her cheeks, hoping her acting isn't gathering an audience. "Dramatic and engaging, eh?"

"You taught me." When she doesn't move to accept the ring, I ask. "Is this a, no?"

She looks around warily, then her gaze lands back on me, observing the black band like it's some off-limit thing. "This is not a joke?"

Scoffing, I shake my head. "It's the real deal."

"You remembered." She breathes, stretching her left fingers. I insert the ring on her index finger. Pulling her hand off mine, she admires the black

band which reflects the moon under the blue neon lights.

"Like it?"

"Love it." Smacking her lips.

"Did I get it right?"

"It's perfect."

"Do I..." This is asking too much. "get a kiss?"

"Maybe later."

"Hmm."

"Much later." She grins, waving her finger at me, then pauses. "Um..." A frown mars her forehead.

"What is it?"

Leaning forward, with cautious eyes, she answers. "I don't want this relationship to mess with our friendship and you know I'm waiting till marriage, so no—"

"No sex. That's fine. I am in this for the long haul." I can live with that. Who says we can't get married in one month? Or she changes her mind, with this sexy goodness all up in her face. "No sex."

"Manny..." She absentmindedly rolls the ring, while training imploring eyes at me.

"Men do it. I can."

"I know you have an active sex life and I—"

"I'll never cheat on you. Don't even think about that." You are enough. "Just remember my promise, the one back at my place." Once we cross the, no sex bridge, all this restraint won't be in vain.

"Um... Thank you?"

I smile. "And I have my ways of dealing with urges."

"Gross." She chuckles. "I don't mind watching."

“Confessor, you don’t want to be in the same space with me when that’s happening.”

“Jeez. So…”

“Time to meet with your father.”

“Not happening, yet.”

I grin and she slowly smiles, her expression wondering what I’m up to. “I love you.” I’ve always known.

Oh boy… I said that out loud.

Waiting for what seems like a thousand years for her response, I reach for her hand. “You good?”

“Mm hmm?” Trying for a brave smile.

“Okay… but I love you. It’s a fact.”

“Can we go with 1 4 3 instead?” Clears her throat. “Until-until I warm up to saying it?”

“It’s strange? You don’t feel that way?”

Pressing her lips together multiple times, she answers, scrunching her face. “I’m fresh from an old relationship. I want to mean it when I say it—”

“You think I don’t—”

“No, no.” Squeezing my hand reassuringly, looking me in the eye. “I feel you do. Just give me time, okay? To warm up to it.” Rubbing my fingers.

Till you warm up to it then. I smile, pressing her fingers.

OceanofPDF.com

Love makes you do crazy things.

—Anonymous

OceanofPDF.com

TWENTY

TURNKEY-READY

Zoya

It's my dad. In plain English, he loves his profession than his family. Than his children.

I DIDN'T SEE IT COMING. NOT in a million chats! All thoughts of asking him out or asking him to ask me out wiped off my brain when he said he had met someone. In my head, I was like, is this it? We're done? And then he… Gosh! Manir fulfilled my childhood fantasy. My dream dating proposal gone right. Righter than right.

April has seen the light showers of March turn to downpours. Although the president has announced the government will subsidize fuel prices to immediately reduce the price, fuel scarcity is still going on strong in some Nigerian cities. Governors are slapping each other at public events. The naira is running a relay race with the dollar, gaining today and losing tomorrow. While Mr. President refused to sign the budget, only until last Friday did he

eventually sign it, because he has been globetrotting, just like Chiluba—going out and not giving me the full gist.

Since her birthday, she has been acting weird. All I see are pictures of her dressed up for one event or the other. She is working on this stuff with 34 Threads and Silhouette, but that doesn't mean we neglect our friendship. Is it me? Because I am now in a relationship? Can't be. Manir and I are still in a hybrid long distance relationship. Doing the same thing we've always done.

Throughout the week, I have been drawing hearts, writing M & E in them. It is so bad, that I did it on a document I was supposed to hand over to Madam Nelly. I had had to bear the consequences of printing the document again. On the bright side, the page of the document didn't contain signatures or letter heading.

Dosu-Andrews Ehizoya. Now that's a cute name. Although I'll go down a list by four letters, Dosu-Andrews sounds so much better than Ainabe.

Manir's calls have doubled and mine has quadrupled. We've even moved to Skype calls. Since we don't spend time physically together, we had to upgrade our communication technology.

"Third Sunday of April sounds like a suitable time to visit your parent?"

"For what?" He is hellbent on meeting my dad. I don't know what game he is playing. "Don't try anything crazy."

He chuckles. "You're not supposed to be aware if that's what I wanted to do."

"Hmm... so this is an innocent visit, right?"

I'll be twenty-eight this year, and have never brought any man to the house, talk less of introduce them to my father as my boyfriend. Manir is going to be the first and I hope he would be the last. He is definitely worth snagging from Lagos girls.

With the level of familiarity Manir and I have, I believe nothing can go wrong with this relationship. Knowing Manir as a stranger and now, knowing him as a real person, I don't think he will ever cheat on me or do anything to hurt me.

****

With preparations for Manir's visit in full swing, Zena returned home this weekend to see him for herself. She was the one who suggested we attend the first service with daddy, where on a normal day we would have attended the second service.

The way Zena carries on about Manir's visit will make a stranger think it is her man coming over. Did Manir plan something with her? Is my life about to change in the blink of an eye? And will I say yes if he pops the real question?

It's too soon. It's barely a month since we started dating.

"Zoya!" Zena sounds like she is by the door.

Wiping soap suds off my eyes, I shout back. "Stop shouting my name!"

"Come out of the bathroom now... We have a lot to do today."

"And so?"

"Daddy has gone, we have to a take bus now." She hisses.

Zena is acting suspicious. Maybe it's not a collaboration with her and Manir, maybe she's met some guy at NYSC and wants me out of the way so she can get engaged or something. Since she returned home, her phone calls seem to go on forever, filled with lots of *hmms* and *yeses*. She has never gone on a date—that I know of—or told me of a guy she likes or something. She's so indifferent with dating and men, never bothering to check them out when they do her or give them a chance. Even the ones in church.

We make it in time for the first service, after which we make our way to the Ikeja City Mall to get fresh ingredients for stew and salad. Not that there isn't stew in the freezer, but Zena pressed on the fact that her soon to be in-law cannot eat a two-week-old stew on his first visit.

"Who told you he's your in-law?" I ask from the back seat.

"Just follow my plan and we'll see what happens."

The plan is that after service, daddy will take us to the mall, then Zena will do all other cooking preparations but boil rice.

Zena is a superb cook, but for boiling rice, she experiences serious difficulties. When she feels down, the rice might be too hard. Or too soft when she feels overly excited. It is her greatest kitchen flaw, but everybody is happy with it because her soups, stews and every other meal is tasty.

We alight from the car, and daddy heads to a cafeteria that sells coffee, timing us to do a quick round of shopping. We make it two minutes before the agreed time and get lattes as a reward. We are his little girls, until one of us flies away.

Besides not going to church with daddy, everything has been going as planned. Even the preacher's choice of topic. It is something to reflect upon.

The preacher had talked on 'Relationship with God as a Basic Requirement to Relating with Men.' He had picked many texts from the bible, but the ones that had stuck with me were 1 John 4:10 and Romans 13:8-10.

> "This is the kind of love we are talking about—not that we once upon a time loved God, but that he loved us and sent his Son as a sacrifice to clear away our sins and the damage they've done to our relationship with God."—1 John 4:10

> "...and any other "don't" you can think of—finally adds up to this: Love other people as well as you do yourself. You can't go wrong when you love others. When you add up everything in the law code, the sum total is love."—Romans 13:8-10

It was a hands-on preaching, where he asked members of the congregation —married and single—to define love in their own terms. The congregation had risen to the challenge.

For some, their answers had sounded childish, immature, even though they were married. The opening bible verses had told me all I needed to know, that love was the ability to care for the other, even when they do not merit it.

It was a glorious service, one I wouldn't mind buying the audio for, so I can listen to it in my soon to come car. Well... the promotion is looking dicey now that I did not pass my PPE exams. I sigh loudly, causing Zena to toss an inquisitive stare my way.

"What is it?" Zena asks. I'm sure she's wishing she's here in the backseat.

"I'm fine." Sitting up, noticing the traffic light changing to red.

Zena nods, turning to face the road. "*What are these ones doing now?*"

We are almost home and I'm so grateful we are on this side of the road. On the other side, car owners are milling about, with various shades of jerry cans and kegs, they look like they're just returning from church and are arguing with men in uniforms in front of a closed fueling station. Some women have their grinding machines and generator tanks rolled to the fueling station. In the name of fuel scarcity, the car owners are causing slow movement as their cars are parked haphazardly by the road.

"Daddy?" Zena starts, gazing at the hullabaloo waiting to happen.

"Yes."

"When do you think this fuel scarcity would end?"

"Honestly, I don't know. Even the media has tried to interview who is who and have gotten no straight answer."

Zena turns her head to face forward as the light turns green while daddy moves the car. "Sometimes I wonder and don't understand why people bother with the unnecessary." She states, lacking her usual enthusiasm.

"Zena, like seriously?" I fire back. At one point in our lives, I thought my sister was a complete emo. But this, seeing herself as superior, mm hmm. "A woman who grinds pepper for a living is deprived of buying fuel for her machine in a keg because they think she would use it as black market is bothering herself with the unnecessary by bringing her machine to the pump?"

Zena slowly turns her head to the back seat, dramatically rolling her eyes, preparing for an argument. "Not that." Her lips twitch. "I understand that."

"Better," Dad says. "I know I trained you better."

We all laugh. But I doubt he gets the joke. He did no training. But love... Preacher just said that today, right? Zena continues, making her point.

"What I don't understand is why Nigerians, Lagosians especially, with the population it has, bother to fuel their car tanks every now and then... Because they want to take it to work? For crying out loud." Clapping her hands to make her point. "It is their personal car. Per-so-nal. Why can't they take the bus?"

"Because they have a car?" I reply.

"Come on... You studied abroad for a while now... I know they have cable cars and trains, and Nigeria has not gotten to that level yet. But at least we have buses. If people took commercial or staff buses to work during the week, it will reduce traffic congestion, increase the gains of commercial drivers, save the road from stress, save people from buying fuel, reduce traffic during fuel crisis and inevitably save people from stressing themselves on queues for fuel that might never come. Big sis, the list goes on." She ends with a big grin that indirectly says I'm smart, you know it.

"Ehizena for Minister of Transportation. I hope that in the next five-seven years, Lagos has found a way to reduce traffic congestion."

"You ladies are brilliant." Daddy says with a big grin, parking the car in the compound.

"You can say that again." Zena nods, hopping out of the car to grab both shopping bags from me. She huffs and puffs, mocking me, who has a weaker arm.

"Thank you." I tell her as we walk into the house.

"Still getting your car?" Everyone knows I want a brand-new car, not second-hand, but brand new.

"I'm thinking about it."

"Really?"

"Yeah, I start making deposits next month."

"After all my preaching?"

"When you start working and living full time in Lagos, you will understand."

"What about global warming?"

"No need to stress yourself. I've made up my mind." I add in a superior voice, "Don't worry, I won't let you drive it."

"I won't ask your permission to." She giggles, pushing open the kitchen door.

12:48 PM

Zoya: It's today. Can you make it?

OceanofPDF.com

TWENTY-ONE

SUBJECT TO INSPECTION

Manir

I'm an only son, but growing up, it never felt that way because I come from a big family.

"ARE YOU SURE YOU WILL MAKE it on time?" Zoya asks, her brows furrowing with worry.

"Yes, ma'am." I'm at a family shindig for Uncle Bashir's 65th. The moment I landed Nigeria last night, eager to meet with her family today, I got a notification on WhatsApp. I never open that stuff. But yesterday it happened, and I saw the talk about the birthday. Uncle Bashir has been my rock in my darkest times. Least I can do is honor the intimate family gathering in celebration of him. Ah... my conscience will not let me go to Zoya's without coming here first. "I'll never stand you up."

"I betcha." So much confidence in me. "Hurry though. Zena has been making life miserable for me, trying to control everything. She thinks I can't make right decisions because I am blindly in love."

Indistinct chatter filters through as a door closes in the distance. I'd wandered into the library without closing the door, wanting to make the call quick.

Casting a quick look to see no one is in the library with me, I grin at my screen. "I finally get to meet Zena."

"I don't know who's the most excited between you two. Just hurry, okay? I'm slaving in the kitchen. You had better not eat anything before coming down here."

That was close. I almost gave in to aunty Ladun's—Uncle Bashir's wife—egusi soup and pounded yam. She was sulky when I mentioned I won't be staying for long and worse when I rejected to eat. "Yes, yes."

"Let me leave you to celebrate then. Take care! Can't wait to see you."

"Same here."

"And don't feel—forget I said that." Feel what? "See you soon." She sings, then adds, "1 4 3."

"1 4 3." I respond, smiling as the call ends.

Zoya is... I don't know what to say, rare? She has these weird thoughts of how she wants things to go because she wants her relationship to be unique—different. It intrigues me, making me want to be the man who makes it possible. 1 4 3, you guess right, I love you.

I know it's her code word for I love you. I'm giving her time to learn to say the actual words to me.

"Is this where you are?"

I jump, turning to find a smiling aunty Rekiat.

"Aunt Rekky," I give her a half-smile.

She draws closer, her smile waning. I know that look in her eyes. I didn't come here for that. Only came to show my respect.

"I've been meaning to speak with you, but you're difficult to pin down."

Oh boy. We don't want to have this conversation. Not here. Not this time. "But I'm here, aunty." I grin, spreading my arms, hoping it is convincing enough, then drop them to my side. How do I get out of this without seeming rude?

Wrinkling her brows, she studies me, like an unnamed insect under a microscope. "How-how have you been?" The door has never seemed so far. "You don't tell anyone anything and distance yourself. It is—"

"Aunty Rekky."

She pauses, looking up at me, concern in her eyes.

"I'm fine. I've been fine."

Pursing her lips, she nods, still trying to understand something I, myself, don't know. This is me. Why can't they just accept that? This is why I don't stop by.

"Dele!" Idris' voice booms from afar.

Our time is up. I need to say my goodbyes and head to Zoya's.

"I need to go." I try walking around her, but she stays my arm.

"Wait. He can wait."

And I do. She's my aunt. I need to hear her out, no matter how many times she asks, no matter that I don't have an answer. "I know you're big man," here we go.

She holds my hands, searching my face. "With big goals and ambitions, leaving your mark in the world, looking out for others, but do you have anyone looking out for you? Have you been sleeping well? Eating well?"

I smirk. "Aunty Rekky, I'm fine."

"Hmm. Are you still seeing someone?"

I'm not in the university or kindergarten. I'm a grown man—a successful grown man. "Yes." Grinding my teeth. "And because it happened once doesn't mean my life has to stop." I reveal a lazy, arrogant smile, flexing my hands in hers reassuringly. "I'm fine, aunty."

"I don't know oh," Idris says as his voice and multiple footsteps draw closer, "he is still around *sha*. Gold said he's in the backyard. You finally get to meet him close up. It's because of Uncle Bashir he came and he's not even making himself useful."

"You people treat that boy like an egg. Like it was anyone's fault. I think it's because of his father. That obsessed freak. Gave birth to one too." A familiar voice says.

Instinctively, my hold on aunt Rekiat's hand tightens, but when I realize what I'm doing, I let go.

"Don't say that." The voice of Ọpẹ Johnson clearly states as they pass the opened doorway. "You were not here when it happened. He has no one. If you know what we went through because—"

"Ọpẹ..." Aunty Rekiat calls, and I wish to God she didn't.

I really enjoy hearing them talk about the freak in their family. Would they be happier if I had died, and my line of the family ended?

Ọpẹ, clearly startled, pauses. Footsteps shuffle as they retrace their step back to the doorway. I scoff as realization dawns on all of them. This is why I don't come to these gatherings. The familiar voice was Damilola's, a second cousin from dad's side of the family. She's into dance and theatre, doesn't follow in the family's business, but expects one of us to fund her projects. Projects that never see profit. Treating me like an egg, uhn?

"Ah!" Ọpẹ beams, everything she was saying earlier, swallowed with her next saliva. "I didn't believe you were here." She claps, eyes wide, smile slipping.

Idris Dosu-Andrews and Ọpẹ Johnson nee Dosu-Andrews were my childhood friends, children to Arc. Wole. Something happened when we were younger. Ọpẹ Johnson, keeps trying to offer an olive branch, but she's more concerned with watching me up close than really having me around.

"Obviously," I mutter. Turning to aunty Rekiat, I force a smile. "I need to find Uncle Bashir." Wish him all the best and leave. I've got another family I

want to spend more time with. Somewhere they'll welcome me like a normal human being. "I'm fine, aunty. I'll visit soon." The only promise I hardly keep.

The trio part to the side, stunned, as I walk out of the room. I can hear my heart beating with every long stride I take. If I can run, I will. But I'm too proud to do so. If I can turn back the hands of time, I would never have stopped by. Time has done nothing to change the way they see me. If I can...

Their voices ring loud in my head as I force a smile through the next activities—find Uncle Bashir, bid him happy birthday, make more promises we know I'll not keep, notice the way Idris' wife shields their infant from my touch, pose rigid for pictures, take my leave.

Treat like egg. Obsessed freak. His father. He has no one. Not useful. Obsessed freak. Not useful. Obsessed freak. Not useful. Obsessed freak. Obsessed freak. His father. Obsessed freak. His father. Obsessed freak. Their voices ring in my ear as I get to the car, knocking on the driver's window.

"Sir?" Ìgè winds down, looks up at me, expectant.

"I'm driving."

He steps out of the car, hands the keys to me, no questions asked. Concern reflects in his eyes. God bless his soul.

"Use a taxi. I'll reimburse you." He nods, and I get into the car.

The only reason I don't drive off the third mainland bridge as I drive to Magodo with Aṣa's Beautiful Imperfection album playing on repeat is Zoya. I can't let her down. I won't. I'll create my family with her, untainted by the past. Without walking on eggshells, waiting for a rebound.

Much better. I sigh as I park the car. Leaning back, I inhale and exhale, practicing mindfulness.

I'm Oladele Manir Dosu-Andrews. I love myself for who I am. I am doing a good job. I am not damaged, I am a whole person. I deserve happiness. I'm Oladele Manir Dosu-Andrews.

Few minutes later, I check my reflection, nodding at it with a smile. Afterward, I spray perfume and clasp a watch on my wrist. Stepping into the living room, I notice Bucknor sprawled on my sofa.

He'd dropped in on Friday night—before my arrival. He lives in an estate but had to crash here because his section of the estate has electricity issues and the body in charge is on strike.

On Wednesday, five days into living without electricity, with subsequent pleading and finally bribery, according to Bucknor, the body in charge promised that on Monday, electricity will be repaired and reconnected.

He has since then been fueling his generator so he can work. It was getting more hectic and expensive, acquiring fuel. It took the swollen eyes of his errand boy, after a fight at the fueling station, that Friday morning, for him to use my place as an alternative.

"How's it coming?" I ask.

Bucknor looks up from his laptop, smiling as he scrutinizes me. "All good. See you all dressed up, looking fresh and dapper."

My efforts have paid off then, moving to pick up car keys I tossed on the sofa when I stepped in earlier. "Thank you."

"Take care, man."

"Take care." I'm almost out the door when the question comes to mind. "Um... Bucknor?"

He looks up.

"Just curious," tapping my keys on my palm as I retrace my steps to him. "It's less than a month to your wedding. But I'm curious to know, is there anything you feel Bose hasn't told you that would change your mind about walking down the aisle?"

His head draws back quickly, then his mouth curves into a smile. "Ah... Is this about—"

"Maybe. But we're not talking about me." Still tapping my keys. "I'm just curious... like I said. Is there?"

"I-I don't know Manny. I love her. Love her enough to be bound to her by the law, by the church, our families and for life."

I stop tapping the keys, inhaling deeply.

“Hey Mann?”

I blink at his voice.

“Are you okay?” he asks.

“I’m good.” Flicking my wrist, I check the time. “Thanks. Got to go.”

As I turn to walk out, his words hit like blows to my solar plexus. “You’ll have to tell her one day. Take your time, but don’t wait too long.”

OceanofPDF.com

TWENTY-TWO

STREET IS HERE

Zoya

People who go into long-distance relationships should have a community. I can't imagine being in one.

"WHEN IS HE COMING?"

I have a developing headache. I am tired... Tired! Tired of Zena's constant probing and question.

"Did you invite Luba?"

"What's his full name again?"

"Hmm, from which state?"

"Which Yoruba person names their child, Manir? Sounds more like what a Hausa person would name her child."

"Ah! The guy from Rosa's blog."

"Um... How old is he?"

"Is he a Christian?"

"Are you sure he is coming?"

That was when we were in the kitchen. I couldn't have escaped Ehizena sooner. We are done now, and I get a moment of reprieve from her one thousand and one questions.

She is acting weird, double checking the bathroom is clean with no washed panties hanging around. Now she's spraying a wild scented mist in every corner of the living room.

I sneeze. "It's enough. It's just Manir. All these paparazzi is unnecessary."

Shaking her head, she tosses herself onto the seat beside me. "This is the first time *just Manir* is coming into our house, our home."

"So?"

"First impressions, big sis."

"It's just one day." I pray dad is on his best behavior.

She hisses, shaking her head like I don't understand what's happening. All thoughts of him asking me the big question today disappear from my head. Zena won't be this extra. Yes, she's somewhat introverted, that's why she's always returning home every other day, but she won't do all this cleaning and double checking because... what am I even thinking?

"Zoya..."

"Ye-yes?"

"I'll answer the door when he comes. You go to the room, so I can check him out before calling you."

"Yes, Zena..." Whatever you say tyrant.

"It's for your own good. Grand entrance and stuff."

"Yes." I check my messages. Chiluba is yet to respond.

"Are you sure he is—"

"If you ask that question, I'll—"

The knock comes three times and Zena jumps off her perch on the sofa, hurriedly making her way to the door.

"Who is it?"

Jeez. Danladi, the gateman, will not let a random stranger in. You know who is there.

From my position in the living room, I hear their exchange, which makes me feel as giddy as Zena was few seconds ago. Getting up, so he doesn't come in to find me sitting, I bounce on my heels.

"You're welcome... a no shoes home." Zena's voice, muffled but clear, carries to me. Jeez... Someone is putting on a show.

"Sure..." Manir's deep voice says, and I'm sure it's followed by his endearing smile.

I hear a thudding sound. Manir punching Zena? I stifle a giggle at the thought. Okay, that's not funny. But the way she has been bossing me around and her talkativeness is enough for me to punch her myself.

"Oh, sorry." Zena says.

"It's fine."

What happened? I hope they are alright.

"Your sandals are lovely. You'll have to link me up."

"Thank you..."

"The craftsmanship is... neat."

My eyes almost pop from their sockets. Zena is complimenting a guy? The opposite sex. Wow.

"Thank you."

A muffled laugh comes from Zena. "I'm sorry. Nervous... Let me take you in."

Zena? Nervous? You obviously are not. Not with the way you've been bossing me around.

I hope Manir finds our home comfortable. Unlike his spacious house he calls an apartment, our home is as homey as it gets. The last time we repainted was like five years ago and a plethora of family paraphernalia dots everywhere. The only noteworthy spot in the house is the landscape. Daddy invested so much in it.

"Yeah... Studied estate management and I'm supposed to be teaching English language in this school, but their former teacher teaches them English with Yoruba..."

Their voices draw closer, Manir's calm baritone and Zena's occasional self-conscious laughs. Should I get dad or wait for them to get here first? We already set the table. Oh. I'm supposed to be in my room... I guess that won't work now as they finally make it to the living room after what feels like an eternity, Zena leading Manir in tow.

He is wearing a black long-sleeved shirt with patches of Kente fabric around the neckline, paired with blue jeans, looking laid back. Perfect for a Sunday family brunch. It's been so long since I've seen him and I want to run into his embrace, absorb his essence.

"Here we have him." Zena announces, a twinkle in her eyes, completely forgetting I erred in our plan. "Welcome to—"

"Zena..." I smile, torn between apologizing for her chattiness or hugging him.

This is so unlike Zena. I have never seen her this flushed about a guy since primary school. She was a girly girl until university, then she changed.

"Do you guys want to... hug? Peck? Kiss?" Zena asks, folding her arms, before checking one of her perfectly manicured nails. "You know... Before daddy comes out."

Sucking air through my teeth with a way too sweet smile on, I shake my head, preparing an apology for Manir.

"Don't worry, I'm not watching." Zena adds to the awkwardness before turning her back on us.

Jeez... If only I can strangle her without a witness.

Manir makes a move before I do. He opens his arms, beckoning me, and I make my way to them. Note to self: add rat poison to Zena's food.

The moment his arms go around me, calmness envelopes me, and we create a bubble. Oh… The warmth from his body alone.

"Made it on time?" he murmurs, for my ears only.

I smile, stretching, as I murmur into his ears. "You did."

"You good?"

"I'm good. Just planning Zena's murder."

He snickers. "Please don't kill her. I like her already."

"We have that effect on men."

That said, Manir breaks into a guffaw. Removing myself from his arms, I swat him playfully on the shoulder. "Welcome."

Zena turns almost immediately. "Done? I didn't hear smacking sounds so…"

"Zena!" I whisper, mortified, casting Manir a quick apologetic look.

She shrugs, sparing us an impish smile. "I'll go tell daddy he is around."

High time you did. "Thank you."

I make sure Zena is on her mission before turning to face Manir with both brows raised in the universal question of, how fucked up do you think my sibling is?

"Lovely home." He dips his hands in his pockets and I can't help but admire how the Kente shirt accentuates his buff body. Wouldn't have pegged him as the Kente or Ankara guy, but I'm learning about him as we grow.

"Want to sit?" What I should have asked a long time ago. Zena had better not be lurking somewhere.

I gesture to the sofa, and he dominates it, dragging me along, to sit beside him. We form our own cocoon and for the brief minutes before Zena returns, I choose to indulge.

Placing my hand in his, he toys with the black band on my finger.

“Manny what is it?” Silence. Still toying with the black band. “Manny?”

I hold his jaw, commanding his gaze to meet mine. He gives a little wistful and unreadable smile as he says, “I’ve missed you.”

My heart reaches out to touch his. Staring at him, wanting to slay the dragons tormenting him. I’ve never seen him switch like this. “Are you okay?”

“Yeah,” his smile sunny, childlike.

Did I imagine the sadness in his eyes earlier?

“I must confess, I was actually dreading this meeting. But without saying much, your sister bought my heart.”

“I see.” So, he was only concerned about meeting my family. Hmm. But that sadness… Did I imagine it?

“And she made me see you in a different light. 1 4 3 extra right now.”

“Hey lovebirds.” Zena announces.

Jolting us from the cocoon we made. Placing a glass of chilled water on a stool, she moves the stool to our front.

“He’s almost here…” Zena backs away from us and moves to sit on another sofa. “But before he makes it,” her attention fully on Manir, “I just want to tell you congratulations.”

Congratulations for what? What’s happening? “What do you mean?” I ask.

“He’s trying to take my favorite human away.”

I snicker, so Chiluba is no longer your favorite human.

Zena moves forward in her seat, her gaze on Manir. “Just know that I have my eyes on you.”

“Ah. You’re here.” Dad says, walking into the living room.

Manir stands and I do too… clasping my hands together.

“Good evening, sir.” Manir nods.

“Good evening…” Dad waves at us to sit as he sits, too.

Zena picks the TV remote and begins flicking through channels.

"How was your trip down here?"

"Very fine, thank you, sir."

"That's good, that's good."

Dad and Manir share small talk—they discuss briefly about the current situation in Nigerian markets, rise and fall of dollar to naira, fuel scarcity, while Zena and I occasionally chirp in. Their camaraderie is remarkable, discussing like they've known each other for a while.

After a while, Zena asks. "Anyone hungry?"

She is really taking her role as a *mother* seriously today. If I have any doubt of my sister being unfeeling for outsiders, the last 24 hours have proved otherwise.

We proceed to the dining table for six. Everyone in the house acting like it's every day a boyfriend visits the house to have a family meal. Dad is really taking this in easy strides. Zena does most of the talking and it feels so natural having Manir over for dinner.

"I hear you are not always in Lagos." Dad says.

"Yes, sir, but I visit at least once a month. I'm looking to settle into Lagos fully by June."

"Asides business and drooling over Zoya, what other things... events brings you to Lagos?" Zena asks.

Drooling over me? Zena! Beware... And what's your business with what brings him to Lagos? I slowly grind the beef in my mouth.

"I have family here. And friends. And oh, next month, I have a wedding to attend. Best man duties. Zoya is going with me."

"Yes, I am," I smile and daddy nods.

"Oh... I'll like to come." Zena says, and I wish she is closer so I can pinch her thigh under the table. "It's been a while since I attended something like that."

I know the last wedding you attended. Zele's wedding and that was like four years ago. Okay... that's been a while. But—

"Same here." Manir stop sympathizing with her! She hates weddings. "Bucknor is a close friend."

Electricity goes out, plunging us into darkness, with only the silvery light of the moon through the horizontal slider window acting as illumination.

"Oh NEPA!" Zena cries.

Racing upstairs, I get rechargeable fluorescent lamps. We were done eating, and the conversation was going on so well—okay not so well as regards Zena's inputs, but on daddy's part.

Welcome to the life of the humble, Mr. Manir. I think to myself as I spy him going through his phone. He has been courteous so far, acting like the dutiful boyfriend. This is the first time I'll see him press his phone since he arrived.

Annoying NEPA. And there's one thing that might make this whole saga worse. "I don't know if Danladi bought fuel for the generator."

"Don't worry," Dad begins, "I have some stored."

"Zena and I will go turn on the gen," I announce.

"Did you get the big gen fixed the last time?" Dad asks.

Uh oh. I completely forgot about that. With daddy's frequent trips to UNIZIK where he lectures on architecture and constant travel for work, I am the only one at home and I rarely use the generator. Can't remember the last time I used it save for weekends and it's been a while.

"Don't worry, I'll work on it. We can use the small gen if it doesn't cooperate." Dad wants to work on it? That's so unlike him. "Manir, care to join me?" I knew it. Men's talk.

"Sure sir." Manir says, immediately getting on his feet, pocketing his phone.

"You ladies can clear the table. We'll restore electricity soon."

Zena giggles. "Super men to the rescue."

OceanofPDF.com

TWENTY-THREE

JOHNNY JUST COME

Manir

If you take everything away, the only people that'll be left is family. That's all we've got. I think you should speak with him.

"DO YOU KNOW WHAT HER FULL name is?" Arc. Ainabe asks as I hand him a spanner, pointing the bright fluorescent light on the task at hand. The big generator will need a professional's touch, so he is touching up the smaller generator.

I smile. How easy for him to change the topic from generator parts to his daughter. "Ehizoya." Is this where he asks what my intentions are?

"Ehizoya." He says with a sigh before using the spanner on the generator. "It means my guardian angel removes my reproach. Elevates me from poverty. And do you know that of Zena?" He turns to me smiling, eyes shimmering with pride.

Shaking my head, I answer. "No, sir."

Before last year Zoya only spoke of Zena briefly, but recently Zena comes up in our conversations when she wants to rant about family.

"Ehizena, it means the one the guardian angel chooses for."

"Beautiful names." I don't know why I said that out loud, but it's what I truly feel and think about not just their names, but of his daughters.

"Yes, they are. My wife named them so."

What do I say to that? I heard about your wife, and I'm sorry for your loss. Instead, I simply nod in agreement. What's the reason behind sharing the meaning of your girls' names? Guardian angels are watching over them? Their late mother? I don't mean Zoya any harm, so you should fear not. Grinding my teeth, it's getting more tense than any meeting I've ever attended.

I'm in for the sermon of my life. I like Arc. Ainabe and understand that though the man already likes me, he must create ground rules. It's the same thing I'll do when my daughter presents a man, she says is her boyfriend.

"I want to believe you are who she thinks you are. You know, I have taught my children the way of the Lord and daily they show me they are in his light. Are you a Christian? Your names are a bit..." he pauses, looking me in the eye, "confusing."

"I'm a Christian." We've got an Islamic background, but I'm not about to spew how my grandmother later became a Christian and my family, a mix of believers.

"And Manir? Isn't that Arabic?"

This is ridiculous. "It is." I didn't choose my names or the family I was born into. I've never not liked my name, and this is the first time I'll put much thought into it. "And it means thanks, that's if you're wondering about the meaning." Twitching my mouth.

"Oh. Good. Good." Arc. Ainabe gets up from his squat, picks a towel, and begins wiping his hands. "I expect you to treat her like the lady she is and the woman you want her to become, since you are really interested in going the extra mile. Although my daughter and I are friends, I'm sure you are a closer

friend right now. And you are looking to help her achieve her goals and not be a stumbling block."

Sleek. He's not directly asking what my intentions are. Must be hard passing his classes in the school he occasionally lectures. The silence is deafening. This is the talk. I need to make an impression.

I want to marry your daughter. Think I'll choose to walk into your house because I want to bang her? Hell. I want to bang her. Now. Tomorrow. Forever. And with that same energy, I want to build a life, a home with her.

Clearing my throat, I begin, hoping to God I don't mess with what we have. "I'm happy when Zoya's happy. I will not pressure her to do things she's not comfortable with and I'll support her with all I can. My intentions are pure."

"Good. Good. It looks good now." He signals to the generator. "Want to turn it on?"

"Sure..."

For the life of me, I have never turned on a generator. But I know there are buttons on most. I fidget around the thing. *Not useful. Obsessed freak. Not useful. Obsessed freak.*

"Oh, the key to start doesn't work anymore. We pull the recoil rope."

Is this a test? I can't even turn on a generator! It's a fucking generator Oladele Manir Dosu-Andrews. Prove to this righteous-loving-father you can care for his daughter! I blink. *His father. He has no one. Not useful. Obsessed freak. Not useful. Obsessed freak.*

"You've not done this before."

Can you just shut up so I can figure this out?

"Have you?"

"No." My voice is harsher than intended.

I should have said no, sir. I should have fucking said no, sir! But that's that. I can't fix the past.

Avoiding his gaze, I stare at the generator like the AI Escargot, waiting for him to lash at me. Ask if I'm alright. Do something.

He does what I least expect. "It's not hard," he says in a friendly, even voice. "Here, let me show you." He demonstrates, switching valves, checking oil levels, and choke controls.

On my fourth attempt, I get the generator working. Puffing my chest, I pick the rechargeable lamp, ready to move into the house, but notice it's still dark in there.

"Did I miss anything?" I ask.

Arc. Ainabe spares me an indulgent smile. "You'll need to switch the connection from NEPA to generator."

Worst way to prove that I can take care of his precious daughter. No worries, there's always YouTube and extra hands we can always employ.

"Don't think too much about it." Arc. Ainabe says as we make our way to the house. "You both will complement each other. Zoya can perform all these tasks and I'm sure there are things you can do that she can't."

"Yeah." I murmur indistinctively.

If he was trying to make me feel better for not knowing my way around a generator, it was not working. If Zoya knows how to do all these things, she's one hell of a strong woman.

"You know," Arc. Ainabe continues as we switch the electricity source and light comes flooding on all sides of the house, "the beautiful thing about relationships is that both parties must meet halfway. Understand your partner's strengths and yours. Accept your weaknesses and most of all, communicate to your partner in love what you like and don't like. There's no perfect relationship, just people who have perfected not giving up on each other."

I understand the nature of this talk; crazy relationships are out there because people have extreme expectations. Don't put my daughter through that. I get it.

"Thanks for sharing, sir." When we have issues, we talk it through, find a compromise. We do... Don't we? Zoya and I do that.

With this assurance, Arc. Ainabe smiles, beckoning me closer, before we enter the house. "I'm not warning you off my daughter or trying to scare you, but please, do nothing stupid. And if it ever leads to marriage, know that I don't support divorce."

This man-to-man conversation has taken a full turn. When did we get to talking about marriage? And divorce?

"Don't look like that. We are men. I understand how this thing works. If you are thinking marriage, remember my daughter is not some model, doesn't check what she eats, loves her job even with the stress that comes with it. If you come and complain one day or I hear you complain about these things in the future... hmm."

Shuffling on my feet, I put on a broad, confident smile. Zoya never said her dad was eccentric or something like this. Can we end this conversation already? "I understand, sir."

"Good. Good." Arc. Ainabe nods, giving me a pat on my shoulder. "You're a good man." His lips tighten into a thin line, and he nods again.

As we step into the living room, I notice Zoya, and Zena are watching TV.

"I thought you guys will never make it back." Zena shakes her head as I make my way to Zoya.

"I'll be retiring early." Arc. Ainabe announces. "I have an online prayer meeting I need to join shortly. I doubt I'll be done when Manir leaves."

"Awwn..." Zoya gets up to hug her dad. "Thanks for your time, daddy."

Arc. Ainabe pats her back before releasing her.

Stepping forward, I stretch my hand to shake him. "Thank you, sir."

"It was great having you around."

With their dad retiring to bed earlier than expected, Zena puts on a comedy show featuring Basket Mouth. Zoya keeps tossing me curious looks, asking if I'm good.

When I bid Zena good night, it's almost 10:00 PM. I didn't realize time had flown by so fast. As little as their family seems, what they lacked in number they made up for in healthy talk, argument and loads of laughter.

"Had a good time?" Zoya asks for the umpteenth time as we walk hand in hand to my car.

Inside the house, when she asked me the same question, I resisted the urge to hug her to myself. Having Zena as an audience, although she is a matured adult, and being in their family home didn't make me go through with getting cozy with her. Coupled with all the marriage and divorce talk her dad was sharing earlier. Borrowing a word from Zoya, Jeez.

"I'm good."

"You sure?"

"Sure." We are now standing by the driver's door.

Zoya smiles, staring up at me as I drag her close for the hug I've been wanting to bury myself in. If Arc. Ainabe had been trying to scare me off with all his talk of marriage, divorce, and stuff, he made a mistake.

"How do you smell so good all day long?" I grin, stealing a quick kiss from her lips.

She withdraws slightly from the hug, our chests barely touching, glances in the direction we're coming from, then back at me. "You're looking for trouble." She grins, the moonlight reflecting in her eyes as she keeps staring up at me. Those eyes, they tell me all I need to know.

"Nope. I've gotten all the approval I need." I reply with a wink. "What do you think your dad and I were doing at the generator house?"

She cocks her head to an angle, like she's seriously thinking about it. Shaking her head, she removes her hand from mine. "That's it. Zena is rubbing off on you."

Zena? We both laugh and I pull her back into my arm, leaning on the car. "I enjoyed spending time with your family."

Tracing the Kente pattern on my shirt, I notice her lips curve in a proud smile. “I’m glad.”

“Yeah. Zena… She’s something else.”

“Tell me something I don’t know.”

“She’s not like you’ve mentioned her to be…” The Zena I met was friendly, curious and quirky, in a fun way.

“Well… I am surprised myself. She’s only like this with family.”

“Means I’m family now.”

“You wish.” Tapping my chest coyly. “Because I like you and yes, I’m catching feelings, doesn’t mean we’re walking down the altar tomorrow.”

“Zena has welcomed me. If that’s not a sign,” I shrug, “I don’t know what will convince you further.”

“If that makes you sleep better tonight, keep on believing that.”

“Thank you, Confessor.”

“So…” She moves to stand beside me, leaning on the door too. “What did you and daddy talk about? You guys were gone for a long time.”

“Just manly stuff…”

She raises her chin.

“Politics… family, religion.” Then her brows, and I’m forced to admit, “and us.”

“So…”

“Don’t worry. We’re good.” I don’t want to rehash my weird experience and have her wondering what’s up with her dad. I click a button on my ring of keys and my car starts. “I wish I didn’t, but I have to go. And you’ve got work tomorrow.”

She does not try to continue our discussion and smiles instead, understanding. “Alright dear. Drive carefully, please.”

“I will.” Reaching out, I pull her in for a hug.

Sighing as her body melts in mine, I sniff her neck and she giggles. I don't want to mess this up. All I need is time to get myself in order, and I'll do what is needed. I know all there is to know about her. She is the one.

"1 4 3," she mumbles, pulling away from my embrace.

"1 4 3 back, Confessor."

OceanofPDF.com

TWENTY-FOUR

SELLER DISCLOSURE

Zoya

I have a brother. His name is Ehizele.

RETURNING TO THE HOUSE, I FIND Dad and Zena watching TV in the living room. The—the prayer meeting ended earlier than expected? Hmm.

I should be thankful we're all in the house at the same time. It is as though as we grow older, the more distant we become. It hurts that mom is not here, not that anything big happened tonight, but I shrug as I plop myself on a sofa, it would have been gratifying having her here. And maybe have Zele in the picture too.

"He's gone?" Zena asks.

I nod, pulling a throw pillow to my lap.

"Awwn. I liked him."

"Interesting young man," Dad mutters with a smirk.

Yeah. Heard you were talking politics, religion, and stuff in the generator house, must have been interesting. “What did you think about him?”

“He has sense.” Zena grins.

I smile, hissing. “Not you. Daddy, what did you think about him?” Smiling, waiting to hear how intelligent and well-versed my man is.

“Does it really matter?”

My eyes widen, taken aback. Why won’t it matter?

“Because I know you. You’ll do what's on your mind.”

“I know it may seem that I don't care what you think, but I do care about your thoughts towards the man I'm thinking of spending the rest of my life with.”

It is his turn to be taken aback. He scoffs, “Spending your life with him?” Shaking his head. “You can do better Ehizoya.”

What! “What do you mean by that?” my tense faint voice betraying my inner turmoil.

“That boy. Hmm. He is disrespectful, rude… and I highly doubt he is the Christian he claims to be. Painting himself to be a businessman.” He tuts. “Do you know what type of business he truly does? Yes, his family is rich, but someone like that would ruin you. I’ve heard stories in this Lagos Zoya. They would swallow you whole, he and his family.”

My mouth moves, but no words come out. There are so many words coming to my mind, but I can’t form them into coherent sentences. What happened in the generator house? What does he know about Manir that I don’t? What’s with the talk of his family or even his wealth? I have never, never thought of his background as a problem and in the space of one dinner, dad knows best?

“What's on your mind? Tell me.” I shake my head, biting my lips as I watch him spew out alien words.

“Talk to me, Ehizoya. You're no longer a child.”

“Dad, I—” I snort. “Hmm. I—”

“Ehizoya,” his low, cultured voice getting on my nerves with every utterance he makes, “speak to me. This is a crucial step in your life. You’re talking about marriage—a lifelong commitment—and I don’t want you to sit there and not have a say. I trained you and your sister to be outs—”

“Don’t start on how you trained or not trained us dad—”

“Zoya.” Zena’s firm voice from a distance stops me.

Okay. Okay. Focus on the discussion at hand. “First off, daddy, he is not a boy. He is a man. A. Grown. Man.” I sneer. “Second, he is more Christian than you are if you are sitting down here saying you doubt him being a Christian. Ar-are you God? And as for the training part, which you toss at every given opportunity, I know for sure if he becomes the father of my children, he will be there for them—physically and emotionally.”

“Zoya.”

I turn to Zena. “I'm going to say it as it is. It’s high time I let him,” turning to face Dad who is staring at me aghast, “know everything he has done or not done, for the past fourteen years has influenced us one—”

“Zoya.”

“I'm still talking Zena. Please.” I widen my eyes at her. “You will have your turn to speak. I’m speaking my mind.” Turning back to face him, I continue, leaning forward. “Daddy, you lost a wife. We lost a mother. Jeez. We were supposed to lose only one parent, but we ended up losing both.” He flinches at my words, but there’s no going back now. “All open days, PTA meetings, the time Zena was having boy issues, and you were supposed to file a complaint with the school and every other thing you were supposed to represent us. Us. Your family. Where were you?

A-and I understand you were grieving, going through so much pain. Yes, you lost your wife. The love of your life whom you didn't get married to because you were chasing your dreams until you returned to find out you left her with my brother. Oh! My brother who is… God knows where, without a father.

And then after losing her, you bury yourself in work. In community service. Church this. Church that. Here you are trying to preach to me about being a Christian and-and-and-and being rude."

Squeezing my eyes shut, I take a deep breath. "Daddy," opening my eyes, "it's my love for you that made me think your thought about the man I intend to spend the rest of my life with would actually matter, but I guess I was only deceiving myself."

"Zoya, that's enough."

"Leave her alone," Dad says. "Let her talk."

I should head to my room before saying more than I should. Tossing the throw pillow aside, I stand up to head to my room. "G'night." I spit out.

"There is something wrong with that boy."

I stop on the spot, turning to face him, folding my arms.

"There is something wrong that you don't know and as a father I can see that."

Where's all this BS coming from?

"You were not with us at the generator house. What I saw..." he shakes his head, eyes boring into mine. "You were not there. He might not be as bad as I paint him to be, but I can wish him for someone else's child, not mine."

Zena gasps.

"However, if that is the path you wish to tread, I believe you will, just like every other path you've chosen to tread."

Nodding, I bite my lips. "Yes. Yes, I will. Because when you were my age, could you boast of my achievements as an architect?"

"Zoya!"

"You make it look like your job is so hard. I'm putting food on your table. I don't have time for my family, my daughters. But here I am, proving to you I can make time for my family, do the job I need to do, and yeah, have a life."

"Are you saying you chose your trade because of—"

“Yes, daddy dearest. Just to prove to you I can do better. You could have done better.” Oh… he tried dissuading me from being an architect. Looking out for my best interest, he’d said, but I-I knew what I wanted him to see. I’m passionate about architecture, working with Mercury Consults and the amazing projects and people I’ve met so far.

“So… you not coming to my firm was not because you didn't want to work with me?”

“It would have made things easy for me, wouldn't it? No, daddy. I didn’t want to be in your shadow. Of what use would that have been when I wouldn’t be able to show you what you could have done better during the period your children needed a parent? Their father? No excuses, daddy.”

“Zoya, enough!” Zena shakes her head.

“Stubbornness Zoya, it will lead you nowhere,” Dad says. “That’s why you have to take your PPE twice.”

Low blow dad. Low blow. “You know what? I'll just leave this place before I say something more irritating or offensive to your ears. Goodnight.”

OceanofPDF.com

TWENTY-FIVE

FACADE

Manir

I'm sorry for your loss.

THE PLACE IS HOT. ONCE NIGHT comes, it should get cooler. That's a lie! I'm in a room. There should be a control somewhere. I cower, bringing my arms to my body as close as I can, struggling to get warm. But I'm hot! Glancing up, I find grey walls, no windows. The room is one long endless rectangle. Nothing is happening here. It's dark, then turns bright. Not bright enough to be blinding, but enough to see things—something, a shadow, moves.

Could it be? How could they? How! This is not fair! The world is not fair. Enough with being a coward.

The shadow moves again, but it's some distance from me.

Got ya!

I jog towards it. It's not it. They are not it. It's two people. I'm seeing them via a fisheye lens. A young woman and a little boy who should be around five years old.

"Come…" the young woman says, tugging the little boy's hand.

"But I want to color."

Color.

It's the magic word! The room turns to a vibrant living room of cream-colored walls, wooden paneled floor, three-seater black leather sofa with throw pillows of distinct colors, and a center table on a brown rug, facing an LCD TV. There's also painting on the wall, it's one with the Lagos Lagoon and a lone fisherman in his boat.

Thud!

I look down to find a loose red crayon rolling towards me like a cannonball.

Oh, no. No. No.

I run. With all my might. I need to escape it.

When I look back, it's not moving and I'm running on a spot.

What? I pause in my useless attempt at escaping.

"Don't worry." My gaze swivels to the lady speaking patronizingly to the little boy. "When you're done eating, you'll color all you want."

"No! I want to color now!"

Bad manners boy… Bad manners. You don't shout at your elders.

The scene is familiar. There are blurred family pictures hanging on the wall, but one picture stands out. It's the picture of a loving family—a man, his wife and son.

Where am I? What's happening? I focus my gaze on the young woman and the boy. She feels familiar.

"It's late already."

But the sun is—a window appears beside me, and true to her word, it's dark outside.

The door creaks opens and an older couple—man and woman—walk in, taking off their shoes. They feel familiar too.

"Mummy! Daddy!" The boy screams, successfully tugging his hand from the startled young woman's.

"Hey champ," the man says, hands on the boy's shoulder. "How are you?"

"I'm fine. How was your party?"

"Fine, thank you." The older woman responds, walking till she settles on the couch before the TV. The screen is static, but she's focused on it.

What are you doing? Get the remote! This is not sane!

"Good evening ma," the younger woman says. "Welcome *Oga*."

"Agatha... how are you?" The older woman asks, her voice soft and comforting.

Agatha? That's my nanny's name. This lady looks nothing like Agatha. Who are you? What am I doing here! I need to get out.

"What are we eating tonight? Has he eaten?" She points to the older man, but I know she's asking about the little boy.

"Erm, swallow ma." Casting fleeting glances at the man and the boy who are now mysteriously on the three-seater couch with the woman, Agatha threads carefully. "He said he wanted to color, so I—"

"We left here around 3 PM and this is..." the man checks his watch, "almost ten and you have not fed him?"

"Sir, he—"

"He is a little boy! You tell him what to do, not the other way around!"

The little boy, used to such ruckus, continues playing, not flinching at the back and forth that ensues, till it stops. The older woman raises a remote and begins flickering through channels.

Ring. Ring.

"Who is it?" The man asks.

“I’ll check.” The older woman brings out a telephone—with the handset cord, dial button and all—from her handbag and smiles. “It’s Dr. Fatuase.”

“Oh. That’s great. I love that you’re getting along with these men. Bringing us more deals.”

The woman blushes, but she looks scared, her eyes on the boy seated on the floor, coloring between the man’s leg. Ring. Ring.

What happened to the scattered crayons on the floor? How come the boy is using coloring pencils now?

“I’m glad you understand that it’s all business.” The phone is still ringing, the sound getting ominous.

“So,” The man’s voice draws the woman's attention back to him. “What does this one want?”

“Like I said,” the woman smiles, looking at the boy again, “it’s all business.”

****

“I can’t have him here!” She whispers fiercely to the man, her eyes occasionally going to the groaning shape on the bed in a young man’s room. “He’s messing things up!”

“But—”

“No! You didn’t hear the names he called me.” Folding her arms. She won’t let them be nonchalant about this.

“You’re murderers.” The groaning shape on the bed shouts. “All of you!”

“See? See what I’m saying?” They walk further into the room, three figures trailing behind them.

“We have to help him. He’s family. He’s my son. He’s—”

“He’s mad!”

“The only mad person here is you. You’re a witch. And I swear to God, if you release me, I’ll show you somewhere in the bible that proves me right.”

“What did you say happened?” One figure—an elderly woman—trailing behind them, asks the other two figures, the moon casting gloomy light on their faces.

“We… we-we. We were playing, and he joined us. Ọpẹ ran to hug him and he told her she was a harlot. We didn’t want to alert anyone because-because he laughed about it and we thought it was a joke. Then he said he was walking to the beach and will see us there. That was when I told daddy.”

“Dele!”

“Sir?”

“Is it true? Is it true you called her a harlot?”

“I can say whatever I like. Anyhow I like it. Because it’s the truth.”

“What happened to you?”

“Me? What is wrong with you? Can’t you see?”

“See what?”

“You need to know the truth. It will set you free. It’s right there, in the bible.”

“Have you spoken to—”

“Take this shirt off me,” he cries, tears clouding his eyes, “take it off me. It’s choking. It’s hot…” he continues whining, crying at how hot it is.

“Dele.” When he gets no response, he repeats, his voice firmer. “Dele!”

“Hmm?” Turning tear-stricken face to a man he called uncle. He hates that all eyes are on him when they should be on themselves. He has to make them see.

“Can you tell me what happened?”

“What?” He sniffs. “What happened? She’s, my wife. My wife.” His taut, hard voice brooks no argument. “We will get married and she will have babies. When you see it, you’ll know what I mean. Have you seen the houses? I’ll buy them. Sell them. And buy them again.” He continues rambling.

“What do we do?” The elderly woman asks. “I can’t watch him like this.”

“He is not staying in this house. I don’t want him hurting my daughter. You people should find somewhere to put him.”

“Where will you suggest? Seems you know it all.”

“Yaba left.”

“Yaba left? Are you okay? My brother’s son?”

A soul piercing shriek turns their attention to the young man on the bed struggling with ropes that restrict his movement. He bares his teeth in frustration. “You’re not listening to me.” He cries, then heaves. “I’m going… I’m going… Let me go.”

Hasty footsteps arrive the room with news. “Uncle Wole is here.”

Wole stands by the door, looking at his nephew on the bed. Tears come unbidden to his eyes.

Dele’s eye’s catches his and smiles hopefully.

“Uncle Wole.” His voice, calm and peaceful. Different from the demanding and insulting voice.

“Dele.” He walks into the room and others stare in amazement at Dele’s serenity. “What happened?”

Dele tries to shrug but fails. Tries lifting his hand, same thing, he fails. “See what your siblings are doing?” Pressing his lips together in a straight line. “See? They think this is normal. Tying their brother’s son down. And that witch over there? I need to pray for her.”

“See… Bashir. I can’t.” Her face rigid. “I won’t let this continue. He is mad! Take him to Yaba. Let them do the needful.”

“Hey woman!” Wole calls her attention. “I won’t let you say that about him.”

Dele turns to the wall, glaring at it. Angry no one wants to listen to the truth. He won’t speak until they beg him. People love wallowing in lies. He knows the truth. Has seen the light. Absolutely, he won’t speak until they beg him.

“What options do we have? How long do you want to keep him tied to the bed? How long? He’s talking gibberish. He’s not eating. We don’t know how this happened. Is this normal? We should—”

Silence meets her questions, and she hugs her middle as realization dawns on her. “Ah! Bashir!”

“Calm down, Ladun.” Bashir moves to hold her, but she shakes the comfort he offers away.

“You three,” Rekiat says, pointing to Bashir’s children, “get out of here. And don’t breathe a word of this to anyone.”

They scramble out, leaving the siblings to stare at their orphaned nephew.

“What are you not saying Bashir?”

“Calm down Ladun.”

“This boy is young. He has a bright future.” Her nostrils flare as she looks at each sibling. One after the other. “What are you people not saying?”

“He will be fine, Ladun,” Wole says. “We just need to know what triggered this.”

“Ah! Has-has-has this happened before? Ah! It has happened!” Ladun turns slowly to the comfort she once rejected. Clinging to Bashir’s shirt, she wails. For her children. Their children. And the ones to come.

OceanofPDF.com

TWENTY-SIX

SHINE YOUR EYE

Zoya

My kind of guy? I have a thing for tall, fair guys.

"NEED MORE SLEEP…" I MURMUR INTO my pillow.

I really need more sleep. It has been a crazy two weeks at work. I am working with a new team and although I can get into work at any time, it is a field job where I am always on my feet. Sleep… I need more… I close my eyes, thinking about my decision to sleep some more, knowing today is another important day.

It has been a long day. I step out of the office and get into a white and red taxi. When did they change the colors of taxis in Lagos from orange and black to white and red? And why are there other people in the taxi? The Governor keeps changing everything on us.

Why am I in the middle of these men? I turn to ask if they can help me buy snacks in the traffic and I notice I am gagged, my hands tied. Who are these men? Where are we headed? Help! Help!

Next, I hear indistinct voices filled with anger. Followed by a loud siren. The police... Help! I scream, but it's silent. How-how do I get out of this? Turning to the angry men in panic, I struggle with all I have. *Help! Help. Help…*

My eyes pop open and my heart is pumping in rapid succession, I'm surprised it's not out of my chest.

Exhaling long, I close my eyes in gratitude. "It was just a dream."

I need to take a vacation... a break or something from work. The accumulated stress is taking a toll on me. And that dream!

Immediately, I take to my knees—hands in prayer mode, with my elbows resting on the bed. I pray for protection, my job, my security, Zena, Chiluba, Zele, Dad, and Manir.

It's not the ember months yet, and the rate of kidnapping, ritualistic killings, and bombings is skyrocketing in the country. No one is safe.

"Sis," Zena says from the doorway.

After the showdown I had with dad, she said she was going to be fully in Lagos now, that there's no future in Osun State for her. She has been applying for jobs and watching TV all day. Two weeks ago, when she travelled to Osun State to sign her monthly PPA stuff and returned the following day, was when I believed she was here to stay. With her Passing Out Parade, POP, in July, less than two months away, it makes sense that she wants to be here.

Deep down, I know it's because she wants to keep peace between Dad and me. What happened that night is a fluke I am not proud of. Speaking of daddy, we're still not on speaking terms, not like we used to speak before. Don't know if I should regret I asked his thoughts or be happy I found out about it earlier. It hasn't stopped Manir and me from hanging out the few times he has been in and out of Nigeria. In the past weeks, I've met his friends at the tennis court—they're cool people—and attended the church's Easter event with him.

"Zoya...?" A hand on my shoulder.

I raise my head from the bed, turning to her with a frown. "You know I was praying."

"I'm sorry. You looked like you were sleeping," she says begrudgingly.

I shake my head in frustration before sitting on the bed. "What is it?"

Before University happened, Zena was an outgoing, inquisitive, black sheep kind of kid, always coming to me for answers. When Zena was eleven, she was furious when she started having pimples, which I never had while at that age, and for that reason, every opportunity she found, she would dot pimples all over my face at night with coal from underneath the pot.

Daddy called her aside, spoke to her and when she didn't listen, he'd spanked her. She has come a long way from that little girl. I guess it's just part of being a grown up that happened to her during her first years in the University.

The bed dips, accepting and adjusting to Zena's weight as she joins me.

"I was wondering which pink shoes to wear with the cream-colored gown Chiluba just sent over."

"The open toe shoe would be best—"

Zena jumps off the bed, smiling and dancing towards the door. "I thought as much. I just wanted to confirm from you. Thank you!"

"My pleasure."

Speaking of Chiluba, she is still acting strange. Asking loads of questions about my mom's family. Giving excuses to hang out. I guess introducing her to my uncle, George, has her busy with work. Everything seems to be progressing nicely, last we spoke on the phone.

I need to get ready for field work and stop thinking about the women in my life like a grandma.

I am so proud of myself for not picking my phone as I usually do. Standing up from bed, I lazily stroll to the bathroom to bathe, then brush.

Toothpaste always has this chalky taste I hate. Left to me, I'll make use of chewing stick like mum did. I miss mom sometimes. But she's becoming a

fading memory.

Going through the mechanical up and down motion of moving my brush, my brain clicks, and I pause in motion.

Spitting out paste, I furrow my brows at my reflection in the mirror. "Zena!"

"Yes?"

"Is today Friday or Saturday?"

"Saturday!"

"Oh my God." Rinsing my mouth, with my mind racing around, I steady myself by holding on to the sink. From the mirror, I see Zena poke her head in.

"What's up?"

I brush her aside as I walk—run into my room, scattering my bedding, searching for—ah-ha! My phone.

Thirteen missed calls.

The police siren in my dream?

8:43 AM
Manir: Morning beautiful.

8:55 AM
Manir: Looking on fleek.
Attached file: a picture of Manir in Agbada.

8:56 AM
Manir: Please let me know when you're ready.

9:32 AM
Manir: What's happening? You good?

10:57 AM
Manir: I'll be leaving here to pick you.

See you in twenty.

"Uh oh. Manir will kill me."

"He can't. I'll kill him first." Zena says, her voice firm, unflinching.

I said that out loud? Didn't realize she had followed me into my room.

"You don't have to worry about me, as you can see..." She smiles, passing her hand in flourish down her body. "I'm done."

"And where do you think you are going to?"

She offers a, I'm coming with you whether or not you like it, smile.

"And you couldn't wake me up." *Yeah. Good thing. Project your slack on someone else.*

This time, she offers a, not my fault since you didn't include me in your plan, smile... and I can't help but smile.

"Jeez." I turn on my heels and start undressing. I have less than twenty minutes to be ready, make up and all.

"I didn't know the plan. I thought the white wedding starts after noon. I was only working on instinct."

I hiss.

"I'll help you."

"You're not coming with me." Always wanting to share my friends. Chiluba is where I draw the line.

****

"I hope it's okay she joins us." I whisper to Manir, my eyes on the rearview mirror, watching Zena, who is busy on her phone. He came in a black Jeep Wrangler, tinted glasses and the works.

"I'll be your companion. He's the best man. You'll be alone and bored." Zena had pitched herself and I eventually gave in.

Focusing on the road, Manir replies, smiling. “It’s fine. I’ll be busy with Bucknor. She’ll be good company.”

Same thing Zena said to bribe her way into coming.

“I wouldn’t want you to be alone, you know.”

I smile, occasionally studying the fine masculine specimen beside me. He has gained some muscles since we last saw each other.

“That’s so thoughtful of you.”

Glancing at the rearview mirror, I catch Zena’s eyes and mouth, ‘not you.’

Zena has a tough time holding back her laughter. Knowing my sister, she will sit with me for five minutes before she disappears. I hear ladies go to weddings to look for men. Is that her plan?

Taking my eyes off the rearview mirror, I observe Manir’s serious look in his suit. He said he had excused himself from the hotel they went to change. How come, as best man, he still found time to come pick me up? That’s some weird macho stuff. And his reaction when I had stepped out in my lace gown, it was priceless. Even Zena was blushing on my behalf.

“Love the haircut,” I tell him.

“I aim to please.” He squeezes my hand, before turning the car into a street.

****

“It’s time for the couple’s dance. If you brought gifts, now is the time to drop them and if it’s *ego* you have, now is the time to show yourself,” the master of ceremony calls.

It’s been a fun reception. Unlike some master of ceremonies who make the wedding about themselves, this one has us captivated by the couple's story.

“Bose,” the master of ceremony calls to the bride, “don’t misuse this opportunity, oh. See all these people out here,” he points to the people who have stepped out to spray the couple, “they have eaten your rice and enjoyed the AC. Now is the time for you to dance your profits back in. For me, I won’t

stop dancing until I get transport fare to Bali for honeymoon. Be like me o, *iyawo wa*."

The audience laughs at his antics.

"Okay now." He turns to the people on the floor ready to spray money on the couple. "It's not only them that will spray oh. Please, come out if God has laid it on your heart to do so. Are you ready latest Adelekes? DJ let's go!"

Bucknor and his wife, Bose, start with a slow dance, The Marriage Prayer by John Waller.

I watch—misty eyed—feeling mushy. Scanning the area I last saw Manir, our eyes click and I smile. We have our moment with the song—both of us staring at each other.

Manir breaks our stare with a bridesmaid demanding his attention. Turning my gaze back to the couple on the floor, Bucknor whispers something in Bose's ear. I smile at how cute they look.

"Excuse me."

A voice says over my left shoulder, and I shift to the right. I'm not wearing headgear like most women here, I shouldn't be obstructing anyone's view.

"A moment please?"

I tut. An usher? Bucknor and Bose's event planner did a fantastic job with their choice of ushering and catering services. Turning on my seat to thank the usher, tell them I'm good. My eyes meet old familiar eyes. Only this time, the eyes crinkle in a smile. My brain, in slow motion, does a speedy calculation.

Fast backward to a time twelve years ago. I was fifteen, about wrapping up high school, lost my mum the previous year. I had just one dream—Arinze will become my boyfriend. We would be so in love. Runaway, get married and have kids.

Arinze, mister nice guy, had more cash to spare, thanks to his nonchalant parents. Last I heard of him, his family had moved to Canada.

To find him here… Today of all days! A wedding! There's no crueler joke the universe can toss my way.

"Arinze?"

He smiles, nodding. The song playing fades. His smile, with its signature dimples, aged well, wrinkles and all.

We were pals back then. Never mind the fact that I rarely spoke when we were together because of my awe of him. He confided in me then. I knew how his family was—his parents always fighting—and how much he wished for things to be different.

Those eyes… and that smile. The song '*Killing me softly'* might have been dedicated to them for all I know. They killed me back then and might succeed even now.

"One and only."

His voice is a soothing baritone. It is deeper, reverberating in places I cannot mention. My heart does a rapid tap dance in glee.

Quickly sparing a glance to where Manir was—he's no longer there—I reprimand myself. This is not good.

"Hello…" Arinze drawls, dragging me back to reality.

A new song begins, louder than the former. The couples are now dancing to high life music. Bucknor is excited, jumping around in the name of dancing.

"I'm-I-I'm sorry."

He smiles again and I notice he has been crouching beside me all along. "No offense taken."

If I were butter, I'll be melting all over this chair.

"Arinze from Chartered High? The same boy I went to school with?"

Hearing this, he laughs, and I smile. I need to be sure before I make a fool of myself.

Other wedding guests are standing up to join the couple on the dance floor and I take the cue to stand up. He does the same, looking edible in a grey and pink *agbada*.

"Same Arinze." He nods slowly, giving me a once over, as we dance to the beat.

I hope my lace gown is doing justice to my modest ass.

"I was over there with some friends." He points to a group of yummy men in matching agbadas, similar to his and that of the bride's family. "When I spotted someone that looked like you—I mean you. I tried my luck and see who we have... Here you are. All grown up." His roving eyes has me feeling hot and exposed.

"So, from you and your goons' outfit—"

"Who is helping with your vocabulary?" He interrupts, looking incredulous, not missing a beat as he moves to the music. "Ehizoya? Goons? I must be in heaven." He grins.

"Wh-what?" I stutter, blinded by his smile. Oh... I can't use the word goons? "You think I'm not current?"

"No..." He drawls. "Ah. The Ehizoya I knew would have a cough fit before that word or slang came out."

Smiling, I nudge his shoulder, moving to the beat. We are dancing forward, towards the couple.

"Well, as I was saying, your outfit shows you know the bride's family."

"Yeah, Bose is a cousin on my mother's side."

"Oh. That's nice." Words, words, words. They fail me now. For some reason or the other, I feel I should have stopped talking to him a while ago. End the conversation in 'nice to meet you, bye.' But something in me is proving stubborn, wanting to learn more about him, what he has been up to...

"So... When did you return?"

"I go and come." He shrugs.

All the men in Lagos. Including my boyfriend. Always on the road. Not sitting still. Looking for means to make big bucks.

"Uh oh." I mutter under my breath with a smile as my gaze lands on Manir. He is wearing a frown, making me withdraw slightly from Arinze. "C-cool."

"Yeah, not so cool." Arinze replies, oblivious to my withdrawal.

We dance out of the audience encircling the newlyweds, with me heading for my seat, Arinze following closely behind. I'm glad I met him here, but what's next?

"We were on our way out when I tried my luck. Mind if I push this luck by asking for your number?" When I only smile, he adds, "So I can contact you some other time? Catch up?"

"I—" What excuse can I give? What do you want to use my phone number for? Catch up? I can find out more about him, know what he has been up to.

Manir was frowning when he saw Arinze and me dancing... was he frowning at us or something else?

Arinze brings out his phone, gives it to me, and I dial my digits. He retrieves the phone, waiting for the call to go through, smiling when it does.

"That's my number." He replaces his phone back to where it had come from, blessing me with another dimpled smile. "The main one." His gaze moves to where his goons are.

"Same here."

"You look stunning." He leans in, giving me a side hug. "I'll call you." And is gone in a flash.

That's some Cinderella stuff, but not for long.

OceanofPDF.com

TWENTY-SEVEN

BACKSPLASH

Zoya

---

*Really, sometimes, I feel this career I'*m chasing is a charade.
Like I'm not doing me. I need to figure out my life.

THE ENTIRE DAY WOULD BE ALMOST perfect if I don't end up killing Zena. Jeez! Manir and I have been waiting in the parking lot for—I check the last time I dialed her number—five minutes. Longest five minutes of my life.

Longest, because of Manir. The weird way he is acting—just scrolling through his phone. What is on the phone that's more important than holding a conversation with me? Ever since our eyes caught when I was talking with Arinze, I sensed something dark… looming around us, as a couple.

"I enjoyed the couple's dance. Did you?" I ask, to ease the tension I can slice with a knife building in the car.

Manir's response is a nod, still scrolling through his phone. His jacket hangs in the backseat, revealing fitted pink shirt and dark slacks. He looks so

good without the jacket; I want to ask him to pose for more pictures.

Did I do any wrong by speaking with Arinze? Zena was nowhere to be found then, just like she is now. And Arinze is an old friend. I've not seen where it is written not to talk to guys because you're in a relationship. Fine, we are a couple, but that doesn't mean I can't talk to other sexes and genders.

"Got any pictures without your jacket?" I ask. "I can take some now." That should be a great conversation starter.

He scrunches his nose, shaking his head.

Ugh!

Seven minutes.

I can't stand this brooding silence anymore. If Zena doesn't come out now, I would—

"I'm here," Zena announces with a gust of energy as she tries to open the locked back door.

Manir clicks a button, unlocking the door. She drops souvenir bags, purse, and finally her ass on the seat.

"And I'm so sorry for the delay."

You had better be.

"I saw an old friend." She rubs her arms. "It's so cold in here."

I knew from the moment she said she wanted to come along, she had plans of her own. Zena is not a socialite. She used to be. And I don't think she intends to be one soon.

Manir smiles into the rear-view mirror. "No worries, Zee. Anytime."

Argh... Zee? When did you start calling Zena, Zee? Oh... so you can smile at Zena but can't smile with me? This is how it is, eh? Game on.

He reverses out of the parking lot, driving like a robot. I'm waiting for another driver to piss him off, so I can see how he would react. Aunt Clara once said you can tell a lot about someone from their driving ethics.

"Anyone cares for ice cream?"

Really? I thought you can't stand being in the same space with me. Saying no is on my tongue's tip, but Zena beats me to it. "Yes."

He must have intended the question for Zena, because he does not wait for my response, before making a right turn to the mall.

"We'll have it there before I drop you guys at home."

Hmm. Does this mean you want to talk?

We arrive at the mall, making a slow beeline to Cold Stone Creamery. Because it's late evening and a Saturday, the mall is packed. Servers in eateries ensure that anyone using their facilities are customers, if not, they politely ask them to leave.

Zena makes a flimsy excuse of not wanting to sit and eat her ice cream in the eatery and heads out to lord-knows-where. I am stuck with Manir. A grouchy Manir. I hope this does not result in another ten minutes' wait for Zena.

I keep silent, waiting for him to do the talking. When I tried initiating the conversation earlier, he kept mute. Minutes into zealously digging into my ice cream that has crushed waffles and brownies, Manir speaks.

"Who was that guy?"

I knew it! This whole drama has been because of Arinze. Really? Men and territories. I can't.

"Arinze. An old friend." I say between scoops of teeth, freezing ice cream.

"What kind of old friend?"

Watch your tone, Mann. You're insinuating things. But I don't say those, instead I say, "What's wrong with you? Is that why you've been acting funny?" Shaking my head, I take another scoop of ice cream. "Have you heard of him before?"

"I don't know. But I think I should have heard about him."

Jeez! Incredible. Just fantastic. Dropping my spoon, I grant Manir my full attention. "Arinze is who I say he is. An old friend."

With eyes fixated on mine, he shakes his head. "That was not what I saw."

Picking up my spoon, I continue scooping ice cream into my body. You know what you saw. Choose what you believe. What do you even mean by, that's not what I saw? What did you see?

OceanofPDF.com

TWENTY-EIGHT

JEGA...

Manir

You're a gem.
A good but naughty girl.
Where can I find you?

TO HER, THIS MIGHT BE A trivial issue. To anyone, this is a trivial issue. But for me it isn't. I had warned her I'm in this for the full haul. What I witnessed was irritating! Demeaning! My woman preening from another man's attention. And that look in her eyes when she turned to me. That was the trigger. She knew she was doing something wrong. Couldn't hide it.

"You are not answering me, Zo."

I drop all feigning of trying to hold my temper. It eats at me she's giving me the silent treatment when I want to talk about what I witnessed. What she did. And who was that?

One part of me wanted to take her and Zena home, sleep what I saw off, but I know it will eat at me for days. Affect my productivity. Our relationship.

That's why I'm confronting her in a public space.

"You didn't ask a question."

Staring at Zoya as she keeps on with her ice cream, I am tempted to push the ice-cream to the side. Maybe that will get her attention and she will know how important this discussion is to me—to us.

We've been friends for over four years, talking about who's who in our lives. I know Zoya has never lacked for male attention. From departmental mates to *brothers* in her fellowship, to men at work or on site, there was always someone seeking her attention. Knowing that early in our friendship made me comfortable and trusting of her.

Without ever meeting her, I know she's a good girl, with a dominant personality, ambitious, with the right dose of freakiness and sexual curiosity. Which guy, getting to know someone like her, wouldn't want to be part of her life? A fool.

I've always known having men falling over themselves to help her or be seen by her will be a norm... but that guy from earlier is no ordinary man. Is this how she gives people, not people, guys. Is this how she gives guys her phone number?

What I want to understand is how they know each other. She has been in her fair share of relationships—childish, short, and serious ones. Did they date? At what point? No... It can't be. She has listed all the guys she has ever dated. There were three of them, including Eric. And kissed, there were five. Eric is the only serious adult relationship she has ever had. I don't know why I feel threatened by this Arinze guy, but I need to know more.

Maybe I need to change tactics. "Zoya..." I begin. "Who is Arinze to you? Who was he to you?"

"A classmate from secondary school." She's clearly flustered.

That was a straightforward answer. Just ask the right questions. Zoya is not the kind of lady to hide things from you.

"You dated?" Young love?

"No. Just a friend. An exceptionally good friend back then that I had a crush on. It surprised me to see him, that's all."

With Zoya, that was not all. But I am ready to let it go. Since he is an old friend. "Oh. Okay."

Thinking, I take a scoop of my ice cream, and notice she is almost done with hers. "So... what was he doing at the wedding?"

"That." She stares fondly at me, before scraping off what's left in her cup. "He said Bose is his cousin. I was so shocked to see him. Would you believe that after over ten years, he could recognize me from afar?" She smiles into her cup. "I still can't believe I met him. Mm hmm." Shaking her head. "He met me."

There's that look again. What nonsense is she spouting? "Did you just listen to yourself?"

She stares at me, perplexed. I can't help but spoil the 'Arinze-ness' clouding her head.

Pushing her cup forward, a sign that she was done, she folds her arm on the table. "W-what? What did I say wrong?"

"You just said he said Bose is his cousin. His name is Arinze. Zoya, Arinze. I've always respected you for your sense of reasoning, but I guess now it's lacking because old friends come to visit."

"What are you insinuating? My uncle, George, is a white man. He is my uncle by marriage."

"One moment you were dragging your feet to come to the wedding with me, the next second, you're all roses and butterfly. Dancing in the arms of another man. A crush you've so conveniently never spoken about until this moment. Who was he to you?"

"Manir!" she whispers, leaning forward. "I was not—"

In my irritation, I stand up, drop my serviette on the table and scoff. "Please meet me outside when you're ready."

I imprinted her confused, hurt face in my memory to punish myself. With every step I take away from her, I try to make sense of what just happened. Why am I acting like a child? Throwing a tantrum.

She has explained—he is an old friend. Cousin to Bose. Using her uncle, George, as an example is reasonable enough, nevertheless, something I can't quite control is eating me up. Making me feel angry.

The annoying thing is she doesn't know she is still crushing on this Arinze guy. I had been busy with best man duties when I noticed the interchange with the guy.

All was fine with me until she tossed a look my way, like she was doing something she shouldn't be caught doing. Maybe even falling for the Arinze guy this time. From across the hall, I had seen them and the sparks they were giving off. The way she was leaning into him, absorbing his every word.

Then they danced! They danced! Like they came to the wedding as a couple. I had been bragging about her to my guys. It was Kien who pointed out she was dancing with this unfamiliar guy, and I knew. I knew it was the reason she had looked like I had caught her with her hands in the cookie jar.

****

I did too much. It was uncalled for. He was her friend—childhood friend she hasn't seen in a while. Maybe she liked him, had a crush on him at some point, but it didn't warrant the stunt I pulled in there. I made a storm in a teacup. The words I said. How I said them.

Fuck it.

Zoya has been nothing but loyal. Trustworthy. Understanding.

I'll wait till Zena gets off before I bring up the topic again. It's going to be a busy week. Best I sort out this mess I created.

"Thanks a lot for today," Zena says, getting out of the car carrying her souvenir bag and purse in one hand, heels in the other.

"My pleasure." My smile is weary, and lopsided. "See you around."

With Zena gone, I have Zoya to myself. I don't know where to start from. Should I apologize for the fit I threw?

No… I don't think so.

I'll simply explain better, so she understands where I'm coming from, and she can be careful.

"Thank you." Zoya says, trying to open the door.

But I hit the central lock. My mind travels to a different time where I had done this with her—the air wasn't thick with tension.

"For what happened earlier?" I begin.

Zoya folds her arms, looking forward, her eyes blank.

"I don't know what came over me to say things like that. I just didn't understand what I was feeling. I didn't like what I saw, and I need you to be careful with that guy."

Her lips set in a thin line, she nods.

Letting out a long breath, I stretch my hand to hold hers, and she lets me. It's limp, lacking that Zoya energy, but I get it. She's angry I called her out. We'll get through this.

"I'll really appreciate if you can delete his number."

"I—"

"I know you got his phone number, Confessor. Please, delete it."

"You're reading too much into this whole thing." Pulling out her phone, she presses some buttons. "Done."

"Thank you." Her brooding silence envelopes me and I add, "1 4 3."

"Need to go inside. Joining the first service tomorrow." With that, she unlocks the door.

"Confessor. I—"

She's out before I complete my statement.

Inhaling and exhaling deeply, I watch as she rushes into her father's compound. So... she had always known she can unlock the door but decides to use it tonight.

When she sleeps on it, she will see things from my point of view.

I am doing a good job.

I wait until she locks the gate, before driving away.

From: *angelinaadeoti@pmail.com*
To: *omdosuandrews@pmail.com*
Subject: Appointment Reminder

Hello Mr. Dosu-Andrews,

I hope you are doing alright.

This is a reminder about your upcoming appointment.

If you need to reschedule, please call, or text me.

Warm wishes.

Adeoti A.,

OceanofPDF.com

TWENTY-NINE

THERE IS GOD OH!

Zoya

Lost my mom early, so I had to grow up, fast. There's nothing I wouldn't do for Zena & Luba.

4:58 PM
Zoya: What's up? Home?

5:03 PM
Chiluba: I'm close by. Home in twenty minutes.
Zoya: I'm headed to yours. Will wait.
Chiluba: Kk.

It is almost six when I see Chiluba being dropped off by a black sedan car in her signature waist-length human hair wig. From her balcony, I notice her wide sexy smile as she leans in to kiss the car's occupant in the back seat. She giggles, before waving, watching the car leave. When she turns to enter her

compound, her eyes meet mine. Her gaze darts to the retreating car, to me, the car, to me, then she walks in.

"What took you so long?" I ask immediately the sliding doors open to reveal her in a shirt dress, black leggings and stiletto pumps.

She steps in, closing the door, before casting a sidelong glance at me. "I have a life besides work, duh." Kicking off her shoes, she walks to the sofa and sits. "This heat, ehn. *Chineke meh*." Dropping her phone beside her.

"Hmm." I join her on the sofa, pushing her phone to the side. "You didn't tell me you started seeing someone. Who was that?" I have an idea, but Chiluba will never do that. It's just paranoia. That's why I'm here. To talk with her. Free my mind.

"My boyfriend." Chiluba smirks, sparing me a wavering smile.

"You ehn." Tapping her thighs. "You didn't wait for Funsho to leave before you replaced him."

She looks good and well. Guilt almost tripped me as I made my way to hers —for coming to her with my man problems when she's working on expanding her company—but I can't share my relationship woes with Zena. I'm her big sister. Besides, I can't remember Zena ever having a boyfriend, so she might fail me on this one.

"I'm following your footsteps, Zo. You're the one with Mr. Dosu-Andrews who I'm yet to meet."

Excuses. Whenever I set up events for her to come, she was always busy. How is that my fault? I hiss, tut-tut and blow out steam. "He is the reason I'm here. He's pissing me off."

"What happened? Did you guys not go to a wedding yesterday?"

"That's where the whole drama happened. I met with Arinze yesterday. You remember Arinze?"

"The tall one with rich parents?" she smirks. "Your crush."

"Yep. He's no longer my crush anymore, *jare*." Scratching behind my ear. "I was young and infatuated."

"So...?" She urges me on.

"I met him at the wedding yesterday. And we danced... together even after he told me he was leaving." Whatever. That's not the point. "Manir saw us—not that I was hiding or doing anything wrong—he saw us and had the guts to tell me, in so many words, that I was openly flirting with the guy at a wedding he invited me to."

"Hmm." She has a slow smile that's building with every word I say.

"Even told me to delete Arinze's phone number. Which I did, because I was expecting him to apologize for all the mean things he said."

She leans back, crossing her arms over her chest. "Did he?"

"Would I be here if he did?" Pouting my lips.

"So, you came here to vent." Chiluba chuckles. "I'm coming. Let me get cold water to wash this gist down."

"The worst thing is," I continue from my position on the sofa, even as she heads to the kitchen, "that Zena experienced most of the whole tension. Like if he—Luba your phone—" I turn to the ringing device. On the screen is a pop-up message.

07:05 PM
Georgie: Missing you already.
Georgie: I can turn the car around.

Georgie? Hmm... Georgi—Uncle George? No. It can't be.

"What is it?" Chiluba returns to sit, gulping bottled water. My expression must have given my discovery away because she takes her phone from my loosened grip. "What now?" Checking her phone's screen, her posture turns rigid.

The black sedan. Pressing my lips together in a slight grimace. It can't be. "Um... Babe." I swallow. "I-I-am confused." Finding it hard to put the puzzle together. "Is that Uncle George? My Uncle?" This is not true. I'm overthinking this whole thing.

Chiluba luxuriously pulls her hair, smoothening them on her breasts. "Erm… yes?" Chiluba smiles, no trace of shame in her expression and actions.

"I-I am not…" Letting out a big breath, I cock my head to assess her. She crosses her arms on her laps, right palm patting her left elbow. I introduced her to Uncle George—my Uncle George—roughly three months ago. My chest tightens, my thoughts freeze. *My boyfriend*.

She said that was her boyfriend. The person in the black Sedan car is her boyfriend. "Is he—Uncle George? Is he the boyfriend?"

"Zoya," she treads carefully, smiling, "we are seeing where it goes. But I think I love him already." Her budding smile falters, then fades.

Scoffing, blood pounding in my ears, I get up from my seat. "You're in love?" No. No. No. What is this? "If you didn't remember he was my uncle, do you realize he is, give or take, thirty years older than you?"

"Yes."

This is not happening. Is this why she has been avoiding me? Avoiding Zena? Using me not introducing Manir to her as a front? What the heck! I introduced you to my uncle for the progress of your business, not let him pimp you!

"Did he force you? Did he make threats? Because if he—"

"Zoya, nothing of such happened." She gets up, moving closer to me. "It was a natural progression."

She tries touching my arm, but I jerk away.

Jeez. I'm going to throw up. Oh Lord, help me. Placing a hand to my forehead, I take deep breaths. …*natural progression*. An image forms and I don't chase it away quick. Closing my eyes makes the image vivid, so I keep them open. …*natural progression*.

"You guys are already sleeping together. Chiluba. This is sexual assault—"

"Zoya."

Her firm voice stops my racing mind.

"Don't hold that thought. It doesn't apply here."

Oh my. Oh my. Who is this lady? You are... You are... Oh no. I move to sit on the sofa as my legs are weak from my sudden realization. "Luba, I want just the truth. Are you pimping my uncle?"

"Oh, shut up Zoya."

"Me, shut up?" The rapid beating of my chest warns to me to count one to ten before I spill anything, but do I listen? "You're pimping my uncle for money, and he is too blind to see it. Is this the business help you wanted?"

Chiluba is not that type of person. She is my friend. An old idea, the only one that makes sense in this situation, returns to mind. I countdown from ten to one, nodding my head. So foolish of me thinking she is pimping Uncle George.

"I would have never taken him to be this type of man. Was that the only way he was going to accept your business proposal?" I move to the edge of the couch, hopeful gaze on her. "Tell me, Luba, no matter the threat, tell me and I'll make sure we find a way around this."

She stares at me like I've lost it, but I won't stand for abuse, whether I'm related to George Van Cleaf by blood, marriage or words. I've been so carried away with work, Manir and our friendship.

"I'm so sorry Luba, I—"

"Zoya! Listen!"

"What? I'm trying to make sense of all the-these."

"You don't have to make sense of anything." She sits beside me. "I already told you. We love each other and that's that."

"He's my uncle... He's... He's old."

"Age is a number."

"Is this because of money?" I bite my lips, frowning. "Or because you're trying to make Funsho feel sorry?"

"Can you stop thinking for a moment?" Her voice slightly breathy. She takes my hand in hers, squeezing it. "Just breathe." Another hand rests on my back, her eyes, smiling. "And be happy for me. He makes me happy."

"Happy? You mean happy, happy?"

Chiluba smiles, nodding her head. Is she expecting me to go along with this harebrained plan?

I scoff, shaking the hand on my back off. "Uncle George's last born is twenty-eight years old! Twenty-eight!"

Chiluba flinches.

"You want to be a stepmom and grandmother to—"

"Zoya, stop it." Her voice is strict and direct. "Please."

"So, I won't remember you're a traitor?" I'm done trying to make sense of this abomination. Trying to make up excuses for them. Removing my hand from hers, I stand up, looking for my bag I had tossed on the seat when I first entered her flat with my key.

Stomping, I pick my bag and move to the door. She rushes to stay me, but I walk around her.

"F you Luba. F. You!"

She tosses her hair to the side, eyebrows squishing together. "It hasn't come to that."

"You're despicable. An opportunistic gold digger and a-a-a a backstabbing friend!"

I give her a once over, feeling nothing but pity, that she has resorted to sleeping with older men for help. "When you come to your senses, you know where to find me."

With that, I leave her apartment, storming off to the nearest bus stop. It takes a while for the cab to fill up. The journey back home is long, but fast. It's Sunday, traffic is nonexistent.

Why would Chiluba do that to me? To us? Did he jazz her, or did she jazz him? As much as I believe Chiluba to be a businesswoman and money lover, she has been my friend since primary school, and I will never dub her as someone that uses jazz for love or for business.

If I were a man, I will date her. She's hot. Has everything a man looks for in a lady—physically, mentally and socially. Maybe uncle George wanted to feel alive, or he has a terminal illness. Maybe she is helping him out with a midlife crisis.

Oh Lord… My best friend is shagging my uncle!

Jeez!

Couldn't she have said no? No matter how much he will pay her or drop on the table. And why did it have to be my friend? He is white! And can get any girl in Lagos just because of the color of his skin. He doesn't need to have money.

When Adesuwa finds out her dad is dating her agemate, I pray it doesn't result in insults, trolling on social media and blogs.

And they are having sex! Nothing will tell me otherwise. Oh God. Covering my face with both hands, trying to wipe off the memory of what I just witnessed—Chiluba leaning in to kiss Uncle George in the passenger seat. Oh Lord. And she has his name saved as Georgie? Ah…

No wonder she couldn't come out to tell me why she has been avoiding me these past months. She has been spending time with him. Hmm. Ashamed, knowing what she's doing isn't right. How would she be proud of doing something like that? Dating someone's grandfather. Adesuwa has three kids already.

"What's up in your knickers?" Zena asks as I step into the house.

"Stop watching those British shows. It doesn't suit you."

"What's wrong? Don't camouflage it."

"Nothing."

"You said you were going to Chiluba's like two minutes ago… and you're back."

I spare her a mind your business look.

"Anything happened that I should know about…?"

“She wasn’t at home.” Yes, she wasn’t. The Chiluba I know has taken leave of her senses. She is dating our uncle, but I won’t be the one to tell you that. That’s why she has been avoiding you coming around to hers.

“Oh.” Putting her hands akimbo.

“Yeah.” Playfully swatting her hand from her waist. “Anything you want to do tonight?”

“Nothing really. But we can watch Hunger Games together.”

“I’ve read the book.”

“No spoilers please.”

“How’s your job hunting going? I’m sorry I’ve not been following up on you and—”

“It’s going great. I got an invitation for an interview. It’s not my number one choice, but it will do for now.”

“Way to go, girl. It’s all a matter of time.”

“I also gave doing masters a thought, but I don’t think I want to go to school. I’ll prefer working my way to the top. Maybe start up a real estate business of my own.”

“Oh-ho-oh. Making big moves!” I laugh, my tightened chest from the earlier betrayal gradually going back to normal.

“I’m almost twenty-five. My mates have done more.”

“It doesn’t matter. Everyone is in their own time zone.”

“Stop making me feel good. Chiluba did more at nineteen than I will ever do.”

Okay… okay. Let’s not tread sensitive waters.

“Zee… Everyone’s journey is different. Chiluba achieved a lot, yeah… that’s fine. But you. You don’t have to compare yourself to her. Follow your heart and do what makes you happy. What should matter to you is that myself and dad loves you…” Biting the insides of my mouth, I add, “Chiluba loves you too. And we all want the best for you.”

Pulling away, she smiles at me with curious eyes. “Someone is being a motivational speaker tonight.”

“Just hear what I have said. Want to get started on the movie?”

OceanofPDF.com

THIRTY

CURTAIN WALLS

Manir

I'm a businessman. I travel a lot. You?

"THE PERSON YOU'RE TRYING TO CALL is not reachable at the moment. Please try again later..." the operators' voice drones.

It's been three days since the wedding. Three days since I last heard from Zoya. Even when our online friendship just kicked off, we stayed in contact consistently, sending at least one checkup message a day. And since we started dating, if messages were not forthcoming, we tagged the other person in a picture or send a meme we find funny.

She has made it clear: she doesn't want to talk to me. Giving me the cold shoulder, all because I shared with her my view on something she did I didn't like.

If she thinks this is how relationships work, she better think again. Our relationship isn't three months old, and she's acting up on a minor issue. Does

it mean I can't tell her if I don't like something? Is it a crime to look out for our relationship's interest? I knew what I saw.

Cancelling a meeting to join a field trip to find if she is alright isn't something I have done in my other relationships, but here I am, counting the seconds till I see her face.

I've got on a yellow hard hat, reflective vest, boots, and the works, for safety. I'm not here to check up on project progress. Damn if I know whose project this is, but my sources confirmed she'll be here at this time of the day.

It's a three-story building that's undergoing inspection for the electrical, plumbing and stuff. There are artisans, engineers and Mercury Consults team on ground. As I scan the area, walking behind a team of two engineers with me on my quest to find her, my gaze keeps landing on men, more men and many more men. This is no place for a feminine woman, but my Confessor handles herself well.

"Watch your step."

My heart stops beating for a second as I turn to find Zoya then resumes pounding, hard. She takes my breath away in work boots, helmet, tablet, and sunshades. Overdosing me with sex appeal and need.

"Oh..." Her eyes go round as realization dawns on her.

"Hi Confessor," I press my lips to keep from smiling but the corners of my mouth turn up in a lazy smile.

She looks around, then back at me. You weren't expecting me to be here? I know. Me too. But this is what love makes us do. My entourage proceeds without me, and it is fine. I have found the one I am looking for.

"Hi," she says, then clears her throat. "Came to check on the progress." Gripping her tablet and pen to her chest, she licks her lips.

Are you asking me what I'm doing here or what you're doing? I knew you'll be here, so I came to find you since you've been avoidant. "Your number has not been going through." Did you block my line? I've been worried sick about you. She's biting her lips, wondering how to deflect. "And you didn't pick my calls—"

"I don't feel up to it." She cuts me, looking away.

I know this is not the place to confront her, but I need to make a move. "For what it's worth, I'm sorry."

Her eyes shoot to mine in surprise. Is this it? The secret tool I have been missing? I'm tired of the cold shoulder and silence. She folds her arms, giving me a tight smile.

Taking a step closer, I add. "I'm sorry Confessor." My lips in a straight line, grinding my teeth, I wait for her response. Anything. Let's get over the weekend's misunderstanding and move on.

"Zoya..." Seconds pass. Nothing. "Zoya, please say something."

She sighs, dropping her arms. "What can a lady whose reasoning you don't respect possibly say to you that you would find reasonable?"

With every word she says, I visibly flinch.

I said some mean things on Saturday. Maybe I overreacted. I'm sorry a thousand times for my churlish behavior. It was my first time experiencing something akin to jealousy, ever. That's what I'll call it, jealousy.

"Confessor." Placing a hand on her forearm, she turns to look at it. I'm close enough for her faint pineapple scent to hit me, causing my throat to thicken. I swallow. "I'm sorry."

Shaking her head, she jerks my hand off, her gaze returning to mine. "I would have loved to stay and chat, but my team would wonder whatever happened to me."

There's more pain in her eyes than I can fathom. It can't be me who caused all that pain. It can't. What's going on?

"This is..." her voice wavers, "This is not a good time." She swallows.

"Damn it, Zo. When will it ever be the right time? When?!"

"That's it Mr. Dosu-Andrews. Have a good day." She brushes past me, and I do nothing to stop her.

****

It wasn't a gigantic task. It was for me to say sorry. The magic word. Sorry. And I did. She was melting, letting her walls down, allowing me to see through her, then I had to mess it all up by cursing.

She was opening up! All I needed to do was nicely ask what's wrong. Fuck it. I didn't even ask how she has been. Fuck. Fuck. Fuck it!

It happened so fast; I didn't take time to process what I was seeing behind those eyes. Am I the problem? Or is she just being stubborn?

Fantastic job Manny. You can't do anything to save your premature relationship. Keep messing it up. Everything you need, is right there, but you find a way to mess it up.

"Hey, what's up?" I sniff, rubbing my tired eyes the moment Bucknor answers my call on the third ring, at my second attempt.

"*Mehn, I dey*."

"Where did you drop your phone? I've been calling." Getting comfortable on my office chair. There are so many things to be done, but there's only twenty-four hours a day.

"Totally forgot I had a phone. Only Bose's phone has been ringing. Non-stop. I assumed it was hers. Everyone has been congratulating her on our wedding. The only reason I've not silenced her phone is because when they congratulate her, I feel like I'm the catch. You get?"

"Yeah..." I smile, rubbing my eyes. "How's the honeymoon going?"

"We're enjoying it, licking-licking the honey from the moon." Bucknor lets out a boisterous laugh and I smile.

"Enjoy it while it lasts."

"Sure thing. And Mann?"

"Yeah?"

"Thanks for standing by me. I really appreciate it."

"No qualms, dude. I'm calling to check up on you." Why I'm really calling is to ask how you handled your relationship until you got to the altar, but I doubt I'll ever ask.

"Where are you?" he asks.

"Lagos."

"Ah-an! With the madam?"

Scoffing, I toy with a pen on the table. "No. I'm at work."

"Wow. Slow down, dude."

"I do. You know me." Hmm... I can't remember the last time I went on a vacay but when I visit new cities, I do my fair share of touring.

"Why aren't you with your madam now?"

Chuckling, I shake my head. If only he knew. "Dude, she lives with her father."

"Oh... I forgot. When are you guys planning to settle down?"

"I can't believe barely a year ago, you were having second thoughts of walking down the aisle. Now you're planning on how to get me into your married club."

"It's a beautiful thing."

"When you guys haven't started fighting. Enjoy the honeymoon phase please."

"That's the idea. It's making every phase the honeymoon phase. Didn't you listen to the sermon during the wedding?"

"Did you?" The pastor kept talking like a radio without battery. I was tempted to pull out my phone, just that I was in front of the congregation, would have been utterly rude.

"I did. Dude... it was my wedding."

Laughing, I sit up. I prefer short and direct sermons. I almost dozed off. The only time, after the dance into the church, I was conscious of what was happening, was during the offering session. "Please share."

“Make God number one.”

“He always is.”

“Re-familiarize yourselves with your shared vision of your relationship and the future.”

Doesn’t work for us right now. “Uh-un.”

“Communicate with a purpose.”

“That’s new. Want to share?”

“You have a wife I don’t know about?” He chuckles.

“*Oga*... tell me what I want to know.”

I hear Bose’s voice in the background, calling out to him to come give her a hand with something and to please keep his phone somewhere.

“Got to go. The Mrs. calls.”

“Haba. And the communicate with a purpose?”

“Watch the wedding videos. Bose uploaded it on YouTube. You got the email, right?”

“Dude, that’s over an hour's worth of film.”

“Enjoy it.”

“Are you serious?”

“My regards to your madam.” He is serious. “And whatever’s happening, sort it out. You don’t sound normal.”

I don’t sound normal? Forcing a laugh that doesn’t reach my chest, I bid him goodnight. “Goodnight.”

“Good—” Bose calls his name again. “Coming babes. On call with Manir.” Bucknor’s muffled reply comes through. “Ok Mann. Take care of yourself. Goodnight.” The line disconnects.

Communicate with a purpose. What does that mean? I type it into a google search bar, ready to assimilate all I can.

01:13 PM
Manir: I need your help with her.

01:15 PM
Lina: I'm happy to help.

OceanofPDF.com

THIRTY-ONE

BACKUP OFFER

Zoya

My favorite part of being an architect is seeing the ideas come to life.

JUST LIKE THE FOOL HE CLAIMED I was, I stood there listening to his crappy idea of an apology. The Arinze that caused the whole drama has not called to compensate me with one or two outings for all the emotional stress he is putting me through. I can't even call him because Zena had exchanged our SIM cards the other night. Her battery was low, and she needed to call the guy that helps with her Community Development Service stuff. Changing the SIM cards automatically erased my call log.

Manir. So unpredictable. One minute smiling and the next, frowning. Like it is my fault Arinze attended his cousin's wedding.

How could Manir have called me unreasonable when I have told him countless times—I don't like people insulting my intelligence or choices. The

best he could have done was tell me he didn't like me fraternizing with someone at a wedding he invited me to. I would understand that.

Time alone has made me rethink my actions and yes, that was unthoughtful of me. Oh yes. And he shouldn't have asked me questions to make me feel stupid.

Yes, Arinze could have lied about anything—after all, we've not seen in years—but I knew him so well when we were younger, dreaming of becoming adults. I know Arinze's mom is Yoruba. I am not dumb to believe he is cousin to Bose. Knowing his mom is Yoruba means it is a highly possible occurrence for him to be Bose's cousin.

Was it really true what Manir was insinuating? Was I acting all roses and butterfly in the arms of Arinze? No. Not at all, he was just over processing the whole thing in his mind. He was jealous. Not forgetting the fact that his last relationship didn't go well because of the same thing—jealousy. On the girl's part though.

The part that really pissed me is the fact that he left me at the restaurant's table alone after talking to me like some petulant child.

Please meet me outside when you're ready.

So dramatic!

I was tempted to call a taxi, but I met up with Zena and remembered that she had her stuff in his car.

But... when I saw him at work today... I felt like crawling all over him. To snuggle in his arms and tell him how much I have missed his voice and laughter. What Chiluba is doing and how I can't wrap my head around it. The humbling look he was serving while expecting an answer from me made me feel sorry for him. I was warming up when he said sorry. Then he had to spoil it—demanding answers—when I was processing the overwhelming emotions churning in me.

Tshew.

Since he wants drama. I'm giving him all the drama I can. Had a brick from the ongoing construction fallen on his head at that point, I wouldn't have

cared. Okay. That's a lie. I would have screamed. Cried my eyes out. Apologized for drawing out our fight and—

"Zoya! Someone is here to see you." Zena calls from somewhere in the house.

See me? *Let him burn!*

Zena knows better than to let a random Thomas step into the house. She's not a kid. She should have noticed Manir, and I are not on good terms.

I left the construction field early today because there isn't much to be done and I need to prepare for my PPE resit in September.

"Please tell them I'm too tired. Drop a message." I shout.

Muttering to myself, I add. "It's because he knows where my house is that's why he's coming here to ruin my evening."

Jumping off my bed, I lock my bedroom door, then flop back on the bed, close my eyes and feign sleep. "I have work tomorrow!"

"Come and tell him yourself." Zena replies, knocking on my door.

"Go away, traitor!"

I hear feet shuffling and a hissing sound. "Do you want me to tell the delivery guy to leave?"

Delivery guy? I bolt up in bed.

I ordered nothing online. Did I? I squint.

"I'll be with you shortly." Fluffing my hair, I ease myself off the bed. Maybe it's Chiluba that has come to her senses. A, I'm sorry package?

The delivery man is waiting outside the gate, package in hand. It's tiny. An envelope. Not what I am expecting.

"Good evening ma," the man says. "Please sign here."

Ma, I stifle a giggle. Like I'm not a young girl. Well, dating someone like Manir can make you feel old. Look at me, I'm a living proof. *That's a bad joke.*

Doing all the signing, I collect the package and head inside, Zena on my heels. It is some few minutes past seven already. Who would this young man

—I giggle at my choice of words again while flipping the envelope—be helping to deliver a package?

Zena will not let me rest. You would think an old woman like her would behave differently for a package that's not hers. I've failed as a big sister.

Mommy, forgive me.

Giggling, we enter the living room and I make a dash for my room, but Zena and I struggle with the door.

"Common. Let me in."

"Boundaries Zena."

"What if it's a letter bomb?"

"I want to die alone."

"I want to die with you."

I can't escape her anymore. Giving up on locking her out, I ease my struggle and she successfully gets into the room.

"When are you going to get a job, you oversized baby?"

"Open the package."

"When is your Passing Out Parade?"

"July. Zoya please *nau*... Let's see what's in it. We used to look at your packages together."

"That was a long time ago. Not anymore!" I reply, laughing. Swatting her arm with the envelope. "You're a potential traitor. Go back to where you belong." We used to be closer than this before I went for my masters.

Zena attempts to grab my package, but I wave it in the air. Good thing I am taller, even though she has all the curves—top to bottom.

I really need to check the package alone. What if it was Chiluba? I wouldn't want Zena finding out that her role model will stoop so low to dating our uncle.

"What if I gist you about it later?"

Zena pauses in her attempts, breathing heavy. "Promise?"

"Zena..."

"Promise or not?" She folds her arms, gauging me with interest. "As you know, I am quite jobless and you... Well, I could stay here all night."

"Okay... promise."

"Good." She smiles mischievously.

I'm tempted to take back my promise.

One problem down. On to the next thing. What's in the envelope?

Shutting my door, I impatiently but carefully tear at the envelope.

"Ah!"

A card with an image of popular comedians on it—a ticket? There's more... an ATM card with what is most possibly the password taped to it and finally, an 'I'm sorry' card.

I know who this is from. He has graduated from text messages and taking us back in time. This is thoughtful. Smiling, I turn the card multiple times before opening it.

It reads:

Hey Confessor,

I'm sorry. Would have said blame it on the alcohol, but you know I don't dig it. You are my only and favorite alcoholic drink. I get drunk on you, your voice and everything that has to do with you. I'm addicted to you, and I'm realizing that when it comes to matters of the heart, I don't do well with words or know how to process my emotions.

I've thought of every feasible way to reach you and when I noticed the change in your demeanor when I said sorry, I knew where my fault lay. I don't have any excuses, Confessor.

I'm sorry.

Would love it if you can go to that show and chill with your sisters this weekend. I'm jealous I can't be there with you, watching you smile, laugh and be happy. But knowing you are, even without me, will give me joy. It's my way of saying sorry. And when you laugh so hard and you heart is light, please find time to call me.

Don't spend a dime. Use the ATM card attached. It's all on me.

Left for Kano earlier today. Will be back next Thursday. I miss you plenty. Can't wait to hear from you…to return to being us. I'm sorry My Confessor. My Queen.

I love you, please call me.

Your Mighty Man.

P.S. Would have included a bottle of wine, but your father…

Just like you to be so arrogant and sign your name as 'Mighty Man' on a note. I hiss, pouting, tossing the card on the bed and diving right after it, screaming with sheer happiness.

"What is it?" Zena asks, panicked, on the other side of my door.

I laugh, sitting up. "Nothing!"

Nothing, right? That you got him to apologize in paper is nothing. I read somewhere that anyone that dares write his or her feelings on paper is damned. Take Lord Nelson and Emma Hamilton of the 18th century. Hah! Manir is making me think of literature and romance.

"Oh." Zena retreats, probably on to other fun stuff that does not involve her curiosity in my life.

I'll tell her about our getaway tomorrow. I'll call Chiluba to—no, I'm excluding Chiluba. She can continue shagging Uncle George and all his children for all I care. *Georgie*. Jeez.

Biting into my pillow, I scream again.

Oh Manir. So romantic… and thoughtful.

I aim to please, his voice says in my head.

You had to write 'please call me' like MTN on the card.

Scuffling off my bed, I go in search of my phone, which upon my earlier commotion with Zena had gotten wedged between the bed and the wall.

I hit speed dial. He picks on the first ring.

"Hello?" My heart melts at the sound of his voice. Mighty man indeed.

"Zoya?"

"Hello, Manir." Forming tough girl, like I didn't just scream my lungs out and stare into space daydreaming of us.

"You good? Got my message? I'm sorry. You know, right?" His words tumble through, and I'm tempted to tell him to breathe.

"Yes... I got your message." Rubbing my face, I acknowledge my wrong. "I'm sorry as well."

He sighs. "So... will you take the weekend off?"

Yes! "I'm thinking about it." I've made final plans on who to take with me.

"Please do. You were looking stressed when I came over this morning."

"Nothing this conversation won't solve." I mumble, smiling.

"You said?"

"No, not you." *Really Zoya?*

"I've missed you."

Should I or should I not? My hormones are running around my head in short dashes. Here. Here. Here. After a brief silence, I respond. "I've missed you more."

I can hear the long exhale from his end, like he had held his breath since he mentioned he missed me. Smiling to myself, drugged by the feeling of being able to control the emotions of one of the top young moguls of Lagos —what?—Nigeria! I lay in bed, my eyes closed. *I am badt like that*.

"How have you been?" he asks. "Because I've not been doing too good."

"Hah, you are expecting me to say worse?"

"Yes..." I feel his grin, wishing he was here with me.

Laughing, I rub my eyes, then stare at the ceiling. "Don't be deceived. I've been doing great."

"I thought as much. The make-up you wore this morning was just an act. Your face—all morose, and serious."

I laugh again, this time, tears fill my eyes. We banter for over thirty minutes, catching up on what we've missed.

Long distance relationship is something I never dreamt of doing, even frowned at a couple of times. But choosing this over a boyfriend who lives close and rarely hanging out or calling, I'll choose this over and over again.

"What will you do with the package?"

"Don't worry about it, it's under control."

"Alright Queen..."

"And I've got great news."

"Oh."

"I got my car."

It's brand new. It had come the following day after my confrontation with Chiluba. Zena and my dad were the only people I could celebrate with. Pelumi from work was happy when I shared it with him but baffled when I asked to continue riding to work with him the following day.

"Congratulations! We should wash that. Why didn't you send a picture?"

"Are you kidding?"

"It doesn't matter if we were fighting. We are fighting with ourselves, not the relationship."

"Who makes up the relationship?"

"Just let's not keep the important tidbits from ourselves, okay?

"I get you." I yawn. "I've not been sleeping well since... and now I feel sleepy."

"Want to take a late nap?"

"Um... yes. I don't want this sleep to elude me. Take care of yourself for me, okay?"

"Yes, my queen."

"Goodnight... And don't follow *eleyah* o, they would use sharia on you."

He chuckles. "I won't."

I grin, bidding him goodnight again. The back of my head hurts from my screams, laughter and giggles. I never knew being in love could make me feel this way.

"1 4 3." He tells me. I love that we use it both in public and private, makes me believe we're special. Different from everyone out there.

"1 4 3 to pieces. Bye..."

"1 4 3 more."

You really want to play this game? "We can do this all night." I smile.

"Okay, okay..." he chuckles. "Good night my Queen."

Once he hangs up, I fall back on the bed, smiling goofily at the ceiling. Rainbows and unicorns are the theme for tonight's dream.

"I heard everything..." Zena's voice comes from the other side of the door.

"Argh!" Standing up from bed, I unlock my door, flinging it open. "Zena, grow up!"

OceanofPDF.com

THIRTY-TWO

PRIVATE SHOWINGS

Manir

I'm yet to meet the woman who will sweep me off my feet.

ZOYA SENDS ME IMAGES OF HER and Zena having fun on the event's red carpet. She is dressed to the nines—a form-fitting skew-neck flowing dinner gown, with a slit that reaches her thighs. For the first time in a long time, she posts on social media and gets some salacious offers I choose to ignore. They can wish, drool, praise. It doesn't change the fact, she's my woman.

What tugs at me is the evidence that Chiluba is not at the event with them. I know I have defaulted on meeting her in person, but that is no excuse not to hang out with her best friend. I wait until Zoya returns home to ask, "Why wasn't Chiluba with you?"

"Her? She'll be fine." Her voice, light and happy.

"Is it because I haven't met her in person? She rejected the offer? I know I owe her a visit, but that—"

"No, not that. She betrayed me. I don't want to have anything to do with her until she gets back to her senses."

"Betrayed you?" I scoff.

"Remember the time I was supposed to introduce her to my uncle at Silhouette?"

"Yes... For the business stuff."

"Yeah. That one. I did and you won't believe it. Last I checked, she is dating—no, not dating, she is sleeping with my uncle."

"She's having an affair with him."

"Duh... Same thing. And he is a widower."

The old man is probably happy he has found a young blood to release his tension with.

She tells me how she found out and the radio silence from Chiluba's end so far.

"So, what's the problem?" I ask.

"I am too ashamed to say it." Her voice, almost a whisper.

"She's having an affair with him alright.... Come on Zoya. There's no big deal. It's a common thing. Widowers need love too."

"Manny, my uncle is almost thirty years older than her. I mean, his last born is twenty-eight years old. For crying out loud, Luba and I are agemates," her voice quakes, "agemates with his last born. How can she, one, do that to me? Two, not tell me?" Her voice gains its normal firmness as she continues driving her point. "It's my uncle we're talking about here. I introduced her to him."

"Okay..."

"Three. He's not just my uncle. His last born, Adesuwa, has kids. Three kids. He is a grandfather. Where does she think she'll fit in his life? Being a stepmother to his grandchildren? I don't think so. The Chiluba I know is scared of having kids of her own, how much more being a step-grandmother."

She chuckles. "I'm trying to envision family meetings and I just can't paint her to be that type of person."

"You need to—"

"Chiluba deserves better. Four."

Oh, we're still counting.

"She claims to love him. Ah! If I didn't know better, I would say my uncle jazzed her or she's after him for his money. Oh… oh. This just occurred to me right now." She slows down, eyes narrowing, her voice low as she presents her latest theory. "Maybe she's with him 'cause she wants to have interracial children."

"Uhn?" What the—

"That explains everything."

"How do you come up with these ideas?"

She giggles. "I'm creative. That's why I am a successful architect."

"You should focus on your craft."

"Really." She clears her throat, brushing my comment aside. "I don't know why she is doing this to us. I don't think she has thought about what his family would say, or what the media would say. She is famous in our own small world—and this might harm her negatively. And… Zena looks up to her." She tuts. "It's not like the young men in Lagos are finished."

Hmm. "That's a lot to swallow." I really don't see any problem in this set up, but I understand the part of feeling betrayed, because she found out by chance.

Sighing, she says, "I just want her to come back to her senses. But I can't reach out to her because now we are no longer on the same level."

I chuckle. "How are you no longer on the same level?"

"Duh. She is dating a rich white Lagos man. Ladies like that have a special association. Wives of Lagos White Men." She laughs at her own joke, but all I hear is the clanking of her broken heart. "With her business mind, Chiluba would happily join and not look back."

"I get you're feeling pained about the betrayal, but don't think too much about it. I know you guys are good friends."

"Good friends don't betray their friend with their uncles."

"But you just said he's widowed." I chuckle. Zoya is hurt, and doesn't want to analyze her feelings, only focused on what Chiluba has done.

"Can we talk about something else, please?"

****

The airport is rowdy, but I make it to the parking lot in one piece. Ìgè is here, waiting for me, engine running. He collects my hand luggage and I get into the cool interior of the car, breathing a sigh of relief to be in a quiet space.

It's been one long flight. Being in first class doesn't save you from screaming toddlers—twins. It was a nightmare. The parents acted like they were in their personal living room, giving the kids free rein to run up and down the aisle, spilling food and water, grabbing onto my armrest, and even pulling my arm. That was when I had it. I spoke to the parents, but they only gave me dirty looks. Glad I made it out without requesting a rope from the flight attendants.

Meeting with Zoya is all that's in my head. I was supposed to arrive two days ago, however, I got sidetracked by visiting clients. I don't mind going to the island to pick her from work. I am done with this thing called long distance relationship. Why are we experiencing long distance in the first place?

05:31 PM
Manir: Just landed. Meet you at work?

I think I have an answer to my question. I have been living like this for the longest time and didn't think through it when I asked her out. Hmm... all I need to do is put myself in order and confirm where we would like to settle.

This should be something I should have thought of a long time ago, before I proposed starting a relationship.

05:32 PM
Confessor: No. I'll wrap up here and meet at yours.
Manir: Your dad?
Confessor: I'm a big girl. *Tongue out emoji*

If she's suggesting meeting at mine, she'll arrive around past eight. She could spend the night instead. I miss her. Most of all, I miss having a womanly essence around. Giving up sex doesn't mean we can't stay in a house overnight together. We're adults.

05:33 PM
Manir: Sleep over? Tomorrow is Saturday.
Confessor: Not in this life.
Manir: Promise not to touch you.
Confessor: Nope.
Manir: I'll place a pillow between us.

There is traffic, as usual, on the airport road leading to Ikeja Under-bridge. Once this traffic breaks, we'll face another one at Allen Avenue. It is so frustrating being a Lagosian. I believe the only reason people troop in and out of here is because it's a business hub, with most headquarters and innovation starting here before spreading out to other parts of the country.

Why hasn't she responded?

05:35 PM

Manir: Still thinking about it?

Smiling, I await her response, going through emails on my phone. If she says yes, it will save me the stress of driving her back home tonight. I really

need to get a full night's rest and having her with me will be an added benefit. Ìgè will be good for the task, but I want to spend time with my woman, with every opportunity I'm given.

05:39 PM
Confessor: Was packing my bag.
Confessor: Pillow? *laughing with tears emoji*

05:40 PM
Manir: I'm faithful, loyal and honest.
Confessor: No way. No sleep over.
Manir: I had to try.

05:41 PM
Manir: I'll pick up dinner from The Place GRA.
What would you have?

****

Zoya arrives some minutes to eight—as predicted—oozing sexual appeal in a white jacket and floral palazzo pants. We hug, engaging in a chaste kiss I initiate, then I lead her to the kitchen for dinner. I arrived almost an hour ago, showered and changed into track pants and a round neck, and resumed chatting with her.

She looks every inch the boss lady, as she takes off her jacket, revealing a white camisole beneath, her afro hairstyle, giving her an innocent look. With every movement she makes, I get light-headed, struggling not to stare at her cleavage.

She laughs at my dinner presentation.

"How do you pull off dressing like this and entering *danfo* buses, when you have a car?" I ask, forking Jambalaya mixed with salad into my mouth. Spaghetti, *asun* and plantains for her. "If I didn't know better, I'll say you are being decent, but..." I shrug, letting it slide.

"I'm decent," she argues, smiling, staring at me from the corner of her eyes, then pouts, forking spaghetti. "It's the life. I don't do buses anymore. Pelumi has been most helpful in that regard." She chews, swallows, then continues. "Concerning the car, I'm thinking of selling it. I can drive daddy's car to church on Sundays or take it out on Saturdays. Driving in Lagos is not for me."

"How much have you spent on transportation this month?"

"I don't keep track. I'm fine the way I am. Zena said we should all carpool and I'm down for that."

"In this crazy city?" With kidnappers on the loose?

"Only carpool with people you know." Gesturing with her fork.

"I don't mind loaning Ìgè to you."

She pauses, smiles, slowly squinting her eyes. "You're serious."

"I am. I don't like that you're out there, entering the car of God-knows-who and..." The thought of something bad happening to her is not something I want to encourage. "I just—I don't like it."

The warm pressure of her hand on my jaw turns my face towards her. "Stop grinding your teeth, Manny. I'm fine." She offers a weak but grateful smile, her finger moving in a calming motion on my jaw. "Thanks for offering your driver. And thanks for worrying, too. I've got this covered."

After the hearty meal, we lay on the couch, watching season eight reruns of the Guilder Ultimate search on YouTube. My gaze constantly moves to her as I keep fighting the urge to ask for more than she has promised.

Hands on her nape, I massage the layered hair beneath her afro. And as she leans deeper into me, I close my eyes, taking deep breaths. I feel my dick getting turgid, at half-mast. Ah... tipping my head backwards, I don't bother with constraining my desire shut.

What if we kiss? That's not asking too much, is it? We've done it before and were not even dating then. It's just a kiss. A simple kiss. And maybe she offers to play with the guy down there.

Opening my eyes, I ask, "A kiss?"

"Uhn?" Her eyes are still glued to the screen when I turn to look at her.

Picking up the remote, I pause the show and she turns to look at me. "They were about to—"

"Want to make out?" I grin lasciviously, shaking off the overwhelming urge to follow through with my wayward thoughts without asking her permission. *I'll make it good for you…*

Her expression changes from playful to confused to stunned—like I have just grown three heads—when she realizes I'm serious.

"No." She shifts on her seat. "Come on Manny. You know I don't want to encourage you or paint ideas in your head."

"I know. I know." Reaching out to take her forearm, running my fingers from her elbow to her palm, repeatedly. "You've done a fantastic job of that. Makes me respect you even more. It's been how long? Like—"

"Two months since we started dating."

"Two months plus." If you count the week that just went by. She giggles, but I maintain a straight face. "Confessor, all I'm asking for is a kiss. Maybe a little smushing too. But first, a kiss."

I roam hungry eyes over her body, settling on the ample cleavage her camisole offers. "Don't we deserve at least a kiss?" Changing my tactics to palming her arms when what I want to do right now is palm her breasts. Oh… those breasts. Fuck. I'm no saint. I stop palming her arms, placing my hands on her forearm, waiting…

"Manir…" She shrugs my hands off, stroking an eyebrow, battling with her needs. "Come on." Getting up, she moves to the end of the L-shaped couch, away from the angle where we've built our cocoon.

I laugh at my weakness and the fact that I am now sitting alone. I plead with her to return but she refuses, smiling, saying it's for our good. I prefer her sitting beside me than having her distant, out of reach.

“Mehn… I don’t believe people date and don’t touch until they’re married.” I thought I could in the beginning, but this is—fuck. This is torture.

“Aunty Clara did.”

“How would you know? Ever since you came in, I wanted to jump you.”

“Oh…” Her eyes twinkle with mischief.

“The smile on your face will disappear when you find out the things I want to do to you…”

“Ooo… he finds me desirable. Sexy…” She croons as she gets up from her seat and begins a slow dance.

“Confessor, what are you doing?” She is stoking this flame, with the sensual sway of her hips and facial expressions.

“This is something to be happy about.” She beams. “I’m celebrating.”

“If you really want to celebrate, come to this couch.” I tap the spot beside me.

With mischievous and hooded eyes, she dances, and I watch with renewed interest, the siren who has my mind in shambles dancing around my living room and me, powerless to do anything. My dick twitches. This has got to stop. “Confessor, please stop.”

“You don’t like this?” Jutting her hips to the left, her hands up, in a wavy motion, she asks, “And this? Your personal Shakira?”

“You really should stop. You are waking the tiger.”

Her eyes widen and burst into laughter, before plopping on the sofa, a hand stretch away.

I ball my fists. “It’s only unseen forces that are keeping me from ripping your pants to shreds and having my way with you right now.”

“Alright. That’s enough warning.”

Moving closer, I try, in my most convincing voice. “Come on, Confessor. I don’t bite.”

Scoffing, she shakes her head. "You've warned me. I dare not play with fire..." Her eyes rake me, from my face, landing on my crotch. "Or tiger. Who gave it that name?"

Laughing, I respond. "His name is not tiger. I only said don't wake the tiger."

"Tiger is actually a nice name." She grins, covering her mouth with one hand.

"Mm hmm." Shaking my head. "We're not naming my privates when he's experiencing no action. He is fine as is."

She laughs, and I smile, leaning into her. *This is my chance. All I need is to get the ball rolling and she'll be game.* Her pinched lips and arms stay me. Letting out an impatient sneer, I throw my hands up in an I give up gesture.

"Manir." She swallows, all trace of playfulness gone. "When I said I'm waiting till marriage, I meant it."

"Hmm." Grinding my jaw, I let her words wash over me, my body vibrating to the silky, sonorous, smooth sound of her voice.

"And it's not based on some religious or-or... spiritual stuff, it's my preference."

"Hmm." I hear you. Are we making out or not?

"I don't... I don't want to sound self-righteous."

"Hmm."

"I don't want to share this special body with the multitude. I want to give my virginity as a gift to my husband."

"And if he doesn't value such things?" Tilting my head to the side.

She gasps, eyes filled with hurt. "You don't?"

"Zoya, that's pressure." Leaning forward, I blow out steam through my mouth. I can't answer the question because I've been the first for multiple girls in my lifetime. Yes, I felt special, being their first, but my mind is not trailing that path. I just want release. *I deserve release.*

"I thought you wanted to settle down." Her voice hardening.

"I do." Sitting straight, I look her in the eyes. "I do. Was that why you said yes?"

"Yes. And other obvious reasons."

"Like?" I press, knowing I'm pushing it, but ignoring the small still voice.

"Like?" She pulls back, eyeballing me.

"Obvious reasons like what? Say it." I smirk.

"Like 1 4 3!"

"1 4 3 Ah!" She flinches at my outburst. "It's I love you. Say it in plain words. It's that easy, I love you! Is this all a game to you?" I let out a manic laugh. "Hey Manir, stay here," I mimic, adding a shimmy with each word as I stare into her eyes. "Let's not have sex till I'm ready because I need to prove to daddy I can do better. Oh... And 1 4 3. Good Manny. 1 4 3." I spit out the last words. "It's fucking I love you! I. Love. You!"

Shaking her head, lips pressed tight into a grimace, she says, "You are better than this."

I avoid making eye contact with her, grinding my jaw. *Lashing out is better than taking you against your wish*.

Getting up, she picks her jacket and I watch as she puts it on.

"It's past eleven. Can you please drop me at home?"

A rebellious spirit in me wants to say no. No, I am not your driver. Find somebody else to drive you. Just came into Lagos to spend more time with you in person and now I want to sleep. I'm tired. Sort yourself out. You are a grown adult and can sleep out if you want to. Making things unnecessarily complicated. See yourself out.

Instead, I say, "Give me a moment. I'll get the car keys."

****

“I'm sorry,” I offer, as we near her gate. She looks away, staring outside, impatient to be rid of my presence. “I’ve been stressed, tensed, I wanted release.” They’re the first words uttered since my earlier demonstration.

She says nothing. I reduce my pressure on the accelerator, delaying the future. “It doesn’t justify my actions or the words I said, Confessor. I hope you understand.”

“It’s fine. I’m asking a lot from you.” Her gaze staring longingly at the gate.

“No Confessor, you never asked. Well, not before I offered.” I shrug, bringing the car to a stop at her gate. Reaching out in the dimly lit car, I touch her reluctant chilly hands. “I’m sorry, Confessor.”

Who am I kidding? If she as much offers to go on with the act now, I wouldn’t mind.

Retard.

Horny fool.

She squeezes my hand and I let out a sigh of relief. “What do we do?”

“Get married soon?” Tightening my grip on hers.

She turns to me, a small smile splayed on her lips. “That bad, ehn?”

“You have no idea.” Sucking air through my mouth, then releasing it.

“I’ll need you to think about it.”

“There’s nothing to think about. You’re the one I want to be with.” Releasing my grip on her hand, I rub my thighs, avoiding her gaze. “You’re the one, Zoya. I’m just trying to set things in place.”

Stroking her forehead, her other hand on her tummy, she says, “You’re not thinking straight.”

You guessed right, but that doesn’t mean I’ve not been planning on popping the question soon. Tonight’s events just sped up things.

OceanofPDF.com

THIRTY-THREE

CONSCIOUS LIVING

Zoya

There are so many opportunities in Lagos.
I can't stay away.

PEOPLE HAVE BEEN LAMENTING THAT THIS is the worst government ever—the president is prone to travelling outside the country to sign treaties without seeing to the needs of his people. In fact, the budget for the president and his entourage for one trip is enough to solve major problems, like the ongoing flood crisis, but all this is just talk, no one is doing anything about anything, they are only looking for how they can get a share of the national cake.

Just like Manir knowing what he was doing when he asked that we make out that first time. I know this because when I woke up seconds ago, short of breath, my torso raised high, as though I'm being exorcised with pure pleasure rippling through me. All I could think of was him walking in, ridding me of this feeling with his fingers and his tiger.

Ah…

Tiger.

Falling back into bed, trying to control my breathing, I recall the last two times Manir had stayed in Lagos, wishing he was here with me.

The first was the night I met up with him at his place where he insinuated making out. We have still not raised the incident of that night in our discussions. The following day, we hung out with his friends at Terra Kulture and on Sunday we went to the beach.

He flew in two weeks after that, and we went to a church concert. Watching him sing his lungs out and dance in praise made me proud of my choice. Mom would have been proud, too.

It doesn't take the fact that Manir has planted a seed in me that is growing at a pace I cannot control. Every other night, I have dreams where he does things to me, and I wake up craving his touch. Googling what I'm going through, I find it's called nocturnal emission—the feminine version of wet dreams. And jeez… Am I emitting sex vibes?

I used to hate watching movies with sex scenes, but now I find myself gravitating towards them. I've watched American Reunion more times than I should in the two weeks since we've last seen.

Having Ehizena around will be helpful at this point in my life, someone I can talk to about my life—besides Manir—but she has returned to her Place of Primary Assignment to conclude the last month of her service year. Daddy has also resumed lectures—not like I'll ever speak of this to him.

With everyone gone, the house is empty, so I ensure I am sucked dry during the day so I can return home, microwave food from the fridge, eat and fall like a log anywhere.

Were Chiluba in her right frame of mind—going by her recent Facebook and Instagram posts, she isn't—we would have organized multiple sleep overs. I miss those times. I miss that Chiluba. I miss my friend. My best friend.

Before Manir and I became an item, Manir was the perfect online friend, but now that everything is serious between us, I've started noticing my

shortcomings and his flaws. When he had told me about his flaws in our earlier chats, before we ever met, I thought it was nothing, but experiencing it in person, it's stifling.

I don't need to recall those messages or unnecessary questioning.

Manir, when he is available, breaks my evening routine. He's been in the CST time zone for weeks now. He once suggested I stay over at his place when I complained about electricity here, but I refused politely. I should be what? Sniffing his clothing while I await his arrival?

1:12 AM
Zoya: Awake?

While waiting for Manir's response, I decide to watch an architectural documentary on my laptop.

The angry buzz of my phone wakes me up. How long has it been ringing?

"Hello..." I say, cleaning my sleep fogged eyes.

"Hey Confessor. That was quick. You good?" His voice is hesitant, as though realizing he woke me up from slumber. "I got your message. Sorry if I woke you up."

Checking my message, I confirm he responded less than a minute ago.

1:14 AM
Manir: Hey love, why aren't you sleeping?

"It's fine. Just missing you. Couldn't sleep." Lie. You could sleep. You have only been having reoccurring sensual dreams.

Manir sighs. "I seriously wish I was on my way back. I'm tired of the heat here. It's ever always so hot and dry."

Closing my laptop, I place it on the floor beside the bed, before curling myself under the blanket, wishing he is here with me. Maybe I should take

the offer of sleeping over at his.

"The humidity here is high. People are falling sick, and it's been raining non-stop for days now. They say it's going to be worse in the coming days."

"That sounds like bad news."

"It is bad news. I spent over five hours in traffic today. The governor and his government people have washed their hands off us."

"I'm sorry babe. Now I understand why you prefer being driven."

"Finally." Sighing, I turn to my side. "You said you were going to return last week." I say, hitting speaker on my phone before placing it on the pillow. "Can you make it back this weekend?"

He sighs again. "You know how it is. When I get back, I'll make it up to you, okay?"

Smiling sheepishly, I reply, "Definitely. How was your day? Meetings? Investors? Clients?"

"A lot of that. I got an office on the twelfth floor for my duration here. We're onto something good. The real estate partner we have here has been taking us on promising tours. Although everyone is scared of working with me."

"Why?"

"Sexual frustration?"

I laugh.

There's keyboard clicking on his end and the sound comforts me. Closing my eyes, I try to imagine the future with him.

"Is this how often you're going to be away when we finally get married?" The question has been plaguing my mind. Don't know what possessed me to finally ask. Our situation looks similar, way too similar. Dad, his work, lecturing, traveling... And now Manir and his plane-hopping obsession.

He is silent than usual. I can feel him processing the question.

Trying to make light of the situation, I laugh. “I know I’m not supposed to act like a nagging wife already—”

“No. You have every right to ask me questions. It’s going to be your life too.”

“Oh Manir.” This is as good as a marriage proposal. Not like that night where he was speaking under the influence of sexual frustration.

“I have also thought about it. That’s why I’m doing all the travels I can now. Um… Where in the world will you like to live?”

As cheesy as it sounds, I love Nigeria and, most especially, I love… “Lagos. You know this.”

“Final answer?”

“Yes, Lagos.”

“Have you been to the United States?”

“No. But I here there’s a lot of gun violence, tax issues and racism.”

“Zo…”

“We can always go there to have kids or… vacation there.”

“Canada?”

“It’s too cold.”

“You’ve been there?”

“No.” I chuckle. “Hearsay and pictures.”

“That’s not reason enough to want to stay in Lagos.”

“I lived in UK and toured Europe for a bit, remember? I can take my experience there and put myself in the shoes of the hearsays.”

“Hmm…”

“That’s why I’m of the opinion of giving birth abroad. If the kids want to live over there, fine, with time, we can relocate, but for now, Lagos is home.” Even though I’ve sat in traffic for almost half of my life here, cursing every moment. It feels familiar. It is home.

"You've said your part. Whatever works for you works for me."

I've chosen the best of men to spend my life with. Speaking of things that work or worked for me... "I have a confession."

"You do..."

"Yes." I swallow, trailing deft fingers on my collarbone. "One reason I think I agreed to dating you is because I know you are always traveling and having a long-distance relationship would keep me from getting intimate with you."

3:00 AM calls are not the best type of calls. You say things you shouldn't. Like me saying, I want to be intimate with someone but don't want to be intimate with them yet. How confusing can I get?

"This is some deep... revelation." The hitch in his voice when he says revelation sends rippling sensations from my nipple to my clit.

"I know. I am-I'm embarrassed to admit it." I stifle a giggle. I've been watching movies I shouldn't be watching. Thinking about tiger. A lot. More than necessary. Closing my eyes, I palm my breasts, wishing he can see what I am doing, too shy to mention it to him.

OceanofPDF.com

THIRTY-FOUR

ACCENTUATION

Manir

Hey hottie, got plans tonight?

"TRUTH OR DARE?"

"Truth."

"What are you doing?"

She hesitates for a second. "Touching myself." Letting out an airy laugh.

Fuck. I blink, licking my lips as my saliva production has gone on over drive. "One moment, Confessor." In a flash, I lock the door, then return to my seat, spreading my legs out, headset on. "Want to play a game?"

"Hmm… it is almost four in the morning." Her voice is low, stroking my alert senses to action.

"Best time for this kind of game."

Her slow but heavy breath sounding more sensuous than any sound I've ever heard. Placing a hand on my crotch, I match my breath with hers.

"Hmm…"

"My hand is on—"

"Tiger…" She breathes.

"Tiger. Yes, tiger." Whatever you want Confessor.

"Hmm…"

"I know you're touching yourself." Holding my breath, waiting for her reply. "Where are your hands, Confessor?"

"My breasts… stroking my nipples." Fuck. Those mounds.

Releasing my breath, I close my eyes. "Stop touching them. I control your hands now."

"You do…" her voice, teasing.

My dick jerks as she relinquishes control to me. My knees loosen, feeling weak. So glad I'm seated. "Imagine me lying beside you, my palm on your forehead, down your cheek, slowly moving towards your mouth."

"Hmm…"

"Open your mouth."

She makes a sexy sound at the back of her throat, obeying my command.

"I'm putting my index and middle finger in your mouth, and you're licking them." I imagine her putting my fingers in her mouth, licking them. The image drives me wild. "Suck it Confessor. Hmm… Lick it…" The indistinct smacking sound of wet lips on fingers reaches me. My dick twitches in response.

Fuck, it's been a while. "What are you putting on?"

"A satin nightgown and panties."

Good… "While you're licking that finger, I trail my other finger down your neck, settling on your breasts. Can you feel them?"

"Mm hmm."

"Tell me Confessor, tell me how they feel."

"Manny..."

"Close your eyes baby, feel them for me, tell me... tell me how they feel."

"Hmm..." she moans, "they're full... warm... and my nipples, they're throbbing..."

Oh Zoya... I moan. Rubbing my immobile palm on the bulge in my crotch, I listen to her describe what's happening to her aroused body. Every word, making her real. Every stroke, causing my breath to itch.

"Atta girl. Now take the other finger, the wet one... rub it on your hardened nipple." I envision her doing that and lick my lips as her breath grows faster, more audible. "Move your—"

"Should I remove my gown?"

My palm stiffens at the distraction.

"No baby. No. And don't speak until I ask you to. All I want to hear is you pleasuring yourself."

"Mm hmm..."

Good. "Now—" I take deep breaths, trying to remember where we stopped. "Now I want you to move your hands down. My hands are stroking your body, down from your breasts to your thighs, then back up your thighs, moving your nightie up as I reach your hip. Take your time baby... because I will... move slowly, slowly to your pussy. Tell me, baby... what do I find?"

"I'm wet Manny. So wet and warm." She moans. "I'm pushing my panties to the side, touching my clit. Hmm... So wet, baby. They're full too. And wet for tiger. For you." She pants in my ear, and I close my eyes. "I am so wet baby... I have been having dreams... dreams where you do naughty thing to... with me... Hmm... Yes... Should I put my fingers in?"

"Don't do that yet." Gritting my teeth together, as the image of her in nothing but a nightie high up her waist, her panties hiding the fingers on her

pussy, floods my brain. “Take off your panties.” I hear the movement on her end as she does my bidding.

“Are you taking off your—”

“Zoya? Stick to the rules.”

She’s so persistent.

“I won’t continue if you don’t touch yourself.”

I sigh. “I will. But I need you to reach your—”

“Take off your pants Manny.”

Who am I to disobey my queen? “Sure.” Unbuckling my belt, I shove my trousers down my waist, leaving my boxers on for control. “Done.”

“I’m touching myself, baby. Just the surface,” she sighs.

“Thanks for taking care of things in my absence. It’s my pleasure to continue.”

“Let me stroke your tiger Manny…”

“Zoya.”

“Stroke him baby. I’m rubbing my clit.” She moans, causing me to arch my back. “It will help me cum faster if I know you are… pleasuring yourself.”

Relinquishing control, I move my briefs out the way, holding my dick and begin stroking. A sudden flush of warmth spreads from my groin to other parts of my body, making my voice catch. “I’m touching myself, confessor.”

“Hmm… You feel so warm. Oh… I’ve got one finger inside me.” She swallows. “It feels so good. Are you stroking baby?”

“Yeah… I’m so hard Confessor… Rock. Hard.” Closing my eyes as I palm my dick, my hip jerks as I envision her in nothing but construction hat, reflective vest and boots. Oiled up. Wet and ready. Fuck. Didn’t know I could get harder by just envisioning her being damn industrious. My queen…

“My clit feels so good,” she pants. “So slick… warm and… it’s… getting… wetter…”

Zoya… fuck! Increasing my pace, I spread my legs wider, my toes curling. "How many fingers, Zo?"

Stroking my dick from root to crown, I conjure her sitting on the other side of the office in her construction hat, vest and boots, thrusting out her chest, doing my bidding with a smile on her innocent face.

With fingers deep inside her.

Telling me how she feels.

Goading me on with her eyes.

Her smile.

Her breath.

Her moans.

Tiny moans.

Loud gasps.

Oh Zoya…

My dick pulses, getting harder.

"One…" she moans.

Fuck. A tingling sensation from my head wants to let go, but I fight for control with my breath. "You're a big girl… want to try two? Hmm?" I need her to come first. "Two fingers. That's a good girl. Two, baby."

"Hmm…"

I hear everything. Feel… everything.

"So full Manny. So full…"

We keep at it. Panting. "Come on, Confessor. Work it for me. Work it for your Mighty Man." Breathing harder. Faster. Zoya… "I'm fucking full for you. Cum for me, baby."

"Oh…" she gasps. "Hmm…"

Zoya. Zoya. Hmm. Hmm. Stroking. Faster. Panting. Zoya.

“I’m cumming Manny. I’m cumming,” she pants and the image I created before me tips her head back, shuddering as silent tremors rock through her.

Yes. Yes. Opening my mouth, I bare my teeth as my dick hardens. Blood stops flowing. Everything stops, as the tingling sensation from my head alerts me it’s time to let go.

Yes. Yes. “Ugh…” I groan, thrusting my hips as semen spurts into my palm. Oh. Oh. Oh. I pant, returning to myself. Bliss…

My knees are weak, my body light from release. All I want to do is lay down, close my eyes and sleep.

“Baby?” I ask.

“Hmm…” It sounds like a purr. A satisfied purr.

I manage a smile, imagining her sleepy, curled to the side. “Think you can sleep better now?”

She yawns. “Mm hmm. I have to go. Long day at the office today. Site inspection and need to fill out some forms for an evaluation session with Madam Nelly later this week.”

“Oh,” I sigh, getting up in search of tissue paper to clean up. “The monthly HR stuff. Don’t worry, you will rock her world.”

“Just like I rock yours, right?”

“Ah babe. You don’t know. I’ve got a pleasant surprise for you when I return.”

“Um Manny.”

I pause, in the act of cleaning up. What is it this time around?

“We can’t—”

“I know.” Tossing the soiled tissue into the basket. “That’s not it.”

“Okay. I won’t jinx it by asking you what it is. Just… come home soon.”

“Be careful what you wish for.”

She gives a small laugh. “I’ll sleep off on you. Got to go Manny.”

“I love you babes.” Now I want to pee.

“Take care.”

It’s when I park my ride in the garage, relieving the moment, I realize she didn’t respond with I love you or 1 4 3.

OceanofPDF.com

THIRTY-FIVE

WRONG SCALES

Zoya

Met this guy at the airport today. I think my heart skipped a beat.

"I'LL BE GOING TO A SITE on the mainland later today. The rain is affecting project work." Pelumi tells me, "I won't be returning to the office."

I smile in confusion, a cup of water I just got from the dispenser in hand. Why is he telling me this? The day has only just begun, but I am tired from yesterday's event. Plan is, to leave for home as early as possible, I'm not having a repeat performance if yesterday was any sign of how bad it will get.

His mouth curves into a smile. "Going home? You'll have to sort that out yourself."

"Oh..." I smile in understanding. "Thanks for informing me." Sipping my water.

"You're welcome."

Walking back to my corner, I calculate how early is early enough to leave the office. Like I mentioned to Manir two nights ago, the rain is persistent, even other states are reporting their own travails.

Honestly, I don't know why I came into work today. Some colleagues didn't make it, calling in sick.

It was fury road last night.

On twitter, a white man kayaking at Victoria Island is going viral. When I saw it, I laughed. I laughed till tears threatened to spill. It was funny. And sad. That is the situation we are living in. I wonder how those living in Ajah are faring.

The government has told people living in flood-prone areas to move, without a precise solution of where they should move to, announcing that the worst is yet to come. Maybe when July begins next week, all this will be a thing of the past.

10:23AM
Unknown number: Hey, I totally forgot to call you until your name popped up on LinkedIn. You still work around Church Street on Lagos Island? I could drop by later in the day. Got work around there. Let me know.

Staring at my phone in confusion, I try to recall whose call I have been expecting. It is already few minutes past eleven, the day is going slow, like a snail.

An email pops up. It is a reminder email from Madam Nelly for my evaluation scheduled for later today.

I stare at the number on my phone again. The tone of the message sounds like a guy, definitely not Manir's since—well, I have his number.

It wouldn't hurt to respond to the message. Could be Chiluba.

Ah!

Joke of the century. Chiluba found me on LinkedIn. Is she playing a prank on me? Trying to reconnect?

Why sit here asking million-dollar questions when I can reach out?

I dial the number, waiting for the owner to pick.

"Hey! What's up?" a friendly voice asks.

Um... who is this? "H-Hello?"

"I'm sure you got my message."

His voice sounds vaguely familiarly. Am I supposed to have his phone number?

"I'm sincerely sorry that I promised to call and did not. It took me seeing your LinkedIn profile popping on my timeline to remind me." He laughs.

Okay... Almost there. I can't quite grasp who it is, but if he continues speaking, I should be able to.

"Ehiz?"

I remember now. "Arinze!"

"You didn't know I was the one?"

"I didn't." Shaking my head.

"I thought you saved my phone number. I'm pained." He doesn't sound it, he sounds excited. "My hands are on my chest trying to stop the bleeding and I am driving."

Laughing at his attempt for a joke, before realizing I am at work, I lower my voice a notch. "I'm sorry. It's a long story."

"Hmm... because of LASTMA, I'll accept your story later."

Mm hmm. I am never sharing that story. "It's nice of you to call."

"I'm happier. So... what's up? Can we see today?"

"Today?"

"I'm sorry about the suddenness. I'm just trying to kill two birds with one stone. I'm on the island today. Usually, I don't come to this side of Lagos."

"Oh."

"It's Friday. Want to hang out? We can hangout after work."

How did the conversation get here? "Oh… I thought you wanted to drop by."

"Yes. I wanted to, but this rain and traffic." Clicking his tongue. "We might as well just hang out since it's Friday."

Amen to that! Maybe see a movie at the cinema? He could park his car here and we get into a *keke napep* to avoid traffic. Definitely break my routine.

"So…" I hesitate, not wanting to force my preference down his throat. "Where do you want to hang out?"

"What do you think about clubbing?"

"Arinze, I don't do clubs." I sigh, massaging the back of my neck. The only times I have gone clubbing are with Chiluba, other than that, I don't club. It is all dancing with overpriced drinks, in a dark noisy room.

"It's Friday Ehiz. You know… work hard, play hard."

"Thanks, but no."

"Hmm… Okay." He sighs. "Really would love to see you today, though. Even if we don't go clubbing."

"I close work around five. With traffic and all, it will be hard doing that. Can we see over the weekend instead?"

"Got any other pressing plan today after work?"

"No…"

"Great. I have appointments till four. I could make it to yours before your closing time and be your chauffeur for the evening. You live on the mainland, right?"

"Yes, around Anthony area."

"Good. So, see you soon?"

"Is that your normal route? Because with this flooding situation it will be unfair of me—"

"No. No, no. It's something I can work with." Hmm. "Lucky you, I stay around Ikorodu."

"Oh..." I will never peg Arinze for an Ikorodu guy. Not in a million years.

"It's a date then?"

I smile at the idea. "Sounds like it."

"Thank God for Lagos traffic. We would get to catch up better than any normal date would do."

"I have to go." It's almost time to meet with Madam Nelly.

"Send me your office address, please."

"I'll do that right away."

"See you soon, it is then."

"Yeah, see you soon."

Jeez. He doesn't know he just rescued me from the stress of commuting home today.

As I prepare a progress report, select samples for my meeting with Madam Nelly, I feel a tightness in my chest.

Call him back and cancel.

Rummaging through my bag in search of my lip balm, memories of that weekend come to mind. It is clear. Vivid.

Manir had been so jealous—the look he had given me, even before the talk that ensued, had said it all. He didn't trust me with Arinze. His reason is just as flimsy and uncalled for.

Arinze is an old friend and catching up with him wouldn't kill Manir. Besides, going home with Arinze is similar to me asking a random driver for a carpool and finding out its Arinze.

If he finds out, he won't like it. Cancel.

What Manir doesn't know won't hurt him. Maybe one of these days, I will organize a meet-up for them. He might end up liking Arinze. After all, what's there not to like about him? He is friendly, classy, and in his own lane. I cannot fully ascertain this Arinze is one and the same with the boy from my childhood. Since he is looking to reconnect with me, I can find out more.

What if he wants more?

Jeez.

Should I have told him I'm in a relationship?

Oh… It is too early for all that. We've met what? Once. I'll tell him today. When we meet, I'll let him know. To set boundaries.

Madam Nelly wastes no time in going into details. "I see you're doing an excellent job with the Stage house," she says.

I nod, smiling.

"By the way, have they created the mock presentation for Monday? I need you on top of that."

She shuffles through designs, sighs, then drops them on her table. "I know you're capable. Ah… I need to get home on time, tomorrow is my daughter's birthday. And *Doki* was on call last night." She laughs. "The man is too tired to handle the preparations and Ada will not let him rest."

"Oh… Happy birthday to her."

"Thank you. Just yesterday she was a baby, now she's eight. These kids, they grow up on you."

Madam Nelly and her husband, an urologist fondly known as *Doki*, have found a way in their busy schedule to care for their two children. With the hours she spends in the office, at clients, and on site, including her friendly attitude to her mates, it's no wonder colleagues would question her loyalty. She's too good to be true. However, hearing her speak affectionately of family makes me realize she is as real as can be.

"About the Stage House," I begin the moment I find the opportunity to chirp in. The Stage House is a residential project for one of Nigeria's revered playwrights that I won over with my design. "I'm faced with a couple of challenges."

"Hmm… what challenges?"

"The materials are…"

I go on about my challenges, suggesting what we can improve on, then move on to other projects. By the time we wrap up, it's almost two. I place an order for lunch. Bring Favor and other available team members up to speed and resume working on suggestions Madam Nelly gave on another project.

2:22 PM
Zoya: Hey big head.
I miss you.
How is your day coming?

Occasionally, I check my phone for messages from Manir, but nothing pops. His day is only just starting, but still... I need him to send something to make me feel tingly.

4:53PM
Arinze: Hello Workaholic, I'm right outside your building.
A Red Honda Accord.

I should have canceled. How did time fly so fast?

4:58 PM
Zoya: I'll be out shortly.

This Arinze looks different.

As I settle in the car, a cabbage-y odor, hits my nostrils. It takes a lot for me not to reject his offer and get on a bus instead. The car looks clean, but-but. Jeez. Pressing my lips together, absorbing the sting. It smells off. I'll just have to get used to it, for old times' sakes. I promise never to put myself through this ordeal again. I'll probably buy him an air freshener as a gift if our friendship continues past this.

We complain about the drab and gray weather as we join the rush hour traffic.

"It's been a while, Ehizoya Ainabe." He sizes me up, leaning back, eyes sparkling with curiosity. "What have you been up to?"

Forcing a laugh at the familiar way he mentioned my name, I give him a knowing grin. "You know..." I play along, forgetting my initial discomfort. "Got my bachelor's in architecture. Bagged masters in UK. A couple of projects here and there."

He nods, smiling. "Ah! Big moves. You're working with the big guns, I see."

"If you say so." I shrug. "What about you? Canada?"

"Canada is great. My wife and twins are there."

"Oh wow." Arinze, a father? He doesn't look it. At all.

He hits the steering wheel, blaring his horn, waiting for the car in front to move. The light has turned green.

"The bundle of joys came in three years ago."

"Wow."

Wow. Wow. Wow. Can I just shut up? So, Arinze is married. Get over it.

I have been over thinking everything that went down between us. To think I wanted to throw the, I have a boyfriend gauntlet at his feet, in case he was getting ideas.

Is she Nigerian? How long have you been married? I hope you have been faithful to your wife. So many questions I want to ask, instead I say. "Do they visit?"

"That... is left to my wife."

He talks about classmates from school, what they're up to, if I hear from so and so. We reminisce our high school days.

"And Chiluba? How is she?"

She is off this discussion. "She should be fine." We don't talk about Chiluba.

"This one that your voice is sounding somehow." He lets out a low, suggestive laugh.

There is nothing somehow about my voice. I am just not interested in talking about my once-best-friend.

"Calm down small now. Smile..." he says, offering me a sidelong smirk which I replicate. "Well, *sha*... you guys were so close back then."

Yes, we were...

"Wait. I thought I saw her post you on her birthday."

Jeez. Let it go Arinze.

He chuckles. "Did she steal your man?"

"Can she ever?"

"That's true. How is your baby sister?"

Look who just realized there are some things left unsaid. The venom in my tone must have done wonders.

"Zena, right?"

I sigh, swallowing as my senses open to the cabbage-y odor again. "Yes. Zena. She's fine." Thunder clamors in the distance.

"She would be a big girl now."

She is. I smile, proud of how far we have come without our mother and our unavailable father. "She passes out from NYSC this month."

"That is great news."

"Thank you."

We talk about the government and the ongoing floods as a steady downpour begins.

Warm air blowing from the A/C never felt so good as the ticking wiper goes whoosh, whoosh.

It is a long ride.

Worse than yesterday.

When we tire of talking, we turn on the radio, listening to the Nostalgic Road Show on Zone-T FM.

Kini Big Deal blasts from the speakers and we rap alongside Naeto C. As night falls, dark rain clouds cast a deep shadow around us, resulting in a moonless sky. The DJ switches the playlist to R & B songs like *No One Like You* by PSquare and *Strong Ting* by Banky W. Back-to-back, we keep singing, moving to the beats, rhyming the lyrics.

When Fall in Love by D'banj plays, I mellow a bit, crossing my arms, thinking of Manir. I check my phone, still no message from him.

"Ah-an. What happened?" Arinze asks, reducing the volume, noticing the change.

"Nothing." I grin. "Missing my guy." There, I said!

"Ah! They've taken my friend oh!" He laughs, asking for more information on who the lucky man is.

Arinze has a pleasant personality, but it doesn't change the fact that spending time alone with a married man feels like cheating.

As I bid him fare well, I do not give him a specific date for our next meeting, even when he presses. Although I enjoyed the time we spent together, catching up, laughing at old jokes, jamming to afro beats, I know it will not take long for emotions to start seeping in.

"Wait, lemme get you an umbrella."

Stepping out in the rain, he skids to my side—almost falling—holding up the umbrella he got from the back seat. A car drives by, the hard bright headlight momentarily blinding us.

We laugh as our eyes meet and for one heartbeat, I imagine what we could have been if life had no plans of its own.

"Thank you." I shout into his ear, avoiding the pelting cold raindrops.

"You can keep it—"

"No, I—"

"It's alright. I've got a lot. I need to go now." He gestures to his car, the corners of his mouth lifting up in a small smile. "It was the best ride I've ever had in Lagos."

"Oh."

"Hug?"

I nod, automatically, reaching out, and it gets awkward with the umbrella between us. We laugh again.

Knocking on the gate, I wait for Danladi to open. I shiver, cold and excited from the turn of events, forcing a grin as I watch him reverse.

Less than fifteen minutes after waving Arinze goodbye, I hear a knock on the front door.

10:21 PM, the clock reads.

Who could that be? Arinze? Did I forget something?

OceanofPDF.com

THIRTY-SIX

TURN UP

Manir

I'll be in London for a conference. We could meet. Coffee date?

IT'S BEEN RAINING SINCE I GOT into Lagos. Traffic was at a standstill on the expressway from accidents, but we get out of it without a scratch on the car.

Things didn't go well with my clients, but it would not stop me from my quest. Rubbing my tracksuit trouser, I confirm the bulge of the tiny box. I got it a month ago. Deliberating the best time to pop the question. Wanting to wait until she gets her promotion or architectural title—whichever comes first.

With what went down on the call the other night... That. That was the catalyst. I can't wait any longer. We're walking down the aisle in a month. Maximum I'll stretch is three months.

We will bypass the flowery stuff and go to the court next week, if left to me. She can always plan the wedding of her dreams after that. I'm done

waiting. Done being chivalrous. It's not all about sex, but her terms and conditions are making it look like so to me.

As we approach Zoya's, with my presence as a surprise, I lean forward to inform Ìgè. "Don't keep the car running, I—" Is that—? What the fuck! My eyebrows draw closer as I watch them.

I watch.

I watch as she laughs. Leans into him—*why is he here?*

They laugh. Again.

The way he looks at her—like the last piece of a sweet-and-spicy beef kabab.

She stares at him, like really stares at him.

They talk. *Why the fuck are you talking with the same man we argued and fought over*?

She nods.

They hug.

Are they having sex? Was he her first?

How would you know? You're not useful.

And laugh.

Her lips part as she watches him drive off.

Fuck. No!

I know the signs. I've seen things go down and I've made things happen.

Sitting there for what seems like hours, Ìgè's voice rouses me, asking if I'm okay.

"I'll be back shortly." I grit my teeth, slamming the car door close, jogging to her gate.

A stunned Danladi opens the gate and I brush aside his greeting, making my way to the house.

I know I lost my head the first time, but you talking to him is highly disrespectful.

For fuck sakes. We deleted his phone number!

And if he sought you out, you shouldn't have bloody entertained his call or-or-or even spent time with him!

If the tables were reversed, you and I know what will ensue.

Have I given you any reason to doubt me? My intentions? Then why make a fool—

The door opens. "Manny! You scared me."

"You're scared, but you opened the door?" I say, offering a lazy smile.

Is that guilt? Were you expecting him to return?

You're smiling like I didn't just witness you getting all sappy with that dude. A dude whose presence never settled well with me from the first day I saw him with you. Someone so important you never mentioned him in all our conversations.

"I used the peephole, duh." Clasping both hands, she cocks her head to the side, scrutinizing me. *Unsure of how to react?* "This is a surprise. I was expecting you tomorrow."

She smiles, hugging, then sniffing me.

I let her hug me to her heart's content. "Well, here I am." Scoffing. "Signed, sealed, and delivered."

Letting go, she cast furtive glances inside the house, her hands making short jerky movement as she speaks. "I'm the only one at home. Um. Em." Clears her throat. "Do you want to come in?"

I shouldn't. I should just tell her I saw her, and I am not happy. That I canceled the reservation I made for us for a weekend at Eko Hotels to celebrate the question I was going to pop. "Sure."

She laughs, rubbing the back of her neck as she makes room for me to enter. "It's not a sleepover."

"I know. It's your father's house." *Even though there are so many nasty things I've thought of doing to you all week long*. "I have ample respect for him."

"I didn't imply you didn't."

As we walk into the living room, my shoes off, she asks, "Want a tour of my bedroom?"

"I don't think that's necessary." It's taking me a lot not to shout and demand answers. Don't want to imagine what I'll do in there.

"You don't want to see where I sleep?" She grins, winking, settling on the sofa, one leg on the floor as she cuddles a throw pillow.

"How was your day?"

"It was..." she nods, staring cautiously at me. "Good?"

Is it my tone? Can she sense my discomfort?

"Want to sit?" She smiles, tapping the sofa.

We are playing a game. I can sense it. She knows I know.

"There's no need. I came directly from the airport. And I've been out there for a while."

"Oh."

Tilting my head to the side, I ask, "Anything happened you think I should know about?"

Biting her lips, she looks away, then back at me. "A friend dropped me over from work." She settles deeper into the sofa, crossing her arms. "Um. That my colleague... um, Pelumi. The one that drops me off? He left work on time, and I had to follow someone else."

"Is that someone else the same someone we spoke about months ago?"

She hesitates, moving the throw pillow to the side. "Manny, please don't. Don't make this something it is not."

Unbelievable! Putting a finger to my mouth. "No. No. I'm not." She's trying to make this about me. Like I'm some dramatic freak. I smile, shaking my head, dropping my hands to my side. "I just want to know."

"He is a friend, and that's all there is to him. An old friend. Full stop."

"Mm hmm. A friend. Zoya, a friend you don't want to talk about."

"That's my business." Her voice is too high pitched for my liking. There's something fishy in all this.

It's none of my business? "You didn't see it fit to tell me you were going to hang out with this friend of yours? Dude we had an argument over?"

"Because it would have led to this. This was what I was trying to avoid."

"It just doesn't make sense." I pace the length of the room. Pausing in front of her, pointing fingers. "It shows you have something going on. If not physically, but something going on in your mind that you don't want to tell me."

"Manny, can you just stop these accusations?" She grimaces. "I didn't want to tell you about it because I knew you were going to react this way. Arinze is a friend. My childhood friend. You can't tell me who to see and who I shouldn't be seeing."

What on earth? Now I'm controlling? "You're getting on my nerves right now." I say through gritted teeth.

She sighs loudly, taking her time as she gets up. "Can you just—can you just leave, and we talk about this tomorrow? You're stressed and—"

"Why didn't you tell me you were going to be hanging out with him?" Drawing my lower lip between my teeth.

"I wasn't hanging out with him." She says through clenched teeth, standing some feet from me. "He only brought me back home. How many times do you want me to tell you Pelumi couldn't bring me home?"

"You're not answering my question."

She tuts, making sweeping hand gestures. "I don't know what sick mind games you're trying to play with me. But that's what happened. He dropped me."

"Damn it, Zoya!" I snap. "You have a car. You have a fucking car!"

"And you know I don't drive it on weekdays..."

As she speaks, I grind my teeth, walking towards her, taking up her personal space. *I need to get into her brain.* She keeps taking a step backward until her back touches the wall. Forehead to forehead. Her are eyes wide, with white showing around the iris. "What are you doing? What are you doing?" she mumbles, pushing at my chest. "Manny, please stop this."

"Use the fucking car you have—"

Gasping. "Manir..."

"—to go wherever the fuck you want—"

"Manir..."

"—and stop relying on random men!" My hand punches the wall beside her head.

"Manir!" she screams.

What has gotten into me? What is wrong with me? How did we get here?

She blinks as I flex my fingers.

They are numb.

Obsessed freak. His father.

Her nostrils flare, fuming from hyperventilation.

"Why were you shouting at me?" The tiny hoarse voice is like a syringe needle, more effective than her repeated shouts of my name.

"Are-are you okay?" Her arm reaches out to palm my face and I flinch, quaking. Shivering as tremors run through my body. My insides feel ripped out, gutted, with a twist in my tummy.

This is not good.

And it feels so familiar.

Obsessed freak. His father.

"I'm sorry Zoya." I mutter, backing away from her.

"Manir." She draws her eyebrows together, opening her mouth to speak, but nothing comes out. She blinks.

Yeah. I've messed it all up. Turning my back on her, I walk to the door.

"Manir."

I can't do this.

"Manir!"

I can't be like him.

"Manir, stop. Now!"

Stopping in my tracks, I don't turn to face her. "I'm sorry about all that."

"What was that all about?" Her voice is strong, but I don't miss the quivering. The tiredness...

Are you tired of me?

"I-I need to leave now." Clenching my hands into fist.

You punched her.

No! I imagined I did.

"Not until you explain what all that was about." Her voice drawing closer.

His father.

Letting out a sigh, I flex my fingers, raising my head to the ceiling, grinding my teeth. "This. This did not happen."

My eyes burn with tears, not wanting her to see me this way.

I cast her a sidelong glance. "I'll see you soon."

Opening the door, I run out, into the soft but plentiful rain, hoping she's not hot on my heels.

This did not happen.

Tears mix with raindrops, clouding my vision and I wipe them off, making my way to the car. *I can't, not now,* patting the bulge in my trouser, flaring my nostrils.

It's better this way.

"Take me home." I say through tortured breaths, biting my fingers, staring longingly at the gate.

"*Oga,* which—"

I glimpse her through the gate, which I left slightly ajar in my hurry. *She can't see me this way.*

"Fuck!" Hitting the headrest. "Just drive!"

How could I? How could I ever raise my hands? Even the thought of attempting to do that causes an unsettling in my tummy. I can't believe I almost hit the one I want to spend the rest of my life with.

It doesn't matter that I hit the wall. What if tomorrow I actually hit her? Fuck! Fuck! No!

This did not happen.

I doubt she knew what was about to happen. Or the raging emotions... the voices... They keep taunting me.

You did it.

You did it, you undeserving freak.

Tormenting me.

Reach out.

OceanofPDF.com

And if love be madness, may I never find sanity again.

—John Mark Green

OceanofPDF.com

THIRTY-SEVEN

TRUST SCALE

Zoya

It's her birthday! Why don't you surprise her with a visit instead?
I would love a thoughtful surprise visit.

I CANNOT BRING MYSELF TO FORGET that night as crazy and life changing as it was. I have turned it, flipped it, analyzed it, processed it, but still cannot make sense of it. And the message you later sent. I don't understand.

Why didn't you tell me?

I was happy to see you. Next thing, all those accusations. Your expression was scary. And at the same time, I wasn't scared. I never told you, but daddy said something about you. Maybe I should have told you. Asked you… What really went down that night in the generator house? Was this what daddy saw?

How long has this been happening? How often does it happen? Do you take medications? Are you okay? I can't believe you never opened up to me about this.

It's been three weeks and I haven't heard from you. I tried reaching you, but nothing. Your phone number is unreachable. You are not responding too on social media. Your friends have nothing to say. Your apartment seems deserted.

Were you ever real?

Is this the pleasant surprise you promised? Are you married somewhere and can't continue living a double life? Do I look like her? Does she look like me?

What was that night about? I'm burying my head in work, but it is not helping. I want answers. I need closure.

I am not complaining. I just want to know... you must know I miss you.

How can you let all our years together evaporate in one night?

You came in all wet... Wet from the rain. Like you had been standing out in the rain. Were you watching the exchange between Arinze and I? It was nothing. Manir, nothing. Nothing compared to what I've found with you. I thought about a life with him—

Jeez.

I feel so embarrassed.

But that was it.

A fleeting thought.

And I killed it.

Killed. It.

I can't believe you'll let this thing go on for this long.

****

There's really no one to talk to about this. I still can't make sense of it.

Daddy is off limits, he might not smirk, but my pride won't have it.

Aunty Clara will have a lot of reasonable things to say that will not answer these questions. Besides, she doesn't know you. She doesn't know you the way I do.

Zena... She is trying to make sense of life after school. I don't want to burden her with us.

And Chiluba.

Chiluba...

She's still in her own world. We're too far gone for me to reach out to her on this. What will she have to say? What would we say to each other?

I think I have been happy with you.

Intoxicated by you.

Forgetting what life was before meeting you. Before knowing you.

I cannot go through my phone without going to your name. Without seeking your status. Without waiting for a call or message from you. Without looking at our pictures.

A thousand plus pictures and videos on my phone, but I feel I didn't take enough. A thousand plus pictures and videos on my phone, they don't equate to you in person. Or your touch. Or the way you look at me.

Now I kind of understand what Chiluba meant when she said she was happy with Uncle George.

Oh Manny...

I miss our late-night discussions. Random chats. Checking up to see if I have eaten. Asking if I'm good. Not everybody cares. Not everyone who askes those minor questions matter. We feel it more when it comes from those we love.

A message a day, I'll take that.

Come on, ask me if I'm good.

You are the one I want. I want to talk to you. And if you don't want to talk, if talking about this makes you feel sad. Then I understand.

I'm lying. I apologize in advance if I make you feel weird by acting tense or worried when you don't want to talk about this.

****

3:16 AM
Manir: I'm sorry I'm away, but I need to do this.
Please hold the fort for me.

What were you doing awake at three in the morning that you couldn't call that night? I keep reading that message, but it doesn't make sense. You left me in the dark!

In. The. Dark!

Hold what fort? You disappeared!

What is happening? You are still not reachable…

I went to your place to throw your sneakers, the one you left at the door front when you couldn't wait to rid me of your presence, but I couldn't go through with it. It's on my bed. I removed the grass and mud stains on it. I touch it occasionally.

Just tell me what is going on. You know me. You know me better.

At least tell me what I did wrong to make you snap like that. Is it your health? Is it business? Family?

Menstrual cramp is worse this month because I've not been caring for myself. I'm trying to fight for us but you're not helping.

Oh Manny…

Where are you? Where in the world are you? I hope what happened that night is not a continuous thing? The thought of you being alone makes me ache. I thought I was your confessor.

Can you reach out to me? Let's talk. Once a week is fine. How are you faring? Are you okay? I promise not to entertain anyone you tell me not to see. That's another lie. We would discuss it and then we'll come to an agreement.

Manir… I love you.

And I miss you.

I miss you so much, that it hurts.

An intolerable, deep, knifelike, sharp pain.

I felt it in traffic today while thinking of you. Of us. I held my breath, blinking rapidly, a hand to my chest. Cars were honking all around. It took me a moment to get myself together, telling myself to breathe. The pain eased away when I focused on me and stopped thinking of you.

Well-wishers told me to check myself.

I took a day off work to visit the hospital. After running tests and asking questions, the doctor said it was nothing.

Nothing

Nothing but a broken heart.

Did you get that? A broken heart!

Oh Manir...

Whatever it is you're going through, please share with me. I really want to be your backbone. I want to be there with you. For you.

****

See, I have been driving to work myself. It's another level of control. I can leave when I want, arrive when I want, too. Thinking back, I'm wondering if I was ever a burden to Pelumi.

Sometimes on my way back from work, I stop to pick up passengers at the bus stop, for free. It felt good doing that. It's like a combination of your advice and Zena's. But I had to stop today.

I heard the news of the lady on Costain bridge. With a good heart she had carried some passengers, but they pointed a gun to her neck taking everything she owned—phones, ATM cards and her car.

Favor has unexpectedly completed her internship. Rumor has it that she messed up a project Ife was working on out of spite, and he wasted no time reporting her to the higher-ups. We have got two new interns. A senior architect has left too, for another firm.

Madam Nelly confided in me. She said they're looking at filling up the position. Although they have put a notice out, they are strongly considering internal candidates.

I miss brainstorming client problems with you. Miss helping you make decisions.

Whenever I'm worried, thinking or lost in thought, I fondly touch the black band. Do you remember the night you gave them to me? I will toss it away at some point, but I'm keeping it as a reminder that you were real. That we had good times. That I knew you.

What are you up to? What is happening to you? Please call me, or message me when you can. A message a week, I'll manage that.

****

"This is strange." Zena knocks, entering my room.

"What?"

"Where is Manir? You guys are usually planning one thing or the other when he is in town."

"You don't want an answer to that."

She walks to my bed, sitting on the edge. "Try me."

Hissing, I shake my head. "Don't think because you're done with NYSC and you're dating—"

"I'm not dating anyone. No man is worth the struggle. I'm focused on my career."

"That's a new one." I observe her observing me, a sly smile playing on her lips. "You know, I've wondered a couple of times if you were a lesbian."

“Me?” She scoffs. “Lesbian?”

“You are always clinging to Chiluba.”

Pulling back, she places her hand to her chest, aghast.

“I rarely see you around guys. And… you rarely speak about guys unless you talk about my guy.”

“I cling to Chiluba?”

“Yes. That is the best way to put it. It’s like you are in awe of her.”

She shrugs. “She’s a cool person to be with. She’s fun.”

“More fun than me?”

“Way more fun than you. I don’t know why you asked. And I notice something has been kind of off between you guys for a while now.”

“Keep your nose out of adults’ business.”

“Hmm. Adult acting like babies.”

“She started it.”

“What did she do?”

Ugh!

I feel stupid anytime someone asks me that question.

You really want to know? Ehn?

Because she played out of her boundaries. Loyal friends will not do what she did. What she’s doing.

I’m justified if I say I won’t speak to her for life, but I need her to come to her senses so we can continue from where we stopped. I won’t be the one bridging the gap. Mm hmm.

“You know what? When next you see her, ask her that question.”

“See? Babies.”

I reach for her, but she evades my touch. “If I catch you, ehn.” Relaxing back, I watch as she makes for the door. “How is your job hunt going?”

"Something good is coming soon. I'm so sure of it."

"Good."

"Once I get the job. I'll move to my own space."

"Zena."

"What?" Folding her arms by the doorway.

"Does daddy know?"

"I've told him. He's not happy about it, but..." She shrugs.

And I thought I was the stuff in this family. Kudos baby sister.

"Keep me updated. If you need any—"

"Before?"

You entitled little minx. Scrunching my nose, I search for something to throw at her, but she laughs, running away.

****

Are we over or what?

I need you to talk to me. Need you to face me, human to human. Man to woman.

I'm finding it hard to focus on my studies here. My exam is in less than eight weeks.

It is not easy for me. How is this easy for you? Tell me. Teach me to live with a broken heart.

Why won't you talk to me? Am I the other woman? Have I been the other woman since day one? Who is she? Is she someone new? Is your family's hand at work here?

I am done waiting for you to return. I'm going to live my life, not holding back.

How can you do this to me? I think I love you. Heck I know I love you. And for some weird reasons I don't know, I've not been able to tell you to your face. Or over the phone.

Those times you goaded me to tell you, they just didn't feel right. I wanted to do it in my own time.

1 4 3.

I thought using 1 4 3 worked too. Since you say it, it must mean the same thing for you when I say it to you.

If you had given me a chance, I would have told you my feelings. Just like I told you about my sexual needs.

Is this the reason you backed away?

Now I'm suspecting all those travels. Were they really business-related travel? Who were you going to meet?

Architect Wole will not work with me. Does he know about us? What are you telling them in your family about me? You never took me to see your family. I should have suspected this, that you were playing foul. And those friends of yours. Are they your real friends?

How do you sleep with all these messages landing in your inboxes? And not responding to them... Does it make you feel good? Makes you feel mighty?

Is this some sort of fetish that I should know about? Is this how you have been treating other girls? No wonder you don't like Lagos girls, because they're too smart for your liking. I'm the dull one. The exceptional one. The fool. The beauty with brains but not love-smart.

Oh Manir.

Manir... I'm broken.

I'm crying.

I miss you.

I need you.

I want you.

I love you.

I love you.

You're everything I ever dreamed of in a man. You are supportive. Fun. God-fearing. An ambitious learner. Respect me.

Although there are some things I would love for you to work on, I would never change you. I love you the way you are.

How do you expect me to move on after feeling such love? After dreaming of the future together with you. Knowing you make time—even with your busy, unpredictable schedule—to spend with me. You put me first, even when I'm in the wrong. You make me see the good side of me. The freaky side. And the naughty one.

You are a part of my family.

You are my family.

You are mine.

I know I have threatened to move on. But I can't. It's impossible for me to find a replacement with the high standards you have set.

You tick all my boxes. Made my dreams and childish imaginations come true. Where would I search for a man like you? I want to love you like an adult. No more dream-like expectations.

Forgive me for not respecting your feelings.

Forgive me for making you feel uncomfortable.

Forgive me for not checking in with you on some things.

Forgive me for putting my stubbornness and pride above you.

I love you.

And I want to say it to your face.

Please give me the chance to. Even if you don't want this relationship anymore.

Whatever choice you make is fine by me.

I love you.

And I mean it.

The occasional excruciatingly sharp pain in my heart is testament to my love for you.

OceanofPDF.com

THIRTY-EIGHT

PRE-APPROVAL

Manir

I find it hard to express myself.

"I'M STILL WORRIED ABOUT LIFE. I know that's something most people would say, but for me it's different. I'm always trying to get to places on time. Trying to stay prepared, ahead of the game. Because I know there are many people counting on me. And because life has given me a platform, some people believe I'm unworthy of. I'm not trying to prove myself or anything... Sometimes I just feel I'm not doing enough. I'll mess everything that has been handed to me."

Tick. Tock.

Tick. Tock.

Raising my head, I find her observing me with thoughtful brown eyes. It's been an on and off relationship for the past few years. Trying to understand my constant worry. To steady my mind. It works. And sometimes it doesn't.

“It’s alright that you worry. It’s coming from a helpful place.”

“Helpful place. Hmm.”

“It makes you productive. It keeps you ahead of your game.” She hesitates. “Don’t you think you are deserving of everything you are? That you worked hard for, to be you?”

“I-I.” Pressing my lips together, looking for the right word. “I don’t know. Maybe they are right. How many people, given the opportunity I had, never make it?”

“I don't have an answer to that but I'm sure if the statistics is done, that answer will shock us.” She taps her pen on her notepad.

Life gave me a second chance. I chose my path. I pay my dues. Still, I wake up feeling undeserving. It’s easy to mask, the impostor syndrome, so easy to mask. But occasionally, it slips. And their words, although written years ago, taunt me. I can’t help but wonder if like my dad I—

“Do you feel happy do you feel fulfilled?” Her voice jolts me back to the present.

I smirk. “That's a tough question to answer.” I look at my watch, leaning back, contemplating ending our session earlier. There are important things to do, than analyze every thought that crosses my mind. “Why do I feel you're interviewing me for a blog or something?”

She smiles. “Mr. Dosu-Andrews. What I believe and what I believe you should believe is that you deserve to be happy and every action we make has a reaction which is what you are getting in terms of your wealth and recognition. You put in the work, you get results. You know this.

Your task this week is to intentionally think of your family as a blessing, rather than a burden. They gave you this opportunity—a head start—and you are running with that. It’s what every child, born into a family gets, no matter their status in life. A head start. I hope you return to appreciating yours soon.”

“Hmm.”

“Our session is almost over, but before you leave, I’ll like to know if you now find sleep easy.”

“It's tricky.” Biting the inside of my cheek. “Most nights I use the sleeping pill. Other times I chat with a friend till I fall asleep.”

She furrows her eyebrows before releasing them. “That has good and adverse consequences.”

“I think,” I nod, sitting up, “I’m going to focus on the good. I sleep easy… seven out of ten times.”

“We can work with that.”

“And I have been dreaming lately.”

“Most of us have dreams. This is a good thing. What type of dreams are they?”

“I don’t know.” Licking my lips, I look away from her. “Disjointed bits I can't make sense of.”

****

“Anything you want to share? Something new, different, or exciting?”

“Nothing.” Shrugging. “Same old, same old.” Looking up. “Am I wasting your time?”

“It’s alright. Not every session has to have that a-ha moment.”

Smiling, eyes boring deep into hers.

“We can reschedule if you want to once in two weeks or—”

“It’s fine this way.”

****

“Thank you for agreeing to this. I’m sorry I couldn't make it in person.” I smile into the camera, “My trip is taking longer than necessary.”

“It’s alright Mr. Dosu-Andrews. How have you been?” She beams. “You look rested? Taking conscious efforts to live a relaxed life?”

“Ah…” Grinning, I fold my arms, subconsciously thrusting out my chest. “Do you have a magic wand I should be aware of?”

“You're smiling. I can sense your trip is doing you well.”

“Is that a bad thing?”

“No… It's a good thing. Would you like to share an update on your progress? What have you done differently this week?”

“I started with the mantras—”

“They are affirmations, not mantras.”

“Hmm. Affirmations. Got it.”

“Mm hmm,” she sounds with a smile, urging me on.

“I met someone special. Remember the lady I've been chatting with for a while now? Met her in person earlier this week.”

Her eyes widen. She places a palm to her mouth, catching herself. “Congratulations. That’s good news. How was the experience? That’s-that’s if you don't mind sharing.”

“Life-changing.” Giving her a lopsided grin. “She’s going to be my wife.”

****

“I’m going to propose to her.”

She looks up from her notes, a line between her brows. “You’re getting married?”

“No.” I laugh. “It’s just something my friend—the lady from online—and I discussed during one of our chats. A girlfriend-relationship proposal kind of thing. I’m going through the process because she enjoys processes. Have I told you? She’s an architect. A brilliant architect.”

Nodding her head, as the information sinks in. “That’s interesting.”

"It is." I grin, staring at the letter P on my keyboard. "She tough but cute. Has always wanted to date a guy who asks her out with a fancy dinner and a promise ring."

"Fascinating."

If she uses another adjective to describe whatever I'm telling her, I'm going to let this laughter out. Must have stunned her with my revelation.

****

"It's hard staying for long. After all these times, you'll think," I sniffle, wiping tears from my eyes, "you'll think they'll shut up and let it go. But behind the walls, they still talk."

"Hmm..."

"I'm sure they're wondering why and how this freak—"

"Language please."

"I'm sorry, Dr. Lina." Sucking air through my teeth, I blow out a whooshing sound, then press my lips together. "It's just... every time I — They see me as this freak who is undeserving. I've tried everything I can. I've tried. I swear to God, it's demoralizing, getting that look from family. Family members. And-and-I..."

She's going to leave me. I know it. I'm going to mess things up.

Breath Manny… breath…

Swallowing, I continue. "I took that feeling to her house and I guess I made a fool of myself with her dad. He has seen me for the scam I am."

"Want to share what happened?"

"I-I." Grinding my teeth, sucking air through them, I summon the strength to continue. "He was trying to bond. Told me to turn on the generator and I flipped. I said some things. Reacted in a way I shouldn't. And never apologized. And he never said a thing. But I saw the look before he could mask it. I'm unfit for his daughter. I'm just the son of an obsessed

freak." Clenching my fists, *a freak who killed his wife*. "I don't want you to give me any task. I know this is a safe space and I just want to clear my head because these voices." Shaking my head, pressing my lips together. "These voices in my head are getting loud."

"Then there are dreams. It's like I'm watching a younger version of me." Shivering, I curl my toes, bidding the tears to stop. W*hy won't they stop?*

"What happens to this younger version of you?"

"Nothing." Shrugging weakly, hugging myself. "It's the people I see in the vision."

"These people, who are they?"

"They don't look at my parents or anyone I know. But they feel like them."

****

"I know this isn't related to what we've been discussing, but lately, after that incident with her dad, I've been feeling insecure in my relationship."

"It's okay. We can discuss anything you want to. My role is to help you understand and cope with your feelings so you can manage stress."

"Hmm. Thank you."

"So... your relationship. Why do you feel insecure?"

"She's perfect. She's ambitious. She does her own thing. She's managing this long-distance thing so well. And I feel like... Like I'm doing something bad. Like something bad is looming and I am going to be the cause of everything. I'm going to cause her pain. I've never had a connection this strong with anyone in my entire life. And I know this is explicit, but I'm dying to make love to her. To show her my love in many ways." Sighing then scoffing. "We have code word for I love you. Can you believe that? Can you?"

A short mirthless laugh escapes me. "I've never heard her say the actual words to me. Her reason is because of her ex. I don't want to tell her it's bothering me, but what if she's in love with the guy and not me? What if she

finds out I'm unstable? That I'm doing everything in my power to be the perfect gentleman? The perfect son? The perfect nephew? The perfect businessman? The perfect friend? What will happen to us?"

"Take a deep breath Mr. Dosu-Andrews. Have you told her about your sessions with me? Does she have an—"

"Not yet," biting my lips.

"Hmm…"

Sessions with Dr. Lina is not something I can hide from her forever. But I need her to trust me—love me—enough to accept me as I am. If not, I'm a ticking time bomb. I cover my mouth, rubbing my chin. *Never. That will never happen*.

"Don't you think it will help her understand you better? Understand your fears?"

"Not yet. It's just not the right time. Can we — can we talk about work instead?"

"Sure. Anything you're comfortable with."

****

"Your reminder came at the right time."

"Hmm… Mr. Dosu-Andrews, you've missed your past sessions."

"I know. I'm sorry. I'm here now." Offering a slight, guilty laugh. "Life has been so good but now and then something happens, to test my balance."

"You were making substantial progress, working through your feelings. I don't think you should jump ship without informing me." She sighs heavily, her pinched expression dissolving, replaced with curiosity. "What is testing your balance Mr. Dosu-Andrews?"

We've been working together for the last seven years and only forged an attachment five months into our relationship. Therapy is something Aunty Rekiat recommended I turn into a lifestyle since I found it hard to connect

with family after that incident. Maximum I've worked with other therapists before her was eleven months. The shift occurred within our first month of working together—an unexpected reaction I had to something she'd said and the way she responded to me in that moment.

"Mr. Dosu-Andrews?"

I tell her of the incident at the wedding. "I know she knew she was wrong, but I had every right to let her know how I felt."

"Do you think you handle it well?"

Sighing, rubbing the back of my neck. "No. I... ah... Insulted her intelligence... Said some mean stuff. Leaving her there... going to the car..." Biting my lips, avoiding her gaze. "That was uncalled for."

"And how did that make you feel?"

Taking a deep breath, I take myself back in time. I felt like shit. I wanted to stop myself from doing what I did. Something in my subconscious made me offer to take them for ice cream because I didn't want to be in an enclosed space when letting my thoughts be known.

"I felt like... I was not myself. It was an out-of-body experience. Deep down in me, knowing I'm not the perfect guy I present myself to be, without dimples and a dazzling smile. Hmm. That dude has those things going on for him. And they were childhood friends.

I just wanted her to know I was not happy. I was scared with what I saw. Ugh. I shouldn't have said all those things. Even asked her to delete his number. I don't know what moved me to do that, but I know that wasn't me."

"Have you apologized?"

"That's the problem. She's not picking my calls or responding to messages."

****

"Mind if I ask? How are things with her—your girlfriend?"

"We're good." I grin. "Doing well."

"Hmm. How did you resolve that issue?"

"I used your advice and that of a friend to get through to her." I smile, remembering her voice on the phone after receiving the package.

"Did you tell her… those things you told me? About the out-of-body experience?"

"I think I did. Not necessarily in the way I told you. But we're good."

"You're making progress, Mr. Dosu-Andrews. Have you told her about me yet?

"I will."

There's more to my life than our sessions together.

When it's time, she'll know.

****

"It's late Mr. Dosu-Andrews, are you okay?"

"I'm so sorry for not showing up. For missing multiple sessions. Can you schedule an appointment for tomorrow?" Gripping the car's armrest. Silent, hot, shameful tears stream down my cheek. I've given up on wiping them.

"Are you okay?"

"Please. An appointment."

"I'll have to check and get back to you."

"I need to see you tomorrow. There's nothing you can do? I know you have something." Laughing, squeezing my eyes shut. "Anything. Lina, anything. Five minutes will do."

Opening my eyes, I watch as rain drops on the window, moving upward, colliding with other rain droplets.

"I can take you up next week—"

"It's-it's—I messed up. Something in me is spoilt. Damaged beyond repair. I—I… I messed up."

"Breath Mr. Dosu-Andrews. Shh..." And I do. "I'm at a family event over the weekend. Does Tuesday work? 9 AM?"

"Yes. Thank you. Yes."

"Will... you be okay till then?"

"I—I will be."

"Repeat after me, I love myself for who I am."

"I love myself for who I am."

"I am doing a good job."

"I am doing a good job."

"I am not damaged—"

"I am not damaged, I am a whole person. I deserve happiness. I'm Oladele Manir Dosu-Andrews."

****

"I almost hit her." I say in a strong, calm voice, having had time over the weekend to think my actions through.

"Do you want to talk about it?"

"I'm talking about it now," replying curtly.

"Alright Mr. Dosu-Andrews." She nods, looking up from her notes. "Thanks for sharing with me. You said... you almost hit her. How did that make you feel?"

"Like my father."

"Hmm... What was your father like?"

"Insecure? Angry? Obsessed?"

"Why would you say this?"

"My uncles drop hints now and then. When I'm at a family event, grinding my teeth. When I get angry during meetings. And I have told no one this,

but I think my father killed my mother."

"Because?"

She's so slow. "Because of his insecurity and anger. They say it's an accident, but I beg to differ."

"Why is this?"

"I keep having dreams but there's one that's consistent. A little boy coloring in what seems like my parent's home. I think that was the night he killed her."

"Want us to go deeper into this?"

"No, it's fine. I just wanted to say it to someone." Almost beating your girlfriend is not something you tell your friends. Shouting like a mad man at her for a minute reason is not something you explain to friends.

It took me two days to realize I ran out of her place barefoot. I can't tell my family that.

****

"The dream. It's reoccurring."

"What do you think this means?"

Always asking questions. "That is why I pay you. You should know these things."

"Mr. Dosu-Andrews," she begins, closing her notepad. "I appreciate our professional relationship so far, but I will not tolerate subtle insults or sarcasm."

"Apologies for that."

"Would you like to continue, or do you want to take time out?"

"Let's continue. Please."

She opens her notepad, her lips move inaudibly, then raises her head to me. "So, the dreams. They're reoccurring. Are they the same ones?"

"Yes. The one I have of little me—the little boy. It keeps reoccurring. It has become more persistent. And I think he's trying to tell me something."

"What do you think it is trying to tell you?"

"I don't—forget it."

Sighing in frustration, she leans forward. "Would you like to try hypnotherapy? Maybe come in sometime? It's been a while I saw you in person."

Have you get into my head and mess with my already messed up head? No, thank you. I've read enough Dean Koontz that paints how it goes. A sane person comes for therapy and next thing you know, they're doing whatever their therapist tells them to do. I don't want to be a zombie. Or develop extreme autophobia.

"I don't think I'm cut up for something like that."

"What do you think we are going to do?"

Smirking. "Basically, what we see in the movies."

"Oh."

"Yeah. You guys have a terrible reputation, you know."

"Some people might look at it that way. But a hypnotherapeutic session is something you do yourself. I'll only be your guide."

"I think I'll just stick to these... discussions." Although deep down, I know I need something stronger, I feel safe just having our regular discussions.

****

"I'm late."

She jerks her head back from her notebook, an incredulous look on her face. "Mr. Dosu-Andrews." Regaining composure, making no comment of my faintly haggard appearance, she moves to turn off her laptop. "I thought you would never make it."

"I'm here." Shrugging, moving to sit in the cozy, familiar armchair. "I'm sorry I didn't inform you I'll be coming in person. But I've made up my mind." Biting my lips, looking up at her. "Let's do this."

"Are you sure?"

Studying my wristwatch. "Want to remind me again why you think I should do this?"

"It is a choice..." She moves to her seat. "You make it sound as though you're being forced to do it."

"No. No. You're not forcing me to do anything."

"All right Mr. Dosu-Andrews." Clasping her fingers on her tummy. "The goal of this hypnotherapy is to tap into your subconscious mind so we can closely examine the different driving forces pushing these behaviors in you—the ones you're wary of—to the forefront. Something like going back in time."

Sounds like magic to me.

But at this point, I will do anything to ensure I don't scare those around me, to the point where I become a woman beater. I know I am being too harsh on myself, but I feel there is something lodged in the back of my brain... Something I pushed from my conscious self. The reason I keep having the recurring dream.

"This might be a painful journey for you. But I believe it is important to finding what it is you really want."

"I understand you."

"You mentioned this dream might be trying to tell you something, so when we begin, I want you to be in the moment."

"Alright." Nodding.

"Your time is up for today. We can do this during our next session."

"Why can't we do it now?"

"As much as I would love to help you find the root cause of all this, I have other clients I need to see."

OceanofPDF.com

THIRTY-NINE

SPATIAL ORGANIZATION

Zoya

Do you want to hear an Architect joke?

THE DOOR CLOSES SHUT, AND I sit up, waiting for her. Zena did her passing out parade two weeks ago and I feel her pain at not getting a job, yet. She has a wonderful future ahead and is enjoying her state of unemployment by being on phone calls for hours, watching horror and dystopian movies. Two movie genres I cannot stand. Life itself is filled with horror, yet my sister chooses to binge stuff like that. Did I go wrong or did mommy go wrong somewhere while carrying her pregnancy?

"Where have you been?"

Pausing in her track, she answers, "Chiluba's."

"I was worried when I returned, and you were not home. You could have at least called."

"I'm sorry," she says, continuing her walk towards me.

“And I was calling, why didn't you pick—” I gasp as she sits beside me, limp, keen eyes making contact with mine. Drawing her close, I ask, “Zee? What is wrong?” I should have noticed early on that it is so unlike her not to have a comeback.

Sitting up, she lets out a big sigh, looking up. “I know you and Chiluba have something going on.” Turning to me. “It’s none of my business, but I believe this is something you need to know.”

Jeez. *Tell me what I don't know.*

“I was at Chiluba’s, and she got a call that her father is dead.”

Oh my God! Putting a hand to my mouth as a wave of sadness hits me.

She sniffles, making a thudding sound as her hand hits the sofa. “I don't know what exactly is between you guys, but she refused to call you. If I had not been led to visit her today, we might have never found out this happened to her.”

My throat constricts and I experience dry mouth, thinking of what’s happening between us. If only we had focused on our friendship, instead of the men in our lives.

“How-how is she?” I ask.

“You know her.” Zena sighs, covering her face with both hands. “And that relationship she had with her dad.” Dropping her hand, she sucks in air through her teeth. “She looks great, handling it all in stride, but I can tell she's one hundred per cent sad because her mom was wailing over the phone.”

“Um…” Shaking my legs in agitation. “What is the plan? What, what is happening? Did she tell you anything?”

“Left to her, she wouldn't go for the burial, but for her mom… she plans to leave next week. Her brother is handling things for the family.”

“Okay… okay…”

She turns to look at me. “Are you going? Because they’re doing it in Abia State.”

I give her a is that real question look, then stalk to my room, my fingers instinctively rubbing the black band.

****

"Hey Zo." Chiluba says the moment she opens her sliding door for us, Zena and me.

"I'm sorry to hear about your father." I have not called because of the bad blood between us, but Zena has been my eyes and ears. And when I heard what she had in mind for the burial, I was furious. I needed to come in myself.

"Thank you." Chiluba says, hugging herself, giving us room to step in. She looks like herself, nothing amiss. Signature wig in place—no make-up on—paired with a white thigh-length round neck top and bum shorts.

We sit in silence for a while, as music videos play on the TV screen, while Zena prepares stew in the kitchen with the ingredients we bought on our way here.

"So... what's the plan?" Adjusting on the sofa to listen to her reason. "I heard you want to drive from Lagos to Abia yourself."

"Yes."

"Hmm. That's an eighteen hour round trip and you're not in the right state of mind to do that. Besides you know how the roads are."

"There's no other option." Her answer brooks no argument.

Seriously? No other option?

With her gaze on the TV, elbow resting on the headrest, hand to her head, with legs shaking, she clearly is not comfortable with my presence in her house or my concern for her well-being.

"What happened to flights?"

Her mouth twitches. "There's no straight flight from Lagos. We will still have to drive one way or the other, and I am not taking public

transportation."

"Got too big for public transportation now? Hmm?" I don't know when that slips out but seems like it...

"Oh, zip it Zoya." Dropping her hands on her lap, fulling turning to face me. "I'm not taking public transportation and that's it."

"We can always rent a bus or a car or something when we arrive at the airport. I have checked. And there are flights going to Calabar, Uyo, Port Harcourt and Owerri. And the easiest route would be to fly to either Owerri or Port Harcourt. With that we'll spend less than five hours, round trip."

Placing a hand to her jaw, the other on her tummy, she observes me, her mouth twitching.

"Thanks a lot for your help," she finally says. "When we arrive at those places, who would drive us from the airport and back to the airport?"

"That is why there are private cars for hire." See? Widening my eyes for effect.

She hisses. "They are public cars, and I am not getting into a public car."

"What is with all the drama about public or private cars? We are looking for a solution to the problem—that is what you should be focused on. Not on whether it is public or private."

"You know I can do without going for this burial, right? The only person I'm concerned about is my mother." Chewing the inside of her cheek before continuing, pointing and making gestures. "I want to be there for her when they put that godforsaken man into the dirt where he belongs. When she cries her heart out, I want to be there for her. For her. Because I won't kill myself going to look at that dead man's body, just so you know." Swiveling her head away from me.

Good point. I really want to sympathize with her, but I scoff. "So... those who travel on public transportations have two heads, huh?"

Shaking her head, she turns to me, plastering a fake smile. "I appreciate your help. But the best solution—what will work for me, that I'm comfortable with—is to drive down there."

As she moves to turn her head the other way, I attack. “What is your problem?”

She stares at me, aghast.

“Seriously, what is your problem?” Leaning forward to hear her reason.

“I have a problem?” she snickers, chin up. “You come into my house where I’m mourning, and you are telling me I have a problem?”

I crossed the line. I agree. Wetting my lips, I apologize, “I'm sorry.” But why do you want us to drive, on these dreadful Nigerian roads? Where is the sense in that? Three women. Three women driving alone from Lagos to Abia? I am a confident woman, but I know where to draw the line.

Blinking, keeping from tearing my hair out, I try again. “I'm just thinking of a way to ease you of stress. I know you are in grieving mode and I'm sorry if I'm appearing insensitive, but really… doing the flight thingy would actually work better.”

“Um… Big sis? Luba?”

I tear my gaze from Chiluba’s stubborn form to Zena, who is now sitting on the edge of a dining chair.

I completely forgot you were here.

“Yes?”

“Luba, what if we find a friend that lives close by that can drive us to and fro? How about that? Or even offer their car?”

Chiluba licks her lips, folding her arms. Her voice is mellow, calm, completely different from the hardened one she has been using on me like I was the enemy. “That can work.”

“Okay.” Zena offers a wan smile. “To solve this problem, let's just think of anyone we know who lives in either of those states and ask for their car.”

Chiluba shakes her head stubbornly. “I don’t know anyone I want to call on.”

Jeez. *Anyone you want to call on?*

"Same here. I—" A light bulb goes off in my brain. I swallow, tapping my palms on my thigh. "I might know someone—"

"Yes!" Zena says, but I quickly correct her.

"I said, I might. I am not sure." Scrunching my nose. "I am not sure they will be willing to go on this journey with us."

"Who is it?" Chiluba asks resignedly.

"Eric." Darting gazes between her and Zena.

It takes a moment to sink in.

Hmm.

Chiluba shakes her head. "*Mbanu*."

"It is not like he has accepted to. But unless you have someone else." I shrug. "That's the rational option we have at the moment."

"You want to call your ex?" Chiluba asks. "The one you dumped for another guy?"

Zena lets out an outraged gasp, muttering with rolling eyes and pressed lips. "Shots fired."

I choose to ignore it, furrowing my brows. "We're friends. He'll help."

"Don't do that Zoya." Chiluba leans on the sofa, shaking her head in frustration. "Don't call him."

"He's our top option because, just like Zena, I will not travel twenty hours on Nigerian road."

"You-you..." Chiluba stutters in confusion, "you want to come?"

Pressing my lips in a grimace. "Why do you think I came here? To look for trouble? Come on... No matter what." Staring at her knowingly. "We are friends."

The corners of her eyes crinkles as she fights back tears. *Didn't you hear me saying we, we, we, since?*

Tut-tutting, I move to sit beside her. "Aren't we?"

Wiping her eyes, she inhales deeply, holding back tears, nodding.

"Don't you dare cry." Shaking my head, glaring at her. "Don't."

"Thank you," she says with a slow fading smile.

No matter what.

I might not like your choices, but I love you.

Always.

"Okay." Getting into action mode. "I'm putting the call through. Zena," she looks up, "please book tickets three tickets for next Wednesday. Anytime in the afternoon, say from two. Return flight for Sunday. Evening period, after the church service."

"And work?" Chiluba asks. "Your projects?"

Jeez.

I wasn't thinking about that.

"I go there every day. It's not every day my friend needs my help. I'll take Wednesday to Friday off." Dialing Eric's number.

"Oh Zoya..." Chiluba sighs, voice thick with emotion, looking like she's about to tear up.

"Shh... it's ringing." Setting the phone on speaker. My palms are sweaty, my heart pounding in my ears.

Zena comes close, squeezes Chiluba's thigh, and heads to the kitchen to do my bidding.

"Zoya..." Eric's familiar voice comes through the speaker.

"Hi Eric." Trying hard to sound breezy.

"It's been awhile. How are you doing?"

"I'm good. I'm good." Not wanting an awkward silence, I strike while the iron is hot. "I am calling because I need a favor from you. It's okay if you can't help but—"

"Zoya." The firmness of his voice stops me in my rambling. "Talk to me."

“Um. I need your help. That's if you're in Port Harcourt or if you know anybody in Port Harcourt. My friend—my friend’s dad’s burial is next week in Abia State. Is it possible for you to—” How on earth did this idea sound okay when we were talking about it? I’m truly asking a guy I dumped to pause his life and help me and my friend—who doesn't even like him—to help us out? *Have some shame Ehizoya.* “You know what? Don't worry. I will find—”

“Zoya. I’m in Port Harcourt. When are you looking at coming in?”

“Next Wednesday.”

“I can move things around. Send me the time you’ll arrive, and I’ll come pick you at the airport, drive you there.”

“Eric, there’s no need to—”

“Friends? Remember?”

“Yes. But it’s—”

“Weird?”

Yes, it is!

I shouldn’t have placed the call. There should be other people on my contact list.

“It's alright. I'll be there.”

“Thank you. Um, we are three?” Chiluba shakes her head, signaling four. “Four. We are four. Is that okay?”

“Mm hmm. There’s more than enough space.”

“Thank you. Thank you. Thank you.” I grin.

“Take care, Zo.” He says fondly.

I end the call, staring stupidly at Chiluba.

That. Was. Hard.

What was I thinking? Really, what was I thinking? He sent me a couple of messages in the last few months, which I only ever replied in monotones.

Jeez.

I am the worst of all.

"Zoya?"

"Huh?" I jerk, turning to find Zena smiling, tapping her phone on her palm.

"Flight tickets booked."

****

Zena shakes me awake as our plane prepares to land in the Port Harcourt Airport. I am too tired to appreciate the architecture of the airport, as I pull out my phone to call Eric.

Since my visit to Chiluba's, I have been putting extra hours at work to make up for this time off. My surprise when I find Abebi—Chiluba's in-house co-designer—toting her bag to join us. Despite us being agemates, with her spending her formative years in the United States, her eyes appear to have seen it all, and she covers it well with her breezy attitude.

I'm on call with Eric, dragging my carry-on luggage with Zena, Chiluba and Abebi trailing behind me, trying to locate him. When I spot him, I blink rapidly, taking in the dramatic change he has gone through since our breakup. He has grown a beard, and it fits him so. It doesn't glisten or looks as full as Man—

No. No. No.

Don't think that.

He doesn't exist.

"Thanks a lot," I say as we arrange the luggage in the trunk of his SUV. "I really appreciate this. I know you have a busy schedule, but you are taking time to drive us back and forth—"

"Zoya, please. Enough with the thank *yous*." He smiles. "I would do anything for you and you know that."

Yes, I do. But not after I—well… I better just accept this and keep living.

“How is she doing?” he asks, nodding towards Chiluba who is placing calls some feet away. Zena is clasping her hands, engaging in a friendly discussion with Abebi.

“She’s handling it well.” After our call last week, I sent him a message telling him it was Chiluba whose father had died. He agreed to drop us in Abia, return to Port Harcourt, and when we were ready to leave on Sunday, after the church service, come pick us up.

My entourage automatically choose the back seats, leaving me to sit in the passenger seat beside Eric.

It is an uneventful ride.

There is nothing to talk about because even while we were dating there wasn't much to talk about, but I automatically save the image of every second we spend together, every word, every action. To analyze when I’m alone.

When we arrive, her mother, though plagued with grief, was thrilled to see Chiluba.

****

The weekend goes over in a blur, with Zena, Abebi and I standing like avenging angels beside Chiluba at every ceremonious rite she had to perform with her mother and siblings.

We are standing by her father’s gravesite, with the preacher going on and on about life, death and living when Chiluba squeezes my hand gripping hers, turns to me, and whispers. “I'm sorry for not telling you about him. Us.”

“Shh…” I calm her, nudging her to focus on the present. “Now is not the time or the place.”

She nods, chewing her lips, returning her focus to the brown coffin where her father lay.

As we bundle ourselves into Eric’s car on Sunday, my mind analyzes my plan for the week. Recalling projects I’m working on, forcing myself not to open my email until I arrive in Lagos.

"Zena," Chiluba says, "Do you mind sitting in front?"

Zena shrugs.

I am really not in the mood to discuss the rift between us, but I understand she has been through a lot, so I indulge her by sitting in the back seat with her. She folds herself into a fetal position, head on my lap as we begin the ride to the airport.

Not one time, throughout the proceedings, did I see her cry. The only time I saw any form of powerful emotion on her face was when she saw her mom the first time and when she was saying goodbye to her mom, siblings, and the half-sister her father had brought back after leaving them for another woman.

"Thanks a lot for arranging the ride," she begins in a small husky voice. "For reaching out to Eric, even when my pride wouldn't let you reach out to him."

She's without her signature waist-length wig, choosing to wear cornrows throughout the ceremony. I run my fingers through the scalp between the rows, a treatment she enjoyed since our high school days. "Anything for you, Luba."

"The reason I don't like public rides is because..."

She tells me about her experience from the summer of last year and how it affects her. Listening keenly to her, as Eric and Zena chat in front, I cannot help but miss our sistership.

When she is lulled to sleep, I lean back, closing my eyes.

Zena's tugging of my arm wakes me and we bid farewell to Eric. I don't miss the sparkle in Zena's eyes when she wishes him well.

Throughout the flight, I think of Chiluba's state of mind. Yes, she is strong, but I worry for her. I don't know what's up with her and Uncle George, but I don't recall her picking a call from him. Nothing.

"Do you mind staying with her for a week?" I ask Zena as we arrive in Lagos, walking close behind Chiluba.

The house is empty when I arrive without Zena. By the time I make it to work on Monday, I had recounted every moment with Eric, reviewing every word we exchanged, asking myself if I had made a wise decision in breaking things off with a good-hearted man like him.

Two days later, everyone is all smiles as I walk into the office from a site, bidding me congratulations.

I take time off for my best friend's father's burial and its congratulations? I smile back, puzzled.

It isn't until I get to my desk, taking time to check my email with Farouq, one of the new interns, on my neck, that I see the email I missed yesterday evening.

Dear Mercury Consults Staff,

I'm pleased to announce the promotion of Ehizoya Ainabe from Junior Architect to our Senior Architect. Ehizoya has worked for our company for almost two years and has been an invaluable member of our architectural department and organization.

She has demonstrated innovative and proactive skills over the course of her career and while working with us, Ehizoya has been a catalyst in multiple projects, both big and small, showing her commitment as an architect and as a leader.

During her time with Arc. Nelly, Ehizoya designed three outstanding drawings, assisted in reviewing Empress by Design project—our biggest project so far—the moment she joined us, and has been at the forefront in implementing practices to bolster morals at construction sites with the project teams. In her new role, she will oversee her own team, working on projects from start to finish with efforts to build and maintain relationships with clients.

For any inquiries about what Ehizoya's new position entails and its correlation with your working relationship, please contact me.

I hope you'll join me in congratulating Ehizoya on her outstanding contributions to her department and this organization, and we're wishing her the

best of luck in her future position.

Best,
Arc. Wole Dosu-Andrews

OceanofPDF.com

FORTY

BUILDING ENVELOPE

Manir

Hey! I really hope your day is as smooth as your ass. You good?

I'M SITTING IN THE USUAL ARMCHAIR, in the same room we have our discussions with a blanket on my laps. What it's for, I don't know, but I'm curious to find out.

"The goal of this session is for you to understand your feelings about your father. To rid yourself of the fear of being like him and to have a better relationship with yourself, because self-love comes first. Am I right?"

"Yes. Yes, you are." If I have a better relationship with myself, love myself, I will not feel dark, capable of destroying my relationship with Zoya for just being me.

"I need you to visualize your most prominent dream. Imagine you are in the room."

"Alright."

"What does this place look like to you?"

"It's a..."

"Want to close your eyes and visualize it before we begin?"

Shifting on my seat, eyes closed, I describe the room to her. Cream-colored walls, the Lagos Lagoon painting, wooden paneled floor, black leather sofas with colorful throw pillows, and the center table on a brown rug, facing the LCD TV.

My eyes are still closed, but I can feel her nodding her head as I list out these things.

"What's the temperature like?"

"I think it should be around twenty-nine degrees Celsius."

"Where is the little boy in the room?"

"He is on the floor, angrily coloring a comic book."

"Is there anyone in the room with him right now?"

Shaking my head. "No one. Just him."

"We are going to do a couple of exercises before we go fully into your subconscious. We need to learn how to work with each other, so we can get the best out of this."

"Okay."

"Follow my instructions."

"Okay."

"Put your hands together. Imagine they are stuck together and every time you pull them apart, they can't be separated. No matter what happens, they can NOT be separated."

I nod.

"Now, raise them up. Take them to the left... Now bring them down. Take them back up again. Bring them to your chest. Try to separate them."

"I can't."

This is crazy. Deep in my mind, I know my hands are not stuck together, I just placed them together myself!

"How does it feel?"

"Like..." Squeezing my forehead in concentration, trying to separate them. "Like they're stuck together."

Try as I might to separate them, they keep pressing to each other, locking in on each other.

"Good. you can open your eyes now."

I do.

"And your hands are free."

Just like that, I separate the palms I couldn't separate earlier.

"Wh-What just happened?"

"It was a practice that tells me how open you are to suggestion. And you did an excellent job." She smiles, for the first time since we started working today.

Interesting. What's next?

With my eyes open, she tells me to focus my attention on the opposite wall and begins to slowly move her hand back-and-forth, in front of me.

"Inhale... exhale..." she says in a silky persuasive voice, still moving her hands in front of me. "Relax your mind... Be one with yourself... Inhale... Exhale... Imagine yourself in the room you described to me..."

We continue this for a while, and I can feel myself slipping. My eyes close on their own accord, but I force them open at every interval.

"I'm going to countdown to zero, and once I get to zero, you'll close your eyes and you'll be three times deeper."

I want to say my usual okay, but words fail me. My eyes are still focused on the opposite wall, trying to keep up with the back-and-forth movement of her hand.

"... Two. One. Zero."

My eyes shut close. I fight to open them, but it's a struggle.

"Open your eyes."

And I open them so easily. This woman has full control of my senses. How is this—

"I'm going to countdown to zero," she begins again, "and once I get to zero, you'll close your eyes and you'll be three times deeper."

The meditation I sometimes practice helps me focus on the spot before me each time, but whenever she says 'zero', I shut my eyes, then her voice brings me back.

With time, I stop forcing my eyes to stay open. My body becomes heavy—I know this because my arms are laying limp on my lap—with each trance she puts me into. I don't think I can move any part of my body if I try to.

"You are now in the living room... Standing on a wood-paneled floor... There's a black three-seater chair..." she describes the room I had described earlier.

"Can you see the little boy coloring his comic book?"

Still in a trance, my answer is slow, like I am just waking up. "Yes, I can..."

"Who is he?"

"Me..."

"How old are you?"

"Five years old."

"Why are you coloring?"

Looking at the little boy, I never noticed he was crying. His anger is stemming from sadness. "I am sad..."

"What happened to you?"

"I don't know... I am trying to gather my coloring pencils together. Someone kicked it."

"Can you try to remember who kicked it?"

My parents were arguing earlier. I don't know why. I went to show mummy my coloring book, and she praised me. I sat down on the floor to color and... Daddy. Daddy passed by and kicked it and I was crying. He called mummy inside his room and started saying things to mummy.

"Daddy..."

"Why did he kick it? Can you remember?"

I shake my head.

"Did he say anything? Tell you sorry?"

"I heard daddy say..." sniffling, my palms still laying on my lap are sweaty. "Daddy said mummy makes him angry... She doesn't listen... He's going to teach her a lesson."

"How does this make you feel?"

The need to ball my fist is strong, but I can't move. Tears pool in my eyes and I feel them slide down my face. "I feel sad... and angry... because... I know he can teach her a lesson."

"Did he teach her this lesson?"

"I don't know..."

"Why? What happened?"

"They went for a party, and I did not see them again."

"After this incident, they told you your parents are dead. Part of you believe your father killed your mother. And now, as an adult, what traits do you think would have led your father to do such?"

"He was ambitious. Insecure. Loved my mother too much. Jealous..."

"Another part of you believe you have these traits your father has, right?"

"Yes..." I simper.

"And that it will lead you to mess up your happiness with your girlfriend."

"Yes..."

"Your recent argument made you feel like your father?"

"Yes... I almost hit her. I was thinking of how she does silly things that make me angry. I don't want to... I don't want to end up like my dad. I don't want to... be... be... the death of her."

"What is the goal of this session?"

"To understand my feelings about my father and rid myself of the fear of being like him... and to have a better relationship with myself, because self-love comes first."

"Good. Self-love comes first."

"Why did you end your previous relationships?"

"Because I was scared of myself... That one day, I will get angry and do something damning."

"Do you trust yourself?"

"I do..."

"Why do you fear you will do something damning in your relationship?"

"Because I am my father's son?"

"Did your father love you?"

"Yes... he did."

"Would he want you to make the mistakes he made?"

"No... Never."

"Why do you think so?"

"Because he loved my mother... and me... Wanted the best for us."

"You believe he loved you and your mother. Do you love yourself?"

"I do..."

"You've come a long way from a young boy diagnosed with psychosis, do you think this hurts the way you see yourself?"

I sigh, trembling as years of shame gets washed by my tears. I move my lips, but words fail me. I try again. "A lot..." I simper, shaking. "A lot..."

Her voice breaks, and I want to run away as she bares me to myself. The grown powerful, successful man, who fears his sanity.

"What is the goal of this session?"

"Rid myself of the fear of being like my father... and to have a better relationship with myself. Because I love myself. And Zoya..."

"Open your eyes."

There are tiny rims of light in the corner of my vision as I blink away the tears. Taking shallow breaths, I struggle to maintain eye contact with her, feeling naked. Exposed.

"Congratulations Mr. Dosu-Andrews," she says.

I offer her a wan smile.

"We're making progress. It's a continuous progression. I need you to continue with your affirmations. That's your daily task."

OceanofPDF.com

FORTY-ONE

AS IS

Zoya

I've always been a good girl, but you make me want to be bad.

THIS MEETING LEFT TO ME WE will never hold. Why is she standing for something I have never imagined her to? The distance between us has not been fully bridged. But I must be empathetic, her father just died... and she's my best friend.

"Hey." Chiluba smiles as I open the door.

"Hi," I reply, wanting to hug her but holding my hands to myself. "Welcome."

She takes off her heels, holding on to the wall, as she scrutinizes the entrance way. *Nothing has changed*. It's not like it's her first time here, but it's been a while.

"How have you been?" She asks once done, clasping her purse to her thigh.

"Pffft. Better than you left me." I shrug as we walk into the living room.

Lies.

I'm worse.

My boyfriend is gone.

I got my promotion, but I failed my exam, and I attempted it the second time last week, with fingers crossed for a better verdict.

Jeez. Did I mention my boyfriend ghosted me?

"Oh."

"How have you been?" I ask as we settle in the sofa, keeping one leg on the chair, underneath my ass.

In the past, I would have taken her to my room because I know when Zena comes in, she would take her attention from me. But... I'm not playing best friend anymore. And Zena, in her *you two should grow up* speech, went out so we can have this—*us time*.

"I'm doing... fine."

"Good." *I have nothing to say to you. You haven't learnt your lesson yet. Uncle George over me, huh?* "Movie?"

"Nollywood please."

Nollywood? I stifle a laugh, stretching for the remote. "Okay."

Jeez... Uncle George has shown you pepper. So bad, that you don't want to see white men on your screen again. Awwn... Poor Chiluba.

We select a movie and begin watching in silence. About fifteen minutes in, I remember my manners. It is not something I used to do because she is not a visitor here, but she hasn't done it so...

"Do you care for drink? Food?"

"Oh Zoya, so sorry."

Sorry for what? That you did not go to the kitchen yourself to get the food or drink? That's nothing to be sorry about, you are a visitor.

"About what?" Smiling, I make to stand up, but she holds my hand, motioning for me to sit.

"About Georgie—um, your uncle."

Oh, so we are repentant. After getting what you wanted. Spending his money and posting it on social media for the world to see. Never posting his picture because you are not proud to be a sugar baby. If I was that kind of niece, we would have been spending that money together but, no… I am not. I respect my elders and I know when to let them stay in their zone. I am surprised Adesuwa has not come on social media to drag you.

"Hmm." I grimace in pain. "It took you this long."

"I am so sorry." She leans in, clutching my hands.

"So, what happened? What changed?"

Taking her eyes off me, she begins. "I need…" Licking her lips, she continues. "I need you to help me speak to him."

What? "To apologize to him?" Squinting, I ask one of the pressing questions on my mind. "Did you jazz my uncle?"

Taken aback, she shakes her head. "No!" Chuckling. "Why would you think such?"

I have missed that sound.

"The same question I was asking myself when I found two of you together. Why would you do such?"

"Zoya." She removes her hand from mine, blowing air into her clasped palm. "I love Georgie."

"Excuse me… He is Uncle George to us. Or you can use Uncle." Tutting, I add, "It sounds weird hearing you say that."

She lets out an agreeing breath. "Alright." Grabbing my arms. "I love your uncle."

"So… you jazzed him? That's why you need me to speak to him? To beg for forgiveness?" I scoff. "Only God can save you on that matter, not me."

"*Mbanu* Zoya." She pulls away, frowning. "I did not jazz your uncle. I love him and I need you to help me speak to him because we're having a

misunderstanding and there is no one else I know that-that-that will do a better job."

The disrespect. The insult. "Chiluba are you okay?"

"Zoya please. You're the only one on my side."

"Do I look like I am on your side right now? Please, please..." I'm the only one on your side? Pfft. "Please. Please. Stop misinterpreting things."

"Zoya stop all these theatrics and just help me. Deep in your heart, you know I love him. I don't know how it happened... Or when it happened. And when it did, I didn't know how to tell you and... how it will sound in your ears. It just happened." Her eyes pleading with me to end this feud. "And we both couldn't help it. You understand these things. See how you and Manir are working out your relationship. You swore off long distance and hated it, but here you are, in one, because you love him. That's how it is for me."

If only you knew.

"Um. You're not with my uncle because he's white. Well, because you want biracial kids."

She laughs. "Where did this idea come from? If I wanted biracial kids, there are plenty young white men out there. You think I'll saddle myself with an old man that can die at any point in time."

"Ah ha! So you're in it for properties."

"Zoya." She huffs, drawing a breath and releases it before speaking. "How many times do you want me to tell you I love him? How can I prove to you this is beyond material stuff? You are my best friend in the whole wide world, and I chose him over you. I-I-I I've had a lot of opportunities to do that in the past—date older men of all races, mutual friends, do something stupid—and if it was not you or what I was going after, it was always you. But this time around it was different... Why can't you see it that way? It hurts me so much that you are yet to understand."

"Wait..." I grin. "I am your best friend in the whole wide world?"

Her nose crinkles. "Are you kidding me right now Zoya?"

"I'm not." I laugh. "Because it took a whole Zena to have you come here to apologize to me for what you did. And you are not even apologizing, you are asking for help."

"I'm sorry Zo..."

She tells me how it all started and how she got entangled in keeping everything to herself. She was scared of how I would react and had been planning how she would tell me all about it. It's ends with us hugging and apologizing for letting each other down.

"I guess luck was... not on our side the day you came around." She smiles. "Fate wanted it to happen that way."

Leaning back on the sofa, I ask. "Have you thought about the age difference?"

"I don't need a reminder. It's the number one thing we both see whenever we look at ourselves."

"Hmm..." I nod in agreement. "Have you met the... family?"

"Something like that." She grins. "Not everyone was around, but I think the plan is to do that this Christmas."

"Hmm. Christmas. Um... are you guys planning on getting married?"

She sighs, shaking her head. "I don't know. I just know I enjoy spending time with him and he with me. He's like the father I never had."

Laughing, I say out loud. "This almost sounds like daddy issues."

It is daddy issues!

Shrugging, she responds. "I won't make any comment. Please, what do you people have in this house?" Getting up from the couch, she makes her way to the kitchen, while I follow behind her. "And don't think I have forgotten you're yet to introduce Mr.—what's that his name self—Mr. Dosu-Andrews to me." She ends, looking me in the eye. "What is it?"

"What? Nothing."

"Hmm." Casting a suspicious glance at me. "How is Manir? Which country is he in now?"

I roll my shoulders, yawning. "I don't know."

"Ah-ahn. What happened?"

"Arinze happened." Arms crossed, I watch as she takes a bottle of refilled water from the fridge and an apple, from the basket Zena bought yesterday.

"What? *You have become champion oh*. Changing men like underwear. You're with Arinze?"

My situation is not funny, but her commentary makes me laugh. "It's not—hmm. I told you of meeting Arinze at that wedding he invited me for."

"When?"

Hissing, I shake my head. "The day I found my uncle at your place now."

"I'm sorry, everything you were saying was flying to another side of my head because my mind was thinking, eissh, Zoya will find out now oh. What do I tell—"

Raising my hand, I gesture for her to stop. "I get the picture. but yes, I met Arinze at that wedding, and we exchanged contacts. Manir and I had a misunderstanding that day. We sorted it. Then some weeks after, Arinze appeared unexpectedly at my office... That was the last Friday in June—"

"Slow down, babes. Please give me the full gist... This *acka acka* thing you're doing is not working."

I don't want to tell her the full gist because I feel stupid thinking back on the situation. Like I used my hands to ruin my relationship. But this is Chiluba, my best friend—my prodigal best friend. I tell her of my flops and the final straw Manir took.

"... he advanced at me, shouting and next thing I know, he backed off, started saying he's sorry, he's sorry and he left. Later that night he sent me this message." I show her the message I've read multiple times than I can count over the past months. "Since then, radio silence."

Chiluba moves in to hug me, offering words of comfort and I breathe deeply, glad for the calmness I feel. I have cried more times than I can count, so it is all dry tears now. I can't believe I messed it up.

"Since then, what have you been doing?" Concern lacing her voice. I miss us. I miss watching out for each other. "How have you been coping?" She gently pats my back, releasing me from her hold.

Pressing my lips together in gratitude, I walk out of the kitchen, into the living room, with her in tow. "I don't know. I've been journaling." After spending weeks sending him messages.

"I'm so sorry Zo..."

Tears threaten to rain down my eyes, but I force them back. Next thing I feel is her arms enveloping me from behind.

"I'm sorry."

I let the tears flow. I thought I had no more tears in me. I can't explain my emotions. It is overwhelming not knowing what is happening to him, to us. Not have that closure. I breathe deep and long, because my heart feels heavy.

"Let it out baby girl."

Turning in her arms, I fully hug her, letting the tears flow.

"I have missed you," I mutter, sniffling, fisting my hands on her chest.

Hugging me tighter, almost cracking my bone, she says. "I've missed you more."

I feel hot wetness on my shoulder. *Is Chiluba crying? My hot babe is crying.*

"Are you crying?" Pulling back from the hug, our palms on each other's elbow, I get the answer to my question.

Shaking her head, she smiles amidst tears. "You're still wearing his band." She stares at it indifferently.

I shrug. *It's mine. I'll do what I want with it.*

I don't know what she reads in my expression—anger? Hope? Lovesickness?

But her smile fades. "What do we do now? How do we get these men back?"

Yep.

We've got boy problems. Make that man problems. And we are about to fix them. I don't know where and how to find Manir but having someone like Chiluba will be important to the success of my search.

Clearing my throat, I withdraw completely from her embrace, cleaning my tear-streaked face, giggling. "I'm still not hundred percent on this you and Uncle George thingy, but let's start with you."

****

The vibration of my phone jolts me awake from slumber. It has been a long day spent at Uncle George's. From their interactions and the drama that unfolded before me—Chiluba truly loves my uncle. There's nothing I can do about it but accept them the way they are.

9:32 PM
Manir: Hey Confessor.

Manir is typing…

My heart pounds furiously, hand shaking.

Breathing, slow and controlled, staring at my phone, a variety of emotions rushes through me. I will my hand to stop shaking.

It's been almost three months since that rainy night. A night I try processing a million times, to understand what really went down and now this.

9:35 PM
Manir: I know I am the last person you want to talk to right now, but I've been dealing with my mental health. This is not a sob story for my disappearance, but trust me, I had to do this on my own. If it's okay, can you please suggest a place where we can meet? I will understand if you don't

want to, but please… please Confessor, please give me the opportunity to explain everything to you. You deserve that.

OceanofPDF.com

FORTY-TWO

PRELIMINARY REPORT

Manir

I want to cause you to look down at your phone and smile, then walk into a pole

---

MY CONFESSOR.

I spot her, dressed in a monochrome free flowing gown, sunshades on, hair in a gelled ponytail, looking so in control, and it feels like the first time—I am unsure of what to do. Grinding my teeth, muscles clenching, I moved to adjust her seat, but she raises a hand, her cold eyes stopping me in my tracks.

I deserved that.

Chewing the insides of my mouth, assessing her facial features, I wait till she sits. Her high, arrogant cheekbones looking firmer than the last time I saw her, with her chin raised high in that familiar stubborn way of hers. Not like I'm expecting any drastic change in the past three months that felt like a week to me, but she looks good.

She had chosen the same restaurant I proposed our relationship to her. It's going to be an irony if, after everything I reveal to her today, she tells me she's done. We're done.

Clearing my throat as I take my seat, I say, "Thanks a lot for coming."

"Did I have a choice?" She gingerly places her hands on the table, still wearing the black band.

My heart jolts in hope. *There's a chance for us. I just need to make her see, to make her understand.*

I reach for her hands, but she withdraws them quickly.

"I'm sorry Zoya." The messages she sent to me, I'd started reading them, but couldn't bring myself to read to the end.

"So... is this the part where we break up?" She's trying to play tough, but I can hear it in her voice. She's broken. I did that to her.

I'm so sorry Zo.

"Never." If looks could kill, I'll be dead on this spot as she sizes me up from the corner of her eyes. "That's... that's if you still want to remain once I'm done explaining myself."

"Better." Tapping her polished nail on the table.

A server comes around and we place orders for only cocktails—she a cosmopolitan, me, death in the afternoon.

She snorts, "Is that what you want?"

I shrug, a faint smile grazing my expression. "Um... how have you been? Your exams?"

She tuts, her look is the universal look for—don't waste my time. Say what you called me here for. "Been fine. Passed the exams."

"Good..." I nod. "That's great news. Congratulations."

"Thank you." Her posture stiff.

"How was it?"

The server appears with our drinks, smiling, but it slides off his face when he notices Zoya's grim expression.

She sips her drink, eyes on me, probably asking herself why she agreed to this.

I'm warming up to the task Zo, please give me time. "Your exam, how was it?" I ask again.

Her features tighten, glaring at me. "That's not why I'm here. Please get to the point."

"I will." Giving a quick nod of my head. I let out a whooshing breath, pressing my lips together, thighs shaking, building up courage. "I don't know how to coat this."

She swallows. "Just go ahead."

Clearing my throat, I do as instructed. "Like I said in my text message, I've been dealing with my mental health. It's genetic..." Staring into her eyes as it widens with every piece of information I drop. "People in my family tend to act irrationally," licking my lips, "doing things that hurt those they love."

She nods slowly, willing me to continue.

"You know my parents' story." I scoff. "Everyone knows my parents' story. What they don't know is that it wasn't always rosy in my house.

My mom came from a wealthy home. Her family were not as rich as dad's but they had a good name. From my childhood mind, I think mom got a lot of advances from men before and after marriage. Even from my dad's business partners... She was a beautiful woman. I think at some point, she slept with someone, with my dad's knowledge and consent, to help seal deals. I don't know what point.

And I guess my dad didn't know how to handle the emotions, the jealousy... and I guess his insecurity... going forward. Some nights I hear them fighting and—and..." I swallow.

"It's all right." Her low, wistful voice says.

I look up to catch her eyes. It's filled with warmth.

"If you don't want to—"

"No. No. I want to. I need to say this. I need you to know this about me."

She smoothens her gelled hair, with the black band hand, swallowing. "Okay then… please take your time."

Taking a gulp of my drink, I grimace. "I had this belief my dad killed my mom."

Her eyes widen.

I quickly continue, "It's not something I've told anyone… except my therapist, but she's bound by our contract."

"Hold on." Scrunching up her face in confusion, she leans forward. "What are we dealing with here? You have a therapist?"

This is why I never told you. This reaction.

"I do." My brows snap together defensively. "It's not like I'm crazy or something."

"I know. I know what therapists do. I'm just shocked I'm finding out about this now." Sucking in her breath, she puts a hand to her forehead, lowering her head. "Jeez. I'm such a fool." Looking up, her head moves in a slow disbelieving shake. "And you called me your confessor? Was that a joke?"

"No Zoya." I hurry to make amends before she opens her mouth to speak. "I was honest with you. With everything. Except for that part. That's why it is also part of my confession."

"How long? How long have you been seeing this therapist?"

"Before I met you. It's something I started after my psychotic experience at twenty. They diagnosed me with unspecified bipolar after a while because I didn't meet the criteria for bipolar I, II or cyclothymia."

Her mouth drops open, eyes widen, and I rush to comfort her, but she pulls away. She hunches over, as if choking on a sob.

"I'm sorry for keeping this away from you for so long."

"I am so dumb," she mutters, releasing a short laugh. When her eyes meet mine, all hope of us getting back together disappears. She pokes a tongue on her cheek, exhaling, forcing back tears. "Did I ever know… know you? The real you?"

"Yes baby. You did." I choke back a sob. "I'm sorry."

She scoffs, tilting her head up, sucking air. "I was planning on spending my life with you and you never deemed me worthy of knowing these things about you?"

This time, when I reach for her hand, she allows me hold them. They are cold and clammy. *You caused this.* I shake off the voice. *This is a process.*

I wish we were at a more private place so I can hug her, comfort her. So she can express herself better. Shout at me. Scream. *But please, don't leave me*.

"If I can reverse time to tell you this earlier, I will."

She squeezes my hand in hers. "Continue."

"I'll tell you about the psychosis too, but I remained in therapy to help me stay productive at work and to be… a fair boss. I think I started an episode around Bucknor's wedding period. And I've been having this sense of insecurity around you because I love you so much and I can't separate my thoughts from the thoughts of, what if I'm like my dad?"

Her eyes narrow. "Your dad killed—"

"No. Mm hmm." Stopping her before the idea develops root in her head. "It's just this lie I've forced myself to believe. I've-I've been having dreams about a little boy—little me—and his family. And when I met you in person, it became consistent. Like it was trying to tell me something. Then I went for my family event and…" I let out a deep breath. "I was reminded all over again, how similar to my dad I was. But that was just my mind playing tricks with me. My therapist performed an Eye Movement Desensitization and Reprocessing with me, and I believe I am in a better place."

She squeezes my arm again, consoling and encouraging me at the same time.

"My therapist also knows about us."

She nods, pressing her lips together.

"And… that night. That night I saw that guy at your place… A million thoughts ran through my head—good and bad." I sigh, accepting my actions. "I followed the bad thoughts. I hit you that night and that was when I realized I needed to take my sessions serious—seek help."

Furrowing her brows, she removes her hand from mine, reaching for her cocktail. "Hit me?" Then sips, curious.

"Yes. You flinched. I scared you. I was shouting at you."

Shaking her head, she moves her now empty cocktail glass to the side. "Yes, you shouted at me. I screamed and all. But you never hit me."

"Zoya. I hit the wall beside you. That's synonymous with hitting you."

"But… you never hit me."

"In my mind's eye, I did. That was the last straw for my behavior. I needed to seek help. I needed to withdraw from you so I could think clearly, examine my actions."

"You didn't have to do it alone."

"I had to, Zoya. Trust me." I sigh, revealing my real truth. "I didn't—I didn't." Choking back my fear. "I didn't want you to see me as less. What if I was psychotic again? The last time it happened, I wasn't aware it was happening."

Warm eyes, filled with pain, hold mine. "What happened when you were psychotic?"

Shaking my head, I answer honestly. "I swear, I don't know." After taking the last gulp of my drink, knowing her eyes are on me, I tell her what I know. What they told me.

"Till today no one knows the cause. I was home for the holidays at my uncle's. They told me I was talking without respect, screaming, not eating… I watched a recording of me screaming at my aunt, Ladun, and till today, some part of me is ashamed… That's why I hate when bloggers talk about me having it easy. About never having a problem in my life. Sometimes I laugh at

them, other times, it plagues my night. My loving family has wiped out my past, so I'm just this young dude, born into a prominent family who has it easy." I scoff.

We remain silent for a while, lost in our thoughts. *Please let her have me back. I'll increase my tithe to twelve percent.*

Please.

"I thought I did something wrong."

Her dreadfully quiet voice singes my heart with every raw word spilling from her lips.

"I've lived these past few months beating myself and my weird ways. Why didn't you tell me...? About this part of you?"

"I—"

"I wanted every side of you. Everything Manir... Why? Why didn't you?" Her mouth opens repeatedly but no words form, so she presses them shut instead.

"I—I'm coming to understand. I'm learning more about myself. These past months have been tough without you. I missed you. Every day. Every second. You were the only one pushing me to go the extra mile. I knew I had to go through this myself if I ever wanted to come back to you. I needed to face myself. My demons. My thoughts. And thoughts of the future we can have prodded me..."

"Did you feel like this in your past relationships? The ones you told me about... the ones before."

"I never let myself to feel." Once they catch feelings, I find something to complain about. End it.

"Oh..." she nods slowly.

"My relationships were usually short and abrupt." I didn't trust them. With my fears or privacy.

Squeezing her eyes shut, she opens them. "Oh Manir... I don't know what to think."

“I don’t know what got into me at Bucknor’s wedding, but it scared me that you were going to leave me for someone else. I was too ashamed to let you know what I was actually fighting with.”

“Manir…” she sighs, covering her face with both palms. “This is too much Manir… Too much.”

“I’m sorry for dragging you into this mess called my life. I know I’m asking for a lot. But I really want us to… To win.”

“This is too much.” Dropping her hands, she stares into space, murmuring, “Way beyond my imagination.”

“I’m sorry. I’m crazy about you. Still crazy about you…”

She gives a short laugh, still staring into space, mumbling to herself. “I was thinking there was another woman. Or that I was the other woman. But this is way more than I can ever imagine.” Focusing her gaze on me, she really looks at me. “I need to go home.”

“Sure. Whatever you want. I could take you home.”

“Thank you, but I drove.”

“Are you sure? I can—”

“I’ll be fine. Is there something else I need to know?”

Pressing my hands to my thighs, I lean forward. “That night… I was going to propose to you.”

She gasps, pulling back.

“I… I… I want us to continue our relationship.” She tries speaking but I rush on, “Not the same way we had it before. But better. And for us to do that, I would appreciate it if we could go for therapy. Together.”

She scoffs. “Therapy?”

“Think of it as counselling.”

“You are asking for too much.” Her lips curl in distaste.

“I—.”

“Enough Manir.” Her firm voice stalls me. “Remember this? If you take everything away, the only people that’ll be left is family. That’s all we’ve got.”

It takes me a while to get it, but she’s reciting one of my many pieces of advice to her.

“I made you, my family. You always tell me of family, yet you did this?” She tuts, picking her purse, rising from her seat.

“Zoya.” I say, rising, my hand holding her forearm, my eyes begging her to stay. “What can I say, or do to make it better?”

She looks to me, my hand on her and then to me, lips curled in a snarl. “You’ve messed this whole thing up.”

Nodding, understanding her, but not wanting to be understanding, I let her go.

OceanofPDF.com

FORTY-THREE

DAYS ON MARKET

Zoya

You're cute, can I keep you?

SHOULD I STAY WITH HIM?

Should I break it off?

I think to myself, staring at the gate, willing it to open, with Manir bearing gifts. But I didn't invite him. The last guest just left the house, wishing me luck in my career. They had come to celebrate my induction as an Architect.

With everything Manir revealed to me days ago, I don't know why I am contemplating being with him. Can I bear to live a life with someone that is unsure of their actions? Who doesn't know what they are capable of?

"Architect Ehizoya." I turn to face dad. "Are you okay?"

Offering him a lazy smile, I look away. "I am fine daddy."

"Hmm." He sits beside me, and I watch him from the corner of my eyes. This is his pastime, sitting outside, getting inspiration from the mini

landscape he created in the compound. “Did you enjoy the party?”

I smirk. “Why won’t I enjoy my party?”

“That’s good. That’s good.”

We resume staring at the landscape. A butterfly flutters past and I smile.

“I—”

“I—”

We both say at the same time. I chuckle, shaking my head. “Daddy please go ahead.”

He lets out a deep breath, clasping his fingers on his laps. “I just want to say again, how proud I am of you, and your sister.”

Nodding, I thrust my chest in pride. Even though we’ve had our differences, I have noticed he has been trying, in his own little way, to make up for past times.

“Your mother is proud of you and how far you have come.” He looks at his palm, then at the gate. “She always wanted the best for all of you.”

I swallow, nodding, occasionally peering at him from the corner of my eyes. It is evident, this is hard for him—expressing his feelings, and I am loving this version of him.

“I know I have not been the best father, but I thank God for making you all, the best children, one can ever ask for. As for Ehizele, I don’t know if he will ever return home, call us, or try to build a relationship with you and your sister. But that is my hope for you all; to bridge that chasm I created between you all with my ambition and stubbornness. I am sorry I deprived you of your father. The man I am, the man I have been, I am sorry it had to be me who fathered—”

“Daddy stop it.” I fully turn to him and still the palms on his lap.

He looks at me with dry eyes, however, I see the pain behind them. “You did the best you could. I don’t want anything more from you. We don’t need anything from you.”

“But—”

"Daddy," I smile, staring into his eyes, searching for the man I have always admired in my love-hate relationship. "All I wanted was for you to acknowledge your wrong doings. I never meant to make you feel unworthy of us."

He shakes his head, his chin quivering. "I am sorry Zoya. I don't want you to jump into something to spite me. Being an Architect—"

"This is my dream daddy. I have always wanted to be like you. But later... after losing mommy, I felt I was doing it to make a point... I was being stubborn... Fortunately for me, I returned to falling in love with the craft again. If at all I wanted to spite you in the beginning—I am enjoying it a lot now, being an Architect I mean. It is my passion daddy... My dream."

He nods accepting my explanation. His brows furrows, "What about everything you said the other night your boyfriend visited?"

"I am sorry daddy. It was all a ruse to rile you up."

"I know it's late to want this, but I would like to be a better father to you and Zena."

"Zena is leaving the house soon. Has she told you?"

"Yes." He smiles, and there are wrinkles in the corner of his eyes. *This man is getting older. Oh no…* "I have you."

"Daddy, I am getting married. Soon."

"Hmm." A slow knowing grin spreads across his face.

"Yes." I smile brightly. "Next year. Around this time."

"Hmm. So, I have about a year to make it up to you, except you want to move—"

Shaking my head, I am quick to assure him. "I'll be here till I get married. Mommy made me promise."

His eyes widen in surprise, blinking rapidly as tears gather.

Mommy and I had a strong bond. Losing her made me grow a tough skin to keep a mother-daughter promise of not giving up my *cherie* until marriage. She didn't want me to experience what she had with daddy.

“I love you daddy.” I move in to hug him, my eyes burning with unshed tears.

“I love you, my daughter.”

As the words sink in, I feel light. He has never said them to me or my sister. Neither have I ever told him, I loved him.

“I am sorry, daddy. For all the times I have hurt you or taken you for granted.”

“Shh…” He pats my back.

Shutting my eyes, I inhale deeply. The scent of his aftershave triggers my childhood memory. Nights when mommy urges him to carry us to bed when we fall asleep in the living room. Tracing architecture designs with him in his office when he picked us after school. Nights where we lay on his old Volkswagen bonnet, counting the stars.

OceanofPDF.com

FORTY-FOUR

FINIAL

Manir

I wish I could go back in time, find you sooner, and love you longer.

01:29 AM
Confessor: Big Head.
Awake?

01:31 AM
Manir: Now I am.
Can't sleep?

Confessor: Yes.
Been thinking.

Manir: About us?

Confessor: Yes.

Manir: Lucky you.

Confessor: Why? What's wrong?

01:32 AM
Manir: I've been holding my breath.

Confessor: Lol.
Why are you up? Are you okay?

Manir: Been struggling to sleep.

Confessor: That's bad.
You need to sleep.

Manir: Why is it bad?

01:33 AM
Confessor: I've been reading up on bipolar and that sounds like a sign. Please go to bed.

Manir: I am in bed.
Can I call?

01:35 AM
Manir: Hello?

Confessor: No.

Manir: Please.

Confessor: No.

Manir: What else have you read on bipolar?

01:36 AM
Confessor: Cause unknown.
Mood swings.
Depressions.
Mania.
Drug abuse.

Manir: Sounds scary huh?

Confessor: Sounds crazy.

Manir: It's a spectrum.
Is there more you learnt? There's one that's my favorite.

Confessor: Extravagance?
You're a poor excuse in that department.

01:37 AM
Manir: Lmao
Not that.

Confessor: High energy?
You travel a lot, so that's a check for you.

Manir: You're very close.

Confessor: Hmm.
Obsession?

Manir: Why do I feel you know but making it hard for me.

Confessor: Are you getting hard?

01:38 AM
Manir: Wanna come check me out?

Confessor: Keep wishing.

Manir: Knew it.
You were playing with me.

01:47 AM
Manir: Awake?

Confessor: Yes.

Manir: What's on your mind?

01:48 AM
Confessor: What's the name of your therapist?

Manir: Angelina, but I call her Lina.

Confessor: You guys are close.

Manir: Not as close as I've been with you.

Confessor: There was always distance between us.
How come I never found out about her?

Manir: Because I never gave you reason to doubt me.

01:49 AM
Confessor: Should I be concerned? Is she your best friend?

Manir: Never.
I've laid myself bare.
Simply waiting for you to pick me up.

01:52 AM
Manir:
I finally read all the messages you sent.

I'm sorry for putting you through so much pain.
I love you.
I can't wait to hear you say it.

02:03 AM
Confessor: If we decide to work this out, would we still be long distancing?

Manir: For a while.
But no longer than six months.
I want to be closer to you.

02:05 AM
Manir: Are you giving us a second chance?

02:06 AM
Confessor: I'm still thinking.
I work with a lot of men.
Wouldn't want anyone suffering a broken rib because I smiled with them or daydreamed of them for a second.

Manir: Never.
I'll be more open with you about my feelings instead of lashing out.

02:07 AM
Confessor: As long as you're working on it.
Make no mistake, next time you think of hitting me, or disappear on me, your ass is out the door.

Manir: Noted.

Manir: Are we back together?

Confessor: I'm still thinking.
Thinking out loud.

02:08 AM
Manir: I love the way you think.
Aggressive and sexy.

02:11 AM
Confessor: How often would we be going into therapy?

Manir: Once a week, until you are comfortable enough.

Confessor: Do your friends know?

Manir: Only Bucknor.

Confessor: Because I don't like them.
Now that I know they were in the dark like me, maybe I'll give them a second chance.

02:12 AM
Manir: Thanks, love.
I can imagine life without them, not without you.
But it makes me happier if you're cool with them.

02:34 AM
Manir: How's Chiluba? You good?

Confessor: Yes.
Where were you staying all that time?

Manir: At a hotel.

02:43 AM
Manir: What's on your mind?

Confessor: Nothing. Yours?

Manir: Hosting you at mine.

Confessor: No sleep overs until I'm married.

Manir: That's easy.

OceanofPDF.com

OceanofPDF.com

EPILOGUE

BUTTRESS

Zoya

I do think of getting married. And it must be top-notch.
Something fun and extraordinarily special.

EVEN THOUGH WE HAVE SPENT LESS than two months together in person, I believe Manir and I have what it takes to make this work.

I knew what he was going to do the moment he pulled his blue blazer back, revealing his subtly printed shirt paired with nice black pants, to take something from his pocket.

He grins, looking up at me from his kneeling position. "Will you marry me?"

I glance around to find the cheering faces of my sister, my father—two most important people in my life—and aunty Clara's family.

We've been going for couple's therapy for the past few weeks. I've learned a lot about myself and my partner. It wasn't easy opening up and being vulnerable to my thoughts, but it has made me so much stronger, confronting my fears. Learning how to communicate and best support Manir in this incredible journey called life.

Manir has been around a lot more. Yes, because of the therapy sessions, but also to spend more time physically with me. We have booked two flights

where I'll be traveling with him for next year. We are looking for how to integrate my role as a Senior Architect at the Mercury Consults to a Consultant at Black Onyx.

His family were open and receptive to meeting me. On the way, home, I was grinning ear-to-ear, enjoying the fact I'm the first woman Manir has ever introduced to them. Architect Wole was stunned, asking if it was the meeting that brought us together, disappointed our story started long ago from a viral tweet.

We have also finally gotten around to meeting up with Chiluba once, and they took an instant liking to each other. On the side, Chiluba told me to enjoy and have fun while it lasts. She's not happy he made me go through such turmoil alone when I didn't have her beside me. All I did in response was to nod.

Sharing with the public Manir's mental health condition is something I have no control over. It is his decision. So, despite the fact that Chiluba is close like a sister and Zena is my sister, the only person we have told is my daddy. If I say yes, it is going to be one long and potentially crazy lifelong journey.

I look back down at a smiling Manir, with an engagement ring—the real deal—raised for me to slide my finger in, and I ask myself...

All these weeks of therapy were for what? Why are you doubting being with him now? Do you trust him? Do you love him? If he gets maniac for real, can you handle it?

"Please say yes," he pleads, grinning.

"No." Holding my hands to my tummy.

I hear the collective gasps. His face and confidence crumple into confusion. Was he thinking after all the therapy sessions, confessions, vulnerability and everything we've been through, I'll just say yes?

The cheering energy, pumped by excited Zena, my smiling dad, Aunty Clara, her husband and their kids, diminishes.

Licking my lips, I announce to my audience. “I can’t say yes until I tell you to your face. Please stand up.” I motion for him do so, smiling wryly.

My Mighty Man looks lost, unsure of what next will come out of my mouth.

Getting up, shoulders almost slouched, he looks at me from hooded eyes. Reaching out, I hold his hands.

“I don’t know where I came up with that crazy idea. But right now, in front of these people that are important to me, I need you to know that I love you.” Manir concentrates his attention on me. Taking large, deep, savoring breaths. “I’ve loved you from the moment you told me you’ve not slept with your female best friends. And you want to make your wife your best friend, hence the reason you don’t have any female best friends. Meeting you in person sealed the deal. I love you more when you fight the urge to be intimate with me, even when our innocent play turns to something serious.”

“TMI Zoya.” Zena jeers.

I smile, turning to her with a wink and an announcement for my dad. “Don’t worry, we have done nothing yet… still.”

Manir chuckles, and I turn to face him. “I love you. As Oladele. As Dele. As Manir… Jeez, as everything combined.”

I love you too, Manir mouths before hugging me.

It is like a weight just left my chest—all these months of trying to understand my feelings, myself and life in general—in the moment.

Taking in deep breaths, I hold back tears threatening to drop.

“Now you can ask me to marry you.” I whisper with a smile before withdrawing.

Without wasting time, he gets on one knee, again, winking. “Queen Zo, my personal Confessor, will you do me the honor of being the queen in my palace, while I be your Mighty man… by marrying me?”

Titling my head to the side, I nod reluctantly, faking a meh expression. “That was… cliché… but yes. I will.” Squealing, “I will! I will!”

He slides the ring on my finger, sealing our fate. Getting up, he hugs me again and I chuckle in delight.

"The real crazy just began," I whisper as I see him off to his car, our hands intertwined.

"As long as it's with you, we'll pull through."

"How do I tell Chiluba?"

"Call her?"

"Hmm. She deserves better."

"I can go with you."

"I'll be fine on my own."

"What's the wedding plan?"

"Um… how soon do you want to get married?"

"December?" He grins.

"Next month? You're joking."

"I don't want you changing your mind."

"You're crazy as it stands. And I am the sane one… or maybe we're both crazy." How could we share so much about ourselves online with someone we have never met? Then decide to begin a relationship shortly after meeting. Only crazy people do that. The sooner I accept it, the better. "Getting married in December will not work for what I have in mind."

"Oh. Destination wedding?"

Yes, in Dubai.

"I'm so glad you recollect all the tiny details." Just that I never mentioned how I wanted to be proposed to, hence why he did an intimate family proposal, which I love!

He smirks. "Those are part of the reasons I love you. The crazy things you think are normal."

Like wanting to say 1 4 3 instead of I love you or getting a dating band, I stifle a laugh.

"So…" He begins, "when do you want to get married?"

"I'll have to check available dates, vendors… Um…" Who will be the maid of honor? Chiluba? Zena? Do I have to select the flowers and food menu myself or let the planner do it? "This is about to get even crazier."

"I'll be here the whole time, actively helping. It's our marriage."

"Hmm… but first I need a wedding dress and accessories."

"Something with layers," he says, giving me a suggestive look, "and fishnets. Fishnet with lace. Have I told you I like that? So, I can take my fine time ripping them off you in layers."

THERE'S MORE HAPPILY EVER AFTER! CLICK HERE TO GET THE EXTENDED EPILOGUE OF ZOYA & MANIR'S STORY.

bit.ly/gagacrazybonus

CONTINUE READING FOR CHILUBA'S STORY, A FORBIDDEN AGE-GAP ROMANCE

OceanofPDF.com

A LETTER TO YOU

Dear reader,

A lot of people, especially Africans, and in my experience, Nigerians, go through mental health issues that are not reported or treated. Depending on the severity of the mental health issue, and the support of family members and friends, few return to being *normal* and end up living successful life, while most, survive.

I wrote two articles while researching bipolar and its spectrum for this book; *Bipolar in a Thousand Words*, and *What it means to be bipolar in Lagos, Nigeria*, you can find them on my blog. With Gaga Crazy, I use the love story of Manir and Zoya to share hope to those who have or know someone going through/has gone through similar situation.

In retrospect, I hope you enjoyed the romance between Manir and Zoya, their earlier chats in the chapter headers, and the sessions. Get ready for Chiluba and George's story in the next Lagos Lovin' installment, Bottom Belle, a forbidden age-gap romance.

Thanks a lot for reading Gaga Crazy! If you are a new reader—new to my books—please check out my other books, let's become friends via camaapearl.com/links and... follow the @lagoslovin series on Instagram.

I am excited to share more sizzling stories in the upcoming Lagos Lovin' series and other collaborations, God willing. Don't forget to download Zoya and Manir's Extended Epilogue here—bit.ly/gagacrazybonus. Till then keep reading and having a swell time!

XoXO

Camaa

OceanofPDF.com

CAMAA'S RECIPES

Preparing Yam Pottage
from Zoya & Manir's Kitchen

Ingredients
½ medium sized **Yam** (yams are not the same as sweet potatoes)
1 diced large red **Onion**
½ cup of fresh **Palm Oil**
1 tablespoon of blended **Crayfish** (optional)
1 diced ripe **Plantain** (optional)
Protein: Smoked Fish/Fresh Fish/Turkey/Chicken/Prawn (optional)
Pepper sauce: a rough blend of three habanero peppers, ½ small onions, ½ red bell pepper, a thumb of ginger
Salt (to taste)
Seasoning Cube (to taste)
Water
Vegetable: Parsley/Kale/Spinach/Ugwu (optional)

Method

1. Place water in a pot to boil.
2. While waiting, peel and cut the Yam into medium-sized cubes and triangles. Rinse twice.
3. Add Yams, protein and diced onions to hot water in pot. Ensure the water is at the level of the yams. Let it cook for 15 minutes on medium to high heat.
4. Add the pepper sauce, palm oil, crayfish, plantain, salt and seasoning cube and allow to cook for an additional 12 minutes on low heat. (Add an extra ½ cup of water if you love the liquid texture, I do!)
5. Mash the Yams with wooden spoon or potato masher. Leave some chunks, it gives texture.
6. Allow to simmer for 3–5 minutes. Viola! Yam pottage is ready. Serve hot.

OceanofPDF.com

ABOUT CAMAA PEARL

Camaa Pearl, also known as Margaret Adetimehin, is an international bestselling author and storyteller with a refreshingly unique style that borders between reality and fiction.

As a true ambivert, when she is not reading or writing, she enjoys traveling, tasty meals, and behavioral research. She is not married with kids and dogs, but if you subscribe to her newsletter, bit.ly/margaretadetimehin.com, you'll be one of the first to know.

Find her everywhere camaapearl.com/links/

OceanofPDF.com

AN EXCERPT FROM BOTTOM BELLE, LAGOS LOVIN' #2

"That's him over there," Zoya says, beaming with a smile.

Over there, where? Where?

"Looking cute, like a silver fox." She adds.

My gaze lands on him and a solemn "Yeah..." is all I can get out as I place one foot before the other like a robot. Silver fox is an understatement. He is the Ultimate Silver Fox.

White men are not my thing. Like never rang my bell, but this... This white man is hot!

Sizzling!

From Zoya's explanation and descriptions I was expecting an old haggard white guy with an ego the size of the American map, but the unsuspecting man she is beaming at looks like a fifty-year-old Ewan McGregor, the British actor, with hair completely dyed white.

"Good evening, Uncle George." Zoya's eyes sparkle with adoration.

George? Sounds too sweet for this man who looks like an Italian mafia. It won't surprise me if Silhouette is a front for an underground gun and ammunition crime ring.

In response to Zoya's greeting, *Uncle George* looks up to find her and a warm smile envelope his face. He gets to his feet, and I am not disappointed when I notice he's slightly taller than me by an inch or two. Most men fall short beside me.

"Hello Zoya." His accent is vaguely British. His voice, deep, rich and dark. *Hmm…* "You're looking well." Pecking Zoya's cheeks.

With him looking this fresh and cute, I hope he doesn't fall prey to the rampant kidnapping going on in the country. Worse is him falling prey to

Lagos babes using juju to tie men down.

She gestures to me when he withdraws. “My friend Chiluba, Luba.”

When his smiling eyes land on me, I want to melt into a puddle. His eyes… they’re green. Sea green.

“Chiluba,” he says with a curious stare, causing a tremor to run through me. He didn’t opt for the straightforward way by calling me Luba instead called me by my full name—Chee-loo-bah. And I think he noticed it, the tremor.

Bottom Belle is available Summer 2022.

Order now and subscribe for early access and information
bit.ly/margaretadetimehin.com

books2read.com/bottombelle

OceanofPDF.com

ENJOYED THIS BOOK?

THANK YOU so much for reading GAGA CRAZY

As a reader, your voice has power, and as an independent author, I deeply appreciate your help in spreading the word about my books.

If you've enjoyed GAGA CRAZY, please consider leaving a **review on social media and all bookish platforms of your choice.** The review could be as brief as you like. Please avoid spoilers in your review out of courtesy to other readers.

Getting addicted to my stories? Sign up for my newsletters to get previews and updates of ongoing projects bit.ly/margaretadetimehin.com. Stalk me online using camaapearl.com/links.

If you have any comments (or find some pesky typos!) please don't hesitate to contact me via info@margaretadetimehin.com.

Find your favorite characters on Instagram: @lagoslovin

Much Love!

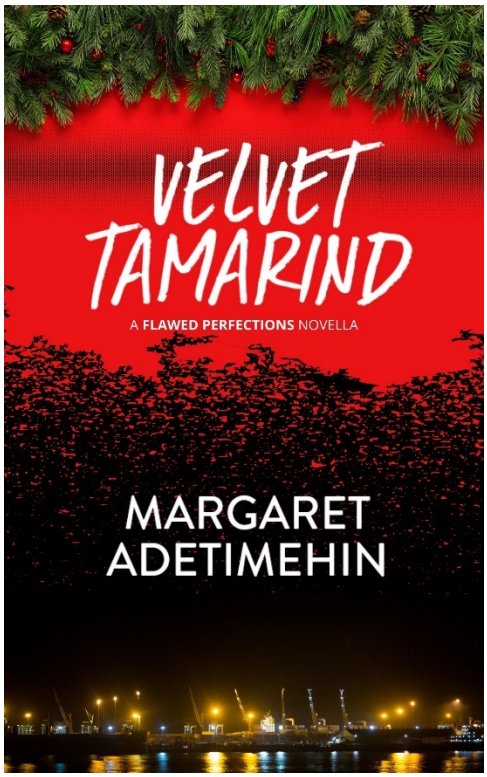
XoxO

Cama

OceanofPDF.com

When her work husband chooses someone else, Lola the Brand Guru, goes to Twin Bliss Resort to lick her wounds. Recoiling from his fiance's betrayal, Onahi buries himself into trying to resolve the war that has broken out at Twin Bliss Resort board room and its grounds. The two meet, sparks fly and they both get more than they bargained for.

OceanofPDF.com



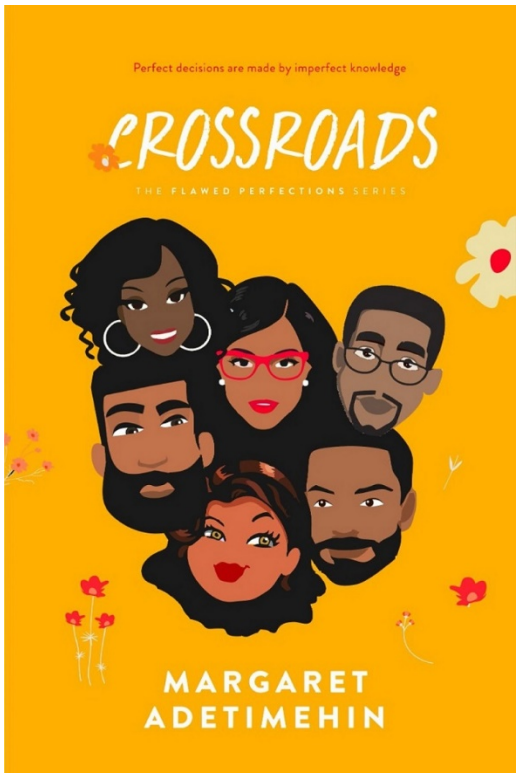
An air hostess returns home after discovering her happy relationship has been a façade. A game developer attached to his manipulative ex-wife reunites with his childhood friend who went MIA years ago. It's Detty December; a time to get loose, a time to forget about the unfairness of the years.

Read for free when you sign up for my newsletters via bit.ly/margaretadetimehin

OceanofPDF.com

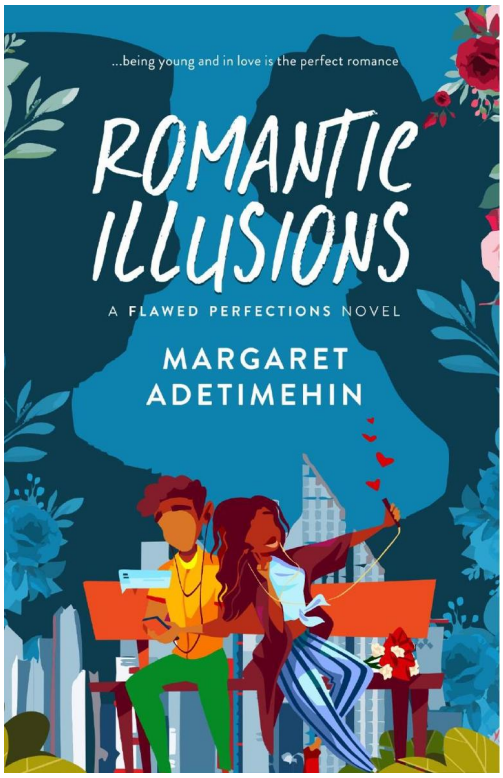
Six African millennials on the quest of finding a perfect match and happily ever after. A series of events would bring them together. First Impressions is the first book in the Flawed Perfections Series.

OceanofPDF.com



Now that they have likely found the one - or not - each of the six African millennials need to make life-changing decisions. For some, there are no choices given. Crossroads is the second book in the Flawed Perfections Series.

OceanofPDF.com



A group of sexually confused teenagers struggle with their emotions, dreams and family, in search of a perfect relationship. Romantic Illusions is the third book in the Flawed Perfection series and can be read as a standalone.

OceanofPDF.com

A phone call changed it all. Funmi is determined to be independent. She is on a quest to becoming her own boss by any means necessary.

OceanofPDF.com